A NOVEL

INTAN PARAMADITHA



NIGHT OF A THOUSAND HELLS

NIGHT OF A THOUSAND HELLS

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INTAN PARAMADITHA

The Wandering
Apple and Knife

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Intan Paramaditha

NIGHT OF A THOUSAND HELLS

Translated from the Indonesian
by Stephen J. Epstein and Tiffany Tsao



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The translations of the Qur'an that appear in this book render H.B. Jassin's Indonesian-language translation of the Qur'an, which were chosen by the author for inclusion in the original work. In doing so, the translators and author honour H.B. Jassin's endeavour to produce an Indonesian rendering faithful
to the poetry and beauty of the original Arabic of the Qur'an.'

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Night of a Thousand Hells

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CONTENTS

The Clot of Blood
Yusuf's Well
The Key
Pillar of Salt
Debts
Whispers
The Curtain Falls
Nana and the Three Sisters
About the Author

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For my mother and grandmothers

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Then Allah sent a crow to dig a hole in the earth,
to show him how to bury his brother's body.
He said, "Alas! Am I unable even
to be like this crow and bury my brother's body?"
And he became filled with regret.
(Al-Ma'idah: 31)

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NIGHT OF A THOUSAND HELLS

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The Clot of Blood

Read
In the name of your Lord the Creator.
(Al-ʿAlaq: 1)

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THE BOMBINGS: A BEDTIME STORY

Revolutions always begin with ugly stepsisters.

Our little sister was neither ugly nor revolutionary. Who knows what darkness lurked in her heart when she strapped on a bomb and blew herself up.

The curtain rises: disaster and ruin slither out into the audience, pushing onward into homes and hospital waiting rooms. Then into your bedroom, into your bed. Filling them with black smoke, with rubble and shattered glass, with frantic firefighters, with civilians huddled at the police line, necks craned. Cries resound: *Make way. Coming through. Ya Allah, Ya Allah.* Amidst the footfalls are screams and wails; the asphalt is littered with body parts, blurred for broadcast.

This is the first explosion.

Annisa is not there. Only two bombs later do we discover her, the beautiful sister, the pious one, the apple of Papa's eye.

Annisa, our little sister, yours and mine—the reason our faces are spattered with blood, which the water of ablution will not wash away, which demands greater restitution: her two older sisters must look back, must find out where they left her behind.

You will be a beautiful bride.

Nana's prophecy to little Annisa, remember? Tell me, what kind of bride did you think she'd make?

The surviving sisters exchange glances and wonder: if we had known Annisa would wind up here, at this point, this day, maybe we wouldn't have felt remorse or doubted ourselves. We should have tossed her into the well after all, those many years ago, like Yusuf's brothers when they betrayed Yusuf. We should have taken her life before she robbed others of theirs. But who could have foreseen it? Even Nana couldn't have predicted such a Ramadan, explosions ringing in our ears, flame and burnt flesh

searing our eyes. The stench, alas, can't be captured on camera. You have to be there, in that city, at the sites of tragedy, for it to drive you mad.

This is a tale of three sisters. Isn't it always? And who doesn't grow up hearing tales of *home, family, us*. But this also is the tale you didn't ask for, a tale of the unseen, the unheard, the unremembered. The two who remain seek clues—why, whose fault, when? For the shame and regret are unbearable, and maybe there's a way out, like at Nana's, when everyone played that game, the hunt for the hidden key. The three granddaughters combing every corner of Victoria's House—familiar terrain. The dark kitchen with its black cement floor; the enormous pots and pans hanging from sturdy hooks; the well out back—goading, goading; the forbidden chamber; and the soft lullabies of some presence neither alive nor dead, drifting through the walls. *Whoever finds my key shall travel far*, said Nana, though people whispered that the road to her house had no end. *You're always on the same path, going in circles. You never arrive.*

There is no answer to be found in this story, no magic pill, pleasingly round, to be halved or crushed, then swallowed. It's a story of those who fail, who fall into debt, who shift shape. During our search we find ourselves focusing on trivial matters. Everything else, so soft and smooth, slips through our grasp. Like our little sister.

What color did Annisa wear that day? I'm sure no one paid much attention—her clothes were blown to smithereens. The newspapers dubbed her the woman in black. But black never appealed to Annisa. Only white, jasmine white, pure and immaculate, the white of her wedding day, when guests lined the hall, left and right, in eager anticipation, eyes fixed on the radiant bride approaching the platform, the long hem of her gown and embroidered lace veil skimming the ground, the rest of the procession bringing up the rear, chubby-cheeked nieces and nephews, the bride's father and mother, and her jealous sisters, also in white; a heady fragrance sweeping in, as if from Paradise. Or from the grave.

Annisa, celestial maiden, garlanded in jasmine, has now passed. For Jannah, she created Jahannam—for Heaven, she created Hell.

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THE CARETAKER

When I hear about the bombings in Kotawijaya I'm busy carrying out my duty and curse: looking after the living, seeing off the dead. No one else can be trusted with the job. I am the oldest, the most adept. I spent my youth caring for Mama before we laid her to rest. Now my father is in decline, may go soon. But our souls belong to Allah. I can only tend to my father's the best I can.

This is my final duty. When it's over, I'll depart.

The hospital feels sterile, too brisk and cold; sunbeams pierce dustless glass, mingling with fluorescent light. I've been here since morning. Not once in my life have I ever slept in, never was the type to laze around in bed before coming to my senses, dazed and wondering where the hours flew.

It's only me and three others in the waiting room, all of us with relatives who have been here for days, all of us now intimately familiar with the acrid scent of medicine and disinfectant, with the AC's biting chill.

Arms folded, shoulders hunched against the cold, I walk over to the TV mounted on the wall. There's been a suicide bombing. Again. They've happened before, and now, bad news on the eve of Ramadan no longer comes as a surprise. Some people have warped views of how to celebrate the holy month.

Heads tilted, we stare up at the screen. The images keep changing: CCTV footage, TV cameras at the scene, recordings from eyewitnesses' phones. The middle-aged man beside me repeats astaghfirullah, astaghfirullah. The young mother behind me murmurs that one of the victims is a small child. Voices rise to a clamor. How many dead? They don't know yet, the number keeps climbing. Transfixed by scenes of the disaster, my body stiffens, my lips press together in a thin line. At this

point, I still have words for how I feel. Grief. Anger. I can label my feelings because the names of the perpetrators have not yet been announced. To see the name and face of a killer is another matter, another horror. You're forced to realize they're a fellow human being, breathing the same air, eating the same foods as you. In all likelihood, their hardworking parents never suspected they might be raising a fiend from hell.

While we're all engrossed in the news, there's an announcement from the ICU. I turn. I'm not sure I've heard properly. Was that my father's name? I hurry to the nurse's station. She shakes her head. No, not Mr. Sulaiman. I nod, somewhat relieved, and return to the waiting room. The three other people are talking about the bombings and the victims they've managed to identify. I listen but keep one eye on the ICU doors.

"If it wasn't for that security guard, the bomb would have gone off inside the church!"

"Mashallah, may he go straight to heaven. Oh, his poor wife. How she must feel. Their baby's only nine months old."

Then, details of mutilated bodies, which I don't want to hear.

We all sit back down and return to worrying about our respective family members. For the relatives of an ICU patient, a loved one's fate is a game of chance. Move on or miss a turn? Escape by a hair's breadth or take a pass on life? A nurse calling could mean the beckoning of the grave. My mind doesn't have room to comprehend deaths happening in another city, much less the victims of such an earth-shatteringly evil deed.

It doesn't occur to me to phone Annisa to make sure she's safe, that she hasn't been hurt. It's not like she would ever be at a church. Anyway, here in the hospital, we've been conditioned to focus on one life at a time, the life at hand.

My father was admitted to the ICU two months ago. He had a stroke in the bathroom and collapsed, unconscious. Sri and I took turns spending nights at the hospital. Sri was my parents' housekeeper, and now she works for me. I worried something might happen and we wouldn't be there. At first, I slept across a row of chairs in the waiting room, but it made me feel like I had broken all my bones. I took to sleeping in the car instead. Sri was made of tougher stuff. Following other people's examples, she brought in a mat and slept on the floor. Technically, this wasn't

allowed; having visitors reclining on the floor or leaning against the walls made the place look cluttered. Security guards kept returning to scold the rulebreakers but, after midnight, who had the heart to kick them out?

Three weeks in, I started running a fever. My work life was in shambles. My children weren't getting enough attention. Sri was missing her own son even though her sister helped care for him. Sometimes I forgot she had a child at home, though I was always thankful she didn't have a husband who might complain if she stayed late.

I soon realized there was no point in us taking so much trouble. My father's condition didn't worsen, but it never improved. He would most likely slip away without waking from his coma, without saying goodbye or leaving me a final message. Not that it mattered. This wasn't my first experience with death. And who needed a message, anyway? Papa had already spent his whole life lecturing me.

Sri and I continued taking turns daily at the hospital, but we would stay only an hour or two, rather than overnight. My aunts, uncles, and cousins from my father's side had stopped in several times to stick their nose into this or that—*Why this hospital?* or, *So-and-So is the best doctor in Jakarta, you should give him a call.* Remarks that added to our burden instead of lightening our load. For it was only the two of us here, day in, day out, me and Sri—Sri, who felt indebted to my late mother who had been so kind to her. Everyone else had only empty words to offer. Maya was in America and wouldn't come home until it was too late, like she had for Mama's funeral. Meanwhile, Annisa transferred a decent sum of money and flew in twice, but I never heard from her again.

I'm not surprised. It's always been like this. There was a time when we went everywhere together, playing make-believe and searching for hidden treasure at Nana's. But later Nana's predictions came true, one by one. Maya went wandering. Annisa got married. And here I was, looking after the house.

We were no longer three.

I return to my chair and recite the Surah Al-Fatihah for the bombing victims. Then I reach for my purse and take out my glasses and the Qur'an. I always read the holy book while waiting at the hospital. After Papa was admitted to the ICU, I didn't have time to attend the Qur'an study sessions organized by friends at work. We didn't meet often, maybe

once a month, depending on work deadlines. Last time, we finished the Surah An-Nisa and were just starting on the Al-Ma'idah.

Because of that We ordained for the Children of Israel
that if anyone killed a person . . .

"You're lost," Maya once scoffed.

She knew I'd begun reading the Qur'an more when I started looking after Mama as she lay paralyzed in bed. Once Mama had departed, I'd taken to carrying a copy wherever I went. Not long after that, I decided to wear the hijab. I'd seen no need to raise it with my younger sister, let alone ask permission. During a video call, though, Maya felt compelled to repeat her previous statement: "You're lost. You're taking refuge in religion."

I remember studying my sister on the laptop screen, eyes rimmed in black, lids dark as soot, a white-collared black blouse. She looked like a nun from a satanic order.

Maya, Maya, Maya. Did she think life was just cosplay? Maya, with her penchant for chasing dreams, for traveling the world. Maya, with no money in the bank, no obligations to anyone. She, of all people, was judging me? Maya who had taken the leap. Maya who had left. I shut the laptop without saying goodbye.

What do you know, Maya? What do you believe in?

I stare at the series of lists on my phone. The shopping list. My work to-do list. A list of everything I need to apply for the visa:

-Digital copy of passport
-Letter of good conduct
-Birth certificate, translated and notarized

That's right. I'm putting together an application for a work visa in order to move to New Zealand. No one in my family would ever have guessed. If my father weren't lying in the ICU he would say: You're forty. You're too old. Why bother with detours now?

All those years ago, I'd let the train leave without me. I'd chosen family instead.

My finger flicks to the mailbox icon. Alfrida hasn't replied to my email yet. She's on vacation with her kids in Dunedin and won't be back in Wellington for another week. I don't want to bother her. Her husband is with them—he changed his mind at the last minute and joined them unexpectedly. I don't get it. Alfrida said it was supposed to be a holiday just for her and the kids.

It's past lunchtime and my stomach starts to rumble. I rise from my seat.

"A whole family."

"Ya Allah, they brought their children."

The murmurs of the crowd make me turn around. More patients' relatives have arrived, all clustering around the TV, exchanging new information: the suicide bombers have been identified. I draw closer, squinting, transfixed by the family photo onscreen. Then closer still, quickening my pace, pushing through the wall of people between me and the TV. The hairs on my neck prickle when I see the couple and their two children smiling at the camera. A mirage, surely. My eyes must be tired. A mistake. My head fills with voices, louder and louder, until the announcer reads out their names.

The room falls silent.

I stand before the screen, my heart pounding in my ears—accelerating, ominous. My knees shake, joints shifting, bone and muscle lurching, falling away. How strange everyone looks, mouths opening and closing, like fish in slow motion, mocking me. I've been hurled somewhere far—and deep. A well. The well of the Prophet Yusuf, the well of our childhood, the site where, for the first time, we entertained notions of death. No one is coming for me. I shiver in total darkness, all alone. I call out, for someone, anyone, but only hear the echo of my own voice.

I glimpse light—the glow of the TV—and find a woman holding my arm. I've teetered into her, and she's asking if I'm all right. Several pairs of eyes watch me anxiously, but, ignoring them, I turn and walk away. My sister. My little sister. I collapse into a chair.

Who knows how long I sit in silence, staring at a fixed point in the distance, trying to slow my breath. I seek refuge. *Call on God, Muti, as you've*

done before. Astaghfirullah, Astaghfirullah, Astaghfirullah. Call on God, for the vacant mind falls prey to the devil. A hundred times over, my lips utter istighfar, recite mantras, and gradually, feeling returns to my fingers and toes. I'm not losing my mind. This much I know:

I'm in a hospital. My father is dying. My sister has blown herself up.

Two hours have passed since finding out what, since finding out who, but I'm trapped in a loop, a circle without end—opening news sites, checking names, *it can't be*, reading other articles, spelling the names out, *no, I won't believe it. I can't.*

I manage to drag myself to the cafeteria in search of a hot drink. I can't be weak, there's no one else. I'm my mother's daughter, the responsible one. The aroma of sautéed garlic makes me more alert, and I note everything I see: my feet walking across the white tiles; the price of tea and cake—25,000 rupiah; the woman in the purple headscarf serving me, the ID badge on her chest. Her name is Rita. My name is Mutiara, the oldest child.

My phone rings.

"Ma'am, someone called." It's Sri's voice. "From the police."

My name is Mutiara.

Mutiara, Maya, Annisa. The three of you must care for each other, said Nana.

But we are no longer three.

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THE TRAVELER

For one night only, let me say this:
Turn out the lights. Let's hide, you and I. In this dark room we'll nest, we'll scurry and squeak, away from the searing light of the outside world, the pores of its skin, the sour stench of its sweat. Let's flee from the glare and the din, from screens of all sorts, ringing phones and morning headlines. We're only in transit after all. Yet another airport layover, another rendezvous, transforming this room into a cheap hotel, where rats can revel, no questions asked. Questions like: where to now? For you and I will never be safe.

For now, like bats, let's dangle, awaiting the bulldozers and collapse of walls. No emergency exit for us when time catches us, drags us out, burns us alive. Maybe I'll pretend to forget. The walls of this transit lounge are gingerbread, a witch's house in the woods, why wait for it to fall, let's tear it down ourselves. It's all pointless anyway. You and I stash the clock in a freezer, fingers frostbitten, but time flows on, tick tick, dripping through, ice-cold on our skin when we make love, splitting our skin, drawing blood, sweeping all defenses away.

But for today at least, here we are. We shut your apartment windows against the warm rays of spring. We live through another morning-noon--night, closing the borders, cutting off all routes, spitting at the world.

From the depths of an embrace and a lullaby, I'll bury my nails in your flesh.

So, what did she say?

You'll answer. What you'll say, I don't know. Or rather, I'll wave away your bullshit explanations.

You haven't spoken to her.

I'll lie on my side of the bed, silent. But I won't stay angry for too long, cursed as I am, desire rising, trembling all over. I'm hungry. I long to run my hands over you, to press against you, to cry out for your tongue on my

body, everywhere, hot, wet, for time is leaking through, drip, drip, drip, and what are you waiting for, let's go, I'll crush you into powder before we turn to dust.

We're cursed, you and I. Don't they say there's a season for everything? A time to nest, a time to fuck, a time to slip from people's grasp. A time to get thrown out, back into the light of day, to return to the trudging of feet and the stale scent of beer, to the stench of piss on street corners.

Night turns to morning, morning to noon. Then, just like that, the clock shows two. Time to leave the nest. But I still can't bear to face reality's slap. Without turning on my phone, I walk to 168th Street Station, and in the subway car, in a dream, I replay everything in slow motion, stretching out every sigh, every silence, every caress. The scent of bedsheets and cigarette smoke still clings to my hair and I breathe it in.

I get off at Jackson Heights. The ear-piercing din of the surging crowds startles me awake. Time to give up. My grandmother's voice, high and shrill, swoops in, all the way from Victoria's House. *Wake up, Maya.* In front of a newsstand, I switch on my phone, to a barrage of texts from Mutiara. In the midst of the crowd, despite the warm sunshine, I freeze.

Wake up, Maya. Wake up!

There, at the station entrance, surrounded by all sorts of people speaking different languages—Spanish, Mandarin, Urdu (I think)—my grandmother's voice clangs like a bell, and my eyes fix on Mutiara's last message. *Inna lillah wa inna ilayhi raji'un*, it begins. We belong to Allah, and to Him we return.

Shit. My father's dead.

I race back to my apartment, trying to call Mutiara, but it keeps going to voicemail and I'm losing my grip. Why, oh why did I turn my phone off at Nadir's? But it's too late now. Frantically, I fish my key out and open the door. Jacket and shoes still on, I head straight to the dining table, sit down, and dial the hospital. The receptionist connects me with the ICU. I'm shunted from one person to another until, finally, I get news about my father's condition: stable, still unconscious, no better, no worse. I mutter thanks, relieved but confused. So who's dead?

Read the news, says one of Mutiara's texts.

I still can't get hold of her. Damn it, Muti, what news? Panicked, I reach for my backpack and take out my computer. I open all the Indonesian news websites. My breath stops. *What news?*—the question, breathtakingly stupid, rings in my ears. There is only one story everywhere.

Open your eyes, Maya.

You fool. Annisa's dead.

I spring from the chair, pacing back and forth, and suddenly, I find myself curled up on the floor, howling, clutching my hair till my scalp burns with pain. The apartment is empty, a strange womb, me trembling inside it, knees pressed to my chest. My screams are piercing, obscene. Darkness, thick and heavy, like black sludge, descends over my eyes.

I move my fingers one by one, and slowly grope the surface where I lie. It's soft and smooth. I hear a voice—*wake up, Maya*—but it's not Nana's. Who's here, then? Who's beside me?

"Maya, are you okay?"

With great effort I pry open my eyelids. I have no memory of how I got here, why I'm in my bed. Nadir is holding my hand. My head pounds. There's a buzzing in my ears. No, this is all wrong, wrong, I shouldn't be here, or Nadir. Everything is in the wrong place.

"What are you doing here?"

"Tatyana called me."

"Home." I shake my head. "Home."

"Home where?"

Go home, Nadir. Back where you belong. To the Rat Hotel.

It's coming back to me now. Faintly. Someone calling my name, soft at first, then alarm setting in. *Maya, Maya!* My housemate Tatyana, shaking my shoulder, jingling her keys next to my ear. And me saying—I did, didn't I?—yes, I could hear them, I could hear her. How long ago was that?

Nadir holds a glass of water to my lips. Tatyana's voice again, distant, from the kitchen. "Is she okay?"

How long have I been here? My sense of time is all mixed up.

What happened, exactly? Before everything went dark?

I recall Nadir's room, our transit lounge, our hideout.

I recall lying limp on the floor, like those depressing dolls of my mother's, in her cupboard gathering dust.

Now, in Nadir's arms, I sob. Why or how, I don't know, but it's like I can hear a blast. Our transit lounge blown to bits, nothing left but crumbs.

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THE BRIDE

FAMILY OF FOUR AMONG KOTAWIJAYA BOMBERS
Sinar Nusantara, 13 May 2018

The suicide bombers have been identified . . .

. . . Church of the Risen Christ, Church of the Sacred Heart, and a multipurpose hall at the Kartini Residential Complex . . .

. . . six individuals.

At the Church of the Risen Christ . . . Abdul Moertidjo (age 32) and Ahmad Qomaruddin (30) . . .

At the Church of the Sacred Heart and the multipurpose hall . . . a family of four.

Muhammad Fahri (34)
Gibran Fairuz (9)
Annisa Dinda (34)
Patricia Dinda (2)

. . . An-Nur, a Islamic study group for trans women.

The victim count continues to rise . . .
10 dead
30 wounded
In an interview, terrorism expert Muhammad Mansyur . . .
. . . such bombings . . . planned in advance:

“Gathering the materials for and assembling a bomb requires great care and forethought—like planning a wedding. And as with a wedding, the ‘brides,’ as we call them, undergo extensive preparation themselves.”

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The Tale of Sha'ban

It starts with a mass murder. Date: 27 Sha'ban, 1439 Hijri; 13 May 2018. The tale of Sha'ban, mind you, not of Shahrazad. Not she who sat behind a curtain telling stories to stop the broken-hearted sultan from slaying yet another bride (a woman's life is all too cheap). Shahrazad, every night becoming martyr, master storyteller, manipulator of time, savior of her own skin. No, this isn't Shahrazad's tale, for it tells of more than death delayed. And Shahrazad the Storyteller was no avenger, never so much as picked up a sword. But come to think of it, both tales spring from the same source, the same dark pool: blood.

Three days before Ramadan, bombs exploded at three different sites in Kotawijaya. Children were involved—and, their parents, too, who had decided for their children exactly when their lives would end. Events unfurled from there, relentless, beginning at 8:30 A.M. at the Church of the Risen Christ. Two men on a motorbike sped past security into the parking lot and blew themselves up. Less than ten minutes later a second bomb went off at another church, its carrier a motorcyclist, and seated behind him, a nine-year-old child—Annisa's husband and their son Gibran, entering the gates of the Church of the Sacred Heart.

Two officers were on duty. The large backpack the rider clutched to his chest aroused the suspicions of the head security guard. Ramadan and Christmas: times of high alert. He approached the bike, but before he could speak, the boy leapt off, sprinting away fast as he could, the father looking back, bewildered, never imagining his son would betray him and flee. Too late. Moments later, the bomb in the man's arms exploded, hurling the boy clear of the grave, just beyond the church grounds. The second security guard carried the boy's bloody body to the hospital. The other, his superior, met with a different fate. Great is Allah. Who knows how many others would have died if not for his vigilance, buying time, like Shahrazad, delaying the explosion by a few seconds more. Together

with Annisa's husband, the guard was blown to pieces. One can't help but wonder: did Annisa know that the man had a wife and baby? Was there room for anything else in her head besides accompanying her own husband to Paradise?

Then the third bomb: at an unexpected time, in an unexpected place, when all attention was on the two churches. At 11:00 A.M., an explosion occurred at a multipurpose hall in the Kartini Residential Complex, where a group of women had gathered for a religious study session in the lead-up to Ramadan. That's right: a Muslim gathering, in the supposed safety of a gated community. A horrible spectacle indeed. And that's where we found her, our little sister, Annisa.

Don't look.

Her head was intact. And her arms and legs. But her organs were everywhere.

Even before these bombings we had learned to be wary—around police stations, markets, malls. And churches, of course. Bombers target crowds. What's the point of a good show without an audience? How awful, we said, shaking our heads, that it was no longer safe to worship in a house of God. But we never knew what real terror meant. It's good to be Muslim in this country, especially during Ramadan. things slow down and there's more Islamic content on TV; restaurants serve customers behind drawn curtains, so as not to tempt those who fast; calls to prayer and sermons and lectures ring through every alleyway, reminding us to be diligent in accruing merit. What a joy!—to be able to worship with such devotion, without distraction, without needing protection from police. Or so it was until Annisa arrived at the hall that day, carrying her little girl. Only two years on this earth and that was that.

Mother knows best.

Three days before Ramadan, and yet again, there were church bombings for good Muslim men and women to condemn. But then we heard that the bomber had targeted our own. We grew bewildered, adding hastily, *Cursed is a Muslim who kills fellow Muslims—may she burn in the innermost depths of Hell.*

Later, we learned from the news that An-Nur, an Islamic study group for trans women, had been meeting at the hall. Good Muslim men and women were divided, confused. Some found it necessary to comment: murder is never justified, but they were deviants, in violation of nature's law.

There was no CCTV footage, but someone standing on the roadside saw Annisa arrive. A woman in a headscarf, the activist who ran the group, had come out to greet her. They spoke. Then Annisa hugged the woman, or vice versa—the witness wasn't sure. But it seemed as if Annisa was trying to get past and the woman was blocking her. The bomb, concealed around Annisa's waist, went off.

The media dubbed her "the trans woman victim"—and really, what else do you think of in this country, when one hears of trans women only when they are stabbed, slaughtered, set aflame? But she had a name. Mami Cindy. Mother to outcasts. Go ahead, Google her. You'll find a big-boned woman in a baju kurung and matching hijab of red, yellow, or green, arms at the ready to envelop you in a warm embrace. At study sessions, Mami would console her children: So they think you're an abomination. So they laugh at you and attack you. Just remember, you're Mami's child, she'd say. Accept these trials from Allah patiently.

Then one of them would ask, Even trials painful as these?

Now Mami Cindy's dead. And someone must pay.

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THE TRAVELER

The Dining Table

I hear a knife against a cutting board, and a gas stove being turned on. Nadir is cooking for me in the kitchen. I also hear Tatyana come out of her room—and snatches of conversation.

"Is she really okay?"

"Yes, yes. A mild fever. Don't worry."

Nadir brings the soup he's made to my room. He feeds it to me, little by little, though I can't taste or smell properly—are those scallions? And broth? It's as if my taste buds are severed from my brain. The sensation spreads across my tongue and down my throat, then through my body, filling me with warmth. I badger Nadir with the same questions over and over, about what happened before I blacked out.

"Did anyone call?" I ask. "The hospital?"

He shakes his head.

Finally, after searching my memory, stumbling, I manage to retrace all the events. I put the jigsaw together piece by piece, lining them up, fitting them in. A little more, a little more, done. My body shudders violently. I remember now. I know.

How strange, to know. How strange to be the *n*th person to find out. How strange, trying to process the news, sentence by sentence, only to have the words attack me—*bomb, blood, body parts, debris*. Then to discover among them, Annisa's name. Not in the context of "victim" but in the context of "inhuman." I couldn't make the connection—not to the darling baby girl with rosy cheeks I used to cradle in my arms, though at times I hated her for being so doted on, the apple of everyone's eye. I keep hoping this must be a mistake, *this must be a mistake. It's some other Annisa*, or, at least, some other sister, a shadow sister from the world of dreams.

But it is Annisa. *Annisa*, a name fraught with meaning. The name of our father's favorite—the fairest and most pious of us all—now printed everywhere by those who never knew her, turning her—and the rest of us—into lab specimens for scrutiny under a microscope.

Something forces its way into my eyes, drawing tears. It must be dust.

Sing your sister a lullaby, I remember Mother saying. Annisa, so cute, fresh from the hospital, a yummy, fragrant, chubby little bun. We two older sisters were soon shunted aside. But who could resist her? Her soft baby hair, her sweet perfume. And so I sang.

Hush, little baby, out with the light. If you cry, the bugs will bite.

Oh, my sister. How could I have known that you would be the one to bite, tearing at my flesh, shredding it, gobbling my lungs, my spleen. My baby sister had fangs, and I never knew.

I drag myself out of bed. Nadir protests, but I need to do something, though what exactly, I don't know. To boil water, to brew coffee, to make myself useful somehow. I have to start somewhere. The kitchen floor feels cold against my bare feet. I pause at the dining table, gaze at the loaf of bread and jars of jam clustered in the middle, then sit and stare at the empty chairs.

I bought this table with Tatyana at Ikea. It's dainty and cute, and childishly small. And I think, by contrast, of the stately dining table in my parents' home with its white marble surface and lazy Susan, surrounded by six carved wooden chairs—a reminder of better days, when Father was rich, riding high on Fortune's wheel. Squeaking by one moment, coming into money the next, living the good life, then going broke again. At that table we would sit: Papa, Mama, Mutiara, Maya, Annisa, with a chair reserved for Nana, for when she would visit from Tanjung Karang. And now, one by one, we disappear, like in the nursery rhyme. Nana, first. Then my mother. Now, Annisa, my little sister, object of my love—and all my hate, and all my regret.

Six little chicks go out to play
Only five come back that day
Five little chicks go out to play
Only four come back that day
Cluckity cluck. Chirpity cheep.

Hear the little chicks go chirpity cheep

I left home. And through all my wanderings, that table has remained in my mind, eternal, unchanged. I was the one who went travelling while they stayed home, static and serene as a still life of apples and pears. But it turns out we're all just a bad joke. *What happened to the chicks when they crossed the road?* Two chicks had a stroke and died, and one chick went *pop!* spraying blood and guts everywhere.

The white marble table—a symbol of our family's rise, and later, decline. It grew scratched and weathered, but we had no money to get it replaced. At the height of its glory, it bore witness to how Father once presided over us, like Lear when he was still king, about to parcel out his domain. Love and power, how easily they slip through your fingers—like grains of sand. And our Lear-like father, clutching at life, would ask his daughters: Who loves me most?

Not that there was ever much to divvy up when it came to Papa's petty fiefdom. Afterwards, he would merely return to the office to resume being a cog in the corporate machine. Even so, being the favorite had its attractions. If not now, surely someday it would pay. But we had to pass a test. You can guess who wound up as Goneril and Regan, shifty, hard to tell apart, and who got to be Cordelia, noble and truly beautiful, inside and out. Mutiara and I, trained in the logic of incentives, would sing Papa's praises. We the dissemblers, the duplicitous, chasing after gifts. But maybe we also craved attention, for we knew all too well who had won his heart. *Annisa, do you love Papa?* The scene of Lear and his daughters three, played out on a stage in the Third World's sweltering heat. And always ending with that question. Annisa, so young, so untender, would say nothing. As we know, Cordelia's love is pure and true; she doesn't need to flatter or fuss.

I don't know why, but here, in this moment, it's this memory of Annisa that burns clearest in my mind. This, and the incident with the well, which I thought I had succeeded in burying. But what about a memory of her from a year ago? I can't recall. Did we even get to see each other? What about two years ago? I don't remember. Where was she, what was she doing, what were her children like? And what happened to her this year? Or last? Ten years ago? Twenty? When did we grow so far apart?

What time is it? I don't know. Here I sit, recalling my father's table, and chicks dying one by one.

Then Nadir's voice:

"Weren't you going to make coffee?"

"Coffee?"

I stare at the white walls of my apartment. Everything I've ever written is now in vain, for I remember none of it. They say God is all-gracious, teaching us through the pen. But my writing is meaningless. I recall nothing about my little sister because I never wrote a word about her.

Where did we lose her?

I know we didn't leave her in the well.

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THE CARETAKER

Damned Spot

Who created you
from a mere clot of blood.
(Al-ʿAlaq: 2)

My flight is delayed. We were scheduled to leave at 9:00 P.M., but it's 10:00. I pace back and forth, asking for updates from airline staff. The other passengers in the waiting area are also getting restless, including the young couple next to me with a newborn and toddler. The mother is busy with the baby; the father entertains the older one, a noisy, snot-nosed kid, and brushes potato chip crumbs from its clothes onto the floor. When Annisa used to eat in bed, Mama would make me clean up after her. It annoyed me, but Annisa was so adorable, I couldn't keep myself from cuddling her anyway.

Allah has a way of revealing wisdom from the odd paths He chooses for us. Here I am: forty, a devout woman, unmarried, though I do have four kids: three gingers, one black. But cats are independent creatures. Beloved of the Prophet, they never tie themselves down. My aunts and uncles call me an old maid, past my expiration date. This evening, after seeing Annisa's face on TV, they storm my phone:

Inna lillah. Muti, is it true, call Uncle ASAP
Ya Allah, Annisa was such a good girl
Sound doctrine is everything. What study group was she attending?
I knew something was off about her husband. Lots of radicals these days.
You should have known something wasn't right

Their brother Sulaiman is in the hospital, waiting to die, and I'm their only link. My mother is gone, and Maya the Traveler can't be relied upon.

I send my aunts and uncles the same text: *Thank you. Sorry. Will phone later. On the way to Kotawijaya.*

My grandmother Victoria raised sons and daughters who grew more religious with age. Some got richer, some grew poorer, but they all had a consistent skill set: a talent for gossip and sneering and pounding your heart into the thinnest and finest of shreds. Like meat floss. At a time like this, holding on to my sanity means ignoring them: Norma the matriarch, my father's overbearing older sister; Linda, three years younger than Papa, a Norma-in-training; and two younger brothers, Benny and Boy, almost interchangeable, both useless, both insufferable.

Not much chatter from my mother's side. Our relationship had been strained for years. A single text arrives from Mama's sister-in-law: *Sorry to bother. It's Auntie Itje in Tasik. Did I just see Annisa on TV? Sorry if I'm wrong.*

I don't respond.

Meanwhile, Victoria's children keep up a barrage of self-righteous advice: *Why are you going? Is that the wisest decision? Even mosques refuse to bury bombers.* No expressions of condolence. Not that I deserve them.

My chest feels tighter by the second. I'm about to boil over, to go off like a fire alarm. But I'm alone so have to keep the lid on. Allah will reveal the straight path, *sirat al-mustaqim*, the path that leads to Him. The toddler next to me is getting noisy. He starts imitating a police siren, over and over, louder and louder, reaching an ear-piercing pitch. The young father makes no attempt to shush him. My head throbs. Our eyes meet by chance and he smiles, begging for understanding, or solidarity, but I look away without returning his smile. My own children are sweet-smelling and clean. I've never had to deal with a human child.

Papa was never very good at playing with us. When we were little, it was always that one game. The rules were simple, but we played along: "Who loves Papa most?" We'd vie for his affections, declaring our love, because we knew, once we were done, he'd head to his room to retrieve the shopping bag where he kept the chocolates that would be our prize. The winner would get her reward first. I was Mama's child, I loved *her* the

most, but Mama didn't dispense prizes so easily. Prove yourself first. Then came Mama's love.

Even in diapers, Annisa knew she was the special one. At the age of two, when asked who loved Papa most, she pointed at herself, but at three, her answer grew inconsistent. By four, she didn't care. She seemed to understand that no matter her answer, she would always receive a bonus —be showered with cuddles and praise. If Annisa was nowhere in sight, Papa would ask, "Where's Papa's pretty girl?" Relatives and neighbors would always give her candy, or extra money to spend on treats. "For the cutie," they'd say.

"They should stop calling her cutie," I remember Maya saying. "It's not like she's a pet or anything."

That was back then, when the three of us went everywhere together, bound by sisterhood and love. And envy.

But it wasn't envy that brought us to the well, one quiet day at Tanjung Karang. We merely wanted to teach Annisa a lesson. Anyway, didn't I make up for it afterwards by always taking care of her? If jealousy was involved, I have no recollection of when it reared its head.

All my life, recognition required passing a test. You're the oldest. You set the example. Be responsible. Prove yourself. That was what my mother would say, before she began to fall apart. And I believed I could manage the whole world, as long as I was the most reliable one. I handled everything well, thanks to Mama. At least, until now.

Annisa never needed to prove herself. Even as an adult, she always got more attention from Papa even when she made no effort to show her love. Her lavish wedding, for example. I helped out with the costs but drew the line at pointless extravagance, so Papa borrowed money here and there. Annisa was his favorite. She had to be the prettiest bride. A wedding happens a once in a lifetime, he said.

And what do you say now, Papa? Did you ever dream that, one day, Annisa would be this kind of 'bride'? A suicide bomber? That's once in a lifetime, too.

The airline staff finally announce that our flight is ready for departure. Everyone gets in line, boarding passes ready. I try calling Maya once more, but still no answer. I send a text:

Where are you? Call me!

I can't break it to her in a text. Every sentence I type feels wrong: *Maya, Annisa's gone. Maya, Annisa blew herself up. Maya, your little sister is a mass murderer.* In the slow-moving queue, my eyes grow hot.

Before we embarked on our separate paths, Maya and I went through a lot together, and I keep forgetting that she can't be counted on. I have to take care of this myself. My younger siblings are allowed to disappear, or go astray, but Nana told me I was in charge of caring for the home. *Look after the living, see off the dead.* Now I'm on a journey between the two, bound for Annisa, leaving Papa behind.

It's close to midnight when I arrive at the hotel. Once I set down my suitcase, I head to the bathroom sink. I scrub my hands clean and keep at it for a very long time.

I have no energy left to keep trying Maya, so I send a message: *Inna lillah wa inna ilayhi raji'un. Maya, read the news. I just arrived in Kotawijaya. Let's talk tomorrow.*

I turn off my phone and the bedside lamp.

At 4:00 A.M. I'm still awake, but it doesn't mean I'm ready to get up, check my phone, or offer the Tahajjud prayer. There's a burning sensation in my chest. It feels like a gaping wound, weeping warm pus. I shift to my right, then to my left, but the pain only intensifies and I start to cry—first sobs, then wails reminiscent of that boy imitating a police siren. My nose is full of snot, congested. I can barely breathe.

I drift off to sleep at some point. Dreaming, or rather, half dreaming—I'm still aware I'm lying on a bed—I see Maya and Annisa walking toward me. Maya has just come from the airport and is rolling a suitcase. Annisa is wearing a white headscarf and is leading her children by the hand. Eagerly, I spring up from my chair in the ICU waiting room. We're going to see Papa together. I hug my sisters in turn and feel Annisa's warmth, like when we were little and I would cuddle her. I look into her eyes and breathe a sigh of relief.

"So you're not dead?"

"You had a nightmare."

"Alhamdulillah, alhamdulillah. I thought—"

“No, Muti. It was just a dream.”

When I open my eyes, the clock shows 8:00 A.M. I’ve missed the dawn prayer.

I stop by the hotel breakfast buffet on my way out and wrap two slices of bread in a napkin. I’m pressed for time, but I don’t want to go to the hospital on an empty stomach. I don’t want to pass out in front of the police.

The taxi arrives at nine on the dot, and I slide into the back seat and tell the driver my destination: Bhayangkara Hospital. The sun streams through the windows. I take out my sunglasses. The driver glances in the rearview mirror.

“Hot, huh?”

And without waiting for an answer he rambles on, “But now they’re planting trees everywhere. It’s a new initiative. Imagine what it’ll be like in three or four years. Cool, shady. Mayor Astrid is doing a great job.”

I want to say, “Can we skip the chat?” but I can’t bring myself to do it. Instead I keep quiet. He watches the road but checks the mirror every so often for my response.

“Mayor Astrid says that when it’s hot, people get worked up more easily and lose their temper. She has a point,” he says. “That’s why I plant trees in our yard at home. I have two trees that are twenty years old. Same age as my son. I’ve cared for all three of them since they were small. My boy and the trees. Yep.”

I do remember Kotawijaya being hotter, although I can’t quite recall when I was here last. Five or six years ago, maybe, on a work trip for a few days—checking in to a hotel, a meeting, checking out, shopping for souvenirs at the airport. I didn’t have the chance to see anything apart from skyscrapers and boulevards. Outside of work, I spent my time looking after Mama, then Papa. I’ve never had the luxury of taking a vacation. And now I’m back, not for work or a holiday, but for my sister. I’m meeting her at the morgue.

I glance at my phone. Maya tried to call me last night, then sent a flurry of texts:

Muti, what’s wrong?

Where are you?

Is Papa okay?

Come on, you're driving me crazy!

After that, no more messages. Did she not know? Was she playing dumb? I consider calling her but decide against it, unsure what awaits me at the hospital. Conversations with Maya often devolve into arguments, even without the added factor of a suicide bombing. I type a short message: *Heading to hospital. To see Annisa*. I delete the last sentence and hit send.

Annisa, or what's left of her.

I gaze out the window at the other cars. We've hit traffic. I take a deep breath and drum my feet impatiently. *Keep going. Don't stop. I just want to clean all of this up.*

"Illness in the family, Ma'am?"

"Yes," I lie.

"Traffic was terrible by the hospital yesterday, too," he says. "You heard what happened, right?"

I give a faint nod, my body tensing. The driver tells me about when he drove by. The road was completely backed up. He learned only later that the victims and bombers had been taken to that hospital.

"Lots of reporters," he continues.

They're probably still there. I hope I can avoid them. There are photos of my sister and her family everywhere I look, and I don't want to be part of the spectacle.

"Poor things." He shakes his head. "Some of them were screaming."

"Who?"

"The victims' relatives. But, apparently, no one from the bombers' families have come. They must be too ashamed."

He begins to speculate. Say his son murdered people like that. He'd wash his hands of his own flesh and blood. Forget about identifying the body, or burying it. Anyway, most mosques won't bury a suicide bomber.

"Their parents must be devastated," he remarks. "Still their children after all. Imagine: all that love, all that care."

"Yeah. Too bad children aren't trees."

The driver turns around and frowns at me. I can't tell what surprises him more: my words, or the fact that I've actually been listening.

A policeman is waiting at the reception desk. He asks me to follow him. We don't say much as we walk past the payment counter and pharmacy. It's cool, and the chemical smell of disinfectant and medicine hangs in the air. But as we head down the corridor, I suddenly feel hot. Under my headscarf, my neck is damp with sweat. I scan my surroundings: the small garden on the right, the ICU on the left, an orderly pushing a bed. We continue on. There are signs: Toilet, Forensics, One Way, Canteen. A row of food vendors—fried noodles, grilled chicken and rice, orange juice—and people sitting on benches. I wonder if any of them are journalists, but they're probably just visiting relatives—like me visiting Papa in the hospital back in Jakarta. But circumstances have made me wary of everyone.

From the canteen we take a left. An ambulance and several police cars are parked across the road. Two officers stand guard in front of the morgue. I see people with TV cameras and press badges. It's not as bad as I thought, but I feel anxious nonetheless. It's obvious I'm not a doctor, or Catholic, so, by process of elimination, I must be a relative of one of the bombers. The people monitoring the morgue entrance look in my direction and exchange whispers. I'm wearing my usual work attire, a cream-colored blouse, black trousers, low pumps. I adjust my headscarf. I have no desire to be judged or feed the morbid curiosity of others.

Another policeman comes out to greet us. The officer escorting me introduces him—Suparto, his higher-up—and they lead me inside.

The noise subsides once we're in the morgue. I feel cold. Beneath the dim halogen lighting sit gray refrigeration units arranged in a grid. Where the corpses are stored, filed away like documents.

"Are you sure you're okay, Ma'am?"

I nod.

Suparto asks me to identify Annisa and Patricia. What's left of her husband is beyond recognition. As he recounts the timeline of events, I notice an odor, faint at first, then increasingly perceptible. It reminds me of ground meat when I leave it in the fridge for too long and it turns from red to brown. I lift my fingers to my mouth, my breakfast rising in my throat.

“ . . . your sister,” he continues. “The torso’s a mess. But the head is still . . . ”

Memories wash over me, of Annisa’s hair when she was a teenager, straight and silky smooth, and her long eyelashes. And that way she had of biting her lower lip, so pink, young and full. And how, sometimes, I wished she would fall and hit her head against the tiles and gash those lips, because it was unfair how stunning she was. But then I’d feel awful for thinking such things and hug her, and that beautiful head.

I try to follow Suparto’s explanation and the autopsy report, but my heart is beating too fast. I press my fingers tightly against my mouth. As the man across from me speaks of body parts, I imagine my sister whole. As she was when she was little, with those cheeks, so rosy, and soft, and round. My heart pounds so wildly I can hear little else, and before I realise what’s happening, Suparto lifts the sheet.

This. The last image I’ll ever have of my sister, one I’ll desperately want to forget, etched forever in my mind. I’ve sought refuge, in household tasks, in the pages of the Holy Book. *Iqra. Read in the name of your Lord*. I recite the words but hear nothing of them once I see her, my poor little sister, the sister I love, her head lying there, all beauty gone. A broken doll, bloated and gray, no longer a reflection of divine love, of the One who created humankind from a clot of blood and who guides us through the pen.

Later that afternoon, I sit thinking about it: *a clot of blood.* That’s how we all start out, isn’t it—as an embryo, a little bloody lump? I recall all the times I looked after my sister when she was alive, when blood still flowed through her veins. After the incident at the well, I promised to care for her always—and I did, through all the scrapes and bruises of when she was a kid on a tricycle, to when she was a teenager, when her changing body gave her a fright.

At the morgue and during the police interviews, I gave them all the information I could. But, honestly, there wasn’t much to tell them. My relationship with Annisa was stuck in the past.

I return to the hotel room and for a long time sit on the edge of the bed before going to the bathroom. On the toilet, I let out a deep sigh when I see the bloody stains. I forgot my period was coming. No wonder that dog

followed me on the way back: it smelled blood. I wash my underwear in the sink, like the time I washed Annisa's, when she was ten.

Annisa returned home from school that afternoon, her eyes red with tears. I let her in and she rushed to the bathroom without a word. An hour went by and she still hadn't come out. Worried, I knocked and called her name through the door. She came out in a towel, sobbing, hair wet.

"I don't want to die," she said.

"You're not dying," I said gently.

Her first period. She was young for it—in fifth grade—and she had panicked. Mama had prepared me for mine. *Always keep pads in your school bag*, she had advised me well in advance. But that was when she was still looking after us, before she disappeared into the woods, leaving me in charge at home.

I peered into the bathroom, the floor wet from Annisa trying to clean herself off. Annisa's undies lay on the tiles, wet, reddish-brown. She had tried to wash them, but bloodstains are stubborn. I helped her get dressed and handed her a pack of pads.

I told her to stop crying. She did, and went into the bedroom. I got out the detergent and started to clean. And for years, that's what I've been doing. Scouring. Sweeping. Cleaning up the blood.

Now, here, scrubbing my underwear, I feel the need to wash everything clean. O my sister, my dearest, my love, why didn't you kill me too? I long to be washed away, to vanish, just like this stain.

Or is it still here? I sniff. A rank odor, here's the smell of blood still. But where is the blood hiding? Has it seeped into the creases of my fingers, or underneath my nails? Whose blood is this, staining my skin? I wash with soap, rinsing my palms, rinsing my thumbs, the backs of my hands, rubbing harder and faster. Everything needs to be clean, dammit, why won't the spot come out? I scrub again, again and again. I feel so filthy, so damaged, defiled.

You are a traitor, Annisa.

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THE TRAVELER

A Boat

I board the subway, no destination in mind, simply needing to feel the sensation of something in motion. I do this every time I have writer's block. Rise. Forward, march.

Eventually, I get off and go into a café for a coffee, but my stomach starts to feel queasy. I dash to a toilet stall, but at the sight of it, the vomit rises in my throat. Shit, everywhere! Cursing, I move to the next stall and throw up. When I flush, I see Annisa's face reflected in the water, and all of us spattered—our hair, our faces, our bodies—not with shit but with her bloody act, crimson and pulsing, clinging to us, refusing to disappear down a hole. Sobbing silently, I kneel beside the toilet bowl.

I remain crouched there for a long while before pulling myself up and going out to wash my hands. I look at my reflection in the mirror. My makeup is a mess, coal-black rivulets running wet down my cheeks. The woman at the next sink takes one look at me and hands me a tissue.

I leave, passing shop after shop, and hordes of tourists, until I reach Times Square. I board the 1 train at random, then the ferry to Staten Island.

Nana predicted my future once: You, on a boat. With books.

And here I am, fulfilling the prophecy. Maybe not as a ruler in exile or a colonizer on a foreign isle, but I have seen the world. Maybe that's why Mutiara hates me.

I try to recall where I left off: my hideaway; the rat hotel, our transit lounge; our torrid romance; time standing still. But the film freezes, won't play on. I'm trapped in a macabre Monopoly game: Leave hotel, do not pass go. Go directly to jail. My sister's a murderer, a monster, and now

she's dead, along with all those innocent people. Annisa's no more, but the monster lives on.

Beyond the railings, the river sluices by, dark but for the moonlight rippling on its surface, distracting me from the others on board: lovers embracing, mothers carrying small children, passengers snacking, all so ordinary. I feel like I'm about to drown. A storm is coming, and this is just the beginning. I have no magic to keep it at bay.

The ferry docks. I step out with the other passengers, swipe my Metro card at the turnstile, and head to the station. It's midnight, so there's hardly anyone on the platform. I board the R for the long trip back to Jackson Heights. Canal Street. Prince Street. 8th Street. Station after station. I lean my head against the window and close my eyes.

By the time I wake, we're in Queens. The door opens and passengers get on. A woman in a headscarf and a long white dress is standing there, holding a pole. She turns to me, smiling. I flinch. She's beautiful, like Annisa on her wedding day, but there's a spot of crimson on her gown. Slowly, it spreads—wider, and wider. And I see the gaping wound in her middle, the sticky, congealing blood.

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THE TALE OF VICTORIA AND HER GRANDDAUGHTERS

Patients usually like a bed by the window but in this case, it matters little. The curtains are closed. It's too bright, says Victoria. She lies in bed, IV in her arm, her eyes half open. People call this the best hospital in Tanjung Karang, but Victoria's room is depressingly dim. Tacky, even, with its pale green walls, faded and peeling, and the bulb flickering overhead. There are two beds: one empty—the patient occupying it has been discharged—and one by the window, where Victoria lies. Her granddaughters Mutiara, Maya, and Annisa concur: Nana is about to die.

This is a tale of three sisters, granddaughters to Victoria. Legend has it she can shapeshift. At least, that's what people say.

Mutiara, the eldest at thirteen, stands to Victoria's right, between the bed and nightstand, ready to fetch water, the Qur'an, anything her grandmother needs. On the table sits a pack of kretek, but no lighter. Victoria's children scolded their mother, but she merely waved her hand: Oh, stop fussing. You can't stand to see me enjoy myself, can you? Don't worry, I won't smoke.

Annisa, age seven, begins to appreciate the precariousness of the situation and clings to the hem of her eldest sister's skirt. Mindful of her duties, Mutiara is alert: serving Nana, protecting her little sis.

To Victoria's left stands Maya, age eleven, carrying a novel but not reading it. Usually, at family gatherings she escapes into books, enjoying the company of fictional families over that of her own. Now she keeps her head down, clings to her grandmother's hand, and tries to hide her tears.

Mutiara, lips pursed, steals a glance at Maya, shakes her head slowly, and fixes her with a disdainful look: crybaby.

It isn't Nana who believes that her time has come, but her children. We must be prepared for the worst, said the aunties and uncles.

This has caused the three girls to argue in the gloomy hospital corridor, on the way to their grandmother's room. The hallway lights are forlorn, dirty and flickering, pleading for replacement. The girls are grateful to visit during the day, for in the evening, when the lights flicker more wildly—dark, bright, dark—who knows who might walk by, a nurse or kuntilanak?

The grownups are unreasonable, says Maya. Why are they telling us to get ready? Do they hope Nana will die soon?

Maya rages on, always the first to raise a fist. On this day, seeds of hatred toward the aunties and uncles sprout. But Mutiara, the most mature, chides her:

If we're not ready, who'll take care of the body? Clean the house? Find the best spot in the cemetery?

So you've already thought about it too?

Maya is incensed, maybe because she fancies herself the most special granddaughter. She picks up the pace, leaving her siblings behind. Meanwhile, Mutiara folds her arms, sympathetic but condescending; her sister can be so childish. Once in Victoria's room, they quiet down. Though the three girls bicker regularly, in front of their grandmother, they are docile, whether out of love or fear.

Lying on her bed, Victoria slowly opens her eyes and surveys her granddaughters. Was she asleep? She seems perpetually watchful, even when weak. In a gravelly voice, thick as kretek smoke, laced with betel nut, she asks archly:

Is this some kind of party? How come you're all here?

Maya bursts into tears.

Victoria looks at her and smiles.

Hey now, don't cry, she says. You need to be strong. Like Muti.

Victoria asks for something to drink. Mutiara pours warm water from a thermos, and Maya helps her grandmother lean back onto her pillow. Nana avoids speaking of death, avoids beginning with, *When my time comes.*

Nevertheless, her words will prove unforgettable. Each sister receives a message they carry into adulthood.

Don't argue. You have to take care of each other, says Nana. Now where are my kretek?

Mutiara gapes. Maya sets her book down at the foot of the bed, shaking her head. Sternly, Nana slaps the mattress.

I can't think properly without a cigarette in my hand!

Hesitantly, Mutiara slides a kretek from the pack on the table. Without lighting it, Nana slips it between her fingers, then stares at the ceiling, lost in thought.

The words come then, words her granddaughters will remember forever:

Each of you has your own path. One shall go off to see the world. One shall go in search of God. And one shall protect the house, watching over all.

The girls regard their grandmother with reverence, and confusion. Mutiara and Maya trade glances. Annisa's eyes widen.

You, my little bookworm, shall be a traveler, says Victoria. You will go far away, to foreign lands.

Maya raises her head, unable to conceal her astonishment.

Nana, how do you know?

Oh, I can see lots of things, my love.

So what do you see?

You, on a boat. With books.

Victoria twirls the cigarette between her fingers and closes her eyes for a moment. Then she turns to Annisa. Her voice softens:

You, my sweet child. I see you in a long white gown, like a princess, garlands of jasmine in your hair. You will be a beautiful bride.

The two older girls observe Annisa. It's easy to imagine the prophecy coming true. Annisa appears pleased, happy at the word *princess*.

And you . . .

Now Victoria takes her eldest granddaughter's hand, contemplating the lines on her palm. Her labored breaths turn into coughing, and she lets the hand drop. Looking worried, Mutiara fetches water. Her grandmother can't die now. She hasn't received her message yet.

But then: Mutiara. You are the strongest. Listen carefully. You will be a caretaker.

Mutiara seems unimpressed.

A caretaker? As in a cleaner? Maya can't resist asking.

Could be, says Nana. Or a gravedigger.

Victoria cackles. Maya and Annisa try to suppress grins, but Mutiara is not amused. Victoria keeps chuckling, her guffaws rising almost hysterically; almost choking her, until her granddaughters give her a drink and pat her on the back.

I'm not kidding, continues Victoria. Muti, you will protect your family. Look after the living, see off the dead.

Mutiara, Maya, Annisa: caretaker, traveler, bride—three girls, too young to understand that Victoria's words, precept and prophecy, might also be a curse.

Victoria doesn't die in that hospital. In fact, she will live another sixteen years. She knows full well her life won't end in 1991, in a room painted a sad, tacky green. She knows far more than her children and grandchildren, including when she will die. When the time comes, a beast within her will whisper: it's time to go. And she will be ready.

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YUSUF'S WELL

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THE TALE OF THE WELL; OR, HOW TO DISPOSE OF YUSUF

His father said: "My son, don't tell your brothers about your dreams, or they will plot to destroy you. For truly, Satan is the enemy of humankind."
(Yusuf: 5)

They said, "Oh, Father! What happened was this: we had a race and left Yusuf by our things, and he was eaten by wolves; of course, you won't believe us, and yet we speak the truth."
(Yusuf: 17)

Victoria's House, that is what the three granddaughters call Nana's residence in Tanjung Karang. Pass through the yard until you arrive at a door of teak, polished red, and there you shall see a nameplate. Cursive lettering proclaims: *Hajjah Victoria, daughter of Haji Tjek Sun*. Nana installed the plate shortly after Grandpa died. If nosy neighbors ask why it bears her name and not her husband's, she says, My husband is dead, and I'm no freeloader. I inherited this house from my mother. Then she points at the photo of her late husband, hanging on the living room wall and has the visitor offer a prayer: Bismillah, Al-Fatihah, for the spirit of our deceased grandfather, Haji Hasan Abdullah, now a guest in Victoria's House.

Let us agree that to open the red door into Victoria's House means to enter a storyland, for so many tales are scattered there. Tales half true, tales half untrue, tales hidden, tales just waiting to be told. In the eyes of the three sisters, Nana's house is wondrously large, maybe even twice the size of their home in Jakarta. The girls love playing on the shady verandah and climbing the starfruit tree in the front yard. But it is the back of Nana's house that seems the most magical, with its mossy well and ancient kitchen, hidden from the light of day. Mutiara and Maya find

themselves drawn there, for separate reasons, whereas Annisa is disgusted at the black grime along the bottom of the well wall. Yuck.

The well is a novel sight for Jakarta-bred children, but they have never seen Nana or her helper, Mak Romlah, draw water; the municipal supply flows freely from the taps. Alongside the well, Mak Romlah squats and scrubs clothes on a board. Once, Mutiara asks, Mamak, why don't you use a washing machine? Mak Romlah replies that a machine's no match for washing by hand.

The well, overgrown by moss, has long dried up. The sisters, fascinated, often peer inside and speculate:

There's something moving.

What? What is it?

A demon.

Liar!

In contrast to Papa and Mama, who have a single kitchen in their small Jakarta home, Nana has two. The wet kitchen lies a few steps away. The dry kitchen, adjacent to the dining room, modern, bright, tiled, is a place to bake Dutch cookies and cakes. The wet kitchen is banished to the rear, as if it bears some mark of shame. Its cement floor is blackened and cold, and so muddy at times that the three girls must wear sandals to walk on it. All is shadowy; sunbeams enter, half-hearted, as if hesitant to bring to light its peculiar cookware: enormous black kuali, nested in stacks. They remind the girls of witches' cauldrons—shallower, but just as sinister. What's Nana cooking? It's a secret.

Chop up the baby, cook it in the pot.

Chop up the baby, cook it in the pot.

Mutiara and Maya practise a singsong chant, frightening their sister, for they know both the kitchen and Nana make Annisa tremble in fear.

Victoria sometimes prepares vatfuls of rendang, especially on Eid al-Fitr, when she and Mak Romlah cook for a hundred: relatives from Palembang, Muara Enim, Ogan Komering Ulu, friends from Padang Panjang.

The back of the house is reserved for the adults, with the children forbidden from playing near the well without supervision. Especially when Mak Romlah is washing; they could slip on the wet floor! The well is deep. Victoria does not want her granddaughters monkeying around, or

sitting beside it. What if one fell in and broke her neck, became a helpless chick at death's door? But to children a warning is an invitation: the more something's off limits, the more curious they become. At midday, when the house goes quiet, when Victoria is sewing, Mak Romlah resting and Annisa napping, Mutiara and Maya sneak to the wet kitchen. Mutiara adores studying the jars on the shelf—dried shallots, ginger, turmeric, galangal, nutmeg—and imagines how fun cooking would be. She has little experience; their mother doesn't cook, and Victoria makes Mutiara a spectator, only allowing her to chop a carrot or two. Maya shows no interest in such things. What catches her attention is unclear, but she circles the kitchen, pondering the implements of all shapes and sizes, before heading to the well. Some days she stares into it, entranced. Maya, the dreamer. Maybe she's concocting a wild tale about her grandmother—Victoria the witch, frying up tender human flesh on a colossal skillet.

But one fateful day, Victoria's well gives rise to a tale of its own. It changes everything, and afterward, Mutiara and Maya will no longer frequent the well. It's the year before Victoria will be admitted to the hospital for a stroke. The well becomes a silent witness. Trace the dreams and desires of children, and you'll discover how cruel they can be.

The two girls stand by the well, peering down. Though two years apart, Maya is already as tall as her older sister. Mutiara believes that her growth has been stunted because Mama made her carry baby Annisa around at the tender age of six. What brought the sisters here, exactly, and how they came to be discussing such things, we do not know. It remains anybody's guess who took the first step, and it is not clear who suggested what. But suddenly their voices form a chorus, in harmony, rising in evil intent.

Here? asks Mutiara.

Yes.

The pair seem lost in thought, Mutiara crossing her arms, and Maya drumming her fingers on the edge of the well.

Here, next week. When Nana's away in Padang, says Maya. We'll have Annisa go down by a ladder.

And then we take the ladder away?

Exactly.

We can say it's a game of hide and seek, says Mutiara. But it won't be long before she'll call us. Then she'll cry. And scream.

The real question: How long should they leave her there?

Nearly every school holiday the three sisters stay at Victoria's House. The month in Tanjung Karang delights Nana and her granddaughters and gives the girls' parents a welcome respite. Nana pays for the food, and Papa and Mama need only prepare a little pocket money. In past years, squabbles between the girls have hardly been uncommon, but they're nothing compared to what's going on this time, in 1990. When Mutiara, Maya, and Annisa get out of the car and the gate to Victoria's House swings open, their cold war spreads to Tanjung Karang.

At the end of the school term, Victoria went to Jakarta to pick the girls up, as always. She enjoys travel, and her oldest son, Sulaiman, is too busy to drop them off himself. Victoria covers her own costs, well aware that she has more saved up than her son, who has three daughters to raise in addition to supporting his siblings through college. Victoria and her granddaughters cross the Sunda Strait by ferry. She has her own standards. Flights are expensive, and she refuses to escort her granddaughters to the port by bus and drown amidst a sea of riff-raff, tormented by their sweat and stinking feet. Sulaiman drives his mother and daughters to the harbor at Merak. When they disembark at Bakauheni, a neighbor of Victoria's is there to meet them. Victoria happily reimburses the full cost of petrol—let me know if it's not enough, I'm an old lady, she says—and the neighbor is content. He often entrusts his own toddler to Victoria's care.

During the cold war in Tanjung Karang, it's our little sister, Annisa, who is marked out as the enemy. She doesn't seem to understand, or pretends she doesn't. As usual, she tags after Mutiara and Maya, but the older girls look annoyed. Victoria catches whiff of this war. She summons Mutiara and Maya, and Mutiara explains what had happened before Nana brought them to Tanjung Karang. Annisa did a—a violation, says Mutiara; a crime, Maya contributes. The little girl poured insect repellent in Kitty's dish. Kitty is her older sisters' cat. The carcass was found the next day, under a pile of rags near the washing machine, giving off an overpowering stench. At the discovery, Mutiara let out piercing howl.

Nana's gaze is piercing now, her jaw clenched, the lines of her face more severe. She sits up and folds her hands.

How did things get so bad? she asks. What did you do?

Maya turns bright red at her grandmother's question.

Why do you assume we're to blame? she asks indignantly.

The girls outline how the fight started. Mutiara and Maya had taken turns reading Annisa's diary aloud, mocking parts they considered silly, like when Annisa was jealous of her neighbor's new clothes, or thought of herself as a princess. *One day Annisa will meet a prince. The prince will want to marry Annisa. Because Annisa is very beautiful.* Mutiara and Maya burst into laughter. Annisa cried, but her sisters didn't apologize. Somehow the quarreling continued, the girls jeering and shouting at each other until Maya poured an entire bottle of talcum powder—only baby powder, mind you, not baby pig's blood—over Annisa's head. The youngest ran to Papa to tattle, but he had just come home from work and, exhausted, merely said, Girls, try not to fight.

Kitty was found dead the next day.

Annisa protested her innocence, declaring to her father that she had been playing, that she hadn't hurt Kitty on purpose. Kitty kept meowing—she had to give her medicine to help her sleep. Papa scolded Annisa until she cried, but she wasn't punished. Instead, there she was, playing sweetly with her own cat, Mimi, whom she'd gotten for her birthday—so she wouldn't have to share with the older girls. Mutiara and Maya, now catless, could only grit their teeth in fury: justice had not been upheld! Is not a cat's life as valuable as a human's? If Papa had been fair, Annisa would have been grounded and not allowed to come to Tanjung Karang.

Victoria falls silent. She tells the two girls to play on the terrace, then rises, goes to the cupboard where the phone is kept and dials Sulaiman. They speak for a long time, and Nana summons Annisa to her room. Mutiara and Maya wonder—is Nana handing down a sentence, or simply reprimanding Annisa and letting her get away with her crime?

The sisters don't believe they can rely on Nana to act fairly.

One hour, says Mutiara. That's how long we'll leave her in the well.

An hour? Maya disagrees. That's not long enough!

Can you stand to hear her cry all day?

We'll turn the TV up. Loud.

Mutiara mulls. What if Nana comes home?

Muti, don't you know where Padang is? There's no way she'll be back so fast. The only one at home will be Mamak.

And Rohadi? asks Mutiara. What about him? I always feel like he's spying on us. He's sure to tell Mamak.

Rohadi's on our side.

Maya sounds so sure. Rohadi, Mamak's son, their loyal sentinel, never snitches. He knows how to keep a secret. He supports revolution.

But forget about Rohadi for now. The harmony between them falters, discord creeping into their song. They debate the terms of punishment. How long is too long, or too short? Why only one day? When this question is raised—by Maya or Mutiara, who knows—new possibilities present themselves. Why only a day and not—

Forever?

This new path, should they follow it, is genuinely terrifying.

If we leave Annisa more than a day, she'll die.

If she dies, what'll we do?

If she dies, and the police come, what'll we say?

If she dies, and the police come, we'll hide.

If she dies, and the police come, and we get caught, Nana will disown us. So will Papa and Mama. We'll go to jail.

If she dies, and the police come, and we get caught and go to jail, I wonder if we'll feel sorry?

Mutiara and Maya pause, deflated by the thought of Annisa's death. They explore other options:

How about we take her on a minibus to the market and leave her there? A rich merchant can find her and take her home with him.

Brilliant! The end. And they all lived happily ever after. Forever.

Girls, where's Annisa?

Mutiara and Maya jump. They turn to find Victoria's head, then body, emerging from the kitchen's dark depths. She stares straight at her granddaughters, arms crossed, a kretek between her fingers. The girls look at her, guilty and silent. They've strayed too far—down an unfamiliar path, a path with possibilities previously unthinkable—and now they are being dragged back to face Nana.

Where's Annisa? she asks again.

She takes a deep drag on her kretek and exhales. The smoke becomes a gray, gauzy veil. Nana is obscured but her voice resounds.

She's playing, answers Mutiara, her voice squeaking like a mouse. At a neighbor's.

Don't just leave your sister any old place. Call her back. Take Rohadi with you.

Victoria returns to her dark kitchen, like a prima donna who has had her fill of applause, striding behind the curtain, away from the glare of the stage lights.

The encounter leaves both girls startled, unsure of how to face Victoria. And they don't have much time. They retreat from the well and fetch Annisa from where she is playing with the four-year-old girl next door. On the way, Mutiara and Maya chat furtively. What did Nana hear? How did she appear so suddenly? Neither of them noticed her entering the kitchen, or even if she had been there for the entire conversation.

Does Nana know about their wicked plan?

Maya reminds her sister about the rumors in the family: Nana knows everything, can hear anything, is everywhere. Nana is half-tiger, half--human—a weretiger spirit; a shapeshifter.

That night, everyone in Victoria's House convenes in the living room for Isya prayers. Standing at the front, on a maroon velvet prayer rug on which is woven an image of the Ka'bah, Nana leads the miniature congregation: the granddaughters wearing white mukena embroidered with pink flowers; Rohadi in his checked sarong of faded green, and Mamak in her own mukena, a yellowed white. After salat and a series of prayers, the women take copies of the Qur'an from the cupboard and distribute them to the children. That night everyone reads in turn from the surah of Yusuf. Annisa has just learned the Arabic alphabet, and Mutiara and Maya completed their first full reading of the Qur'an last year, although they have yet to study the individual chapters. As Nana begins the story, her granddaughters listen attentively. They've heard the tale of Prophet Yusuf once or twice, but the way their teachers told it was dull. From Victoria's lips, the first part, about Yusuf's separation from his family becomes mesmerizing. And it goes something like this:

One day, Yusuf tells his father, Yakub, *Oh, Father, truly I dreamed I saw eleven stars, and the sun and moon; I saw them bow down to me.* His father is stunned. So his son has been chosen by God. Just like himself, and their forefathers, Ishak and Ibrahim. The eleven stars must be Yusuf's brothers. Yakub imagines the envy on their faces. If they learn of this dream, Yusuf might meet a bad end. *Do not speak of your dream to your brothers*, counsels Yakub. *Should Satan incite them, they would conspire to do away with you. For truly, Satan is the enemy of man.*

Elsewhere, Yusuf's older brothers gather and plot. *Father loves Yusuf and Bunyamin more than the rest of us. Verily, Yusuf is in manifest error.* They come to an agreement: *Let's eliminate Yusuf. Kill him, or send him far away. Thus shall Father's love be shed only upon us.*

Tell me, children, how can his brothers hold such a wicked conversation? And where? Their room isn't big enough for a meeting of ten (Bunyamin is a good lad and doesn't join in). Maybe they went into the forest, to practice hunting, and found a well there. Maybe they sat at this well, peering into it, when inspiration came.

Now these brothers think they're real cool, bragging and boasting and acting like thugs. A far cry from Yusuf, the most handsome man in all creation, lest we forget. You know, countryfolk believe that if a pregnant woman reads the surah of Yusuf, she'll give birth to a handsome boy. (Which is a load of rubbish. If that were all it took, there wouldn't be any ugly people around!)

Victoria returns to the story:

Satan lives at the bottom of a well, stirring humankind to evil. But where does injustice come from? Isn't the father also to blame?

The thug-brothers argue heatedly, for Satan is at work among them. After all, to do away with a younger sibling is no mean feat.

Let's not kill him, says one. *There shall be too much blood. Let us toss him into the well. Later a wayfarer shall pull him up.* Thus, the brothers carry out their devious plan, asking Father's permission to bring Yusuf along with them.

Yakub is worried, but trusting his son's fate to Allah, he merely tells them: *Do not be careless and allow him to be eaten by wolves.*

And so, the brothers return home at dusk, wailing. They hand over Yusuf's shirt, stained with blood.

Yusuf is indeed discovered by travellers. They hoist him up and sell him in the city for a few meagre dirhams. And who should buy him but an Egyptian official, who takes him into his home.

Sadaqallahul azim. Almighty Allah has spoken the truth.

The lesson is over. We shall continue tomorrow.

No lengthy sermon is given. The surah of Yusuf is long enough—111 verses—and all manner of tales within them, stories of slave traders and seductresses. They will read more tomorrow. Victoria rises and folds her prayer mat.

But Nana, ventures Mutiara. What if someone has a sister who steals? Or lies? What if she's wicked?

If she is wicked, it is because you don't look after her, Nana replies.

With Mamak's help, Victoria returns the copies of the Qur'an to the cupboard. She then turns on the television and sits on the sofa. In half an hour she will watch the news on TVRI, but, as she waits, she works on a crossword from the morning paper. Mutiara follows and sits beside her grandmother.

This time she asks: What if she kills an entire village?

Then why did you let it happen?

Mutiara falls silent. Victoria adjusts her glasses, then reads the clue for 3-across: Act that violates God's laws or religion. What's the answer, Muti?

Mutiara has no reply.

Victoria returns to her crossword. You sisters must care for each other, she says.

And so, this is the tale of the well, the tale of Yusuf. A cautionary tale. Do not wrong your sibling. Do not stand by the well, for Satan dwells below, prowling in the dark, waiting for the right moment to whisper in your ear.

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THE CARETAKER

Ayat al-Kursi

Sh. The plane is about to take off for Jakarta, and here I sit, recalling a crossword from long ago. Whenever I feel agitated, before take-off and landing, I recite a prayer. *Ayat al-Kursi*, my mother's prayer: The Verse of the Throne.

The plane starts to taxi. From behind the sunglasses shielding my puffy eyes, I look out the window, but there's nothing to see, except the airport terminal, and a barren field, dry and brown beneath the blazing sun. After I identified the body, I decided to return to Jakarta the next day. I have work I can't put off, a father to visit at the hospital, children I need to feed.

I've always been afraid of dying in a plane crash. God can call us home any time, preachers say, but I'm afraid of dying weighed down by my sins. I've long refused to think of faith as a matter of simple binaries: reward and punishment, Jannah and Jahannam, Heaven and Hell. No more religious teachers frightening me with images of Hell filled with people roasting in fire, only to be revived for a neverending cycle of torment.

And yet, after Annisa, after what she did . . . I can't die now. I can't appear before Allah in this state of shame, in rags. Imagine the look on His face: despite all His kneading, the bread failed to rise. I, who have been dutiful in praying, in reading His verses—a colossal flop. But hadn't I made up for the errors of my childhood ways—those vicious thoughts at the well—by caring for my family, my sister included?

I'm not the one who blew myself up and took others with me.

As a flight attendant tells us to fasten our seat belts, the voice of another woman, older, sterner, echoes in my ears: *if your sister kills everyone in the village, you're the one to blame.*

I recite the Ayat al-Kursi even though I probably don't deserve Allah's protection. My mother, from the world beyond, smiles scornfully. I imagine her asking, *Remember this verse?*

I have never forgotten it, Mama. Please forgive me. But if I die now, my hands will be covered in blood.

I still have so many questions. But I just want to wrap things up as quickly as possible.

This morning, after leaving the morgue, Suparto requested I come along to the police station to provide an official statement. It wasn't far, just next to the mosque beside the hospital. Perhaps I looked pale—he offered me a drink. I politely declined and got out my water bottle from my bag.

"When did you last see the perpetrator and her family?" he asked.

Perpetrator. I would have to get used to the term.

I told him Annisa and her daughter had come to Jakarta a month ago, to visit our father in the hospital. As for her husband, I couldn't remember the last time I saw him.

Annisa had asked if my father's treatment was covered by insurance.

"For the most part," I told her. "But some medications aren't."

After her visit, Annisa had transferred a substantial sum of money to my account. Three times more than what she had been sending.

Suparto jotted that down. I wondered why the excessive amount hadn't raised questions for me at the time.

"Did she talk to you at all about religious study groups she had joined? Or new organizations? Anything like that?"

I shook my head. We'd only talked about my father's illness, the doctor's diagnosis, the usual conversation topics for two people in an ICU waiting room. I had asked about her children and she had given standard answers: Gibran would be in fifth grade soon, Patricia would enter preschool next year.

"Did she mention any names? Religious teachers, friends, neighbors?"

Again, I shook my head.

"Did you know she was involved with Jamaah Junud Al-Huriya?"

The water bottle in my hand began to tremble. I didn't know which mosque she attended in Kotawijaya, or who any of her friends were. I

barely knew her husband, even though they had been married for a decade. I tried to remember, but it was as if all my memories of Annisa were stuck in the past: either in childhood when the three of us were inseparable despite our squabbles, or in adolescence, when she became obsessed with the idea of being a princess. After marriage, life changed for her. She had two small children to care for. It was to be expected: getting married meant becoming someone's wife, becoming someone else. Then there was me: busy with office work and caring for our parents, no one's wife.

Suparto asked other questions, but, again, I couldn't offer any answers. My conversations with her as an adult had consisted of a string of *as-salamu alaykum, how are you, everything's fine. He's just started school. Did you hear so-and-so passed away?* I sat there, childhood memories playing in the background, like a song on repeat.

Finally, Suparto stopped. He must have realized there was little use in talking to me. The conversation ended on a practical note.

"So, what would you like to do, Ma'am? Will you take the body with you?"

"What are the others doing?" I asked.

He paused, confused perhaps about whom I meant by "the others." With whom was I identifying—the relatives of the bombers or those of the innocent?

"The victims are being dealt with by their families," he said. "The bodies of the perpetrators—so far no one's claimed them."

"And if no one comes?"

"Then we'll have to make arrangements ourselves. We'll probably bury them somewhere here."

So, the other bombers' families had distanced themselves. Only I had come to the hospital to associate myself with the cursed event. How shameless I must be. Maybe, in my desperation, I thought coming here would give me something to cling to, some clue as to why this happened, or how I could set life back on track. I just wanted everything to go back to how it was. To be normal again.

I never dreamed that one day I would be burying my little sister. I didn't know where, or how. Suddenly the voices of my aunts and cousins filled my ears. I imagined my eldest aunt's objections if I buried her in

Tanjung Karang: How dare you bury her anywhere near my mother? Then I imagined what my cousin would say, with his expertise in Islamic law: As long as she's a believer, her body must be taken care of.

"I'll leave it to you," I told Suparto at last.

Suparto promised to let me know where Annisa and her family would be buried. At least that was one problem solved. When you spend your whole life looking after your family, you learn it's best for most matters to be dealt with as quickly as possible. Even after everything is neat and tidy, something new is bound to fall apart.

The plane has taken off.

I recall the words of the Prophet: *If you read Ayat al-Kursi, Allah will protect you until morning comes and not even Satan will disturb your sleep.*

And God does protect me—at least until the seat belt sign switches off. Or perhaps Ayat al-Kursi has rescued me too late. Satan stirred my sister to sin, and maybe even now he whispers in my ear.

What kind of Islam did you follow, Annisa? I think of Surah Al-Kafirun: *Lakum diinukum wal liya diin*—you to your religion, and me to mine. Yet I can't help but wonder: *Why, Annisa? Why did you do this? When you killed everyone in the village, what verse was running through your head?*

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THE TRAVELER

Three Sisters

For the most part, siblings in stories come in threes. A few tales do feature pairs—say, Garlic White and Onion Red. But it's the odd number that has a magic to it. That's why you get three witches prophesying in Macbeth. And the three maiden sisters—Nunung, Nana, and Neni—of Umar Ismail's beloved film. I could go on: Goneril, Regan, and Cordelia; Olga, Masha, and Irina; and Mutiara, Maya, and Annisa. Of course. Little wonder then that, when Annisa was little, she loved playing Cinderella, dressing up as the youngest, the soon-to-be princess. None of us could remember the names of the jealous older two, but I'm sure one was kind of out there—Barbarella, maybe?

At school, whenever we were told to write an essay about "A Visit to Grandma," I'd change the title: "Playing Pretend at Victoria's House." All three of us. Four, actually, with Rohadi in the role of oldest stepsister. I'd be Stepsister Number Two, the middle one, acting important but ignored by all. We always cast Mutiara as the stepmother since she was a pissy control freak. Annisa was obsessed with playing Cinderella, again and again. She only lost interest when I told her the ending that gets left out: the princess gets pregnant every year and dies giving birth to her umpteenth child. Massive loss of blood. Bang, dead just like that. After hearing my version, Annisa moved on from glass slippers to tales of other princesses. Meanwhile, Mutiara and I moved on to adolescence, busying ourselves with other things besides playing pretend. Mutiara experimented with baking while I holed up in my room, reading for days on end. Make up your own drama, I advised Annisa. Try something new. What about a revolution against colonial oppressors? You can skip the Prince Charming, Happily Ever After bullshit.

That was the first time Annisa heard the word. *Revolution.*

Yes, revolution. Losers always want revolution.

My sister fell silent. After that she stopped whining about wanting to play-act.

Mutiara asked what was up with Annisa, and I said revolution didn't seem to interest her. She was too beautiful, too sweet, too loved, and she got her every wish. Only the oppressed have revolution on their minds. Why would the rich and beautiful want change?

That's when I said it:

"Revolutions always begin with ugly stepsisters."

I believed in this statement with all my heart and would declare it in front of everyone—Mutiara, Rohadi, my classmates—repeatedly and urgently, as such credos deserve. I continued to live it after my sisters and I parted ways. I went left, Mutiara went right, and Annisa . . . I have no idea where she went.

"Maya, where are you?"

This is the question Mutiara asks me now. Everyone is always asking me this question, or similar ones: *Where are you? Where were you? Where will you go now?*

I'm here. In my apartment, going to and fro between kitchen and bed. I know I often irritate everyone with my wandering. I'm neither here, nor there, nor anywhere at all.

When I finally reached my sister, she was in a hotel room in Kotawijaya. She had left our dying father in the hospital, taken a night flight from Jakarta, and met the police the next morning to identify the body. The first thing she did was blame me. When there's a crisis, someone has to be at fault. If we're not willing to flagellate ourselves, then we have to decide who that someone is.

"You're not here. You're never here."

She's furious at me for not picking up before, when she needed me most. I let her vent; she had the right to. I didn't tell her about blacking out.

"You didn't have to go, Muti," I say.

"Meaning?"

"I read the news. No one else from the bombers' families went."

But maybe a few had gone, discreetly, like Mutiara, risking the shame—of being questioned by police and hounded by journalists, not to mention coming face-to-face with the victims' families.

"I did the wrong thing? Is that what you're saying?" asks Mutiara. "Just like our crazy relatives?"

"I meant—"

"You're drunk, aren't you?"

The wine bottle on my desk is almost empty. But that's none of her business.

"You're making it harder for yourself," I sigh.

"You think I enjoy this?"

I didn't answer.

Has she forgotten? I was by the well with her that day, when we both promised to look after Annisa. It was a promise I couldn't keep because I left. Maybe I'm an asshole, but I consider pointing out that Annisa went astray under her watch.

"I'm all alone," says Mutiara softly.

"I know . . . "

"Not that you'd be any help if you were here."

There it is again. That sharp tongue of hers. I don't blame her. No matter what the situation, she's always on hand, ready to clean up, like some sleek state-of-the-art vacuum cleaner, pulverizing trash, sucking up crumbs, without so much as a second thought. Abracadabra. Everything spotless. Immaculate. My sister genuinely can't stand the sight of dirt. She won't rest until everything is in order.

"Muti . . . did you see—"

"Annisa?" she asks, cutting me off. "What do you think?"

Suddenly my sister bursts into a long, cruel cackle she herself can't seem to stop, until her voice begins to go hoarse. I shudder. I've never heard her laugh like that before.

"You're so naive, it's pathetic," she says. "It must be nice living abroad, never having to start your day cleaning up shit and blood."

Once we hang up, I bury my face in Nadir's arms. All I want is to stop shaking, just for a moment, to feel strangely, and inappropriately, calm.

He strokes my hair and I feel myself curling up, thinking of home. I've been on the run too long. Would going home be so bad?

Stop sniveling, hisses my grandmother's voice, out of nowhere. *Crybaby*, it sneers. *Look at you. Only partway through your journey and you're whining to go home, throwing yourself into the arms of another woman's man.*

I cover my ears. The Nana in my head thinks she knows everything. Nadir's just a transit lounge, not a home. He hasn't even told his wife he wants a divorce, and I feel like a debt collector every time the subject comes up. Before long, he'll slip from my grasp, like the other chicks cheeping at the dining table, dropping dead one by one. What do I have left?

There's my writing. And my memories of Victoria.

I'm reminded of the main reason I'm here in this city: I'm writing a book about my grandmother. I have to keep writing, but here's Annisa's ghost, dragging her own story in. I imagine launching my book and someone emerging from the crowd to ruin everything: *why this story in particular? Oh, and what about your sister? You know, the mass-murdering suicide bomber?*

If only I could erase Annisa's story, but see how it trickles then flows. I don't know how to staunch it.

"Are you all right?"

In Nadir's arms, I blubber like a child.

"My book," I wail. "What's the point?"

Everything I do from now on will be worthless. I will carry the mark of Annisa wherever I go now, like a bloodstain. Everything that hasn't yet exploded has already crumbled to dust.

"You'll keep writing, Maya," whispers Nadir. "Just not now."

Why do I struggle to believe him when they say that to all things there is a season? A time to write. A time to look in the mirror. A time for the mirror to crack.

In the middle of the night, my phone rings. Nadir is sitting at my desk as I lie in bed, staring at the ceiling.

"I just got home," says Mutiara.

"You're back in Jakarta?"

"Who else is going to look after Papa? And my cats?"

Mutiara sounds defensive but calmer than the day before. She gives me a rundown: the investigation is ongoing, but the police have said they'll handle the bodies of Annisa and the other suicide bombers.

"Is Gibran still in the hospital?"

"I guess," she says. "I don't have to deal with that, too, do I?"

I don't know what to say. We lapse into awkward silence.

"So when are you coming home?" she asks.

I give a date, ten days from now. There's no hurry, is there? Annisa's already dead and there's no burial to attend. What's left for us to do—apart from reopening old wounds and weeping behind closed doors for a sister undeserving of grief? Maybe I'm going home purely for Mutiara's sake, and my father's. It might be the last time I see his face.

I don't mention that Nadir is returning to Indonesia in ten days, and that I want to fly with him.

"Ten days?" says Mutiara drily. "You're something else, Maya."

Then, just as she's done on our calls in the past, my sister ends the conversation without saying goodbye.

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THE BRIDE

Goes International

RADICAL COUPLE INVOLVED CHILDREN IN BOMBINGS
Priya Mukherjee, UK Broadcasting Service, 14 May 2018

Kotawijaya, Indonesia—A radical Islamic couple brought their children with them when carrying out suicide bombings on Sunday, 13 May 2018. One of the children, a nine-year-old boy, escaped death by fleeing from his father's motorbike; the other child, a two-year-old girl, died with her mother.

At a recent press conference, the Chief of Indonesia's National Police confirmed that a total of six people had carried out the bombings, which targeted two churches and a multipurpose hall, leaving twelve dead and forty injured.

Indonesian President Joko Widodo condemned the attack as "cowardly" and promised to push for the passage of a new anti-terrorism law to combat militant networks. Police speculate that the bombings were carried out by the Jamaah Junud Al-Huriya group, suspected to have connections to ISIS.

According to the national police chief, the bombs contained triacetone triperoxide, an explosive also known as the "Mother of Satan," often used by ISIS.

TRAVEL ADVISORY FOR BALI AFTER INDONESIA TERROR ATTACK
Michael Nash, *Australian Daily*, 15 May 2018

The Australian government has issued a warning to its citizens visiting Bali . . . in the wake of a bombing . . .

12 dead and 40 injured

Kotawijaya, one of Indonesia's most important trading centers

Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade . . . travel advisory . . . Australian citizens . . . including Bali

Prime Minister Malcolm Turnbull

terrorist threat

"ISIS is still very dangerous."

"I condemn unreservedly . . .

. . . as President Joko Widodo has often said, such acts blacken the name of Islam."

Indonesia radical Islam Terrorism

. . . like the 2002 Bali bombings, which killed 202 . . .

a night club . . .

88 Australians dead . . .

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THE BRIDE

Was Not Poor

"I WOULD NEVER HAVE THOUGHT" SAYS MAYOR OF KOTAWIJAYA
Jakarta Raya, Monday, 14 May 2018

Yesterday evening, Kotawijaya Mayor Astrid Maharani visited the house where four of the bombers lived: Muhammad Fahri (34), his wife Annisa Dinda (34), and their two children, Gibran Fairuz (9) and Patricia Dinda (2). The family lived in the Melati Asri complex, a middle-class area.

"Frankly, I would never have thought that people so comfortable would want to cause others such harm," the mayor said to reporters, explaining that those involved in terrorist incidents typically lived in rented rooms and came from lower socioeconomic backgrounds. She admitted her surprise when she learned that the terrorist family was well-off.

"This pains me deeply," she said.

Under Mayor Astrid's leadership, Kotawijaya has experienced rapid economic growth. Particular attention has been paid to infrastructure, with the aim of encouraging investment. Her other initiatives include effective programs for dealing with school dropouts and a new campaign, currently in the works, called "Creative Kotawijaya."

KOTAWIJAYA CHURCH BOMBERS LIVED IN
ELITE AREA
The Gegar Tabloid, Monday, 14 May 2018.

Police officers are still keeping a tight watch over the house belonging to deceased suicide bombers Muhammad Fahri and Annisa Dinda, located

at Melati Asri Housing Block L No. 23, Jalan Bangunjiwo XII. Situated in an elite area of Kotawaijaya, East Java, the house boasts a secure gate and a covered terrace out front. On the left stands a garage. Not only did Annisa Dinda have a nice home, she drove to the bombing site with her daughter, Patricia, in a new Honda CRV.

"House prices here can reach two billion rupiah," said Alexander Kusworo, head of district RT5/RW3.

It was confirmed at a recent press conference that Densus 88, the police counterterrorism detachment, searched the house and found three plastic packages containing pipes. Each pipe was filled with the volatile explosive TATP, alias "Mother of Satan."

A plywood barrier and police tape now surround the former family home, in addition to armed guards. As of publication, the area is accessible only via a checkpoint monitored by federal and municipal authorities. Entry is restricted to residents and accredited journalists.

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THE CARETAKER

Broom and Cat

I open my front door to find Layla looking up at me expectantly, head tilted. She can always sense me coming, even before I open the gate. I bend down to stroke her glossy black fur, and she gives a soft purr of contentment despite the questioning look in her jade-green eyes. Her name is Layla because she arrived during Ramadan, on a night when the moon was shining brightly—a night believed to be full of blessing. Laylat al-Qadr, the Night of Power, a night worth a thousand moons of mercy, a thousand months of favor.

Sri has already come and gone. The house is clean and the children are fed. The glass I left on the table before heading to the airport has been washed and put away. Fragile objects can't be left out or they'll get knocked over by the cats. My home is practical, free of useless knick-knacks like the ones my mother owned—tiny crystal ornaments and porcelain souvenirs. I look around this morning and find everything in its place, unchanged. But, strangely, my house feels roomier. Spacious. Hollow, maybe. As if everything that has happened since Sunday never happened at all.

But it's not as if anyone has been here apart from me, Sri, and the cats. I walk to my room and nudge the half-open door. My three gingers leap out of bed and circle me, meowing noisily. Coco, Pico, and Cookie. They're siblings. I kiss each in turn and bury my face in their soft fur, as sweet-smelling as melted butter on popcorn. *Dear little babies, Mama is home.*

I set out their meals in the kitchen: four dishes all in a row. My children rush over. Then I remove my headscarf and get out the broom, even though Sri has already cleaned. It's an old habit. Whenever I come back from a trip, I engage in a ritual of return:

• Wash hands thoroughly
• Feed cats (wet food, with a few creamy tuna treats)
• Load dirty clothes into washing machine immediately (so suitcase won't smell)
• Dust table
• Sweep floor

Nana used to say that an empty house is just asking for some brazen spirit to set up residence—a djinn with kids, say. These superstitions of hers used to irritate me. Believing in ghosts is the first step toward sin and idolatry, toward worshipping gods besides Allah, for then we begin to hold other powers in fear and awe. Nevertheless, I still sweep. Organize, sanitize, straighten—then the heart will feel at ease.

Layla leaves her dish and follows me, as she always does when she sees me holding a broom. I shoo her away, but she persists. I bend down and stroke her again.

"Mommy's busy. She'll play later."

Layla retreats but keeps a close eye on me. Soon my living room returns to its usual state, with everything as it should be: me, my broom, and my black cat.

The next day, at the office, the world keeps turning, as if nothing had ever happened. As soon as I arrive, I head straight for the rest room, turn on the tap, and wash my hands—clear, cool water to wash the stains away. Then I apply lotion and, from my bag, I take out some perfume—one of my mother's favorite scents. I spray a little on my wrists, neck, and headscarf. Before leaving, I cast a backward glance at the sink, to make sure everything is clean and dry. I hate it when people drip.

In the corridor, interns nod deferentially. A few colleagues ask about my father. They know how much time I've been spending at the hospital. They have no reason to connect me with the bombings: in all my years here, I've never shown anyone photos of my parents or siblings, or told them their names. Now, I don't know whether to feel relieved or hurt.

Before I even reach my office, an intern pipes, "Don't forget, Ma'am. You have a meeting with the Singapore team at twelve."

"That's fine."

"Do you want to be tagged on the promotional materials for social media?"

"Tagged?"

"You know. Since you're the Senior Brand Manager."

"I'm not on social media."

"No Instagram? Twitter?"

"No."

"Oh, so you still use Facebook."

I fix him with a stare. "I'm afraid not."

I shut the door behind me. Sitting on my desk are reports I have to sign off on but have yet to touch. My eyes drift to the corner of my computer screen, to a folder I've titled "NZ." I still need to apply to the police for a certificate of good conduct. But after all that's been happening, maybe I should give up on the New Zealand idea. Maybe Allah doesn't approve, and these are all signs from Him, signs I've ignored, starting with my father's stroke.

Maybe I should have no desires at all.

There's an email from Afrida in my inbox, but I don't dare open it. I wonder if she knows about Annisa. She knows. She must. And I wonder if she's distraught, if she, like me, sees nothing but a dead end. Dreams staying dreams yet again.

I give into fear and choose an illogical detour: I open Alfrida's previous emails. I've kept them all, from last month, last year, years prior. It was fifteen years ago, as I worked alone in my cubicle—I didn't have my own office then—to the accompaniment of keyboards clacking on either side of me, that I read the message she sent from Wellington:

So this is what it feels like. I knew getting married wouldn't make me happy. But I never thought it would be this painful.

Tears come unbidden, dripping onto the desk. Hastily, I wipe them away and stare through the glass, at the sea of cubicles, at chairs and computers, at boxes—reminders of partitions and places.

Work, Muti. Work.

I stop by the hospital on the way home. Papa's the same as when I last saw him, in the ICU, on the same bed, hooked up to various machines. I

stand at the foot of his bed, watching the green lines on the screen. Sri visits when I can't make it, but I feel the need for an official update from the hospital staff. I ask the nurse if the doctor has been visiting every day.

"The doctor's monitoring for any changes," she replies.

I nod. We both know it's only a matter of time. What change for the better can I possibly hope for? How gaunt he is, and pale. His bones can barely support his frame, are ready to surrender. His face, lopsided, ashen, broken-down.

A memory of Annisa comes to me. She stood where I am now, at the foot of the bed, watching Papa sleep. Maybe she was praying. I had her go in alone because ICU patients aren't allowed more than one visitor at a time. One after the other, we went in to see Papa. I observed Annisa from behind the window to his room.

That was the last time I saw my sister alive.

I forget now what she was wearing, under the green hospital gown. With Papa so ill, I hardly paid attention to details like that. I do remember that she looked a little old, at only thirty-four. Maybe she was worn out from caring for the kids. The image of teenage Annisa, prettiest of us all, had faded. "Through the passage of time, surely humanity is in grave loss." So begins Surah Al-Asr. The best versions of ourselves are consigned to the past. Funny, then, that here I am, lingering on.

"Gibran is memorizing several surah," Annisa told me. "By junior high they're supposed to know the whole Qur'an by heart."

"Wow, terrific," I said.

"Alhamdulillah."

I'm not sure what insight I can glean from that interaction with Annisa. It's like when I speak to Papa, hoping he hears my voice: there are no signs. Or, at least, none that I can read.

I just want to get on with my life—the life I decided to postpone. But how do I move forward? I'm stuck asking myself *why*, instead of *where do I want to go?*

Before leaving the ICU, I draw closer to my father, but I don't touch him.

Ramadan begins tomorrow, Pa. Forgive me for my sins.

I'm still having trouble sleeping. For three nights now I've lain in bed tormented, awake but with my eyes shut, unable to sleep until four. Tonight's a little better. I manage to doze off at ten, but soon I wake up. At first, I think I've slept for a few hours, but my cellphone shows eleven.

I get up and go to the bathroom. I switch on the light, which is so bright that my body refuses to be lulled to sleep again. I get the broom from the kitchen. Before long, Layla appears behind me once more, to keep me company as I sweep. She often hides before suddenly showing up out of nowhere. She naps for hours during the day, then roams at night, presenting me with a dead mouse the next morning as a gift. The other three, Coco, Pico, and Cookie, have never done anything like that.

Layla arrived a year ago, when I found her asleep on my doorstep. I asked my neighbors if they knew of any lost cats and notified the community leader. After weeks of no one contacting me, I decided to adopt her. My neighbors say black cats bring bad luck, but I still remember how bright, how clear that night was, and the way her fur gleamed in the light of the full moon. At that moment, I knew something was going to change. I could feel it. I was welcoming in a new life, blessed not cursed, and this black cat was a secret message whispered by Allah on Laylatul Qadr.

When Papa fell in the bathroom soon after, my conviction wavered. Maya suggested that I might have misunderstood.

"Maybe your cat is from another sort of night," she said.

"Such as?"

"A night of a thousand hells."

Before Mama fell ill, I'd had even more cats. They had long drawn disapproval from my nosy relatives. When I bought this house, Papa pressured me to invite them to a family recitation of the Qur'an.

"Who ever heard of not blessing a new house?" Papa said. "Don't be so weird."

Funny he should call me weird when I was the most stable daughter he had, the one who shouldered most of the family expenses after his retirement, the most patient with his brothers and sisters. I did as he said, prepared a big meal, and invited the extended family. But even this made me no less "weird" to those meddlers, that gang of happiness thieves. Damn. I can't help but wonder if my house is still littered with strands of

their hair or dust from their clothes. I steal a glance at the space beneath the sofa and run the broom underneath.

"A two-bedroom house, and one bedroom is for a cat?" Wak Norma asked me that day.

I corrected her: "Five. I have five cats."

The house was full. My older cousin brought her three kids. Back then, Gibran was four or five years old. He wandered in and out of the kitchen, looking for Annisa, asking for cat food. "Mommy, the kitties are hungry," he said.

I stop sweeping and tighten my grip on the broom handle. I remember that, amid all the noise of my relatives, there was a lull. Then:

" . . . an old maid, living on her own. Her cats are her kids . . . "

Aunt Linda then broke into a loud laugh that filled the air. She was sitting on the larger sofa, Wak Norma to her left, a designer handbag taking up the seat on her right. She held a steaming bowl of fishcake soup in her hands, sweat beading on her forehead.

Meanwhile, Uncle Benny, on his way to the terrace for a smoke, conveyed his sympathies to my father: "You need to talk to Muti. No man will want her if she keeps living like an old witch."

Never mind that I could afford this house, unlike him, sponging off his in-laws, or Uncle Boy, who'd have wound up on the streets if his rich wife hadn't rescued him. Such people were beneath me. What did I care? I let them laugh away and amuse themselves. I didn't need to explain anything, not how I loved my cats as if I were their mother, or how I had nurtured them from infancy, or how I saw to their diet, took them for regular checkups, or selected the most comfortable blankets for them. Shortly after the gang of happiness bandits raided my house, I adopted two more cats. I became the mother of seven.

I never forgot Kitty, though. I never called any of my cats by the same name. A child can't be replaced. Once departed they don't return.

I let the broom drop to the floor and collapse on the couch.

On Thursday, the second day of Ramadan, I don't fast. Usually I leave for the office by 8:30 A.M., but today I feel dizzy and my whole body aches.

Maybe it's because I'm having my period. I ring the receptionist to let her know I'll be late.

From the sound of the faucet running in the kitchen, I know Sri has arrived. I sit down at the table to drink some water and eat some bread.

My phone rings. An unfamiliar male voice on the other end identifies himself as from the Kotawijaya police. He puts me on hold while he gets his superior.

"Good morning, Ms. Mutiara."

It's Suparto. His tone is formal but amiable. I want to sound the same way when I return his greeting, but my voice won't come and I squeak something instead.

"I'll get straight to the point," he says, sounding apologetic. "It's about the burial of your sister and her family. Something's come up."

Clutching the phone, my fingers go cold.

Suparto summarizes the situation, which I'll see repeated ad nauseum later on the news. My sister's grave has been dug, but it was filled in before she could be buried.

"The residents are protesting. They don't want suicide bombers buried in their area."

"So what will you do?"

"The municipal government is seeking advice from the Indonesian Ulema Council. We may have to find another site."

It never occurred to me that such a matter could drag on like this. Didn't the Prophet bid us bury a body as quickly possible? I thought I had sorted everything out. Now it feels like someone is pissing on a floor I've just swept clean.

After the call, I remain sitting, staring at the TV but not watching. I'm hungry but I can't even bring myself to chew.

I think of burying the dead, all the hassle it entails. Religious rituals aside, why have cemeteries at all? Some might even consider my sister and her family heroes. They'll visit the graves, build shrines. Who knows what the Devil will hiss in their ear. Wherever they bury my sister, the misguided will find her somehow.

It takes me a long time to realize that Sri has been standing there all this time, watching me as I gaze blankly at the TV, shredding bread into

crumbs, not taking a bite. She doesn't dare say anything, so I break the silence.

"How are you, Sri?"

Her eyes are full of tears. She knows.

I often forget that she's the same age as Annisa. Sri was fourteen when she started working for my parents. I was at university, but when I went home she treated me like an older sister, calling me "Mbak." My parents put her through high school and she graduated at eighteen. Shortly after that, some guy proposed. Then, ten years later, after divorcing her husband, she returned to us. Now that I pay her wages, she's taken to calling me "Ma'am." And I don't stop her.

"I saw the news," she says. "Ya Allah."

I nod, but I don't move from my seat. I think of Rohadi, our childhood friend, and his mother, Mak Romlah. Never once did we hug them. An invisible boundary separated us—one that couldn't be crossed. Unexpectedly, Sri dashes over and hugs me. I catch the scent of my mother's perfume, and I remember that Mama gave her some near-empty bottles when she fell ill. The sweet fragrance transports me back to the days when my mother was still in her prime—back when she had friends and connections, before poverty ate away at her skin and disease left her paralyzed in bed. I feel as if that version of her is with me now, not what she became before she died—Mama in a neat pencil skirt and high-heeled shoes, hair smelling nice. Mama, smiling at me. Mama, urging me to be strong. *Be strong, Muti.* I nod my head. I always listen to what she says.

I burst into tears, calling out for her. *Mama! Mama, don't go! Don't die. Don't leave me alone.*

But Mama isn't here. And I'm not crying.

"Sri, can you visit Father tomorrow?" I ask.

She quickly wipes her eyes and nods. "Are you traveling again, Ma'am?"

"Yes. There's something else I have to take care of."

I squeeze Sri's hand before finally getting up and going to my room.

Be strong, Muti. You're Mama's girl. You have to be strong. Even though Papa's at death's door and Annisa's blown herself to bits.

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The Tale of the Endless Road

So many nooks and crannies in Victoria's House, so many twists and turns. It's dizzying, disorienting, and in some cases, mysterious, like the black, mossy well by the kitchen out back.

This is a tale of three sisters, but don't believe everything I say. After all, childhood memories are deceptive. The world is more massive, more menacing, more magical when seen through the eyes of a child.

In the heat of the day, Nana's well seems to summon them, beckoning the girls to peer in and daydream. But at night, as everyone slumbers, strange sounds emerge—a tapping, a tossing of stones. One time, Nana's nephew, visiting from the village, hears lullabies, carried on the wind, wafting through the walls.

Why were you singing in the middle of the night, Auntie? he asks.

Her reply: No one was singing. It must have been a dream.

One day an old man in a peci and sarong sits at Nana's table, smoking a kretek. He's sipping black coffee, which Mamak has made for him. But he won't stay long. He has to go to Friday prayers. He's a dukun—a healer, a keeper of djinn. Since we Muslims are forbidden to inquire of anyone but Allah, let's just call him the Wise Man. Let's not bicker about semantics. Anyway, his djinn are Muslim, not the infidel kind.

The Wise Man reveals who—or what—is wandering around at night and making visits to the well. It's a kuntilanak—a woman who died in a tragic, unnatural way. He closes his eyes and describes what he sees: a kuntilanak beside the well, sitting in a swing unseen to the human eye whenever the moon is full.

We don't have a swing, says Nana.

Certainly not now, replies the Wise Man. But what about before?

People say a kuntilanak can be tamed by driving a nail into her head. But since she isn't bothering us, the Wise Man advises us not to disturb

her; she merely likes this house and wants to stay close.

Close to who? asks Mamak.

The Wise Man glances briefly at Nana and hesitates before shaking his head.

Who knows. A kuntilanak's affairs are her own.

According to Mamak, the Wise Man cast a protective spell over the house. A few charms muttered, some sacred water sprinkled, and except for the occasional thud of a falling object, nothing bothered the occupants again. Only when Nana was admitted to the hospital did Victoria's House begin acting up once more. A relative from Jakarta claimed to have gotten lost for hours before finally reaching Nana's door. He had hired one of the drivers who hung around Bakauheni Harbor, offering their services. He'd gotten into the car and dozed off in the back seat. When he woke he realized they had been going around in circles on the same road. He spied Nana's house on the left, but the car kept going, looping twice more.

Stop! Stop! he yelled at last. This is the house. Yes! Stop! That one, with the red door.

Even then, the driver didn't stop immediately. It was as if he were bewitched. Brusquely, the relative told the driver to help unload his bags from the trunk. He took out his wallet, grumbling the whole while, and the driver, clearly aggrieved, snapped back.

So why did your wife say to keep going?

My wife? What are you talking about?

The woman in the red dress sitting beside you.

Don't look.

The legend of Victoria's House spread swiftly among the other drivers, whose numbers swelled in the '90s. The stories varied. *If you're just passing by, inshallah, you won't get lost. Only if that's where you want to go.* Then there was the story of a lady in red standing alone on a street corner, flagging down a ride. The next day the unfortunate driver found himself shivering in bed, a heaviness in his back. The Wise Man was summoned. When asked why the lady in red was out and about, he simply replied: a kuntilanak's affairs are her own.

The stories grew ever more convoluted, but the moral was always clear: be careful. Steer clear of that address. You'll feel like you've been driving for hours and hours, on a road without end—round and round, as if you'll never arrive, even though you're right there.

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THE BRIDE

Without a Grave

Jakarta Raya, 16 May 2018

Kotawijaya's municipal government has designated Widuri Public Cemetery as the site where the bombers' bodies will be interred. The land, which belongs to the city, is usually where unidentified bodies are buried.

The police and burial team left for the cemetery early Tuesday morning. Seven graves were dug. But, by the afternoon, the graves had been filled back in without the bodies being buried, due to opposition from local residents.

"A bomber is not the same as an unidentified person," explained Murtopo, Widuri District's Community Head. "We don't want them buried near our homes."

The municipal government will consult the Indonesian Ulema Council about finding another cemetery, but the same objections may well be repeated elsewhere.

Islam Today, 16 May 2018

After protests from residents, the Kotawijaya Municipal Government has agreed to bury the bombers in another city, Mojokuto.

"The Indonesian Ulema Council has issued a fatwa," said Dwi Raharjo, spokesman for city government. "The bodies must be buried right away."

In a separate statement, council representative Abdul Gafur confirmed the Ulema Council's insistence that the municipal government take action, especially now that the autopsies have been completed.

"It is imperative that a burial site must be found," he said. "Have not Imam al-Bukhari and Imam Muslim said what the Prophet bade us do? 'Be swift to dispose of a body. Should the corpse be of the good, you have

brought it closer to goodness. Should the corpse be of the wicked, you have removed a burden from your shoulders.'"

The bodies will be conveyed to Mojokuto on Saturday.

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THE CARETAKER

Gravedigger

A caretaker, Nana said, is also a gravedigger. So here I am, seeing off the dead. No open field under a blue sky here, or crows scratching the ground for me to imitate, but I've never broken a promise or shirked my duties, and I won't start now. Nana can't be choosy; she is already by Allah's side. I am laying my sister to rest, just as Qabil learned, in the end, how to dig a grave and bury his brother's corpse.

I thought the task was finished, but now I'm starting all over again. And, like a fool, I've returned to Kotawijaya. The taxi drops me off at the gate and, fifteen minutes later, the ambulance arrives, bearing Annisa's and Patricia's bodies. *Bright Blooms Crematorium*. The name feels mocking, almost vampiric, as if draining the souls of the departed to fuel its cheer. Not that there's anything bright here, let alone blooming. The building needs renovating: the walls are a sunny kindergarten yellow and sooty smudges stain the cheap white-tiled floors.

I'm greeted by a young man in a black T-shirt and skinny jeans wearing a silver chain necklace. I spoke to him yesterday over the phone. The police and the hospital have been helpful, but even so, I'm well trained in dealing with bureaucracy without letting it grind me down. It's like getting a shot: the quicker the needle goes in, the quicker the healing can start. A policeman, along with the ambulance driver and an assistant, unload the caskets. It seems to exhaust them: as they say, the heavier the sins, the heavier the corpse.

Mother and daughter must enter the furnace separately. "It's the rules," explains the man in the silver necklace. I think it a waste of time—what's the point given the state of their remains? But I'm too tired to

argue. I do ask for their ashes to be combined. I really don't want the hassle of carrying two separate urns.

This request is granted at least.

The two caskets are lined up, one after another, at the mouth of the furnace. The man in the necklace asks if I want to say any prayers. I shake my head. Just get on with it. He tells me all about the religious rites he usually sees performed. He says most people who come here are Buddhist. He's never seen a Muslim here. I say nothing in return.

My father would be furious if he knew I was having my sister cremated. I picture him rising from his bed, suddenly in the pink of health, like when he used to gather his three daughters to tell us something, this time, booming: "In Islam, a body must be buried. Never cremated!"

This is haram.

You're a sinner, Mutiara. This is sin.

Papa isn't here, will soon be dead himself, but still I turn away in shame.

From earth we have been created, and to earth we shall return. I can't let the soil reclaim my sister. I can't let the nutrients from her decomposing body feed the growth of trees, lush and full. What kind of fruit would grow from a contaminated source? I haven't even bothered to bathe Annisa's body. No amount of water can purify tainted blood.

The furnace door opens, and Patricia's little casket goes in. I hold my breath. Here we are, at an endpoint I could never have imagined for us when Annisa was small, when I played mother to her, assuming I would die first. Today I'm seeing her off. Today I'm letting her go.

Farewell, dear sister. I hope Allah's mercy is greater than I can comprehend. No jasmine strands in your hair now, like on your wedding day, but I won't say sorry—the word imposes too great a cost, unfair to me, unfit for you. I haven't even ordered a casket in white, your favorite color. But I'll escort you home. It's the best I can do.

Annisa's casket moves forward, and the furnace door lowers. It seems I finally got what I wanted that day by the well, and I don't want it anymore. I've shoved my sister in, fed her to the demon lurking in the well's depths, and she can never get out. Soon she'll be trapped in a bottle, like a djinn. I imagine her pulverized, sapped of all strength, and my heart, too, is crushed to bits.

Annisa is gone. *For eternity*.

"Three hours?"

I feel slightly ridiculous at how indignant my question sounds, but the man in the necklace is patient as he explains. It's a chance to show off his knowledge.

"The cremation process itself takes around two and a half hours, Ma'am. Then we have to let the remains cool. After that we separate the bone fragments and pound them into a fine ash. So, yes, about three hours in all. Please feel free to take a walk while you wait."

I get out my cell phone and search for somewhere nearby to eat. Meanwhile, the young policeman accompanying me strikes up a conversation with the crematorium worker. Until now, the policeman has maintained a dignified silence and professional demeanor, but curiosity gets the better of him: how is it possible for a body to turn to ash in a furnace and disappear?

Can I blame him? Maybe we all want to know what awaits us. What is stated in scripture is obscure, wrapped in enigma. We're all trying to piece it together as best we can.

"Do you like working here?" asks the cop.

"Yeah. Been here for a while now," the crematorium worker replies. "Going on six years."

The policeman acts as if he's carrying out an inspection, chest out, hands behind his back. Then, a little awkwardly, feigning indifference, he asks, "So, ever seen anything weird?"

"Nah. I'm used to it all now."

The policeman nods nonchalantly and the worker casts a mischievous glance at him and adds, "Though sometimes when I clean the furnace, I feel something on the back of my neck. But I don't give it a second thought. Doesn't bother me. I feel right at home."

The worker's phone goes off, blaring "Gangnam" *Style*, and the policeman practically jumps.

"Excuse me. I have to take this call."

The man in the necklace is just like me. A seasoned caretaker. Incinerating corpses has made him an expert in his field, just as tending to family duties has forged me into the life administrator I am today.

I think of all the logistics I had to run through with the worker before the cremation. “Documents, please.”

Death certificate from hospital. Family register and identity cards of deceased. Family register and identity card of applicant. Check. Check. Check.

“Which package?” the worker had asked, explaining that price was determined by casket thickness. The thicker, the more expensive, and the longer the cremation would take.

“Did you bring your own urn, or are we providing one?”

I made a series of snap decisions, answering all his questions with composure. My only thought was to get it all over with. No need to fuss about coffin sizes or urn shapes.

I leave the crematorium to get something to eat. The worker and policeman are probably still chatting away, wondering why I, a devout--looking Muslim woman in a headscarf, would want to have my own sister and niece cremated. I’m not sure the worker is aware of who my sister is, but I also don’t care.

Even at this late stage, I keep thinking about whether I’ve done the right thing. Maybe I should feel ashamed, but I also couldn’t bear to see her carted off to Mojokuto simply because they wouldn’t take her in Kotawijaya. It was just awful, all those coffins, lined up, with their disgraceful contents and no place to go. Part of the job, sure, but what gravedigger would want to sacrifice weekend time with their family to do that? Traveling for hours in the company of body parts defiled by sin, rejected by this world, reviled in the next? I couldn’t bear the thought of going to Mojokuto one day only to see three mounds of earth where my sister had been buried, potentially all mixed up with others, her limbs intertwined with someone else’s husband, maybe—who knows? And who could guarantee that the graves wouldn’t be vandalized? Could I blame someone for acting in anger? For scrawling obscenities on the tombstones?

Would there even be tombstones?

Cremation was the better option. I told the police it was my dying father’s request, that he wanted his beloved daughter with him before he died, and not to have her buried who knew where. I wanted to grant his last wish, but I had no one to help me, I was all by myself.

Sometimes it's better to avoid the rigmarole and play the suffering woman card. The police acquiesced, on humanitarian grounds. They would see what they could do about getting Annisa's and Patricia's names removed from the list of those to be buried in Mojokuto. At first, I worried that word would get out, that the media would attack our family. But at that point, I don't think anyone cared much anymore. The public's hate was spent.

I've also benefited from some news on the family chat: just this morning, my cousin Erika, age forty-four, was admitted to hospital. She's about to give birth to her fourth child. This will distract everyone's attention from the matter of Annisa, at least, for a while.

I hurry back to the crematorium three hours later. It's started to rain. The policeman assigned to me has left. The man in the necklace asks me to wait a moment before returning with the urn. He seems proud of his work. Annisa and her daughter, bone, tissue, and flesh, ground down into dust.

The man shelters me with an umbrella outside the gate as I wait for a taxi. It's pouring now, even though the sun is shining and the air is heavy. He calls it the rain of the dead.

The urn is heavier than I expected. I hold it tightly to my chest, just as I used to hold Annisa when she was a baby and I was a girl.

In my hotel room, sitting on the floor, I place the urn in a cardboard box lined with styrofoam and crumpled newspaper. I seal the box with packing tape, double layers, just in case, and stare at my handiwork. My sister and her daughter, encased in a box, ready for me to transport by plane. At last.

How strange to say "at last."

I fly back to Jakarta on Sunday, and then what? Finally, I feel like I'm asking the question that is my right to ask, one that pushes me to look forward rather than back. Then what? Then I'll return to my life, caring for Papa as best I can, seeing him off as I seek a way out of my trap. I get up from the carpet and walk over to the window. I open the curtains. My room faces not the main road but the side of a building, where the dumpsters are kept.

Maybe this really is the last of it. Soon there will be no more corpses to care for. But confusion still lingers, trailing me, taunting me, because I still don't understand. I don't understand how I got here, head down, hands busy, air conditioner droning noisily in the background, in a hotel room all by myself. Just me and a box of crumbs. The remains of my little sister.

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The Tale of a Woman Writer

Should you ever visit Victoria's House, ladies and gentlemen, head into the family room. There you'll find a cupboard of teak, standing sturdy and proud. Look inside. On a shelf sits a row of romance novels from the twenties and thirties, a few cookbooks, some Islamic texts, and notebooks filled with elegant cursive Dutch. From here we can deduce much about our dear grandmother, Victoria: daughter of Haji Tjek Sun, retired teacher turned household matriarch, education imported from the Netherlands, her life steeped in feudal heritage and religious piety. Case closed? Oh no. Don't be so easily deceived. Those aren't all her books. There's one tucked away in her dressing table drawer, with the lipstick and prayer beads, and the blessings and incantations on slips of paper, and a booklet bearing a photo of our late grandfather with Surah Yasin printed inside. It's a slim book of poems. *Barren*, reads the title, by S. Rukiah, published in 1964 by the same publisher as the romance novels in the cabinet, Balai Pustaka.

Once, when playing in Nana's room, the three granddaughters asked why the book wasn't in the cupboard.

Nana snapped to attention. Don't tell anyone about it. It's banned.

The sisters were confused—why would a book be banned, and, if it was, why did Nana keep it?

Nana's reply: It reminds me of someone I love.

A picture on the first page showed a woman in a kebaya, hair in a bun, pendant around her neck. Was she a lover, a writer, a lover who wrote, does she still write? No one knew. And no one heard a woman's singing, ever so faint, penetrating the walls, as the girls turned page after page, bewitched. *Read. Read in the name of*—are these poems or riddles? How hard they are to comprehend, these forbidden verses, by a forbidden woman, and yet these lines capture their hearts:

In the screaming hot sun

you circle up the toy blocks
overalls smeared with snot
joyous squeals and
tearful pouts by turn

What are you building on this land
my little one?![1]

[1] "My Little One," a poem by S. Rukiah, published in *Tandus*, [*Baren*] (Balai Pustaka, 1952, p.96)

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THE CARETAKER'S URN

I stop outside my sister's house before leaving Kotawijaya. The investigation is still ongoing, and the police aren't allowing anyone in. So I just sit in the taxi and stare at the house and the yellow police line stretched across the gate. I didn't have time to visit Annisa on my last work trip to Kotawijaya, but I knew she and her family were renting some place smaller and less conspicuous back then. I look at the carved pillars framing the entrance, and the tiny yard. It's a soap-opera house, tacky through and through. But one thing's clear: my sister was wealthier than I thought, thanks to her husband's business most likely, the exact nature of which was never clear. And all this time, Annisa had only ever chipped in a little when it came to my parents, leaving me to shoulder the household and medical expenses. Well, yes, but she was a housewife with two kids, whereas I was single. Couldn't I easily spare the cash? That's what my father thought.

From the news, I learned that she and her husband had built the bombs in their bedroom. Now, all sorts of questions flood my mind. How did you sleep that night, Annisa, with those bombs by your bed and plans for destruction running through your mind? Did you sleep soundly—eight solid hours? Or maybe you thought sleep pointless; you'd soon get rest enough. And did you take a moment to leave your bedroom and check in on your daughter? Did you ever think, even for a minute, of sparing her? Your daughter, snug in bed, the gentle rise and fall of her chest. Her sweet breath—you could choose not to snatch it away.

I wonder what else Annisa kept in her suburban palace. Beyond the explosives. I want to discover something, but I'm not sure what. Some secret, perhaps, involving my name, all our names. I want to know if there are traces of us where she went astray. But even if I were allowed inside, where would I start searching? A desk or a closet? The kitchen? My taxi

drives away, and her starter castle and its yellow police line disappear from view. There must be clues. If not here, then somewhere else.

I leave for the airport at dawn on Sunday. After passing through security, I head to my gate and lower myself wearily into a chair, coffee in left hand, a bun in my right, alert to each announcement (did they say Jakarta?), every ding, every dong. Waiting area, crumbs on carpet, queue in restroom, delayed departure, Ayat al-Kursi, on repeat. Again and again. It's been a week of reliving a bad dream. Anxious thoughts gnaw at me. Am I even heading anywhere? I recall the legend about my grandmother's house, about the road without end. Maybe this was what those people felt like, you keep going, but you're just going round and round.

When the taxi from the airport drops me at home, I stop in just long enough to set down my suitcase and the urn. I drive to my parents' house, only thirty minutes away; I bought a place nearby for peace of mind. I knew that if they fell ill, no one else would be able to care for them. It pleases me to find the potted plants in their yard looking healthy and green. Fishing the key from my bag, I open the front door and step inside. It's hot, but it's not as bad as it is outdoors. Under the bare soles of my feet, the floor feels squeaky clean, and the living room and dining room are neat and tidy. I sniff the air. No musty odors or dust. I pay Sri extra to look after my parents' place twice a week, and she does her job well.

Annisa's bedroom, like the others, is unlocked. It smells like mothballs and old clothes. There's so much stuff in here, it blocks the sunlight coming in through the windows, so I turn on the light. After Annisa got married and moved to Kotawijaya, her bedroom became a storage closet. We shifted my mother's '80s-vintage outfits there after she died. Papa was adamant about wanting to set aside a few, as keepsakes, before giving the rest to a mosque or charity. But he never got around to it. So, Annisa's room grew mustier, gloomier, more cramped. A museum of the dead.

I feel my chest tighten. After all this is over, I'll throw everything away. I'll sweep and sweep until there's nothing left.

Annisa's desk is still here, from her school days, before she left for university in Bandung. It's a teenager's desk, on the smaller side, stuffed with memorabilia from long ago. I sift through everything: textbooks, photo albums from middle school, stickers, a box filled with mementos

like movie ticket stubs and birthday cards from friends. I thought most of her books had been donated to the mosque, but it seems there's no end to it. There are always more things to dispose of, more things to clean up.

Then I spy a book with a pink cover. One of Annisa's old diaries. She was always diligent about writing, even from a young age. I know because Maya and I once found one and made fun of what she'd written. But we learned a bitter lesson from it: Kitty, followed by Nana's well. I never touched any of her diaries since. She would have had several, but this is the only one I find. Perhaps she left it by accident and brought the rest with her to Kotawijaya. I imagine she shifted to typing her entries on a computer after getting married, or perhaps she stopped altogether because she was busy with the kids. I flip through: first entry, 2003; the last one, 2008.

After a few hours at my parents' place, I wind up bringing a few items home: the pink diary; pictures from Annisa's wedding, probably Papa's since she would have brought her own to Kotawijaya; and the box of mementos. Will these items help? They're all from another time, from another Annisa, the Annisa I cared for when blood still flowed through her veins. But every search has to begin somewhere.

At a long traffic light, I study three photos from Annisa's wedding. The first shows the bride and the customary pagar ayu, a row of young women in white kebayas, most of them in headscarves, ready to greet the wedding guests. I recognize Sarah, Annisa's friend from high school. Maybe she knows something. Did they stay close after Annisa moved away? Contacting her via Facebook would be a good idea, but I've closed my account. I'm done with social media. Senior Brand Manager but not on brand, as my staff like to joke.

Next, a family shot. Annisa, beautiful in her gown of white, like a storybook princess. She stands beside her husband, Fahri, flanked by Papa, Mama, and her in-laws. The two older women wear headscarves and kebaya, the mother-in-law in batik and Mama in songket. How I miss the plump, full-cheeked Mama of those days, before she was confined to her bed, before her face became lopsided and her features began to sag. Then, further to the left, I see myself, no headscarf yet, standing next to Maya. Like the bride and groom and parents, we're wearing white. Maya had

been upset at having to surrender her signature look—perpetual black. But we played our supporting roles to perfection, standing on the sidelines, looking our best but knowing our place, mindful not to dim the glow of the radiant bride. To the right stand Fahri's older brother and younger sister. That was the first and last time I met any of his family. None of them came to the hospital or tried to make contact after the bombing. They were probably like me, overwhelmed, stricken with grief and shame.

Last, a big group photo. Some faces are unfamiliar, most likely from Fahri's side. Then our catty uncles and aunts, and various other guests. On the right I spy Ali, my old math and physics tutor, and next to him, his wife. There was a time when I would think about him day and night. I was young and stupid back then. Quickly, I shift my gaze to the left. There's Maya and me at the edge of the crowd, and next to us, a tall, slender woman with long, cascading hair—Rohadi, our childhood friend from Nana's house in Tanjung Karang. Her mother was Nana's helper, Mak Romlah. I remember she arrived late, in a figure-hugging kebaya, hair dyed light brown, the added height from her heels making her stand out even more. Heads turned. Eyes stared. How rude, people whispered. Stealing the spotlight from the bride. We didn't recognize her at first. Then she approached Maya and me and introduced herself by her new name, Rosalinda.

After the party, I told Maya I'd forgotten to invite her. I hadn't known her new address in Yogyakarta, or for that matter, that she'd changed her appearance and name.

"Good thing you remembered," I said.

Maya was quiet.

"I didn't," she said at last. "And Annisa didn't either."

"But how did she know to wear a white kebaya, like the rest of us in the pagar ayu?"

"Annisa's favorite color? Of course she'd know."

The traffic starts moving. I return the photos to the bag. Faces from the past, and, like Rosalinda at the party, intruding and unwelcome. They bother me all the way home.

It's almost Maghrib by the time I get back. I park and lug the bag inside. I open the door to find my three gingers chasing each other around the

living room and meowing. Layla's not there.

And then, for a few seconds, my vision goes black. I howl, calling Allah's name. The urn has rolled off the table and lies broken. The ashes of Annisa and her daughter are all over the floor.

I phone Sri after the Isha prayers. As my voice rises, hers shrinks.

"How many times have I told you? No fragile items on the table!"

"It was a cardboard box, Ma'am. I didn't know what was inside."

"That's impossible. I took the urn out."

"I'm so sorry, Ma'am. But I remember—" Sri pauses. "Sorry, maybe I'm wrong. When did you put the urn there?"

I'm momentarily speechless.

"My point is, it was left on the table. You know you need to be careful around the children."

"But they hardly ever climb on the table."

"If a cat didn't break the urn, who did? Me?"

What a hackneyed scene we were trapped in: me, the boss screaming with rage, her, the maid scrambling to apologize, desperate to keep her job. The conversation goes nowhere. By its end, I'm even more frustrated because Sri thinks I'm at fault. She doesn't say so, but I can tell. And I begin to doubt myself. Did I take the urn out of the box? When? Why are there holes in my memory?

But that's not the issue, is it?

This isn't about me. The fault must lie elsewhere—with Sri or my cats, with everything else.

That night I have a dream. Grains of rice are scattered all over the floor and I have to pick them up. My feet are bare, and the floor is hard and cold, and muddy. This isn't my house. I'm squatting on the stones where Mak Romlah used to wash clothes. Beside me stands the forbidden well, towering, covered with moss. I'm at Nana's, in Tanjung Karang. This is Victoria's House.

Nana emerges from the depths of the kitchen, a kretek between her fingers. She issues a command: pick up the rice. All of it. I want to see every single grain in your hands.

I wonder where Maya is, and Annisa—and why I alone am stuck here gathering grains of rice. Once Nana leaves, I get up and slink away

through the side door, abandoning the kitchen and well. Upon reaching the yard, I run to Nana's starfruit tree, broader and taller than I remember. I clamber up and sit on a branch, watching the red door of Victoria's House and ruing my bad luck in being singled out to pick up grains of rice. I hear a cat purring beneath me, soft at first, then gradually rising to a growl. When I look down, I see that it isn't a cat at all, but a tiger circling the tree.

It's caught my scent, and now it stares straight at me, eyes blazing, ready to tear me to shreds. My eyes turn to the roof. What if I leap on to it, and make a running jump from there onto the neighbor's house?

You have to jump. Get ready. Now. Now!

Jump!

But I don't dare. Soon the tiger will climb up and get me, and I sit in the tree, sobbing about what a coward I am. I'm not brave enough to jump, or even look Nana in the face. I feel nothing but regret. Nothing can rescue me now.

I'm sorry, Nana. Forgive me.

The next moment, I find myself in bed, awake and weeping, tears streaming onto my pillow. Eyes wide open, I stare at ceiling in the dark. No tiger, no Nana, and I'm not a little girl climbing a tree.

It's one in the morning when I shut my eyes again. I just want to fall asleep, but the sound of my own erratic breathing keeps me up. I toss and turn, wrestling with my own thoughts in the darkness, my head full to bursting; I still don't know which cat broke the urn.

Earlier, at the sight of the urn, I sank to my knees, staring at the ashes strewn across the floor. I stayed like that until I heard the call to prayer. Maghrib. Nana's words came to me then: never bring a baby out at Maghrib; that's when spirits roam the crossroads. I dashed to the kitchen for a broom and swept up all the ash I could find, pouring it into a plastic bag. One stray speck and Annisa would be lost, just another wandering soul. But who could tell whether all of it had been collected, whether all of her was there, like before? I had yet to check under the couch. My cats probably had stepped in the ashes and tracked some into the living room, the bedrooms, the kitchen. Annisa wasn't in just one place. She had spread into every corner of my house.

2:00 A.M. I sit up in bed with only one thing on my mind: I have to clean. I leave my bedroom, turn on the light, and get the broom and dustpan. The kitchen lights I leave off. I start under the table and chairs, hunting for any remaining specks of ash, and I sweep and sweep until I'm sure the floor is clean. Then out of nowhere, a clattering sound. It comes from the kitchen, followed by meowing. Still clutching the broom in my right hand, I call Layla's name. There's no response. But out of the corner of my eye I spy a shadow. I hold my breath and slowly turn my head. A woman in a wedding dress and a veil of white lace drifts past. I quickly look down, eyes on the dustpan, afraid to look anywhere else, the clock on the wall ticking louder and louder, and questions, so many questions fill my head: *where are you, little sister, where are you going, what do you want to say?*

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THE BRIDE IN WHITE

Tanjung Karang, 30 May 2003

I've always dreamed of a white wedding. Since I was little, I've imagined myself in a white gown, its long train trailing behind me, all the guests admiring me as I glide past. I wear a long lacy veil adorned with pearls, a dainty silver tiara, strands of jasmine dangling to my waist. Ahead of me, the wedding platform, columns garlanded in silk bunting entwined with fragrant jasmine and white rose. Attendants trail me in embroidered kebayas, also pure white.

So basically, Euro princess meets Goddess of the Southern Sea.

That's what Maya said.

I hate how Maya acts so superior. She accuses me of having a Cinderella complex. She's one to talk. She looks like an anti-princess, a cartoon villain, with all that black eyeliner she cakes on. After all these years, after all my achievements—getting into ITB, getting good grades, even publishing two poems in Muslimah magazines—she still treats me like a kid. At least Mutiara never insults me, though I know she doesn't really take notice of me yet. In her eyes, I haven't come into my own.

Nana, in her wheelchair, just cackled along with Maya. That evening the three of us, along with Mak Romlah, were in Nana's room, preparing for Cousin Erika's wedding. The doors to Nana's wardrobe were flung wide open, revealing glittering piles of songket fabric, richly patterned with gold thread. The scent of mothballs and old clothes mingled in the air. Mak Romlah, kneeling on the floor near Nana's feet, helped choose songket for Muti, Maya, and me.

I love Nana, but I have to admit that I don't always like talking with her for too long. When I was little, she looked so fierce and scary. She's not as scary anymore, either because I'm getting bigger or because she's shrinking the older she gets. But she's still fearless as ever, and likes to make fun of people. She makes me feel stupid a lot of the time.

Nonsense, Annisa, said Nana. People from Palembang don't get married in white. Everything has to be red. If you want white, marry someone from Lampung. Or a white guy.

While everyone was laughing, there was a knock at the door. Rohadi entered with a golden kebaya on a hanger. It's Aunt Linda's, he said.

Nana told him to hang it in the wardrobe. All the close relatives on Erika's side are wearing golden kebaya. But Aunt Linda's looks different, more elegant, and, of course, more expensive, since she's the richest of us all.

This is gorgeous, breathed Rohadi.

Imagine how stunning it would be in white, I said.

Beautiful, isn't it, Annisa? he said. French lace.

I made a note of it. I wanted to get married in a white dress with French lace. But suddenly I was consumed in my own thoughts: Lingga is Javanese, not European or from Lampung. What color will we wear on our wedding day?

Maybe I shouldn't dream so much. Lingga and I haven't been together long. Don't let your imagination get ahead of itself, Annisa! The road is long, and Allah will determine your soulmate.

I can't wait to go back to Jakarta and see Lingga.

Tanjung Karang, 31 May 2003

Nana's house is so full of activity! Wak Norma's family held a big traditional Padang-style reception in Jakarta, like the fiancé's side wanted. But she and Nana also decided to hold a *ngunduh mantu*, maybe because they don't want to be outdone by the in-laws. So, we had a Palembang--style reception at Tanjung Karang.

They hired caterers for the event itself, but with all the relatives coming and going, the kitchen is never quiet. Wak Norma's in charge, with Mutiara helping, and everyone defers to her commands. Honestly, I'm not sure Mutiara will ever be like Wak Norma, with that kind of presence and power, not while people still tease her about not getting married. She hasn't come into her own.

Wak Norma decided the menu. She reminded me of a general, overseeing a whole troop of women busy in the kitchen, seasoning meat, stirring soup, chopping vegetables. They're Nana's distant kin from the

countryside, brought in to help with preparations. Their voices are loud, and laughter fills the air.

Once she was finished in the kitchen, Wak Norma strode to the living room to receive Rohadi's report that two beauty salons had been booked: makeup and hair would start at half past three the following morning. So much hustle and bustle! Everyone working together for the sake of the bride and groom.

Cousin Erika spent a lot of time undergoing beauty treatments in the bedroom, but every so often she'd come sit in the living room and help with small tasks. A bride should stay in the house and get a lot of rest, said Nana. Erika looked positively radiant whenever I caught a glimpse of her. She has always been my role model. I still remember when she first started wearing hijab—I was still in middle school—and she looked even prettier, mashallah! I couldn't stop thinking about how elegant she looked in her headscarf and long flowing dress. When I started wearing hijab two years ago, Mama and Nana thought I was too young, but I had Papa's support.

You know how I am. Once I have my mind set on something, no one can stop me!

Before the reception, I snuck a peek at Erika's gown, crimson velvet, studded with gold. When Mama got married, her wedding dress showed her arms, but Erika's was modest, with long sleeves. Her outfit for the traditional Padang reception in Jakarta was long-sleeved too, and bright red and embroidered all over in golden thread. Plus the gold headdress—five kilos! I wondered if she felt dizzy under the weight.

Well, that's the sacrifice a bride has to make if she wants to look like a princess, said Nana. By the end of the night, your head might snap off.

But all through the reception, Erika held her head high. She even smiled sweetly at the guests, graceful as a princess. And when she nodded, the gold ornaments on her head swayed.

I've never asked Nana again about the time she was in the hospital and told us our future. Maybe she doesn't remember, and anyway, I don't dare. It's not good to believe in fortune-telling. But I do pray. I have faith that Nana's words will come true. Someday, I'll matter. I'm coming into my own, destined for glory.

I will be a beautiful bride.

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THE KEY

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THE TRAVELER

Heir of the Tiger

I am the offspring of neither mother nor father. I am the heir of my grandmother, a shapeshifter. When we were young, Victoria predicted our fortunes—where were each of us bound? North, south, east, west? Three sisters, three points of the compass, three spears cast in three directions: caretaker, traveler, bride. But as an adult, I realized that travel wasn't only my wish. It's what Nana wanted for herself, before her dreams ran aground.

She had nailed herself down at home, presiding matriarch and center of gravity for her children and grandchildren as they scattered. And she contented herself with riding the bus to market in fine clothes. But part of her did roam far: Nana in sepia, standing hands on hips next to a woman on a bicycle, a photo taken in a studio long ago. It had been left in the house after she died, and I took it, transported it over land and sea.

I emerge from West 4th Street Station, passing a newsstand on the right and a small basketball court on the left. It was here, years ago, amid a crowd watching a game that I received the message that Nana had passed on. I didn't buy a ticket home, traitor that I was—me, the favorite grandchild, missing her grandmother's funeral. I had no money, true, but there was another reason: my train was in motion. I wasn't going to stop, not even for Nana's death. And I was certain that Victoria was on board too. I imagined her in the prettiest dress from her youth, sitting and joking with other traveling ladies to the accompaniment of jazz or kroncong. Though the train stops at every station, no one gets off. They're having too good of a time.

I rush past a convenience store opening for the day; a slumbering bar, dreaming of clinking glasses and music and chatter; a café, awake, alert,

the aroma of coffee suffusing the morning air. My shoes click against the asphalt like time running out: tick tick tick, then faster, and faster still, leaving behind those unwilling to follow or unable to run.

Victoria spent her final years confined to a wheelchair. My mother's turn came next, bedridden, dependent on Mutiara, who was equally trapped, bearing her own curse: caretaker, housecleaner, gravedigger. As for Annisa, she got married, became a wife and mother, roles that seem to have led her down another path—one inconceivable to us all.

I'm sure I have my own curse to live. But here, at least, I live my grandmother's dream.

I wander in the shoes of a third world woman, usurping the place of predecessors—men, all of them, civilization's supposed rightful heirs. Here I write the life story of my grandmother, a weretiger. A weretiger, burning bright. Or at least that's what I was doing until last week, when Annisa jumped off a cliff and dragged me with her into the abyss. All these years on the run, and now I have to stop; I've been crammed into a dark, stuffy coffin, entombed in sorrow and shame. You want to leave your mark on the world, Maya? Well, the future starts now. Your little sister will follow you. And oh, by the way, we regret to inform you, she's not alone; round her ankle hangs a chain of corpses, dangling daintily like charms.

In the park across the street, pink cherry blossoms are starting to fall. Maybe I'll just let my life collapse, take my cue from their transience. But, faintly, I hear my grandmother's voice: *Be strong, persevere, write—as you have always done. A storm has come, but you, my grandchild, shall be safe on your boat with your books.*

So, I write. I write, resisting time, resisting fate. I write against my little sister who has forced her own story on me in the here and now. To write is to sail a boat towards eternity. This is my dream, don't steal it. It's all I have.

The morning sun streamed through the chapel window, bathing the faces of the girls sitting in the front pew—brown-skinned angels, radiant, ignorant of wrath or woe. Eight o'clock and no sign of Rohana. Sister Superior motioned to Mevrouw van Aerden, seated at the organ, and the girls began to sing. As Dinar's lips moved, her eyes darted about. Where could Rohana be?

Ave Maria
Gratia plena
Maria, gratia plena
Maria, gratia plena

Dinar remembered crying when her parents sent her away to study at the Normal School in Padang Panjang. She told them she wanted to stay in Palembang, "to look after Papa and Mama," she said. Though she knew her parents hardly needed looking after. Her father, a district chief, strong and healthy, had more than enough wealth to spare. And her mother managed the family with a troop of servants, a gardener, and a driver at her command.

Dinar's father turned to his wife, loath to part with his only daughter. "Maybe she's right," he said. "Maybe she shouldn't go so far away."

At this, her mother spit out the betel nut she was chewing. "Dinar, how can you be so ungrateful? Do you know how rare it is for a girl to get an education? Most of them just wait for marriage to change their lives. The lucky ones marry rich and get their families out of debt, but what about those that don't?"

Who can argue with one's mother? Dinar set off on a ship to Padang and stayed in the girls' dormitory at the school. The Dutch women who taught them emphasized the importance of discipline. Determined to prove that natives weren't lazy, Dinar always rose at half past four: morning prayers, study, sports, bathing, chapel, and then, with the others, classes. Developing these habits was no easy matter, but she wasn't alone. She had her dearest friend.

Ave, ave Dominus
Dominus tecum

The door opened and the entire chapel turned to look. It was Rohana, out of breath, plaits in disarray. Sister Superior cast a frown her way but motioned for Mevrouw van Aerden to continue playing. Rohana crept in, searching for a seat at the back, and Dinar suppressed a smile. She had woken Rohana up that morning, but Rohana must have gone back to sleep. Taking a seat, Rohana caught her breath before scanning the pews for her best friend. She greeted Dinar with a wink.

Every morning I come here, to this library, to reimagine my grandmother's life and turn it into fiction. I had always dreamed of doing so but have never been this daring. Prior to this, my life was haphazard, decided by chance. Or, as Mutiara calls it, luck. Because didn't she work hard, whereas I was just the lucky one?

I got a scholarship to America to do my master's degree. And in my first year, I noticed several of my fellow Indonesians were already applying for doctoral programs. I asked them why the rush, shouldn't you enjoy life, take your time? Don't you want to stay overseas longer, they asked. I was stunned. They had a point.

I was willing to go anywhere but home. I didn't want to be either of my sisters. Not Mutiara, working an office job just to make money, or Annisa, following a predictable path—birth, school, marriage, kids. Outfitted with a photo of my grandmother with a girl on a bicycle, I too applied for PhD programs—in History. My research topic: girls' schools in the Dutch East Indies. A dozen rejections later, I was prepared to give up and go home, to accept that my research topic wasn't any good, but one university put me on the waiting list and eventually accepted me. More school. How nice for you, said Mutiara. For her I was just putting off getting a job, drawing out the days before I finally grew up and came into my own.

While writing my dissertation, I wondered more and more about my grandmother's life at the Normal School. What became of her friends—native women marked out to receive an education when so many others went without? Who might Nana have loved before she married my grandfather? Gradually, I built up a story around Victoria. And over the years, the story grew as the time spent on my dissertation dwindled away. Traitorous me. I set aside my dissertation, just for the time being. A week became a month, a month became a year. Something else was calling. Now here I am, writing a book that will capture Nana's past hopes and dreams. And possibly her present ones too, for I believe she lives on. I want to know: is she still on the train? Is she still enjoying herself? Or has she disembarked and run roaring into the forest, hunting for prey?

Eight o'clock is best. Even half an hour later, and my favorite seat will have been claimed by another. It's my near daily ritual: I exit the subway and hurry to the stairs, joining the crush of people filing out of the dim

underground into the light. I walk briskly all the way to the library, with its lofty ceilings and patterned black and white marble floors—the shrine where I honor my Nana's memory.

The eighth floor is my stop. As I exit the elevator, I can see every level and their rows of carrels, separated by columns and glass, a fusion of doll house and prison cell. Passing aisles of bookshelves, I head to a reading room—carpeted floor, mahogany tables, towering glass cabinets, ancient tomes, busts of dead white men: patriarchal symbols of knowledge to be smashed by brown women, descendants of concubines, midwives, servants—we want the world, and we want it now.

Here the results of the morning's competition are decided. The first arrivals are rewarded with the long table facing the window, and views of the public park and fountain while they work. Draping my black leather jacket over a chair, I set my backpack on the floor. I close my eyes for a moment, seeking strength from something outside of myself—something abstract, like God. This is the first time I'm returning to the story since Annisa's death.

Steady now, Maya, whispers Nana. Sunbeams illuminate the specks of dust on my laptop monitor. Against the blue sky stretching over a row of buildings across the park, I replay that day at Tanjung Karang, at Victoria's House, where Nana invented a game, a hunt for a key dangling from a pair of tiny red shoes. Whoever finds the key will go on an adventure, she said. We searched without success. Afterwards, I realized she was getting us to clean—just some light exploitation—and years later I left anyway, without needing any key at all. Still, if it weren't for that quest, I probably wouldn't have discovered the true key—Nana's photos. And now here I am, on a journey across the world to bring Victoria to life. In my story, her name is Dinar.

Victoria, Dinar, this is a tribute from your granddaughter. With all my love.

My family would go berserk if they learned I was writing a novel based on Nana's life. *You're making things up about your grandmother? The nerve!* But my father may not even live long enough to find out. And my awful uncles, aunts, and cousins don't read novels, so they'll never know. Their reading consists entirely of things they find online: Qur'anic snippets

posted by shady clerics; articles about the economy or health; hatemongering political views (The Jewish conspiracy! The cunning Chinese!); fake news about political candidates and LGBT groups.

In stages over the years, I've compiled my grandmother's archive, now digital and stored on a computer. In the early 2000s, before I conceived the idea of a novel, I smuggled out a stack of photos from her wardrobe, which she kept in a Van Houten chocolates tin. I just didn't want them to get ruined, all jumbled up in that dusty cupboard with a hodgepodge of crockery. Keeping an archive is important. A moral obligation to history. (Years later, I regretted not saving Nana's lovely tea set too, but where would I have kept it with no house of my own?)

On another visit to Victoria's House, my father spoke about asking Nana to live with us in Jakarta. Her health was failing. Realizing she might not last much longer, I rescued her notes from her days as a teacher, along with a collection of recipes. And when Nana died, on my father's advice, I returned to take whatever I could, like a petty thief. But it was too late. Victoria's House was almost empty. Everything valuable had already been looted by my aunts, older cousins, even Nana's village relatives. In the end, I salvaged my blue toy piano from her room, various mementos of my childhood days with her, and a pile of letters, seemingly unimportant, which became my most crucial source. Those letters are what compelled me to write about Dinar and Rohana.

Victoria's House no longer belongs to our family. Two years ago, my father and uncles sold it without consulting any of the grandchildren. They said no one wanted to care for it, that it was too big, and haunted by a kuntilanak. Mutiara flew into a rage. Eventually my father admitted that he needed to pay off some money he owed. This made Mutiara madder still: why hadn't he told us he was in debt?

I'd found Nana's letters, some in Indonesian, some in Dutch, in the room beneath the stairs. On that final visit, the room was unlocked and looked thoroughly ordinary; all it held was a bed with a bare cotton mattress, seams loose (even the family bandits couldn't be bothered) and a wardrobe with mirrors on both doors. Some faded moldy curtains were stored inside, and stashed among the folds were Nana's letters. It was hardly surprising that the family bandits had been reluctant to disturb the room, let alone pilfer anything. We used to call it the forbidden chamber

because Nana always kept it locked. I remember learning what it really was—neglected and small, with a single window facing the terrace. No aura, no enigma. How disappointed I was. My sisters and I once believed that the room harbored secrets, like the well and the kitchen, and other parts of Nana's house. We didn't know who, or what, would visit the forbidden chamber, spying through the window as we played on the terrace, just as we were unable to decipher the scene before us when we finally peeked inside and saw Mama and Papa with the strange man.

Victoria's House no longer stands tall. So I put it back together piece by piece. Doesn't everything start at home?—ghosts in the attic and wardrobe, lingering past their expiration date, waiting for you, harrying you as you try to make haste.

My eyes remain fixed on the outside. I see people on park benches: a mother with a stroller, an elderly couple holding hands, a woman in a headscarf. I gasp. The figure appears without warning, in a flash, sending Victoria's House up in smoke. The library window is soundproof, but I hear the faint sound of a woman's laughter nonetheless. There is my sister, in her white wedding gown, sitting on a park bench. Meanwhile here I am, holed up in my turret, pretending she doesn't exist.

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THE TALE OF THE ROOM BENEATH THE STAIRS

Tucked away in the back of Victoria's House, beneath the attic stairs, is a room that's always locked. Visitors ask: why a room under the stairs? It's bad luck, the old folks say. No wonder students don't board there. Who'd want to bed down behind a creaky, cobweb-ridden door? One granddaughter calls it the forbidden chamber. The others scoff. What does that even mean? Isn't everything forbidden in Nana's house? Don't go in this room, don't make a mess of that one, don't play on the terrace after Maghrib, don't stand near the well.

For the sisters, mystery lurks in every corner. Why is Nana's kitchen so dark and what does she need such enormous kuali for? Tell me, how many rooms are there in Nana's house? Three! Four! No, dummy, five. Five, including the room beneath the stairs.

From the terrace nothing within the room can be seen. The purple drapes are drawn fast. Until one day, the door opens, and the girls can peep inside.

This time, Victoria's granddaughters journey to Tanjung Karang with their father and mother, Sulaiman and Mae. Three girls with their Papa and Mama, crossing the sea—in a Toyota Corona loaded onto a ferry. The sisters squeeze together in back, with Papa at the wheel. Mama sits beside Papa. She looks exhausted by the time they reach Victoria's House and heads to the guest room to take a long nap. Then, toward sunset, a cry of pain, long and loud, startling everyone in the house. Papa and Nana rush into the room, the three girls close behind. They find Mama sitting on the side of the bed, struggling to rise, her left shoulder slumped. Her face is pale and her lips are dry. Beads of sweat trickle down her forehead. Muttering a prayer, or maybe a mantra, Nana fetches a glass of water for Mama to drink. She orders her grandchildren away: *Don't bother Mama. She's sick.*

The following day Mama's still unwell, but the girls gather on the terrace as usual. They playact Garlic White and Onion Red, a story about a widow with two daughters, suitable for a cast of three. The widow has a spoiled, lazy daughter, Onion Red, and a stepdaughter, Garlic White, whom she treats like a slave. She was saddled with Garlic White when her second husband died. The moral of the story is all too obvious: Widowers, beware!

One day, as Garlic White does the washing by the river, Onion Red's favorite sarong drifts away. The mother berates Garlic White. The girl can't come home unless she retrieves the garment. The widow's role falls to Mutiara, of course. Though she remarks that if she were the mother, such a thing would never have occurred: I wouldn't trust someone else with something so precious. I'd have taken care of it myself.

Predictably, Annisa plays Garlic White, pure of heart, and Maya, the self-centered Onion Red. Garlic White sets out, following the path along the river in search of the sarong, until she spies an old woman emerging from a hut.

Act Two: Stepmother Mutiara and Red Onion Maya wait on the terrace. Garlic White should be back by now but hasn't arrived. *Hey, what's taking Annisa so long?* The girls look for her in the living room, and every other room, but their sister is nowhere to be found. They hurry to the kitchen. Mamak sits by the well, scrubbing clothes on a washboard; no, she hasn't seen Annisa. Mutiara and Maya head for the attic stairs—and are stunned to find the door to the forbidden chamber ajar. Annisa, no longer Garlic White, is peering inside. *Don't look!* It's a warning none of them hears. Mutiara and Maya tiptoe behind Annisa, trying not to make a sound. The two girls hold their breath. Their eyes grow wide.

In the room is a bed covered in a white sheet. Mirrors on the wardrobe's double doors give them a view of the person on the bed. There Mama sits, grimacing in pain, in a dripping wet T-shirt and a sarong around her waist. On the floor beside her kneels Papa, holding her hand. Before them stands a local elder, the Wise Man, a black peci on his head. He mutters a prayer—in a mix of Arabic and some unknown mysterious tongue. He fills his mouth with water from a glass and sprays it all over Mama's face.

The sky is golden pink when Papa readies the car and, assisted by Mamak, helps Mama shuffle out from the house. He opens the car door and gently lowers Mama into the passenger seat. Annisa darts out to her father, shrieking she wants to go too. Her older siblings dash after her. Victoria follows at a half-run and grabs Annisa by the hand. The little girl insists on knowing where her father is going.

Papa is taking Mama for treatment, says Victoria. You all stay here. Don't make a fuss.

So they're going to the doctor? asks Mutiara.

Victoria doesn't respond. She focuses her attention on her son and daughter-in-law: has he packed bottles of water? A change of clothes? Papa nods, then walks over to Annisa. She's pouting because she can't go. He strokes his beloved daughter's hair, assures her that he won't be gone long, as the older sisters exchange meaningful looks. Annisa stops whining. Papa kisses Mutiara and Maya on the forehead before getting in the vehicle. The three girls watch as the car drives through the gate and disappears.

What's wrong with Mama? Mutiara presses.

When you grow up, you'll understand, says Victoria. Mama is going to get treatment, and she'll get better, inshallah. We'll just wait here. Nana has a game.

She ushers her granddaughters back inside, to an antique Balinese chest in the living room. Arranged atop it are a flower vase, a miniature globe, and a blue urn with a dragon engraved on its surface. Nana lifts the urn and turns it upside down. A key slides out onto the floor—copper in color, not very distinctive, attached to a keychain that looks like a small pair of red shoes.

I'm going to hide this key, she says. Whoever finds it will get a prize. But remember, as you search, you must clean. The more thoroughly you clean Nana's house, the more likely you are to find the key.

Which door does it open? Maya wants to know.

Victoria smiles.

You'll just have to find out.

In the fairytale, Garlic White searches for Onion Red's sarong along the riverbank until she meets a mysterious old woman. She promises to reveal the sarong's whereabouts if the girl is good at helping with chores. Garlic

White toils so diligently that the old woman not only returns the sarong, but also presents her with a gourd filled with diamonds.

Victoria speaks. So if you girls work hard and keep searching, a special gift awaits.

Maya takes a deep breath as she eyes Mutiara, as if ready to surrender, afraid to compete. Everyone knows that Mutiara is a cleaning whiz.

Annisa's eyes light up. Is it a key to a treasure chest?

Call it a key to secrets, says Victoria. Great power is stored within. Whoever finds it will go on an adventure.

So Victoria's granddaughters begin their search. They start at the same point, the large teak cupboard in the living room. Its numerous doors and shelves and drawers make it an ideal hiding place indeed. Annisa and Maya have feather dusters, but Mutiara really looks ready for action, rag slung over one shoulder, broom in her hands. Every vase, book, and family photo is lifted and thoroughly cleaned. Mutiara barks commands at her troops: leave nothing unturned! All drawers are yanked open, fingers riffle through piles of paper, rummaging everywhere.

An oblong tin of Van Houten chocolates catches Annisa's attention, but inside are neither the key nor chocolates, just a stack of sepia photographs. Maya snatches the tin away and pores over each yellowing, faded shot. All three girls giggle at the sight of little Victoria in a studio, perched on her mother's lap, staring back at the camera. Neither child nor mother smile. The girls have never seen this picture, much less ever imagined their stern grandmother as a child. Maya holds up other photos. Some are from a ball, Victoria and her husband among other youths in suits and gowns. Many pictures are of people they don't recognize, adults their parents' age, or various grandmas and grandpas. How they're related to our family, no one knows.

Annisa points at a photo. Is that a friend of Nana's?

Maya looks thoughtful. Could be, she mutters.

Mutiara and Annisa renew their key-finding efforts as Maya studies the photo that caught Annisa's eye. She can't tear her gaze away from the two young girls in knee-length dresses, their hair in plaits. One poses atop a bicycle, the other stands with hands on hips. They're in a photo studio, against a backdrop of a tropical jungle. Maya instantly recognizes the girl

with arms akimbo. It's Victoria. She knows those features, that defiant stance, from how Nana stands in the kitchen, left hand on hip, right hand holding a cigarette. But who is *she*, the cute girl on the bike? Maybe *cute* isn't the right word; she's not smiling. She gazes boldly at the camera. There's fire in her eyes.

The three granddaughters disperse. Maya stays in the living room, examining the contents of all the drawers. Meanwhile, Mutiara combs every room, one by one. At first, Annisa follows her into Uncle Benny's old room, plastered with posters of Phoebe Cates and Raquel Welch, but she searches only briefly before heading off by herself. Mutiara remains in Uncle Benny's room, peering under the bed, poking the broom in annoyance at the dust-covered floor. Every now and then Victoria emerges from her room to check on her granddaughters. She and Mamak take turns.

Come on, keep looking. Don't give up too easily. If you can't find the key, it means you're not cleaning thoroughly enough.

Victoria returns to her room. Whenever she shuts herself away in there, it usually means she's sewing. By her bed is a black sewing machine with letters embossed in gold: S-I-N-G-E-R.

The hours slip by. Nana's antique clock chimes four, and the grandchildren take turns for the Asr prayer—the search has yet to bear fruit. The two older sisters are growing bored. The sheer filth in some parts of the house is setting Mutiara on edge. Meanwhile, Maya remains riveted by the old photos and cookbooks in Nana's drawers. Annisa has stopped cleaning entirely, but she's still determined to find the key of secrets.

Why are you stopping? scolds Annisa. If I win, I'll travel round the world by myself.

Mutiara leans her broom against Victoria's teak cupboard and flops down on the couch. Annisa runs to the forbidden chamber and tugs on the door, but, of course, it's locked. She returns to find both her siblings sprawled out on Nana's sofa. She still has ideas about where to look: maybe it's near the well. Mutiara shoots Maya a worried glance and proposes another place.

What about the wardrobe in Nana's room?

I already looked.

You're not being thorough enough. Check again!

Annisa races to her grandmother's room, to the relief of her two sisters, abandoning her original intention of heading to the well. Maya reaches into the cookie jar on the table and bites into a kastangel. Mamak bustles past. She's off to sweep the terrace and water the plants.

You get it, don't you? says Mutiara. Nana's game is just a trick.

Maya is puzzled. A trick? What for?

So we don't ask questions about why Mama has to visit a dukun.

Mamak stops in her tracks. Circling back, she puts a finger to her lips. Enough. Don't make so much of it. It happens all the time. When your thoughts are idle, lots of things slip in. That's why we get sick.

Mutiara tilts her head. What things, Mamak?

Mamak thinks for a moment—about how to best explain the matter to two young girls.

Like a kuntilanak? asks Mutiara.

I don't know, Mamak replies. The most important thing is to be on your guard so that nothing gets in. Don't let your mind be empty. Always remember Allah.

So Mama doesn't remember Allah? Mutiara asks.

The day's nearly over when they hear the car coming through the gate. Mama's back, looking more refreshed, no longer slumping to one side. Now she can crouch down, give her daughters a hug. Her movements are relaxed, or should I say, docile? Like a kuntilanak tamed, like a nail's been driven into her skull. Mama smiles, but something has dimmed the spark in her eyes. She's here, and yet she's not.

Are you still sick, Mama?

She shakes her head and strokes Annisa's hair.

It's almost Maghrib, she remarks.

She goes to her bedroom. Annisa and Maya seem happy their mother is healthy and back home. Mutiara watches her parents as they walk away, seeking answers she can't find.

Victoria approaches. So, girls, who found my key?

Nobody, answers Maya. Nobody's going on an adventure after all.

Oh, you'll find it, says Nana. It's just a matter of time.

The call to prayer echoes through the air. Enough games, it's time for salat.

Nana watches her granddaughters head to the bathroom at the back of the house to perform their ablutions in turn. On the way they steal a look leftward, at the room beneath the stairs, wreathed in cobwebs, drapes drawn tight.

Victoria can always sense when someone's stealing glances, snooping, observing, taking note of everything that's going on. Slowly, she turns—and to my surprise, addresses me as I hide behind the curtain.

Come out. Don't you want to play too?

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THE TRAVELER

Childhood Friends

Dinar and Rohana loved being together, spent every spare moment together—even though they already shared a dorm room and went everywhere as a pair. There were six bunk beds to each room. Rohana slept on top, and Dinar below. The girls were allowed to leave the grounds on Saturdays and Sundays providing they were back by five. Some stayed in and received visitors—parents, or sometimes boyfriends, though with the latter, surveillance was tight. Male visitors were only permitted to chat with the girls in the living room or terrace, or they could stroll together within a radius of five hundred meters, and even then, not for long. Other girls, with tiffin carriers filled with rice and assorted side dishes, would go picnicking by the river.

On weekends Dinar and Rohana would stand by the bridge, looking out over the flowing water. They would talk about anything and everything—their families, the teachers, what they were learning at school. History was Rohana's favorite subject, while Dinar preferred reading and writing, and liked to imagine herself as a character in the novels she read. She had just finished With Sails Unfurled *by Sutan Takdir Alisjahbana and the pair of them were talking about which sister each of them was like.*

"So which one are you, Maria or Tuti?" asked Rohana.

"Not sure," Dinar said. "I'm not as pretty as Maria, that's for sure."

"But Maria's boring. She's too nice. She likes everyone and everyone likes her, and anyway, she dies in the end."

"But I'm not Tuti either," said Dinar. "She's more like you. Smart, decisive . . . "

"I'm more rebellious than Tuti, but yeah, okay."

Dinar could see Rohana attending women's congresses someday in the future, just like Tuti in the novel—though following in Tuti's footsteps wasn't enough for Rohana ("We're writing our own novel, Dinar!"). Dinar tried to imagine her own

future, the person she would become. Would she attend meetings on women's rights? Or stay at home with her parents? And where would Rohana be in ten years' time?

A friend cycled past and reminded them they should be getting back to the dorm. Rohana seemed upset.

"I don't want to go back," she said. "I want time to stop right here, right now."

"Because you don't want to see Rusli tomorrow?"

Rusli was betrothed to Rohana. Just last week, the young man and his parents had paid Rohana a visit. Objectively speaking, he wasn't bad at all—dashing, even. He was always polite and his hair was always sleek and neatly combed. He had just graduated from school and had gotten a job in Jakarta. Rohana's parents hadn't chosen just anyone for their daughter: Rusli, well-educated and from a good background, had a bright future ahead.

"I don't want to get married," huffed Rohana. "Why should we have to? Why even bother going to school if we're just going to get pregnant and spend all our time taking care of kids?"

"You could be a teacher," suggested Dinar, "even after you get married."

"A teacher?"

"My mother says it's a noble profession. You'll be respected. And the hours are good for women with kids."

"So is that your plan? To teach?"

"I don't know," confessed Dinar. "I just want to be near my parents. Maybe I'm too obedient. I'm not brave like you."

"But women have to be brave, Dinar. We're going to start a revolution."

Revolutions always begin with ugly stepsisters. What sets me apart from Victoria is this: she was an only child from a well-to-do family. She never had to deal with siblings; whereas, my life changed forever when Annisa came into the world. Our places in the sibling hierarchy were cemented by our names. In 1978, early in my parents' marriage, back when they still had aspirations, the name Mutiara came to them, a pearl, a precious jewel from the sea. My mother chose the name, and Mutiara was indeed a child after her own heart, the steadiest, the strongest. By 1984, my parents' aspirations had shifted from hippiedom toward Islam, and "Annisa" sprang to mind—a beautiful, godly name for their most successful (pro)creation. Father picked it out.

Unfortunately, in the interim, I popped out—an accident. Or to put it more politely, "a surprise gift from God." In 1980, "Maya" was trending. There were Mayas everywhere. "As in the star Maya Rumantir?" teased my parents' friends, the name chosen at the last minute by both Papa and Mama.

Annisa wasn't even one when she started walking, which worried our neighbors where we were living at the time. What if she fell when no one was looking? My parents came to a big decision. They sent me to Tanjung Karang to live with Nana. It was only temporary, but to a child, two years is basically forever. When Nana came to pick me up, Annisa was dancing to a Stevie Wonder cassette, singing, "Aekoooo," her version of "I just called to say I love you." My mother and father laughed and clapped, as jealous little me stood wiping away tears, trying not to cry. Out with the old child, in with the new. Maybe that experience of feeling unwanted and abandoned took root, and ossified, and got me thinking: I wasn't Papa's or Mama's. I was Nana's child.

Once I grew up, I realized that all parents have reasons for what they do, even Hansel and Gretel's. They left their kids in the woods and kept their cool even when the pair found their way home instead of saying, *Shit, they're back.* Back then, my parents were struggling financially. They had their hands full dealing with three children, and it certainly didn't help that one was four years old and another just a baby. An infusion of funds from my grandfather allowed them to hire help, but the woman wasn't very happy working for such low pay. My father claimed she was too distracted by the bakso vendor she was dating. After all, someone had to be blamed.

Whenever I revisit the past based on my parents' version of events, I've tried my best to be understanding. But there's always that one nagging question: why didn't they send Mutiara to Tanjung Karang? My mother once tried to explain that Mutiara was already a big girl then, old enough to help look after Annisa. *Whereas I was just their little Roly-Poly, the one who ate too much,* or so I'd add in my head. My parents made the decision they did for purely utilitarian reasons. Upon reflection, though, maybe getting sent away was for the best. After all, Mutiara wound up being the shortest, from having to carry Annisa around when she was only six. It stunted her growth.

My father would always become maudlin when he told the story of seeing me off at the airport. How he waved at the plane as it took off. Not that I can verify it—I couldn't see him from my seat. But wouldn't I have had more cause to be upset? Granted, I don't remember bawling on the plane as I sat next to Nana. One thing was for sure: I came to have no regrets about staying at Victoria's House. Maybe I was even secretly happy to go on an adventure and leave my family behind. My memories of that period in Tanjung Karang are vague, but one photo would always stick out whenever I flipped through Nana's albums. It was taken on my birthday. No big party. Probably because I didn't have many friends. Nana and I are leaning over a cake, blowing out a candle shaped like a five. My grandfather sits on the right, clapping. I don't know what made them organize that little celebration, but my body still feels it, still carries the imprint of Nana's warmth. She hugs me from behind, cheek pressed against mine, blowing out the candle with me. Who took the photo? Mak Romlah? Maybe Rohadi's there too, eating a piece of cake, out of frame.

When it comes to the map of my childhood, I've never quite been able to place where Rohadi belonged. I dimly recall we were very close, but the sense that he wasn't family had been instilled in me too, by my father and uncles and aunts. He was just Mak Romlah's son, whose schooling Nana had paid for. Born the same year, we grew up together—at least until I turned six, when my parents took me back. It was from Rohadi that I first learned about the weretiger and kuntilanak.

When I was six, I loved trying on Nana's things and pretending to be grown up. I know from the goofy pictures Nana kept of me wearing her handbag and heels, face caked in powder, lips scarlet-red. Nana kept her lipstick tucked away in a dresser drawer. I found it while playing with Rohadi, and we tried to figure out how to put it on. I applied it and felt instantly beautiful. Rohadi grabbed it and put some on too.

I remember being annoyed by his mimicry sometimes. It made me feel less authentic. *What are you, my shadow?* Maya traipses, Rohadi trails; Maya preens, Rohadi primps. *Who says I'm copying you*, Rohadi would snap. *I've got my own style.*

Yes, yes. Of course. Everyone's beautiful at Victoria's House.

At first, Rohadi was pleased with how he looked. But then he felt his lips were too red. Like a kuntilanak!

"What's a kuntilanak?" I asked.

"A monster. She wears a long white gown dripping with blood," Rohadi replied. "She eats babies. That's why her lips are red."

He continued. "Have you ever heard a lady singing at night? Mamak says it's the kuntilanak. She lives here!"

"Where?"

"Near the well."

"Then . . . have you ever heard crunching sounds, Rohadi?"

"Crunching sounds?"

"You know. From the kuntilanak eating baby bones."

"No, never."

"Is the kuntilanak beautiful?"

"There, in the mirror!"

"Where?"

"Don't look!"

No one knew what the kuntilanak ate, or what she looked like. But at Victoria's House, everyone, seen or unseen, is beautiful.

After experimenting a little more with Nana's lipstick, we put on a play: *The Story of the Kuntilanak*. Rohadi played the part of the woman who gets turned into a kuntilanak, coming home in bright red lipstick, carrying Nana's handbag, and prancing around. Then I, the villainous stalker, would jump out and stab her to death—which was when Rohadi would turn into the kuntilanak. He put on Nana's mukena and hopped around the room—like a ghostly pocong. I laughed so hard I'd slump to the floor.

Then one day, mid-performance, Mak Romlah entered to see Rohadi decked out in his lady costume, lipsticked and handbagged. Shocked, she pinched Rohadi's skinny arm. Hard.

"What's wrong with you, Rohadi? Don't act like a girl!"

I'd never heard Mak Romlah sound so angry. Rohadi burst into tears. Roughly, Mamak rubbed the red off Rohadi's lips while I stood petrified, watching Rohadi cry. Eventually, she calmed down. She hugged her son. "It's okay, it's okay," she whispered. "Just don't let Nana find out."

"Why? What would happen?"

"I could get fired," his mother replied.

I didn't believe Nana could be that mean. And I couldn't understand why Rohadi's red lips made Mamak so furious. But I didn't dwell on it; I only thought about how it was Rohadi who'd gotten scolded. After all, I was the one who asked him to play.

After Mak Romlah left, I took his hand. "Rohadi," I said, "You'll always be my best friend. I promise. We won't play with lipstick ever again. And we'll keep this a secret from Nana."

"Cross your heart?"

"Cross my heart."

"But Nana will find out anyway," said Rohadi. "She's a weretiger, you know."

It was years later when I heard the stories about my grandmother being a weretiger from my father and uncles. They laughed them off as exaggerated gossip. Nana did have razor-sharp instincts, they said. She could sniff out any lie. Cousin Erika once said that tiger "instinct" was black magic and she worried on Nana's behalf. Those who dabble in black magic die painful deaths. It went against Islam, she said. Erika believed it was our duty to keep Islam pure—to return to the Qur'an and the Hadith of the Prophet (Peace be upon him, Salallahu Alaihi Wasalam).

My relatives spoke of the "tiger arts" as something abstract, invisible. But Rohadi had concrete proof. One morning, Mak Romlah had gone into Nana's room, concerned. It was already eleven, almost midday, and Nana still had not risen. Seeing Nana asleep, and how exhausted she looked, Mak Romlah didn't dare wake her. But when she swept the floor, she was stunned to find traces of soil scattered all around. She summoned the courage to creep closer and study Nana's face. My grandmother was slumbering deeply, as if she would never wake up. Then Mak Romlah realized that Nana's cheeks were scratched, as if she'd brushed against some twigs. Where had Nana been last night? Mak Romlah examined the footprints between door and bed, but she could find none in the corridor outside. It was as if everything had somehow taken place without her leaving the room: Nana's departure, and also Nana's return.

I treated this marvellous story about my grandmother as a secret between me and Rohadi—like the story of the kuntilanak. I never shared it with my sisters. I remember asking Rohadi at the time, in awe:

“So Nana is really a tigress?”

“Shh! Not so loud,” he said. “Not a tigress, *a tiger*. Not female but male.”

“I know your secret,” whispered Rohana.

They were having lunch in the school hall. On the menu that day was rice, braised beef, spinach, and little cobs of corn. Using both hands, Rohana picked up a cob, gnawing and sucking at it, making loud smacking sounds. Dinar didn’t dare follow suit. They were supposed to eat quietly, with their forks and knives, like their Dutch teachers had taught them. Only uneducated natives ate with their hands and smacked their lips.

Rohana continued. “At night you sneak out and come back just before dawn.”

Dinar shook her head.

“Don’t deny it. I’ve seen your bed empty. And in the morning, there are traces of dirt all over the floor. How do you go in and out without anyone noticing?”

Dinar swallowed and lowered her spoon. She studied the girls around them, busy eating and talking, worried one of them might hear.

“Don’t tell anyone,” she said in a low voice.

“Yes, but where do you go?”

Just then, the school bell rang.

My phone vibrates. I glance over, fingers still on my laptop keyboard. A call from Mutiara. It’s already evening, and all around me, people are leaving—the students who’d competed for seats in the morning, packing up one by one. Others take their places, night owls who’ll stay into the early hours. I’m reluctant to pick up and subject myself to more of my sister’s caustic remarks, but I finally relent.

“Hey, Muti,” I whisper, getting up from my seat.

“Maya. Annisa’s body has been taken care of.”

“So she’s already buried?”

“Cremated.”

I’m silent as she recounts, concisely and methodically, how she went back to Kotawijaya and handled everything on her own.

“Her daughter too?”

“Yes. I arranged coffins for them, even though their remains were in such a bad state. As for her husband, that’s not my problem.”

I hold back from probing further—how she came to her decision, given that Islam dictates otherwise; why she'd separated Annisa from her husband; why she hadn't visited our nephew, despite his narrow escape from death.

"You don't mind, do you?" she continues. "It's not like you're not religious."

It's true. I'm not. And when I die, I don't want anyone to go to too much trouble with my corpse. But for some reason it does bother me.

"I'm fine with it. But Papa might mind."

"Since when have you thought about Papa?"

Don't start, Muti. Please. Just stop.

I feel the urge to argue, even though I'm not sure what it would be about. Cremating Annisa? How Muti's acting like Papa's already gone (weird on my part, since I was the one who always disagreed with him most)? Or maybe I just can't stand seeing her make decision after decision, one after another, while I'm unable to do anything from here.

"Papa doesn't have much time left," she continues. "Mama . . . Nana . . . they're already gone. It's just the two of us now."

A bully in a hijab—that's my sister. I open my mouth, but nothing comes out. I'm too cowardly and have no right to say anything, to question anything. After all, I'm never there.

This time we manage to end the conversation without arguing, and I head back to my seat. My fingers return to the keyboard. I stare at the screen. I type two words, delete them, five words, delete them, and so on and so forth. I reread what I've written, paragraph by paragraph. Everything I've committed to the page has lost meaning. My story has come to a halt.

Closing my laptop and putting it in my backpack, I rise and leave the reading room. A night owl swoops in to claim my vacated seat.

From the eighth floor, through the transparent pane, I watch the people passing below. The sun will set soon, and the electric lights will bathe the library interior in a dim orange glow. The geometric pattern on the black and white marble floor makes me dizzy—and, somehow, drains me of all hope. Several years ago, there was a string of suicides—students jumping from the top floor—and that's the reason we now work in a prison, each floor walled in glass.

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A Nail for the Caretaker

Have We not made the earth an expanse,
And set the mountains as stakes?
(An-Naba: 6-7)

In the afternoon, outside the ICU, we're startled by the sound of a woman wailing. Moments later, two orderlies wheel a bed past the waiting area; on it lies a patient, stretched out, shrouded head to toe in a white sheet. Some of the other visitors crane their necks for a good look. I glance up briefly from the Qur'an. The woman who was wailing follows the bed. A relative on either side holds her up to keep her from collapsing in her grief.

"Inna Lillahi," says someone next to me. "Her husband was only admitted two days ago."

"How did he die?" another asks.

"Don't know."

"Poor thing, she's hysterical."

"Yes, he wasn't even fifty."

"May her faith be strong."

The poor woman really is beside herself. How frail she looks, like a leaf about to fall and be carried off on the wind. But I remain where I am, seated, perfectly still, Qur'an open in my lap. A caretaker does more than look after the house and see off the dead; a caretaker is a support, a stronghold, like a mountain. Mountains carry great significance in the holy book, not only because of their soaring peaks but also their roots, penetrating deep into the earth below. If not for the mountains that anchor the earth's crust and keep it steady atop the layer of magma, who knows, we might have all crashed a long time ago.

My roots go deep, they keep me steady, so I don't waver. Steadfast like the mountains Allah created. Volcanoes are mountains too. Under extreme pressure, volcanoes erupt. Here I am in my chair, upright and strong, but inside, something's shifting, almost imperceptibly at first, a centimeter or two. Slowly I begin to falter, to fall apart.

I check my phone for messages. My search for answers continues, and I know Allah will show me the way. He will lead me along the straightest path. I'm waiting to hear back from Sarah, Annisa's best friend from high school. I finally managed to contact her. She's busy with her three small kids, so we haven't had a chance to speak, just exchange messages over WhatsApp. She sent her condolences and a series of sympathetic messages, after which I asked if she and Annisa had kept in touch. An unwelcome question. She replied that they hadn't spoken for more than a year.

My query must have caught Sarah off guard. After all, wasn't everything clear? Annisa had joined a radical group which had stirred her to take action, and that was that. Maybe she was worried about the police wanting to question her, and with three kids to take care of, she didn't want the trouble.

I supposed Sarah had a right to know why I was digging for information, so I wrote: *I want to understand Annisa's deeper motivations. I'm gathering every clue I can*. I was honest, though I kept the extent of my preoccupation to myself—how wide, how deep, how desperate I felt. Who had started it? Who had stoked it? What kind of Islam had my little sister believed in?

Maybe out of respect for the past—Sarah had been close to Annisa and visited our house often—she promised to forward my sister's last messages to her. I haven't heard from her yet, but I'm hoping I'll find a clue. Something that will help me stand strong—a stake, a clamp, to secure and sustain me. To keep me standing firm so I can stake the world in place, like the mountains in the Qur'an.

I recall the stories about the kuntilanak near the well at Victoria's House. Maybe that's why a nail has to be driven into a kuntilanak's skull. Something has to hold her in place—and if the nail is ever removed, she'll fly into a fury and who knows what damage she'll cause.

I enter the ICU and stand watching my father. After witnessing the orderlies wheel away the shrouded body of the other patient, I felt the sudden urge to see him. I peek behind the partition to find the neighboring bed empty, already dressed with fresh sheets. Not a trace of the departed. How efficient the staff are.

Our turn will come, Papa. Someone will peer at your bed and find it in the same condition. Empty.

I whisper a prayer for my father: *Allahumma ghfirli wa liwalidayya*.

I remember being taught how to say a blessing for our parents: *Keep my mother and father in Your love just as they kept me in love when I was a child*. My father was incapable of being impartial, but he did take care of us. He watched us grow and mature, just like plants. Here in the hospital, I see nothing grow, only life withering and rotting away. But here I am nonetheless, looking after him. Like it or not, we once worked as a team—me and Papa, caring for Mama.

My mother also was brought here in her final days, but she died before reaching the ICU. In life, she was hospitalized several times, but the incident I remember most vividly was one we never brought up. It happened twenty years ago, in a different ICU—at a public hospital, not as nice as this one. Cases like hers weren't covered by workplace insurance policies, the hospital informed us. She lay unconscious for two weeks, and Papa sold his car to pay for her care.

"Pray for Mama, Muti," my father whispered.

I was twenty—and echoing through the corridors of that gloomy hospital, I heard Nana's command: look after the living, see off the dead. I tried to assure myself that Mama only needed looking after. I didn't want to see off anyone yet.

"If your sisters ask, remember what I told you."

"Mama had an accident," I replied, parroting what he'd told me to say.

And for all these years, that's what my sisters believed. No one knew otherwise, except Alfrida, who kept me company everyday during that time. There was a time when she was the only person who knew my secrets, with whom I shared everything.

After two weeks, Mama regained consciousness. Wordlessly, she hugged her three daughters, and all I could do was cry. All the questions stuck in my throat. We took her home—and didn't talk about it, for there was

nothing to discuss. When she was healthy enough to travel, she went away for a month to Sukabumi.

"Mama needs some peace and quiet," my father explained, to quell any suspicions. When she returned from Sukabumi, my mother was wearing a headscarf. Papa said Mama had spent the time taking religious lessons from a kyai. A kyai or a dukun, I wanted to ask but kept quiet instead. I already knew the direction this had taken. They thought my mother was possessed and they held an exorcism.

I finally understood what had happened all those years ago at Nana's house, when we peeped into the forbidden chamber, and while we were hunting for Nana's key. The treatment my mother had received was neither medical nor Islamic—a ruwatan. Words were recited—Qur'anic verses, mantras, who could tell? Then she was purified. That time at Nana's, the water the dukun had sprayed over my mother from his mouth was meant to drive evil spirits away. Holy? Who knows. Unhygienic? Absolutely. The mere memory of what happened makes me furious, at my father, at my grandmother. They treated my mother like a kuntilanak. They thought they could tame her by driving a nail into her head.

I head to the hospital parking lot and get in my car. My hand is steady as it moves between steering wheel and gear stick. My feet are practiced too, accelerating and braking smoothly. At twenty I couldn't drive, and when we had to rush Mama to the hospital, I had no idea what to do. I remember my father driving in silence as I sat trembling beside him, Mama's words filling my head: *Strong, Muti. Be strong.* My mind raced, searching for clues as to why, tracing all the events leading up to that day. I recalled when she had been shrieking hysterically, but also another time when she had given me a message, gentle but firm: *Remember, Muti. You must always have your own money. Never depend on anyone.*

The reason Mama worked was to support her mother and younger siblings. I once overheard my father complaining to my Nana on a long-distance call: *Mae's brothers are useless! They didn't even finish high school. All they know is how to gamble and drink.*

And the problems on Mama's side really did sound like something out of a soap opera. One day Bi Itje came all the way from Tasik to Jakarta to tell my mother about the domestic problems she was having with Mama's

younger brother, Mang Ujang. Mang Ujang beat her because he was depressed and unemployed.

"It's all too much, Mae," she sobbed in Sundanese—Teungteuingeun, Ceu Mae—before begging for a loan so she and her husband could start a small business.

My mother used money from her office to help her. Months later, we learned that Bi Itje had fled and used the money for agent fees to kick off her dangdut-singing career. Of course, the money was never seen again. Bi Itje returned home, my uncle returned to drinking and beating her, and Mama couldn't pay back what she'd borrowed at work.

Money became the main source of conflict for my parents. I remember dreaming about being born into a family where no one squabbled over money. But when she got married, Mama brought all her baggage with her—an "uneducated" family, my father would call them, and "not very Muslim." And she fell further into debt as the years went by. Her mother's house in the village was on the verge of collapse; it needed repair! Poor Aa Cecep's son; he wanted to continue his schooling, but his father was out of work. Over time Papa grew less tolerant of Mama's decisions, which he considered unreasonable. Mama, in turn, shouted at him more and more. And then she fell ill.

"She's gone crazy," Papa would say. "Or maybe she's possessed."

Maybe none of us ever understood her, but she was my mother. Mama made me who I am. See, Mama? I'm working hard so I don't have to worry about money. And needless to say, I don't know what it's like to keep a marriage together despite class and cultural differences. I don't even have a husband.

I loved Mama no matter what, in all her incarnations: when she advised me, *Be strong, Muti. You're Mama's girl. You must be strong.* When she made it as far as the front door with her suitcase, intending to leave Papa before lugging it back. When she sang softly as she made us breakfast in the kitchen before smashing all the glasses and plates. When I helped Papa break down the bedroom door, as we crouched over her in the darkness, crying Allah's name.

Now I find myself wondering whether Annisa took after Mama more than I knew. Whether they shared some connection. But no, I refuse to

believe it. Annisa was Papa's child, not Mama's. No one knew Mama better than I did. Or at least, I felt I knew her—in all her forms.

But, of course, I have my doubts.

When Mama returned from Sukabumi, I remember how healthy she looked, how she would always remind us to pray. How serene her smile—a mother who was truly motherly, at last. But how could I be sure that the woman in the jilbab who came back to us from Sukabumi was really my mother?

To this day, being in an ICU makes me me uneasy, reminding me how, for years and years, Mama was tamed. Just like a kuntilanak, whether it was Allah she had submitted to, or a nail.

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THE BRIDE

The Man of My Older Sister's Dreams

Jakarta, 1 July 2003

Dear Lingga,

This isn't really a letter for you. Maybe I'll show you my writing someday. I don't know when. Maybe next month, when we're both back in Bandung. Or sometime in the future, after we get married and have kids, or when we grow old together. Obviously not now, not when I'm barely nineteen. I'm too embarrassed to let you read all my silly little thoughts.

On Sunday we had guests. Ali visited for the first time in ages. When Mutiara was in her last year of high school, he used to come twice a week to tutor her in math and physics. I'd sneak a peek from my room whenever I heard him at the front door, calling out, "Assalamualaikum!" And there he'd be, an actual fourth-year student majoring in Engineering at UI, a stack of books tucked under his arm. *Oh wow*, I remember thinking. *He looks so grown-up, so mature.* You'll have to forgive me. I was only in sixth grade then.

Maya used to tease Muti. Your future boyfriend's here, she'd say, which made Muti turn red and start mumbling. My sisters assumed I didn't understand anything about romance because I was only twelve, but I always thought Ali was handsome, especially when he would adjust his glasses.

One day, Papa had me sit in the living room as Ali tutored Muti. I didn't understand why, but years later I learned that Ali had asked not to be left with Muti by himself. A man should never be alone with a woman without a mahram lest Satan be the third among them, according to the Hadith. "What a virtuous young man," Papa remarked.

Sitting with the two of them, I came to realize that Muti liked Ali. When he talked about mathematical formulas, she'd lean closer and tuck her hair behind her ear. Sometimes I'd see her tilt her knee a little to the left, maybe hoping to brush against his. When Muti started college, I thought they'd become a couple for sure, but no guys ever came calling, not Ali or anyone else. The only person who visited Muti was her best friend, Alfrida. She came every week. But Muti's never had a boyfriend.

So, yesterday, when Ali showed up at the house, I assumed Muti would sit with him and Papa and join the conversation. But all she did was serve them coffee and retreat to her room. To my surprise, Papa called me into the living room, and the three of us sat together until Ali left. Ali asked about my studies at ITB, about how I liked Bandung. I kept my answers brief. I felt shy about making eye contact for too long. He gave me a present, the latest copy of the Muslimah magazine *Aisyah*, and Papa told him my poetry had been published there. Ali seemed impressed: Mashallah, he exclaimed. Then he went back to telling Papa how he'd joined one of the Islamic parties and was pursuing a career in politics. I sat quietly with my eyes downcast. It's improper to look too long at a man who isn't a family member. And I sensed that he no longer saw me as a sixth grader.

Jakarta, 8 July 2003

Dear Lingga,

Today the postman delivered an express package. I thought it was a surprise from you. I dashed to my bedroom with it and tore off the wrapping to find a pale blue jilbab and a handwritten card: *Assalamualaikum, I hope this gift pleases you, Annisa.* It was signed by Ali.

Lingga, I swear. I didn't think about Ali once after his visit last week. I even kept quiet whenever Papa brought him up: *Ali is really something,* he'd say. *A graduate of UI . . . has his own business . . . going into politics . . . just turned thirty and already paying off a house.* I thought maybe Papa was planning to set him up with Muti, who, of course, is a more appropriate age. He's the only guy I've ever seen her attracted to. But now, after so many years, he's back. Only, it's not to teach her math.

The pale blue jilbab wasn't for her.

What would Muti say? *Why is it always Annisa*, maybe. But it's not my fault that I get all the attention. I know my sisters envy me and try to deal with it in their own ways. Maya makes fun of me. Muti tries her best to act maternal.

This evening, after Muti came home from work, she went straight into the kitchen to cook dinner. As she was chopping vegetables, the cats began meowing and she went to the cupboard to get their food. Every day it's the same routine: she wakes up super early and feeds the cats before going to work, she comes home around six and heads to the kitchen to cook dinner, then she looks after the kitties some more. At twenty-five, her life consists of working in an office, paying all the household expenses, devoting herself to our family and her cats. It makes me wonder: isn't there more to life?

I wonder about all the opportunities my sister might be missing.

I hid the jilbab from Ali in my closet. I won't tell anyone about it.

Jakarta, 10 July 2003

Dear Lingga,

Last night, there was a small quarrel at our house. I say "small" because my parents haven't had any big fights since Mama started wearing the hijab. Papa never argues with her these days, let alone yell at her like he used to.

Mama said she never wanted to see Ali in our house again.

That monkey! You should have just kicked him out!

Don't be so rude, Mae, Papa said.

You think I'm being *rude*? That what he did was polite? Don't you have any dignity?

Papa didn't put up much of a fight. He seemed to accept Mama's wrath and go along with everything she said. I didn't understand what they were talking about until Maya told me: Ali had wanted to ask me to be his wife.

Lingga, please know, you're the only one I want. Of course you are. But I'm curious about why Ali was so attracted to me. After all, he's handsome and smart, he's involved in politics, he has a bright future ahead of him and is becoming more established every day. Why would he be interested in me? I'm only nineteen.

Does it make you jealous, Lingga?

While they were arguing, I glanced at Muti. She was at the dining table kneading bread dough, a cat lazing at her feet. She looked unbothered. It's so hard to tell how she really feels.

Maya was the one who was angry.

Gross, she said. You know he already has a wife, right?

I shook my head, confused.

You mean he wants to get divorced?

Do you really not get it? He wants two wives.

Then Maya went on a rant about how much she hated the Islamic parties and polygamy, but I wasn't even listening. I was too busy processing what had happened. In the end I just laughed it off. I thought about the blue jilbab I'd hidden in the closet. There's probably another one that looks just like it, which he gave to that other woman, to show he divides his love fairly, two wives under one roof.

He thinks I have no choice.

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THE BRIDE, A BEAUTIFUL MOTHER

YOUNG MOTHER TURNS BOMBER

The Daily Hubbub, 23 May 2018

A photo of suicide bomber Annisa Dinda has been making the rounds on Twitter, shocking netizens. Taken when she was in college, the photo elicited much comment and debate, kicked off by a tweet from popular YouTuber Saddam Habibie (@saddam_habibie): "Annisa Dinda. Talk about a beautiful terrorist."

Most of the Muslim online entrepreneur's followers were in strong agreement, as the photo does indeed show a striking beauty. Many expressed regret that the young mother should turn to terrorism. "Headed straight to heaven as an angel?" tweeted one user, only to immediately come under fire from others, including Ustadzah Nyai Syarifah, who condemned the tweet as "disrespectful to the victims."

Other netizens blamed Saddam Habibie for detracting from efforts to discourage terrorism. "Terrorism shouldn't be glorified," said human rights activist Ahmad Syarief. "Don't make irresponsible comments just to get likes."

Meanwhile, activist and feminist Andini Yulianti from the Women's Commission observed that the whole matter was merely symptomatic of a broader, deeply worrying, social phenomenon. "You only have to look at media reports about women who've committed suicide or been murdered. They're still referred to as 'beautiful' even when they're dead," she said. "How sick is that?"

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THE BRIDE, A MOTHER FROM HELL

THE VALUES OF A TYPICAL FAMILY

The NYT Insider, May 21, 2018

Karen Anderson

The NYT Insider provides behind-the-scenes coverage from news and opinion pieces featured in the New York Tribune.

It was a photograph that initially sparked my interest in going to Kotawijaya—a family portrait, of a father and mother with their daughter and son. The boy in the photo isn't so different from one of my own sons, age ten. The girl smiles at the camera. She looks adorable in her pink headscarf. *A family like any other*, I thought to myself.

I flew from New York to Kotawijaya. My colleague in Indonesia, Dina Suprapto, met me there. Together we visited the family's home, a large, two-story house in a gated middle-class community. To all appearances, nothing seemed out of place.

Yet on May 13, the entire family took part in coordinated suicide bombings, one targeting a church, the other a neighborhood multipurpose center. Father, mother, and daughter perished, while the son, critically injured, is being treated in hospital.

The father, Muhammad Fahri, is thought to have been a leader of a local radical group called Jamaah Junud Al-Huriya, which has links to ISIS. The mother, Annisa Dinda, was known to neighbors as a stay-at-home mom, devoted to her children. As a mother, I found myself asking the same question that many are asking, to the point of travelling to Indonesia in search of answers: what could possibly have led these two parents to bring their own children along on a suicide mission?

Ending our own lives is one thing; taking innocent children to their death is another.

Over several days, we spoke to several people who knew Fahri and his wife. Everything about them seemed normal: their children liked to play outside, Fahri commuted to work by motorbike to avoid getting stuck in traffic, and his wife used their car to drive the kids to daycare, school, and various activities. She was always friendly to their neighbors.

Gibran, the oldest child, attended a prestigious private school run by a moderate Islamic organization. According to the school principal, Heru Suharyadi, interfaith dialogue is part of the school curriculum, with students taking excursions to local churches and Buddhist temples on a regular basis.

"Gibran was a model student, and his parents were active in the school community," he said. "If they can be terrorists, anyone can."

As of the publication of this article, Fahri's relatives, who also live in Kotawijaya, are still refusing interviews. But their neighbors remember Fahri as a fine young man who managed to secure a spot at a top local university, and that the family was respectful to those of other faiths. Moreover, Fahri's mother and sister apparently did not wear headscarves or give any other indications that they held conservative Islamic views.

One neighbor of the deceased, Sri Banowati, spoke to us about her last meeting with Fahri's wife, which occurred the day before the tragedy. Annisa knocked on her door, holding a large Tupperware container of braised beef. Annisa said she'd cooked too much and her family couldn't finish it all.

"She said I could keep the container," recalled Mrs. Banowati. "She really was a good neighbor to us."

Like me, Mrs. Banowati has two sons. Neither of us could imagine how such a good neighbor, and a fellow mother, could ever force her children into suicidal jihad.

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The Caretaker and Mama's Room

I still remember when the blue hospital bed was moved out of Mama's room and into the family room. It was positioned directly across from the television, facing away from the dusty display cabinet with its porcelain objects and shabby old dolls. The whole room was crowded with stuff: a brown leather sofa with scratch marks; a coffee table covered with medicine, vitamins, balms, and bottles of water; and, next to the bed, a folding chair where the nurse would sit. Near the foot of the bed stood a round marble dining table that had seen its heyday in the '80s. Now it looked outdated and drab. Atop the table was a blender, a permanent fixture, always plugged in. Sometimes it sat there unwashed for hours at a time.

After changing my mother's diaper and feeding her, the nurse would sit in the folding chair and wipe the sweat off her face. Then, left hand fanning herself with a thin book, she would scroll on her phone with her right thumb. On Sundays, her day off, it was me who would sit there. The bed made everything feel stifling and cramped. But Mama didn't want to be in her room.

"I don't want to be alone, Muti," she said.

I tried to reason with her. "You won't be alone."

But she insisted. And so there she lay, staring at the ceiling and listening to the TV. Whenever the nurse was busy preparing food, I'd sit beside Mama and work until the laptop grew hot on my thighs. Mama would make comments about the news, then tell me to turn to a soap opera. But soon she'd ask to switch back to the news. Soap. News. Soap. *Stupid, cheesy soap operas*, she'd mutter before finally telling me to turn the TV off.

Whenever she fell asleep, I would feel a sense of relief. I'd gaze at her face, her closed eyes, her chapped lips, half-parted, before turning my attention back to my laptop screen. But not for long, because ten minutes

later she'd open her eyes and ask me to read to her from the Qur'an. I'd choose a surah at random, and she would close her eyes. After fifteen minutes or so, she'd tire of my voice and have me find a reading of Ayat al-Kursi on YouTube. The volume would be too low, so I'd need to turn it up. Soon Mama would ask me to turn it down. Up. Down. Up. Off.

"Everyone dies," she'd remark. "But I'm not dead yet."

Papa, retired by this point, was always in the room. He would station himself near the dining table, at the ready. Before we decided to hire a nurse, he cared for Mama around the clock, except for the days I stayed over. I would come directly after work on Friday and leave only on Monday morning.

"No talk of death before its time," cautioned my father once. "It's a sin."

He got up from his chair and reached for his phone and keys.

"Where are you going?" Mama asked.

"To the mosque."

Whenever the call to prayer sounded, Papa would stand to his feet. He reminded me of a schoolchild, waiting for the bell, itching to dash outside. He'd rush to get the water for his ablutions, put on a fresh koko shirt, and comb his hair before donning a peci. He went to the mosque for all five daily prayers, every Fajr, every Zuhr, every Asr, every Maghrib, every Isha. After each mini-vacation he'd return home to my mother, to find her still alert, still drawing breath, alternating between the TV and recordings of Ayat al-Kursi, back and forth, on and off, twenty times or more. Mama was determined to make us as miserable as she was lying there on her blue bed. Outside the confines of her room, the bed took over. It became the center of the house, the heart of everything, imprisoning not only Mama but us all.

To me, my parents' bedroom was Mama's room—her place of refuge when she felt she had failed as a mother. When Mama was young, whenever she was fed up with the three of us, she'd go in and lock the door. The closed door, locked tight, served as a reminder: my mother wasn't easy to please.

I still remember when I was in fourth grade and Mama came to school to pick up my and Maya's report cards. It was Saturday. Even though she wasn't going into the office, she arrived in her work outfit: a blouse with

shoulder pads, a pencil skirt, and a pair of pointy heels. With every step she took, her short curly hair would give a little bounce, and the scent of perfume would waft from behind her ears—Chanel No. 5. A gift from her boss, used only for special occasions. I remember how proud I would feel whenever she picked up our report cards, because in 1987, she was the most stylish of all the moms—a career woman straight out of the pages of *Femina* magazine.

My mother came by herself, in a taxi. Annisa, only three at the time, had gone with Papa, who had taken the car to get repaired. Mama entered the assembly hall, greeted a few teachers, and found a seat. I could see all the housewives turn their heads, whether from envy or admiration. There, seated amid all the other parents, she gazed attentively at the stage, listening to the principal call out the names of the outstanding students that term. When he announced the second graders, Mama leaned forward. Maya's name wasn't mentioned. In first grade, Maya had ranked tenth; and only in the first term of second grade had she made it to fifth place. My sister had yet to be in the top three and had never ascended the stage.

The principal moved on. When he got to the fourth graders, my name was called, like in previous terms, but this time I'd slipped to third place after being top of the class for so long. From the stage I stole a glance at my mother, wondering if she was still happy with me. She kept her eyes straight ahead and clapped.

Mama congratulated us but didn't speak on the way back. Usually, after she picked up our report cards, we'd stop by the bookstore. Good grades always deserved gifts, but that day we went straight home.

Our family room was neat and tidy back then. The brown leather sofa still gleamed, the coffee table was draped with a white tablecloth, and the only thing on it was a vase of fresh roses, the water of which my mother never forgot to change. Mama walked straight to her room.

"Aren't we going to the bookstore?" I asked.

"You want a present?"

Her voice, curt and scornful, made me realize that I was being punished. Lower ranking, no bookstore. I felt wronged.

"Maya only came in fifth," I pointed out.

Mama turned. She came toward me, fixing me with a glare.

“Maya’s different,” she said. “You’re my firstborn.”

That was what she always said. Maya had a hard time concentrating, was good at reading and writing but bad at math, whereas I was the role model. I had to be reliable, responsible. The eldest child. Mama went into her room, and I stood outside for a very long time, the door shut tight.

I was my mother’s experiment, back when she still had faith in life. She was hard to please, so I spent all my life trying to show her what I could accomplish. Look, Mama, I’m top of my class again. Look, Mama, I can cook. Look, Mama, I’m taking care of my little sisters. I stopped only when I realized she no longer had faith in anything.

At night, Mama’s room turned into a battlefield. The fighting would start after ten, once my sisters and I were asleep, or so my parents thought. The first time I heard Papa shouting at Mama was when I was eight, maybe nine—I can’t recall exactly—and as the oldest, I knew I had to allay my sisters’ fears. Maya was always buried in her books and listening to her headphones, and I didn’t worry too much about her. But Annisa, Papa’s favorite, always wanted to know what was happening.

“It’s nothing,” I’d say. “Go to sleep.”

As we grew older, the fighting became more frequent. Papa would still shout, but now Mama would scream back. She even started throwing things. But the next day, when Papa left for work, Mama would lie on the couch listening to ’80s music, singing happily, giggling every now and then. *I just called to say I love you.*

I started keeping my distance from Mama’s room. I avoided my father because of his violent temper, but I also didn’t want to be around my mother. She would cry, then laugh, cry, laugh, cry-laugh, and I didn’t know why.

Sometimes, from her blue bed, Mama would do a roll call of her daughters. On one sweltering Sunday, as I fed her porridge, she stopped chewing and asked to turn down the TV.

“Annisa.”

“What about Annisa?”

“When is Annisa coming to see me?”

“I don’t know,” I said. “Eat.”

“She must be busy in Kotawijaya, huh? Husband . . . kids . . .”

In reply I fed her another spoonful. Slowly, she swallowed.

“And Maya? When is she coming home?”

“I don’t know. She’s saving up.”

“New York is far away, huh.”

“It is.”

“And Muti?”

I was silent, waiting. Didn’t she see me? I was always here, no child, no husband, no plans to go anywhere. Meanwhile my sisters were enjoying their youth, gorging themselves till they had their fill. And here I was, lacking the inner strength to follow my chosen path as the first child, the role model, the one who could always be counted on.

“The diaper is full.”

“Yes, I’ll change it after this.”

“Muti,” she said again. “Don’t you want to go out?”

One day, Mama called me into her room. I had just changed the water in the flower vase, something I’d been doing since my first year of high school because, in those days, she always forgot. When she told me to come in and sit on the bed, my heart began to pound. She locked the door. By the side of the bed was a folded prayer rug, and I touched the edge with my fingers. As if it could protect me.

“Muti,” she said. “You’re Mama’s child. You must be strong. You need to be able to earn your own living.”

We were sitting side by side. I noticed that Mama’s hair, now down to her shoulders, was wild and unruly. She no longer visited the salon every month to keep her curls in a neat bob. She had stopped working.

“Do you have a boyfriend?”

I shook my head. I was fifteen.

“Never depend on anyone,” she said. “All men are bastards.”

It was then, for the first and probably last time, that she opened up to me about Papa. Her tears flowed. I held her hand, and in my heart, I felt angry along with her, because I was Mama’s child.

See, Mama? I’m always here with you. I want you to be happy.

“Why don’t you just get a divorce?”

Her eyes widened and, I don't remember exactly how it happened, but she slapped me.

"How dare you," she barked. "Acting like you know what's what. You don't know a thing."

The ringing in my ears lasted for a long time. Then I heard nothing at all. Suddenly Mama was hugging me tightly, saying sorry, her tears spilling onto my shoulder. As she held me, I remained silent, tearless, because I couldn't recognize this strange woman clinging to me, because I could no longer feel the prayer rug, or my fingers anymore.

After it happened, Mama's room could no longer be locked. The wooden door bore rough scratches, marks of a forced opening, a secret between Papa and me. It happened in 1998, when I was twenty. My father pounded on the door. No sound came from within. I stood behind him, a toolbox at my feet, while he, drenched in sweat, knelt and picked the lock with a snap gun. The door flew open, banging against the wall, and though we hoped Allah would erase all memory of it, to this day I remember—clearly, without the aid of nightmares—my mother's arm hanging off the side of the bed, the bottle rolling on the floor, and Papa screaming at me because I didn't know how to call an ambulance.

After spending a year holding court in the middle of the house, my mother asked for the blue bed to be returned to her room. Surprised, we asked her why.

"I'm bored," she replied.

Papa nodded obediently. He never contradicted my mother again.

On the day Papa and the nurse shifted the bed into her room, I sat at the dining table, saying nothing, staring at the wooden door that could no longer be locked. My parents' room was a chest full of secrets, not to be opened. But that night, we had, and I would never forget.

My father's laptop was also moved to the bedroom; Mama wanted to continue listening to the Ayat al-Kursi recitations on YouTube. Papa complied. In retirement he rarely needed his computer, using his phone more often than not to watch sermons or exchange messages with friends. And so, after everything was in place—the blue bed, the folding chair, the laptop, the medicines—the vicious circle began once more: read

the Qur'an, play the Ayat al-Kursi recording, turn the volume up, down, up, down, can you find a soap on YouTube, enough already, turn it off.

Three nurses had resigned because they couldn't put up with Mama's nagging, so I began staying at my parents' almost every night. I ended up moving everything over: car, clothes, computer, cats. *Look, Mama, here I am, no kids, no husband, earning my own living. I pay most of your medical bills.*

I longed to tell her all this—like when I used to show off my work as a little girl, *look at my pretty drawing, Mama.* And how I longed to hear her say, *Oh Muti. I can always count on you. Mama's firstborn.* But I kept my mouth shut and sat beside her in silence, listening to Ayat al-Kursi, watching her chest rise and fall.

"Muti," she whispered.

I leaned in so I could hear her more clearly. Her breath was warm against my hair, her dry fingers brushed against mine, and I heard her soft voice,

"Mama's tired."

In 1999, my mother took up the hijab. I stood directly behind her, watching her in the mirror. On the dressing table, I could see cheap face powder, deodorant, a tube of broken red lipstick, a vase filled with plastic flowers. Mama's collection of expensive perfumes had been archived in a cupboard; no more bosses or rich acquaintances to buy her new ones. Mama asked me to zip her up. In the mirror, I caught a brief glimpse of a woman with bobbed hair in a pencil skirt and high heels, a woman with many dreams, who had lost faith when all her little experiments came to nothing. I blinked. My mother's hair was still long and unkempt, but under her headscarf, none of that was visible now.

"What made you decide to wear a hijab, Mama?"

"A hijab protects the heart, you know."

Since that day, when we had forced open the door to her room, nothing had been the same. Mama spoke in clichés now, and I prepared myself for the usual lecture given by bearded clerics who told women to take up the veil. Instead she said something I'll never forget.

"There will come a time when you will have to veil your heart, and bind it tight," she said. "So many snakes inside. Don't let them out."

I never had a chance to tell my mother she was right. Several years later, when my heart grew too wild, I made the decision to wear the hijab.

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A Postcard for the Traveler

As I ride the F train, a shabby-looking man makes his rounds, holding out an empty potato-chip bag and asking for change. I pretend not to notice. Turning to my left, toward the window, I stare at my weary face reflected in the glass, against the backdrop of stations passing by. I'm in no mood to be generous; I have nothing to share. Total word count for the day: zero. The library is no longer my refuge, but at least I'll soon be back at my apartment—*home*, even, if I may be so bold, since someone's waiting for me there. Nadir is still caring for me. Tatyana went to stay at her boyfriend's for a few days. Maybe she sensed I was unwell and needed space. I wonder who Mutiara vents to when she gets home. Her cats?

A woman in a headscarf boards the train with her two children. They sit across from me. In another life, maybe this would be Mutiara, with her little family, but I don't remember her ever having a man in this life. Our pretty little sister, on the other hand, never wanted for admirers. I remember her first boyfriend—just his face, not his name; then her second boyfriend, Lingga, and finally, Fahri, whom she married. Not to mention all the unofficial ones, the suitors who courted her online and by phone. One of them even had a wife and still tried to propose—Ali, Mutiara's former math tutor. He actually had the nerve to make a move on Annisa. As for Mutiara, she was always different. We all thought she had a crush on Ali, but that he wasn't interested. There hasn't been a single boyfriend since. Just Alfrida, her best friend from college. They spent all their time together. But when Alfrida married a foreigner and moved abroad, Mutiara never mentioned her again.

By the time I get to my apartment, it's eight o'clock. I fish the key from my bag and unlock the door. The door to my room is ajar and I can hear Nadir talking to someone. I take off my shoes and head wearily over to the kitchen sink. I turn on the faucet. Nadir still doesn't hear me, despite the running water, and I feel even more tired than before.

I walk into the room and toss my backpack on the floor, catching Nadir off guard. Lowering his voice, he ends the phone call. I make note of his last words: not "goodbye," but "see you later"—yes, "later." Because that's what there will be: a tomorrow, and tomorrow, and tomorrow.

I stare at him, my arms folded, fingers digging into my flesh.

"Her father is sick," he says.

I turn away, my heart too small for forgiveness or pity, and I feel it shrink, smaller and smaller, until it's completely deflated, with no space for anything at all. Nadir calls after me, but I walk out to the kitchen without turning my head. I remove the swollen black garbage bag from the trash can. It's been three days since the trash was taken out and my kitchen is starting to stink.

"Maya—"

Grabbing the keys from the table, I stride out with two bags. I walk briskly down the stairs to a pair of bins behind the building, black for regular trash, blue for recycling. As I hurl the bags in, I feel a sense of satisfaction spread through me amid the stench of garbage in the air. I get an inkling of why Muti likes to clean.

Piece of junk boyfriend. This is where he belongs. Just throw him away, he's non-recyclable. That piece of shit. How dare he call that other woman from my apartment.

But Maya, you're the other woman.

Be quiet! My grandmother, meddling again. I wish I could silence all these pesky voices in my head, including hers.

I've taken out the trash, but I still can't bring myself to hurry back up. I'm still seething. I head to the mailboxes. After not checking for so many days, there's bound to be a lot of junk. Tatyana and I are both lazy and only empty the mailbox once a week—if we even remember. So ads for everything from supermarkets to pizza joints tend to pile up.

Not one letter for me. Tatyana, Tatyana, Tatyana. Ad for Target. Domino's. Then I feel something different. It's thicker, and glossy. I pull out a postcard of a ballerina in red shoes. Slowly, I turn it over; the back is plastered with Indonesian stamps and a postmark—that city. I choke up and my eyes mist. My heart skip several beats as I read words written in a hand vaguely familiar to me:

Where to next, Maya? Jannah?

I don't know how long I stand staring at the postcard. Annisa sent it three weeks ago, or so I gather from the postmark. It had been ages since we last emailed or called each other, let alone sent any letters. Every year I received Eid greetings from her on WhatsApp, but I'm sure it was a generic message she sent everyone. And now, after all this time, here was this postcard, traversing land and sea to arrive in my hands. A souvenir from the dead.

I stare at Annisa's handwriting, pretty much unchanged from her teen years, and search between the neatly written lines for gaps. In the strokes of the *M*, in that full, rounded *a*, I hunt for clues, I feel for cracks. She already knew she was going to kill herself when she sent the postcard to America, fully aware I'd only receive it after she was gone. But why?

How am I supposed to read this postcard? As a farewell? A cruel joke? A cry for help?

She never asked me for help before, but maybe I simply didn't recognize when she had, or how. After the incident with the well I promised to look after her. But of course, she grew up. She didn't need looking after, and we went separate ways. I always assumed she was doing just fine on her chosen path. I'd get updates from Papa or Mutiara: that being a stay-at-home mom kept her busy, that she was determined to find good Islamic schools for the kids, that she had gone through a number of housekeepers, and so on. She never got really sick, or had an accident, or became depressed when someone died. Mama's passing was hard on us all, of course. And Annisa was sad, but we always knew she was Papa's girl. But Mutiara—I think Mutiara was hit the hardest by it, so much so that she started wearing the hijab.

But maybe I'm missing something.

An incident comes to mind, which I dismissed at the time. It happened after Nana came to live with us in Jakarta. It was dinnertime, and Annisa wasn't home yet. We started serving up the rice and side dishes, but Nana went on strike. She refused to eat until we knew where Annisa was.

Annisa came home at ten, head downcast, face swollen and bruised. She struggled to get the story out: a gang of thugs had pushed her off her motorbike, knocking her to the pavement. Then they took her bike and fled. We didn't report what happened to the police because Annisa locked herself in her room for days afterward in her distress. And my father

didn't want to traumatize her further by having things drag on. We never retrieved the bike, but at least Annisa was safe.

Something seemed off that night, but I was too busy with school and never brought it up. I remember how attached Annisa was to Lingga before she married Fahri. They were both from Jakarta and had gone to Bandung for college. My father's blood pressure rose whenever he knew they were staying out late, worried that they might sin, and he was grateful when they broke up. Where was Lingga when Annisa was robbed? Why was she going home alone?

Had she really been robbed?

I did wonder about it, but preparations for America took over, and life rolled on: Annisa graduated, got a new boyfriend, married, had kids. We had our own lanes, and Annisa was speeding along. She didn't have time for lengthy pit stops.

We left her not at the well but somewhere else. I keep reading the postcard over and over: *Where to next, Maya?*

I won't follow you to Jannah, Annisa, because you're not there. I need to go back and find where you were left behind.

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THE BRIDE IN LOVE

Tanjung Karang, 31 May 2003

Lingga called me at midnight. I answered in a low voice because when we're at Nana's, I share a room with Muti and Maya. We whispered to each other in the dark.

You're still awake?

I can't sleep. I miss you.

I miss you too.

I want you. I keep having dreams about you.

What kind of dreams?

It's a secret. You'll get angry.

Why?

What are you wearing?

Um, why?

I want to see you.

My heart fluttered at the sound of his voice, softly vibrating in my ear. Next to me, Maya stirred restlessly.

I'll call you tomorrow, I said.

But I couldn't sleep all night. My heart was racing, with yearning, with shame. I couldn't stop imagining him, strong and tall, gazing at my body, covered only in see-through white French lace.

Bandung, 7 October 2003

Lingga,

I keep thinking about the two of us that evening, in a quiet corner of campus near the bathrooms, afraid of being caught, like thieves. Every second of what happened hangs over me as I walk down the street, when I'm riding the bus, as I sit at my desk. We're only a step away from sin, I said. But we've already been sinning, you replied. Then we each went back home. You and I haven't told a soul, but I feel like every stranger on the

street knows my secret. They stare and point at me, a woman who doesn't lower her gaze, a woman with a jilbab but without morals. Don't you feel any guilt?

I do. I've sinned. And I remember it late at night, when I'm trying to fall asleep, imagining Hell, and you—the sound of your breath, so close, your fingers on my skin—both tormenting me.

Bandung, 30 January 2004

Lingga,

What happened wasn't your fault. Wasn't I the one who started it? It was my choice, and I have no regrets.

All my life, I've had voices telling me who I am, what to do, saying I'm too young, too spoiled, too naive. *Annisa, Papa's little girl. We have to protect her*. Then Muti came along, trying to arrange everything, insisting on mothering everyone and anyone, sisters, cats. But I'm twenty and I've had enough of being bossed around. Who can deceive me now, or have power over me?

No one can know who I truly am.

I allow only you to enter and discover me. And every time you do, I breathe it in, the dust of the open road as I bury my face in your neck. I want to break free.

No one knows every recess within me but you. There is no story like ours. And we will always be together, inseparable, forever.

Bandung, 18 February 2004

Lingga,

Papa called yesterday and told me to bring you to our house. Who is this Lingga? he asked. A respectable woman should be courted appropriately. A suitor has to ask for a woman's hand.

I said nothing. Papa thinks of me as a precious object, to be handed over from father to husband. I wasn't happy about what he said, but I love him, and I fear Allah. I can't talk about any of this with my friends in the Young Muslimah program. They're always asking about you, but I'm afraid of being judged. I'm beginning to keep my distance from them. I think I'm afraid of being found out. I'm afraid they'll see past my headscarf and find traces of you there.

Bandung, 28 March 2004

Lingga,

The way you acted yesterday—I could hardly recognize you. I've never seen you so angry. I cried, and you apologized and said, I love you too much.

I believe you, Linga, but you're scaring me. We won't be like that again. Can you promise?

Bandung, 10 May 2004

Lingga,

I used to like making you jealous. You said I belonged to you, that I was off limits to everyone else. My heart would beat so fast when you said it, because, despite everything I had, no one had ever desired me so much. Maybe it's because I've only ever known so few ways to feel valued: to be desired, adored, courted, won. But that was before.

I can't breathe!

You're holding me too tight. Let me go.

Bandung, 30 June 2004

Lingga,

I never said I didn't love you anymore. All I said was no. I didn't say no yesterday or the day before, and I'm not saying no to everything that lies ahead. I've given everything to you and I'm willing for you to hold my future in your hands, but for a short while, I want my limits, my body, for now.

Jakarta, 22 July 2004

Lingga,

You've apologized so many times, and frightened me so many times. It feels like I'm on a tightrope that could snap at any moment. I'm afraid to ask. I'm afraid to talk. I can't turn to anyone because I'm afraid of being judged—what's the use of being religious, what's the use of wearing a jilbab? I fear your anger, but I fear them more.

But you're right, we've been through too much, we must bear our sins together. And I'm afraid of losing you more than anything else.

There is no story like ours.

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THE TRAVELER DEPARTS

When I return to my apartment, Nadir showers me with apologies. Usually, we'll spend hours arguing and discussing (yes, we have plenty of time for that), then we'll make up and make love. Greedily, we'll savor every kiss, every nibble, because the argument we just had makes what we have seem more fleeting, more temporary, more tenuous. Tonight, I skip the first part of the menu. Without responding to Nadir's apologies or mentioning the postcard, I kiss him and pull him onto the couch. We make love, because I want to remember that I'm alive, for in another reality it could be me and not my sister who's turned to ash. And now, panting, pulse racing, heart pounding, I cling to every hot, sweaty second to remind myself: I throb with life.

Sex with Nadir always calms me down but it also makes me uneasy. I feel like an addict. The noise in my head subsides, and together, in my tiny room, we doze off. But the drug wears off, and at 2:00 A.M. I wake to find myself wide-eyed in the dark, a tightness in my chest. I go to the kitchen for a glass of water, and sit cross-legged on the couch.

I get out my laptop and click on a folder I haven't opened in a long time—photos of our family. The most recent picture of me with Annisa was taken in Indonesia, during Eid in 2016, because it's been two years since I've been back. I come across photos from her wedding reception. How stunning she looks, standing next to her husband in her kebaya, her white veil sweeping the floor, the rest of us flanking them, like ladies-in-waiting. It was always Nana's secret past that I pored over, turning it over, sizing it up, the beating heart of it, warm and wet. And all the while, I overlooked my mother and sisters, dismissed them as two-dimensional, like these photos, square and flat, no hidden depths beneath their headscarves.

Dinar woke up in the middle of the night to find Rohana beside her. She must have climbed down from the top bunk and slipped under the sheets. Dinar almost

cried out, but Rohana put a finger to her friend's lips.

"I know your secret," Rohana whispered. "There's a wild animal you keep inside you."

In the darkness, Dinar's eyes grew wide. She didn't dare move for fear of waking up the other girls.

Rohana continued. "Do you want to know my secret, Dinar?"

Dinar felt Rohana's breath, soft and warm in her ear.

"There's another Rohana," she whispered. "And she wants to break free."

It's four o'clock when I return to the room. Carefully, I climb into bed and lie next to Nadir, who's still sound asleep. Nadir's not a home, just a stop along the way, and I must be growing more dependent on him, my calming drug. He hugs me in his sleep. I've spent so many years running away, now I'm tired. How I wish we could stay this way.

Those are dangerous thoughts, Maya.

I'm hardly religious. But tonight, I seek refuge in God—*deliver me from evil spirits and their wicked temptations, including that damn weretiger in my head.*

It's here. Departure day. Nadir and I have arranged everything: handing over my keys to Tatyana's friend, who'll sublet my room for the month I'm away in Indonesia; booking a cab to JFK for 8:00 A.M.; tying a red ribbon on my suitcase handle for easy identification. We discuss my plans in Jakarta. I'll stay at Mutiara's and visit my father. We even talk about how to steel myself for talking about Annisa with my sister. Pain needs planning.

What we don't discuss: our future. Nadir says his wife won't be picking him up from the airport, and I smile wryly at how he appears to regard this as some sort of minor triumph. His willingness to be so sly means nothing to me now, apart from the fact that we can be more leisurely in our melodramatic farewell before I take a taxi to my sister's. After all, we both know who he's going home to.

"We'll meet up," says Nadir, but I cut him off. We both know it's not as easy as that. Like how he intends to tell her he wants a divorce, but something always seems to come up—a problem with his mother, one of

her relatives falling sick, blah blah blah. Meanwhile, isn't it amazing? My own sister's dead, and it hasn't changed the situation between us one damn bit.

On the plane, when the cabin lights dim for take off, Nadir squeezes my hand, as if to say, *even if it all comes to an end in this life, we'll still be together.* Such moments are emblematic of our relationship—its ambiguities, its boundaries, its recklessness, with a death wish running through it all—but here, with Nadir's hand in mine, I pray. I don't want to die now. Not because I'm afraid of going to hell, no, not that, but because I haven't made my mark on the world yet. And now I'm too late—now, no matter what I do, there's no escaping her, the ghost of my little sister, trailing after me, grilling me with questions: *where were you*? *How could you let it happen?*

The seatbelt sign has been turned off, but the cabin lights remain dim. Next to me, Nadir watches a movie, headphones on. I try to keep myself occupied too and pick something to watch at random, but I get bored. Meanwhile, Nadir's glued to his screen, utterly absorbed, occasionally frowning or breaking into a laugh. I reach for the bag I've stowed under the seat in front of me and take out my notebook. There's nothing left for me now. I'm on a plane with my lover, maybe for the last time, and I must keep my dangerous thoughts at bay. *You don't want a home, Maya.* So, I keep on writing, I must, on my boat, with my books. In the soft glow of the cabin lights overhead, I turn over a new page and begin.

Turn out all the lights. Let's hide, you and I.

Dinar's eyes were wide as she lay there in bed. Soon she would steal away, run off into the forest, but for now, here she was, Rohana's breath warm on her neck.

Her voice came out in a whisper. "Dinar, do you want to run with me?"

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THE BRIDE RUNS

Bandung, 14 November 2004

Lingga, I want to be a beautiful bride for you. But if I stay with you, I'm afraid of losing my head.

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THE TALE OF AL-MA'IDAH; OR THE REPAST ON THE TABLE

(Remember), when the faithful followers of Isa said, "O Isa, son of
Maryam! Will it please your Lord to send down a repast
for us from the sky?"
Isa replied, "Fear Allah, if you are men of faith."
(Al-Ma'idah: 112)

At Victoria's House, not a mouthful of food was to be wasted. Ingrates, she'd mutter if she spotted a morsel left on a plate. And we'd know she was sneering not only at her granddaughters but also their mother in Jakarta, too busy—negligent, to be precise—to attend to her children's *zalim* ways. Nana insisted that was what she meant: not *mubazzir*, but *zalim*—not *wasteful*, but *cruel*. Every meal at that table became a lesson in godly behavior: offer prayers, be grateful for food, be thankful to Allah.

The followers of Prophet Isa asked God to send a repast from heaven, and Isa urged them to fear Allah. Understand, all of you? So, read! Nana would thunder. Read the surah of Al-Ma'idah, of the banquet on the table. Food doesn't fall from the sky like rain but reaches us after a wondrous journey, helped on its way by the work of many people, many hands—the hands of those who plant, of your father who works day and night, of Mamak who cooks in the kitchen—glorious is Allah and His hidden ways.

A wondrous journey! Annisa was delighted. Does everyone on the wondrous journey get to be happy and eat yummy food?

No, not everyone gets to be happy and eat well, Nana answered. And that's why you should never act spoiled.

But one evening, at a round table, a last supper, Nana refused to touch her food. Here was a different repast, a different dinner, in Jakarta not Tanjung Karang. Victoria's House had lost its power, and Nana felt it. Her

mortal form was giving way, the roof beams gnawed away by termites, the walls cracking, mildew spreading, out of control; a vacant house, empty, the kuntilanak's song heard no more. Gone, the mighty matriarch holding sway over the dinner table with her booming voice. In her place, a hunched woman in a wheelchair, soft-voiced, brittle. There, in that strange house, that foreign territory, cramped and crowded with junk, sat Victoria at the round table, to partake of the repast, in the company of her two granddaughters, her daughter-in-law, her son.

Where is Annisa?

At her question, they exchanged glances. Annisa had gone out earlier, to attend her high school reunion. But now it was eight o'clock and she still wasn't home.

Look for her, she said. Don't stop until you find her.

Nana refused to eat until Annisa returned. She'd never acted like this before, but perhaps it was the weretiger within, whispering that something wasn't right.

The evening rolled on. The entire household went into action, ringing all of Annisa's friends, since Annisa wasn't answering her cell phone. The eldest grandchild kept vigil near the phone, the second made sure that mother and grandmother stayed calm, the father made frequent trips to the bathroom: the anxiety was giving him diarrhea.

Finally, at ten o'clock, Annisa returned, her face swollen and bruised. She said she'd been attacked, and her motorbike stolen. Mutiara went pale but knew she had to get the situation under control. She tended to Annisa, reassured her parents to keep them from bombarding her with questions and adding to her trauma, and told Maya to be matter of fact when she informed Nana ("let's not make matters worse by giving her a heart attack.") As bidden, Maya entered Nana's room and announced that the long-awaited granddaughter had returned. Victoria shook her head. Maya thought that Nana, who was starting to lose her hearing, hadn't understood. She repeated, more loudly: Annisa is home. Victoria shook her head even harder.

What do you think I am? Deaf? she barked. Look for Annisa. Don't stop until you find her!

And so, ladies and gentlemen, here ends our final tale—from the House of the Three Sisters, that is, not Victoria's House. The storyteller gets ready, shuts the book and folds the chair. The curtain will rise soon. Any moment now.

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PILLAR OF SALT

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THE CARETAKER

Pilgrimage

I've just stepped out of Papa's room when a junior nurse asks me to follow her. I hurry along behind her without asking any questions. In my mind's eye I picture a doctor wanting to discuss my father's condition, or an administrator waiting to tell me what costs aren't covered by insurance. The nurse keeps walking, down the corridor, past the waiting area with its rows of chairs, toward the glass door leading out of the ICU. She holds it open for me.

"If you please," she says.

Then she goes back in, leaving me next to a woman in a navy-blue pant suit and a stocky man holding a video camera. My eyes narrow. Meanwhile, the reporter, a friendly-looking young woman, introduces herself and the TV station she's from. She holds a microphone, while the man next to her, sweaty and silent, readies his camera.

"What's going on?" I ask.

"It won't take long, Ma'am. A few minutes of your time."

As soon as she mentions Annisa, I realize my mistake. I've dropped my guard and the flies have slipped in. The nurse just now must have been new, still green. I could report her. She'd get a warning right away. But these journalists truly have no shame. How naive I was, to assume it would go no further than the hospital in Kotawijaya, with all the reporters prowling around the morgue.

"Who told you to come here?"

The reporter shoots a quick glance at her colleague before replying. "Sorry, Ma'am, our source has asked to remain anonymous."

"I haven't given any consent for media coverage. You two had better go."

I won't allow my family to fall prey to these vultures. The woman tries to explain herself, but I'm not listening. Her colleague is pointing the camera in my direction.

"Hey!" I say, jabbing a finger at him. "Stop it now!"

He lowers the camera. The reporter signals to him before turning to me and folding her hands in front of her, eyes downcast, in an attempt to convey sympathy. Talk about bad acting. Her tone remains the same, sweet and crisp, toothache-inducing.

"Apologies for the inconvenience, Ma'am."

Inconvenience. A word I'm all too acquainted with, though she doesn't know it. I too work for a corporation. We use the word to downplay the losses people suffer: with regard to their time, their work, their emotions.

"Shut up and leave before I call the police."

I arrive at work the next morning and cast an eye around the parking lot to make sure no one is following me. Keeping a brisk pace, I stride through door after door, making my way toward the elevator. A cameraman could ambush me at any moment, who knows? Yesterday's incident has put me on high alert for reporters scrounging around, in pursuit of the sensational, in an effort to extend the news cycle. Faces I've never seen before have started appearing on TV—Annisa's neighbors—one after the other, giving firsthand accounts about the suicide-bomber family. Viewers are invited to picture Annisa's family, to reconstruct them in their minds: *Who could have imagined? They're no different from the rest of us! The husband would drop the kids off in the morning before driving to work, the wife looked after the house, and on weekends they went shopping at the mall!*

Once they've exhausted the supply of neighbors, reporters begin hunting down relatives, siblings. From the news I learn they've tried to interview Fahri's parents in Kotawijaya, with no success. In the end they resort to broadcasting shots of their house from the outside, a news anchor's voice explaining that the family refuses to talk, along with background music—what a cheap trick—to lend an air of tension and mystery.

A coworker stops to greet me, chatty and jovial, and I nod along without paying attention. Every person who says hello in passing I regard with distrust. No one must know. I don't want my life to become even

more of a circus than it already is. I close my office door, turn on my computer, and start replying to emails from clients, efficiently, robot-like. There's a formula to everything. I check off every task I complete. Check. Check. Check. I've almost emptied my inbox when my eyes land on a message from Alfrida. For a moment, I hold my breath. Then I open it.

Are you alright? I'm worried. Do you want to talk about it?

Talking about things, a luxury of the past.

Sometimes, back in college, we'd talk until morning. There in my snug, warm room, Alfrida would lie in bed reading comics, hair spread across my white pillow.

Suddenly, I recall her letter, the one she sent me from Wellington, which I left unanswered for days. Her departure—something she had long talked about, made plans for—had stirred up strange feelings. And in my twenties, I'd been incapable of identifying most of them. So I replied*, If only I'd known. If only I were brave enough. But to do what? Now it's too late. I'll do what I can.*

My fingers rest on the keyboard, motionless, frozen. I must remember not the past, but this: Alfrida, now forty, working at a nonprofit and living in New Zealand—a wife and mother of two. I have no right to burden her. I type a short email and, without pausing for thought, hit send:

I'm fine. I'll tell you about it later.

At noon I check my phone. Sarah has compiled all the messages she's ever received from Annisa and sent them to me. They're in chronological order, "I changed my number and don't have any from before this," Sarah explains. Many are conversations about their kids, or such matters in general—*apparently School A expects its students to recite the Qur'an from memory starting from sixth grade; I hear the teachers at School B conduct some classes in English and Arabic*. Not too different from what Annisa talked about when I saw her last. Other messages consist of text copied and pasted from Islamic websites and forwarded en masse, like:

Why Scattering Flowers on Graves Is Not Permissible

Annisa once sent me a similar message—about why we shouldn't scatter flower petals over people's graves, as there was no evidence to indicate

the Prophet did.

Sowing flowers is an infidel tradition adopted by Muslims who mix too much with infidels.

I argued with her. The Prophet once placed wet branches on a grave to lighten the torment of the deceased, says one Sahih Hadith. "Be careful how you interpret it," Annisa replied. "Good deeds, not wet branches, save us from eternal punishment." We never discussed the matter again, not because Annisa convinced me, but because I had more important things to think about. Now I think about how she's gotten what she wanted. No flowers. Not even a grave.

I scroll through the other texts Annisa had forwarded. They became more political over time:

Those in power are breaking their promises to the poor.

Defend Islam. Join us in protest.

Free Palestine.

Empty words. Annisa always had it so easy. When our family nearly lost everything in the late nineties, her only concern had been getting herself back to safety in her middle-class lifeboat. She studied hard, and worked, and began dating a Muslim boy from a well-to-do family. When did she ever think of the poor, let alone Palestine? I'm not too surprised at her sharing messages and articles prohibiting this and that; she had always been legalistic when it came to matters of fiqh. The most trivial things would annoy her as un-Islamic, from flowers on graves to statues in the home. But politics was another matter. It had never been her flavor of choice.

Protect our children from the LGBT Threat.

This stopped me in my tracks. Was this why Annisa chose to blow herself up at a gathering of trans women? Two years ago, she and Maya

had fought over a similar message she'd sent to the WhatsApp group chat for our extended family.

You're spreading hate, said Maya.

Don't you care about the children, Annisa replied.

When we talk about 'LGBT,' we're not talking about individuals. We're not attacking anyone on a personal level. What we take issue with is LGBT as an organized movement.

The quarrel on WhatsApp between my two sisters didn't last long. Our aunts and uncles came to Annisa's defense, and Maya left the chat. I asked why she left, and Maya said they were way past redemption. So she kept her mouth shut, like me. I'd kept mine shut for a long time, there was so much on my mind. My job. The cost of fixing my parents' roof. Papa's medications.

Where did Annisa go astray? I want to know, in as much detail as possible—year, date, day of the week: where, when, and how someone planted certain ideas about Islam in her head, which she adopted as her own, without asking too many questions. I pictured Fahri stirring my sister up with ill-conceived notions about jihad. Maybe because it was harder to convince her to agree to polygamy, and he'd started fantasizing about the heavenly maidens that awaited. And Annisa had complied, for a pious wife always follows her imam.

In Surah An-Nahl, thus says Allah: *And He set mountains in the earth so it would not shake with you, and He created rivers and paths so you may receive guidance.* I've been collecting clues one by one: Annisa's diary from before she got married, all the messages she sent her high school friend. I have them in hand, but everything is still so hazy. All I ask is to remain steadfast in my faith, to cling tightly to it, and to be fully certain that the path my sister walked is not the same as mine.

In the afternoon, I leave the office early to visit my mother's grave. I'm in my car by four, hurrying to get on the road and avoid traffic. Since Mama passed away, we visit her grave every year before Ramadan, setting out at dawn to beat the traffic, with so many other people also visiting the cemeteries. This year, everything's a mess. And now I'm late.

I park by the side of the road and buy flowers for scattering, along with a bottle of rose water from a vendor at the cemetery entrance. Mama's grave is five minutes from here, on the left, shaded by a leafy frangipani. I study the wild grass growing around the edges of my mother's plot, already high.

"I've been meaning to cut them. I just haven't had time."

I turn to see Rojali walking up. He's one of the caretakers here. He dug my mother's grave, and I still pay him to keep it neat.

"I'm sorry," he continues. "I'll trim them today."

"Thank you."

Every time I see him, he's wearing the same clothes—a striped beige collared shirt, untucked, and skinny brown pants bunched up around the ankles. He's smoking a kretek, and the smell makes me step back. He looks older and skinnier—he might be older than Papa. His hair has grayed and thinned since I last saw him too. I narrow my eyes. A pungent scent assails my nostrils, but it's not cigarette smoke.

"Someone's burning incense," he says.

Then he smiles—some teeth are black, some are missing—and takes a long drag on his kretek.

Rojali walks away, whistling. He comes and goes swiftly, disappearing to let families visit and pray in peace, ducking behind a tree, perhaps, before reappearing, hoping for a tip.

I crouch beside my mother's grave.

Forgive me, Mama. I'm late.

I strew flowers over her grave before getting out the slim volume of Surah Yasin I've brought with me. I begin to recite. This booklet contains the surah in Arabic, as well as a translation. We had it printed to commemorate the hundredth day of my mother's passing. The cover is red, Mama's favorite color, and there's a photo of her in the back pages, of her in a white jilbab. I was the one who arranged it all. I am Mama's child. The most obedient, most dutiful, keeping Mama's secrets close.

Have I let you down, Mama? Whenever you wanted to leave, to be away from us, I never asked any questions. I obeyed all your orders. I cared for Annisa when you weren't around. How it stings, this wretched sense that I've failed at acting in your stead, at being a mother. I thought I was doing

a better job, but we're not that different, as it turns out. You failed, and I'm falling into the abyss.

Mama, I feel myself wavering. What do I do now?

Faintly, from beneath the ground there comes a voice.

Keep cleaning, Muti. The guests are starting to arrive.

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THE TRAVELER RETURNS

Getting out of the taxi, I stand on the roadside with my suitcase and squint at the row of houses, trying to make out the tiny numbers in front. The sun beats down on my head and the air is furnace-hot, dusty, humid—*welcome home*, I hear the city say. My skin feels sticky. I peel off my jacket and reach for my phone so I can look at a map. Which house is Mutiara's? I can't remember because I usually stay at my parents' whenever I return to Jakarta, and she always goes over there. The houses all look virtually identical, on the small side but well-designed. Two stories, painted white, complete with pint-sized garages and tiny gardens. No gates—a trusting community of the like-minded, bound by class and home ownership. The real barrier, of course, stands tall and proud at the entrance to the complex—a security gate staffed by officers who determine who may pass.

One door swings open. A woman in a headscarf emerges, carrying a broom, a black cat following after her, tail held high. It's Mutiara. My pulse quickens, my body tenses. She doesn't see me, the expression on my face, the hesitation in my step, the trembling in my legs, because, now, after more than twenty hours in the air, the time has finally come: standing before my older sister, I'll weep for Annisa—it's just Muti and me now. How horrible—and when I'm done, she'll launch into her usual rant: *You're never here, Maya.* Or maybe she'll busy herself with appraising me, sizing me up, before passing judgement, her words sugared but scalpel--sharp. Same as it ever was.

We've never brought up what we said to each other all those years ago at the well. There's never been reason to. We never go to Tanjung Karang anymore. What's past is past. But occasionally, my sister will make some sly remark—*You're a cunning one, Maya*—and I recognize the jibe, what she's getting at. For years she believed it was me who came up with the plan to abandon Annisa in the well, who convinced her to conspire with me. I can't quite recall what we said to each other, but I'm not so sure the

idea began with me. Mutiara cared for Kitty around the clock; but at times she could be neglectful, liking to play with her, but not wanting to bother with feeding her or changing her litter. I can still hear that howl of anguish, when she found her cat stretched out, beautiful and stiff, like an animal stuffed and mounted for display—except for the odor, the leaking fluid, marking a life cut short. Teenage Mutiara was the one set on dispatching her kid sister. Hadn't she suffered most? And after the incident at the well, she tried to paper over her guilt, treating Annisa like not only a sister but a daughter as well, all the while gaslighting me with the idea that I was the jerk—and I couldn't defend myself because I was never there, the curse upon our house. And so everyone always saw us in black and white, the one who stayed and the one who left. Never mind the fact that, all her life, Mutiara has been preoccupied with herself too, collecting cats, cats, and more cats, with no love for anyone else.

There you have it. My sister, the old witch.

My suitcase trundles over the asphalt, making a low rumbling sound. But Mutiara doesn't look up, engrossed in her favorite act of worship: cleaning. My sister, with her broom and her cat. She's somewhere, anywhere but here, ready to take flight.

When I reach her front step, we embrace. Briefly. *Just for a second or two*, I think. But when I feel her, breathing, alive, the only one I have left, my chest aches so much I curl up in her arms for support. The stony earth inside me cracks and fissures, about to crumble. I release my hold and see her eyes are red. She glances down at my dusty shoes and tells me to put them on the rack behind the door. Her cats come over, I count them: one, two, three, four. She and I avoid each other's gaze.

"Don't you ever use waterproof eyeliner?"

That's her first question, her tone awkward and dry.

"The bathroom's there. Wash your hands. Do you want tea? Coffee? You're not fasting, right?"

I leave my suitcase near the wall and head to the bathroom to wash my face and hands. From the kitchen, a spoon clatters in a cup. Soon Mutiara reappears and sets my cup of coffee on the table. She's fasting, of course.

"Sri's off on Sundays," she says, as if needing to explain why she would go through the bother of making me coffee at all.

She keeps her headscarf on. She looks mostly the same, her skin still youthful, with hardly a wrinkle, though it's not as if she has her diligent ablutions to thank. No, she follows an expensive skincare regime as religiously as the other rituals in her life: praying five times a day, cleaning house, looking after her cats.

We sit together in her living room, she on a large glossy brown leather sofa, three ginger cats lounging around her like spoiled concubines: one to her left, one to her right, another whom she strokes in her lap. I sit facing her, on a smaller couch, unsettled by the black feline weaving between my legs. At one point the cat freezes, tilting its haughty head, sizing me up, just like its owner.

"How long were you standing there?"

Mutiara speaks softly, but she still sounds like a government agent who's caught a spy.

"Not long," I reply.

"I really didn't see you there. I hardly ever have guests. I just assume anyone in a taxi is for a neighbor."

So, this is my sister's life. Consumed with caring for our sick parents before eventually having to let them go. No lovers coming to call, despite her nice, dust-free home, no flies buzzing in the kitchen or cobwebs in the corners. Sunlight streams in through the ample windows, and the apple--fresh scent of cleaning spray rises from the gleaming tiled floor. For a witch, she has exacting standards. No dead rat, lifeless bat, or severed fingers here.

Anything rotten has been neatly bundled up, hidden away in her heart.

I sip my coffee, she pets her cat. It's been a long, frantic journey through busy airports, and now I feel time slowing down.

"Nice couch," I say.

Somebody has to start. Usually, as the older sister, she takes the lead.

"It already has scratches," she sighs. "Kids. Can't be helped."

She points beside her, to a few sharp lines. I smile though I don't understand, having never been a mother, having never imagined looking after kids with claws.

"I bought this sofa right before the house blessing," she continues. "You were in America."

It was nicer than the one our parents owned, bought when they still had money. My sister has spent her entire life trying to prove she can afford everything our parents could when things were good. Of the three of us, I've always been the nomadic one—and the poorest. The suitcase I've brought with me from New York contains everything I own.

"Yeah, you told me about it," I say. "And how all our crazy aunts and uncles were there."

"They were especially mean to my cats. My poor babies. They were only kittens. I didn't have Layla yet, I found her a year ago, out in the garage."

"Layla?"

"You always forget. Coco, Pico, and Cookie are the gingers. They're from the same litter. The black one is Layla."

"Oh. Right."

"You really should get a cat."

"Why?"

"They're such a blessing. Rays of divine light. And they don't smell."

Mutiara lifts her pets in turn and kisses them. Then she gets up, walks over to the cupboard, and takes out some clippers. She starts trimming one of the gingers' claws. The animal meows in protest, but Mutiara mumbles something to it (maybe she's speaking cat), and its two siblings dash away.

"The three of them remind me of your old cats."

"Yes. Sweetie, Stripes, and Momo."

She always calls them by their names to help others remember which one is which. Not that anyone actually cares.

"Remember how you saved up to adopt three cats?" I said. "To replace Kitty?"

Her expression changes.

"That wasn't the reason," she snaps.

"Oh. Yeah, of course. I mean—"

"You can't replace one child with another."

Her tone softens a little. "Take Layla. She's so different from the others. She'll show up suddenly before disappearing again to who knows where. Sometimes it's midnight and she'll still be prowling around."

"Outside?"

“I don’t know where she goes. She comes back in the morning with a mouse for me, a little souvenir.”

And here it is, our first conversation. After so many years apart, brought together again by our little sister, who strapped a bomb around her waist and blew herself up—the pair of us, two out of three, sitting on our sofas, chit-chatting about cats.

Mutiara asks if I want to take a shower and relax in the guest room, or rather the room that the cats have been kind enough to vacate and let me use. Next to the bed, dressed in clean white sheets, I spy a tiny cloth basket—like a baby bassinet, evidently no longer in use. Inside it sits a ball of yarn and a small blanket bearing traces of feathers. I am but a wayfarer in a kingdom of cats.

We have yet to talk about Annisa or even mention her name. Maybe we’re working up the courage first. Once her name leaves our lips, we’ll have to face everything that comes flooding out next. All the madness. All the loss.

My phone screen lights up and I glance at it. A message from Nadir: *Where are you now?*

I type my response*: Muti’s house. What about you?*

I take out a towel and toothbrush from my suitcase. Half an hour later, I check my phone again. Nadir still hasn’t replied.

I get a long nap in before the evening call to prayer wakes me. Mutiara appears at my door. Her hair is tucked into a round cap that leaves her neck uncovered, the skin smooth and unwrinkled. She invites me to join her in the living room to break her fast. We drink sweet tea and eat small cakes, and I wait for her to finish the Maghrib prayer before we sit down to dinner.

There’s fried chicken in a butter soy glaze, and perkedel, and mushroom soup, still piping hot. Maybe I’m just hungry, but from memory, Mutiara was always a much better cook than our mother. Of course, this only confused my father more: a woman in a stable situation, with a job and a house, a good cook to boot, and still no takers? But my father had stopped pestering her to get married years ago. Money talks. If Mutiara hadn’t supported my parents and flexed the economic muscle

they no longer had, my father would have been running around trying to sell her off for sure. *Hey, who wants to marry this old maid daughter of mine, she's got lots of cats but let's talk.*

And there it was, in the middle of dinner, when the TV ushered in the inevitable.

On the screen we saw the hospital where my father was being treated. *The father of the suicide bomber is in intensive care*. Three images cycle on repeat: a hospital lobby, a corridor, and five seconds of Mutiara telling journalists to go away, face blurred. As the pictures play, we hear a voice, accompanied by melodramatic music: *There has been no statement from the family of Annisa Dinda, one of the Kotawijaya suicide bombers. Her father is being treated at a hospital in Jakarta. The family refuses to comment*.

"We're part of the circus," Mutiara says.

She keeps her gaze fixed on the TV. Her fork and spoon are steady in her hands, but I watch her chest rise and fall. It was only a matter of time. We were all going to be exposed sooner or later, for viewer consumption, reduced to media content. And now my sister has to come to terms with her new identity—the blurred-out relative of the bomber, possible sympathizer, possible co-conspirator. Mutiara tells me about the reporter and cameraman who accosted her, who kept recording the whole time despite her refusal to speak. Now here are the images, presented out of context, piping hot, for a ravenous public to feast on. My sister tells me everything, the words pouring forth with electric speed. She goes back a few days. To how she went searching for clues—from Annisa's friend, from photographs, from the diary she brought back from my parents' home. Annisa can't bear it any longer. Without waiting to be summoned, she appears in our midst.

We can't turn away.

"She killed herself and took Patricia with her, and now we're being splashed all over tabloid TV," says my sister.

"It's not just about what people think, Muti."

Her voice rises. "Who said it was just about what people think?"

She glares at me, for so long that I avert my eyes and focus on finishing the food on my plate. I regret what I said. Of course, *of course*, she understands it's not just about what people think. So much, intertwined, tangled up like string. Deep down inside her are memories of a baby sister,

sweet as an angel, an infant she carried in her arms. Memories of lullabies, of watching over her, of making sure the bugs didn't bite. Silly us. The bugs were no match for our wicked little sister.

Mutiara turns off the TV.

"Do you remember the story of Qabil and Habil, Maya?"

I nod, offended. So she's testing me, now? She thinks I don't remember the story of the first murder in the history of creation, Habil killed by his own blood. My sister retells the story, from Surah Al-Ma'idah: Qabil didn't know how to bury his brother, so Allah sent a crow to dig at the earth. I ask myself if Qabil ever loved his brother the way my sister once loved Annisa.

The clock on the wall ticks on, all the louder without the TV's blare. The cats, having eaten their fill, have settled down somewhere. At the table, it's just my sister and me.

"You think it's easy, seeing to everything when someone dies? She gives a bitter laugh. "And I had to deal with my own sister's body, out of nowhere. It wasn't even intact."

And here we are, post-coffee, post-dinner, post-small talk about cats. Now comes the real conversation: speak the name, open the door, and everything comes pouring out, gushing onto the floor. Of course, Mutiara can't help but remind me that her pain is different, that I don't know how she feels because I wasn't there, in that morgue, looking Annisa in the face, seeing her into the furnace, and finally, cradling her ashes in an urn. With Mutiara, there are only two types of grief: that which meets the standard and that which falls short.

She continues. "I packed the urn in a cardboard box and sealed everything tight," she recounts. "But do you want to know the worst part? The urn fell. I haven't told you, have I? It broke. Knocked over by someone or one of the cats, I don't know. Annisa and Patricia were all over the floor. I swept the ashes into a bag and put it in what was left of the urn."

My sister's voice grows smaller and smaller, almost vanishing completely.

"A mess," she whispers. "A complete mess."

I hold her hand. Her fingers tremble, her gaze is unfocused.

"Why. That's what I want to know. Why Annisa betrayed us, why it ended like this, why I wound up alone in a hotel room, sitting on the

carpet with Annisa and my niece stuffed inside an urn. I have a right to know."

It's five minutes to seven. An in-between time. Past Maghrib but not yet time for the Isha prayer—twilight moments that belong to the living and the dead. *Spirits are roaming. Don't play outdoors.* But what about the ones trapped inside?

I look around the room, searching for any traces of Annisa that might have escaped the urn.

"And you? Do you even think about Annisa?"

Her voice is weary and hoarse, even as it betrays her ungraciousness, her desire to think the worst of me. I shake my head in disbelief. She can't conceive that I too am grieving, the kind of grief I'm going through, a razor slicing into my flesh again and again.

I answer her. "Every day, Muti."

Every day, I live it, walk it, this fear of what the future holds. For after all these years of running off wherever I please, I will never be alone again. She'll always be with me, my little sister, drenched in blood. She refuses to leave. She can't be erased.

The azan sounds in the distance, but Mutiara isn't going to the mosque for Tarawih prayers. She sits with me. We're caught up in this together—me, my older sister, and any ashy remnants of our little sister that may have escaped the broom. For the first time, I feel at ease. The call to prayer is a reminder that another world exists out there—not one I want to enter, but another world, still turning, all the same.

"They manipulated her," says Mutiara. "Annisa was duped, tricked into false Islam."

She sounds like her usual self again—firm, decided. She seems so certain, but I'm not sure she's right.

She goes on. "I *know* her. I looked after her from when she was a baby. I'll send you the WhatsApp messages she sent to Sarah. She was fixated on labelling all sorts of things as haram."

"But so are our cousins."

"Yes, but this was different. Suddenly, she was interested in politics. Since when did she care?" Mutiara points to my plate. "Are you done eating?"

Wordlessly, I nod. To my surprise, dinner's over already. Mutiara ferries the plates to the kitchen, gets a rag, and wipes the table until it gleams. Hastily, I get up too, to avoid being accused of laziness. I head to the sink, but Mutiara beats me to it. I wait as she washes her hands. She scrubs her palms carefully, then lathers the back of her hands and in between her fingers, making sure to get any dirt under her nails. Then she dries them—shakes them, rather, examining the left, then right, brow furrowing in dissatisfaction.

She rinses her hands again, and again, but something lingers, it seems, refusing to go away.

I have to remind her I need a turn. Unsteadily, she moves away from the sink. I turn on the tap and add dishwashing liquid to a sponge.

"If you don't believe me, look at her diary," said Mutiara.

"She still kept a diary?"

"It's an old one, from before she got married. She left it in her room." My sister pauses. "Know what's in it? Boys. All boys. And wedding plans. Mama always said, don't depend on men. They'll just make fools of us. But I guess I'm the only one who listened, huh?"

My face grows hot. I'm glad I'm washing up, with my back to her, so she can't see my expression. Mutiara doesn't seem to care if I'm listening or not; I keep my mouth shut, but she keeps going on, repeating what she said before: how she'd looked after Annisa since she was little, how men snatched her away, filled her head with promises of heaven, how our sweet little sister swallowed it all.

"People change, Muti," I say. "You can't draw conclusions from the way Annisa used to be, ten or twenty years ago. "

"Read it," she counters. "Then tell me what you think."

I turn off the tap and turn around. She places Annisa's diary on the dining table. Before heading to her bedroom, she informs me, "Tomorrow we'll visit Papa."

There's a time for everything. A time to hate your father and wish he were dead. A time to reconsider, but sadly, too late. A little while longer, and he'll be no more.

The hospital foyer is deceptive. The walls painted a pristine white; the friendly receptionist at the front desk; Nurses bustling around, raising

people's hopes, their quick movements suggesting a quick recovery; patients in wheelchairs with their balloons and bouquets, ready to go home. But the further in you go, you become aware of it, of death's slow and steady creep. We keep calling his name, but Papa is absent, present only in body. His mind must already be gone, has wandered away.

"It's Maya, Papa."

Upon entering my father's room, I feel the need to state who I am. I whisper my name for the benefit of this brown-skinned Lear. I worry that if I keep silent, he might mistake me for Annisa, so untender, so young.

"I'm Maya. Your other daughter."

A less important one.

My father has shrunk. This must be one of nature's little jokes. Make daddies feel big and powerful, then shrivel them up, smaller, smaller until —poof—they're gone.

Gazing at him now, I can no longer imagine my father at that round table, still wearing his collared shirt from his day at the office, looming so large he seemed to fill the whole room, and us, so small, waiting for presents, punishments, pats on the head. I can no longer imagine how, from that same table, he would rage at our helpers, making everyone tremble in fear, simply because the food was too sweet—*these damn Javanese*—and then, once the poor girls would quit, fed up, he'd cuss Mama out—*you can't manage money, can't manage children, can't manage yourself.* At other times he'd return from work, a ball of rage, lumping Liem Sioe Liong, the fancy-suited tycoon on TV, in with his bosses, *those bloodsuckers*, he'd grumble. *Greedy Chinks*. And then, glancing at his mother in her wheelchair, he'd see Rohadi, her carer. And the boy's slightest mistake would set him screeching. *Just look at you! You move like a girl!*

My father. Racist, sexist, fascist. The world won't miss him when he's gone; just my big sister and I, I suppose. He raised us as his daughters, after all.

Now my father has been deflated, skin sagging like an empty sack, the flesh it envelops no longer firm or strong. And before his silent form, wrinkled and wan, tubes snaking from his arms and nose, I have no choice but to swallow contradictions. Forgive me, I plead. I think about forgiveness, for my father, for myself. And, shamefaced, I admit, after all these years, I think about God.

O God. Make smooth his path.

I leave the room and hang the protective gown on the back of the door. My nose is stuffy from crying, and I wipe the tears away with my hand. I turn to find Mutiara standing behind me, holding out a tissue.

Few people know what a crybaby I am. My sister is one of them.

We sit together in the ICU waiting room, belongings heaped on the chair between us: Mutiara's purse, my backpack, and a tote bag with her mukena and Qur'an inside. We'll stay here for another hour, though I'm not sure there'll be any meaningful change in Papa's condition, not today, or tomorrow or even the day after that. But this has been Mutiara's routine for nearly two months now. She and Sri take turns, sitting in the waiting room for an hour or two, making sure someone's here for Papa, even if he isn't aware of it.

I scan the room, studying people's faces: a mother in a jilbab with two young children; a man absorbed in his phone (her husband, probably); an old man sitting with his eyes closed, head tilted, mouth half open. Not far from him sits a white woman with dark brown hair. Our eyes meet for a moment, then she looks the other way.

"You must see these people a lot," I remark.

"Only the old man who's sleeping. I've never seen the mother with the kids."

"And the white woman?"

Mutiara squints in her direction.

"No," she says. "I hardly ever see Westerners here."

"Maybe she's visiting an in-law."

"Maybe."

My sister takes her glasses out of her handbag and opens the Qur'an. It seems this too is part of her hospital ritual. From my seat, I watch her flip through the pages, white with golden edges: Arabic script on the right, Indonesian translation on the left.

"My prescription has changed. I'm farsighted now," she says. "What about you?"

"I still don't need glasses."

"Wait till you turn forty."

Mutiara returns to her Qur'an. Her lips move, silently reciting the words.

I still wonder why Mutiara decided to start wearing the headscarf after our mother died. Not that it's exceptional—lots of women do in Indonesia these days. You see them everywhere: in schools, government offices, shopping centers. Some do it out of piety, some for fashion, and others because of social pressure, because it's uncomfortable when you're the only woman in the building with your head uncovered. I was sure my sister didn't belong to any of the above groups when she made her decision. And I didn't know how deep her faith is, but I did know she was lost. Now I sit with her, trying to understand her way of living out her religious beliefs, but I find no solace in the holy book. I take out Annisa's diary from my backpack.

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THE BRIDE

Intact

Bandung, 20 April 2005

Last night I had the strangest dream. It was about a broken vase. I thought it was mine, but Muti was kneeling on the floor staring at it, cracked in two. She was surrounded by cats, and she was crying. I went up to her and asked how the vase broke, but she didn't answer, just kept on sobbing. She didn't even see me!

Life is good and classes are going smoothly. But inside, the cracks are spreading. I hope no one notices.

Maybe there will be no bride, no future. But I'm going to repair what's broken. I'm no longer looking for true love. True love can only be found in Allah. All I want is to gather up the pieces, to make it whole.

Bandung, 26 January 2006

I haven't written in ages. There's so much to say. Maybe I'll just start with Fahri. He's an Industrial Engineering major and aiming for a scholarship. Sarah introduced us, and soon after, he began texting me. People want to get to know me, to send me messages. It's never been difficult for me—*Annisa, Papa's prettiest daughter*, that's what they always called me. I replied to Fahri, then we began chatting on the phone. Last week we went to the movies with his cousin.

In no time Fahri knew all my favorite foods, my favorite films, my favorite color. He'd text me before exams and send me chocolates when they were over. He likes children, and I started wondering: what would it be like to have kids? To raise them in a happy and peaceful home? To live life with purpose, play a meaningful role, an invaluable one? I once had

my heart set on someone else. If only Fahri were handsomer, bolder . . . But Fahri isn't Lingga, and maybe no one ever will be.

I have to forget Lingga. I have to erase him from my mind. Allah still loves me and is giving me a second chance.

Jakarta, 17 July 2008

In just ten days, I'm going to be a bride in white. Dressed in a white gown, seated on a wedding stage of pure white, garlands of jasmine everywhere you look. My childhood dream. Maybe it's not as important to me as it used to be, but I do cling to some beliefs. All that has been shattered shall be restored.

Lately I've been diligently visiting spas, getting massages and body scrubs. Maybe the one thing I'll skip is the "all white" fast that Fahri's mother is suggesting: nothing but white rice and water for three days! The Javanese say it transforms the bride and gives her a radiant aura, but I'm not going to do it. I'm worried that it's heresy.

Jakarta, 20 July 2008

Today Papa took me to the supermarket. I had just picked up the phone to order a taxi when he asked where I was going. He insisted on taking me. This might be the last time Papa will drive you anywhere, he said. I didn't argue. In a week I'll be married and living somewhere else. I won't be his baby girl anymore, the one who needs to be looked after, picked up and dropped off, waited up for at night until she comes home.

Papa borrowed Muti's car. The AC in his car isn't working. She was cooking in the kitchen, so she took her keys from her bag and handed them to Papa. She asked us to stop by Holland Bakery to buy bread.

I turned on the AC, and the hot air trapped in the car gradually turned cool. Every now and then, I caught the scent of Muti's perfume lingering on the fabric of the seats. Squinting in concentration, Papa kept his eyes on the road while I imagined my sister at the wheel, in full control. Her presence seemed to grow, filling the car, and I had to open the window for a bit.

Papa and I talked about my plans to follow Fahri and move to Kotawijaya. He says Mama worries that I don't have a job. Women need something to fall back on, just in case. I hardly ever talk to Mama, but she

did suggest once that I keep a separate bank account after I get married. I don't understand. Isn't marriage built on a willingness to share and mutual trust? I once asked Muti if Mama didn't trust Papa. She said Mama doesn't trust in anything.

My parents' marriage isn't the kind of marriage I want to have.

At one intersection, Papa pointed to the left. My mechanic's over that way, he said. Remember when you were little? You used to come with me and bring your dolls.

I could see that Papa's thoughts were filled with the scent of little girls, the color pink, candy, dolls. I had no memory of it at all.

We passed Cikini and stopped at Holland Bakery. I got out to buy a box of buns and cakes. Papa took one and snacked as we drove. Your mother used to bring these home a lot, he said. They're a luxury now.

I asked him how much he had borrowed from Muti.

Don't worry about it, Papa said.

I know he borrowed money from her to pay for my wedding. And that now she's the busiest of us all, arranging everything, the wedding hall, decorations, catering. And she's not even married herself.

If she ever does get married, I'll repay her. I pray that she finds her soulmate. I don't want her to live alone forever, with her cats. Because everything is connected! Marriage, home, responsibility, respect. It's all part of being complete.

We don't know when that time will come, sighed Papa. Then he reminded me of the snide things Wak Norma and Aunt Linda like to say: *Mutiara, always a bridesmaid, never a bride. But even a pretty bridesmaid passes her expiration date at some point. Guess she's more cut out for planning weddings than having one herself.*

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THE TRAVELER

Transit

Can you spot them, Maya? The gaps in what she's written?

The weretiger in my head growls, prodding me with questions as I read Annisa's diary, the entries written at haphazard intervals between 2003 and 2008. I carry the diary everywhere the next day, from room to room, to the hospital, feeling the compulsion to read and reread it, to search for hidden meanings slipped between the lines. Mutiara's right, the whole diary is about love—falling in love, lost love, new love. But I sense something creeping behind my sister's yearnings for wholeness, for fulfilment. I feel it stirring but can't hear it.

Nana speaks again: *You can spot the gaps, can't you, my little bookworm? You can read behind the words.*

I sense a certain hysteria, something not written down. In 2004, not a single entry between July and November 2004. Then suddenly:

With you, I'm afraid of losing my head.

April 2005. A shattered vase, and Mutiara weeping, surrounded by cats. I try my best, but the image is blurry, like a hologram. Every sentence is clear, legible, visible, and yet there's something beyond my reach. Something stirring.

I do sense the gaps, but what's the use? Even if I can figure out who my sister was fifteen years ago, who's to say she was the same person this year, in the moments leading up to her death? I find myself mired in a few paragraphs shorter than the others, written in much larger letters. The handwriting reminds me of the postcard she sent me: childlike and oversized, menacing somehow.

The air in the hospital waiting room is bitingly cold. Shivers run down my spine.

“So, what do you think?” asks my sister, eyes on the road.

We’re in the car, on our way home from the hospital. She knows I’ve been reading the diary.

“I have something to show you,” I say.

I pull out Annisa’s postcard from my bag and point to the large, emphatic letters, then some of the entries from the diary. Mutiara glances at the handwriting, how it conveys something unsaid. When we stop at a red light, Mutiara reads the postcard’s message.

“You were closer to her,” I say. “Why send it to me?”

“You think I was closer?”

“Because you’ve always been here. You never left.”

Mutiara shifts gears and steps on the gas. Her jaw seems to clench. Is it the postcard that bothers her, or the fact that she’s never left?

“Maybe she wanted to leave too,” I continue. “And we don’t know where she wanted to go. Maybe she wanted to escape but couldn’t. Did she ever talk about moving? Going abroad?”

Mutiara thinks. “There was a time when Fahri wanted to go to Egypt to take some courses. But he didn’t get a scholarship. And Annisa had already stopped working by then. In the end they stayed put.”

“Why Egypt?”

“He wanted to study Islam.”

“But couldn’t he do that here?”

“He wanted to study Islam in an Arabic-speaking country.”

I nod, trying to understand.

“So maybe Annisa felt trapped?”

Mutiara shrugs. “She thought she was going to Jannah . . . ” she murmurs.

I shudder at the word. After what Annisa and her husband did, after reading the postcard she sent, that word will never mean the same thing again. Annisa’s ruined it.

“Did she ever see a psychiatrist?” I ask.

My sister changes lanes.

“This doesn’t have to do with mental illness.”

“Why not?”

After the Columbine massacre, experts read through the shooters' journals, speculating about their mental health. How was Annisa any different from those two white teenagers? All three committed terrorist acts.

"Annisa and her first boyfriend—do you know much about them?"

Mutiara shakes her head.

We stop at another red light. A magazine peddler approaches Mutiara's window. He holds out a news magazine, but when he sees her behind the wheel, he takes out a women's one. My sister waves him away.

"It's pretty clear if you ask me," says Mutiara. "Annisa was being manipulated. If she wasn't, she would never have gone astray. Don't I pray, like she did? And study the Qur'an? The Islam I know is nothing like hers."

"Okay, but why do you think she killed Kitty?"

My sister pumps the accelerator, a little roughly.

"There's no need to bring that up," she says. "I always cared for her after that."

The well. We both know about it, but we don't go there anymore. I lift my eyes to the darkening city sky. The cars around us start to slow. Jakarta's traffic will be at a standstill soon.

"I'm taking leave the day after tomorrow and going to Pacific Place. Do you want to join me?"

"To go shopping?"

"I'm meeting Sarah."

My sister's still convinced she's right, still searching for clues. I suppose I am too, even if I'm looking elsewhere.

We reach the main entrance to the housing development. My sister rolls down the window and greets the security officer. From inside the guardhouse, he smiles and nods, and Mutiara rolls the window back up.

"I could have left, you know," she says quietly.

The statement startles me, coming out of nowhere as the car glides along.

"When? Before?"

She nods.

"So? Why—"

“I was left behind. And I chose family. Being here. Looking after what I could.”

It’s my fourth day with Mutiara, and I’m becoming familiar with her routine. She wakes up at half past three to eat the pre-dawn meal, waits for the Fajr prayer, then goes for a morning stroll in the park. (I know all this because my jet lag just won’t quit. Even so, I stay in my room.)

After her walk she writes a to-do list and a shopping list, and sticks them on the fridge door for Sri to attend to. Sri seems happy under Mutiara’s management—clear working hours plus overtime pay minus Papa’s peevishness. Every day, Sri arrives at eight and goes home at noon. But since Mutiara’s not working today, she’ll be here from eleven to three, her main responsibility being to feed the cats.

So far, over four days, our differences have yet to inflict any wounds: Mutiara is a control freak, whereas control slips from my fingers daily. Her meeting with Sarah is at one, so we’re ready to leave two hours before. Twenty years ago, we’d only have needed thirty minutes to get from here to the city center. Jakarta’s traffic has molded Mutiara.

“It’s congested all the time now, not just mornings and evenings,” she says.

She’s dressed smartly in a blouse and trousers with a brooch pinned to her headscarf. After going through the day’s to-do list with Sri, she goes to get her handbag. I’ve been waiting by the door, shoes already on.

“I don’t know how you can stand living in this city,” I remark.

Mutiara picks up her keys. “Some people don’t have a choice.”

She gets into the car and starts the engine. I climb in beside her and close the door. Putting the car into reverse, she checks the mirror, and we wave goodbye to Sri. As we exit the housing development and head out to the main road, she turns to me.

“Don’t tell me you still can’t drive,” she says.

Ask me if I can read—between the lines, against the grain, backwards. Ask me to construct an argument, to create structure, or betray it. Ask me how all of history informs my writing—what has been read, what has been written, and what has been viciously erased, the history of the body, and bodies that have evaded history’s record. But don’t ask me to cook, drive,

manage money, buy a house, be an adult. Practical matters are my weakness, whereas Mutiara is their master. Given her expert handling of everything lately—dealing with Annisa's corpse, looking after Papa, all without losing her cool—I shouldn't be surprised by how calm she remains when smoke begins billowing from the hood of her car.

"Muti, pull over! Pull over!" I shriek.

Mutiara's eyes widen but she doesn't make a sound—just signals left, pulls over, and stops the car. I fling open the door and leap out, leaving Mutiara inside, doing who knows what. I tap on her window frantically. With a deep sigh, she opens the door. Then, ignoring my panic, she walks over to a nearby warung.

"How can you be so calm? Your car is on fire!"

"No it's not," she says. "It's just overheating."

Mutiara buys two large bottles of water and pours some into the radiator. As she waits for the water to stop boiling, she replies to messages on her phone. I send my own text message, to Nadir. Unexpectedly, he gives me a call.

"Where are you?"

"On the side of the road," I say in a half-whisper.

"It was the radiator? So you're okay?"

"My sister is completely unfazed."

I restrain myself from asking where he is.

"Who was that?" asks Mutiara after I hang up.

"A friend."

I've kept Nadir a secret from Mutiara. If she finds out, she'll only judge me—*What kind of woman are you?*—because, of course, she has the highest moral standards, and has followed all our mother's advice. Love really does make us stupid.

After the steam subsides, Mutiara lifts the hood. I peek at the tubing, the pipes, the wires. Everything is alien to my eyes, like a language system from another planet. Two men approach.

"What's the matter, ma'am?"

"It needs more water."

The pair of them look ready to help, probably concerned at the sight of a woman in a jilbab standing by a car with an open hood. But Mutiara coolly pours more water into the radiator and thanks the men for their

offer of help. They give off a sour smell of sweat, and Mutiara covers her nose with her hand once they leave. My sister prefers feline scents to human ones. And she never needs help.

We spend an hour and a half by the side of the road. Mutiara can start the engine but feels she should take it to be checked out right away. She calls her regular mechanic, then phones Sarah to apologize for having to reschedule.

"I'm sorry, Sarah. I ran into some bad luck."

Bad luck, external matters, nothing intentional. Of course, Mutiara doesn't say she forgot to fill the radiator because all the recent tragedy has distracted her. My sister's never wrong. Muti's Law: Muti never apologizes, even if she's at fault, and even if she does apologize, she has to make sure we know she doesn't actually mean it. But I'm just a wayfarer in her cat kingdom now. What choice do I have but to follow where she leads?

Mutiara's mechanic is in Senen, a hot and dusty part of the city. My father used to be auto savvy and would bring his own car here too. Annisa was the one who usually went with him, but ironically, it's Mutiara to whom the art of motor maintenance was handed down. Annisa, on the other hand, grew into a princess who drove luxury cars, and never needed to set foot in a repair shop again. I remember my older sister texting me when Annisa bought her Honda CRV.

Looks like Annisa's princess dreams have come true, typed Mutiara. *She doesn't have to work her butt off to earn a living, but she still gets a fancy car.* My sister had long been saving up just so she could upgrade to something run-of-the-mill. *So what? Boring*, I texted back—me, the sister with no money, who knew nothing about mechanics, who couldn't even drive.

A man in a singlet greets us.

"How did the radiator wind up empty, Ms. Mutiara?" he exclaims.

"I've been very busy, Koh Acong."

Acong is skinny but his arms are muscular. He's probably in his sixties, so, younger than Papa. I remember hearing my father mention him from time to time: *I'm taking the car to Koh Acong's.*

Acong tells an employee to bring us water. Mutiara's fasting, so she declines, but I take some.

“I’ll check everything else too,” says Acong. “Maybe an hour or so? If you want to wait somewhere with AC, you can go next door.”

My sister gives a nod.

“A friend of yours, Ms. Mutiara?”

“My younger sister.”

“Ohh . . . the one your father used to bring?”

“No,” I reply.

My name is Maya. The other daughter.

I feel a need to state this over and over.

“The one who came with your father was the youngest, wasn’t she?” asks Acong. “Such a cutie, she always brought her dolls. Sometimes she’d talk to herself and play make-believe when she got bored. How is she doing now?”

“Fine.”

Next to the workshop is a bakso noodle shop, also part of Acong’s family business. It’s not very big, but at least it’s cooler than in the garage. I order only iced tea, a token of respect for my fasting sister who’s probably as hungry as me.

“Annisa brought her dolls,” I murmur. “I genuinely don’t remember.”

“Strange, isn’t it,” says my sister. “To look back.”

“Aren’t you afraid of becoming Luth’s wife?”

Mutiara looks surprised to hear me say a prophet’s name. She thinks the stories of Adam-Idris-Nuh-Hud-Soleh-Ibrahim-Luth-Ismail-etc. belong to her, whereas I’m the apostate, the idol-worshipping sister, godless, ignorant of the examples set by the prophets and messengers of Allah.

“Maybe we should just keep moving forward,” I say. “And not look back.”

“Is that even possible?”

I sip my iced tea. It’s too sweet.

How do you make sense of the past when you have no future? I’ve been waking up every morning haunted by the same question: *Why are you so determined to write about your grandmother? To deny any role in your sister’s atrocities?* Before me lies nothing but wasteland, littered with bones.

“Do you still have hopes for the future?” I ask.

“I was applying for residency in New Zealand,” she replies. “Before all this happened.”

She studies me coolly as my eyes go wide. I never thought my sister would leave one day, or ever wanted to go.

“Why New Zealand?”

“I have a friend there.”

“Who?”

She pauses. “Do you remember Alfrida?”

“Your friend—the one who married a white guy?”

“He’s Lebanese.”

“Why did she get married so soon? She was barely in her twenties.”

She corrects me. “Twenty-five. She didn’t have a lot of choice. Her family was conservative. Then along came this guy, Lebanese, Muslim, living in New Zealand.”

“Is she happy?”

Mutiara doesn’t answer.

Here, at Acong’s, where Mutiara is a regular—or rather, where my father was a regular, back when we were small—I begin to wonder if I’ve been seeing things all wrong. Here is a portrait of my family, a still life of apples and pears: Papa the patriarch, predictable; Mama the rebel; Mutiara, keeper of the family, enforcer of norms, servant to cats. But maybe there are details I’ve missed—like how Annisa used to bring her dolls here. And maybe there are others I’ve misread. In my mind’s eye, I glimpse Alfrida with her short hair and checked flannel shirt, moving freely about our house, no questions asked: kitchen, bathroom, Mutiara’s bedroom.

“So what are you going to do?” I ask.

Mutiara merely smiles. Leaning forward, she peers next door where Acong is examining the car.

“After all this? How can I go?”

I think of all the years she has spent as caretaker, living out her curse. More than anyone, Mutiara has the right to leave all this behind. I watch my sister’s slender fingers tap the table as her eyes avoid contact with mine, gazing off into the workshop as we sit together, silence overtaking us. I stare at the white pin holding her headscarf neatly in place, and at that moment, I realize how long it’s been since I’ve seen her hair. I

thought all my travels had taught me how to locate people and objects, to place them correctly. But it seems there are things too subtle, too elusive, too hidden to find on a map.

"Muti," I venture. "Do you know I'm writing a novel about Dinar and Rohana?"

"Who are Dinar and Rohana?"

So far, Nadir is the only one I've told. But here, now, there's a warmth flowing between my sister and me, intoxicating, nudging doors ajar. A pin to fasten us. I want my sister to know.

"Read it someday, okay?"

By the time the car is ready, raindrops are starting to fall. Acong tells my sister what he's done. Unable to comprehend their exchange, I wait and watch the cars being serviced, Acong's crew laboring away with greasy hands.

When Mutiara tries to pay, Acong won't let her. "Don't worry about it, Ms. Muti. There wasn't much to do."

Her wallet's already open. She insists, but Acong shakes his head.

"When my grandfather was sick, your father gave me extra money and prayed for him," he said. "Now let me pray for your father in return."

I have no memory of the father who would come here to while away the hours, to enjoy the company of his Chinese mechanics and beloved baby girl. For me, only the marble table, where he sat filling the whole room, my father the misogynist, the hater of Chinese. I walk out of the workshop without turning back, because who knows what else might change places, what else might shift. Because I have no desire to turn into a pillar of salt, to crumble away, like Luth's wife.

The rain comes pouring down, pelting the car windshield. When we were little, Nana would say that rain brought good fortune, and we believed her. But over time I came to realize that, in Jakarta, rain only brings bad luck. Traffic jams. Floods. The cars up ahead are beginning to slow down, a sign that the city will soon be in gridlock. I fiddle with the radio, going from station to station. Finally, I connect my phone and play my own music. Mutiara frowns behind the wheel as Bauhaus sings *undead, undead, undead*. At least the song is about Bela Lugosi, not Annisa Dinda.

We talk about the relatives we've been avoiding, our crazy uncles and aunts. Apparently, Aunt Linda has flown in from Batam to see our newborn nephew. She wants to visit our father in the hospital, and talk about what happened to Annisa. Our grief is fresh, but the relatives still need to be faced. I decide to reveal my own plans: I want to go to Kotawijaya. She glances at me in surprise before her eyes return to the road.

"What for?" she asks. "All the business with the police, with the body—it's all settled."

"Have you ever thought about the victims' families, Muti?"

Taken aback, her gaze remains fixed on the road ahead. Her eyes are wide, and her lips are a line, growing thinner by degrees. Every part of her face stiffens. The car accelerates briefly, before braking sharply as the traffic slows to a crawl.

"I can't leave Papa yet."

"If you're not ready, I can go alone."

"What do you mean, 'not ready'? You think I don't care?"

In an instant, it all bubbles away, that intoxicating sense of warmth from before. The doors close shut. I'm suddenly alert, cautious: my sister's back in her proper place, behind the wheel, and I retreat to mine, in the corner. The AC feels chillier now.

"I didn't say that," I reply, choosing my words carefully. "I just want—I don't know what I want. It won't resolve anything, or make up for anything. But maybe, there'll be some . . . "

I trail off. No, not consolation. Not relief. Some space, to talk, to share, perhaps. Though who knows what shape it would take, or whether it's even possible.

"You'll only cause them more pain."

She's probably right.

"Maybe I'll visit Annisa's son," I say.

"There's a lot you want to take care of, isn't there?"

"I'm not sure what to do, but we can't just abandon him, can we?"

"And who do you think should raise him?"

I sigh.

"I don't know. Not yet. Why are you being so uptight, Muti? I just want to go there, that's all. I realize there's only so much I'll be able to do. I'm

not you."

Mutiara's lip curls. After a long silence, she steps on the gas, then brakes again. The Toyota Avanza in front bears a decal of a stick-figure family—a father and mother and three kids. To the right is another decal: *Baby on Board*.

"I've done what I can," says Mutiara.

Her defensiveness startles me.

"Maybe we're going through different phases of grief. Maybe we each have to mourn in our own way. This is my way—I have to go, to see what I can find. Maybe nothing will come of it, and it won't go anywhere."

"Oh, please, be my guest, if there's someone who wants to care for the child," says my sister. "But it won't be me. Who knows what false teachings his mother's infected him with. She turned my religion into a murder weapon."

Her voice is hard. She acts as if we're talking about something filthy. In my mind's eye I see her sweeping the floor clean and scrubbing her hands raw.

"That doesn't make sense. So that's what it comes down to? Defending religion?"

"Don't start, Maya," she warns. "It's not just about defending religion. You know nothing about me."

She turns off the stereo, my music, as if shutting me up by extension. We carry on in silence, but something else is still going strong: Mutiara's desire to be more right than anyone else, blazing bright.

"I have my reasons, you know. For why I chose to stay and care for our family."

That old refrain. I lean my head against the window, watching the rain and the cars backed up outside. This is so messed up. All of us trapped in Jakarta traffic, and I can't stand being with her, Miss Always Right, bully in a hijab.

"If it was your choice, why do you keep blaming me?"

"I'm not blaming you."

"Don't play ignorant, Muti. Everything I do is wrong in your eyes because you think you were cursed to stay at home. It's not my fault that you don't have the guts to take risks. That you never dared to jump."

"Oh, and you're the bravest?" thundered my sister. "Like I said. You don't know a thing about me."

"Of course I do. You're the biggest martyr." *Don't start, Maya.* But I keep going. "You don't even know what was going on with Annisa before she got married."

"You were home then too, Maya. Or have you forgotten?"

"But I'm the asshole, aren't I? And you're the most responsible."

Maya, don't start.

I don't know whose voice it is that I'm hearing in my ear—my sister holding back her rage, or my grandmother warning me not to cause trouble. *Stop, Maya, stop. Why are you always picking at old wounds?*

"In your eyes, no one else is ever good enough. You're the only one who's right. Maybe that's why you wear a headscarf."

Ah, too late.

Mutiara says nothing. When the car in front slows down, she signals left and switches lanes. The sound of the turn signal and the squeak of the wipers blend together. *Tick tick, tick tick.* Mutiara signals again until she's in the farthest lane over. Then she stops the car and presses a button to unlock the doors.

"Out."

As I sit there, stunned, she adds, "There's an umbrella in the back seat."

Every possible question, every possible swear word fills my head, full throttle. Oh, so this is how it is, fuck, this is how it is, dammit dammit dammit, everyone's gone, and I'm stuck here, why aren't *you* dead, Muti, just die already, DIE.

But as usual I'm too slow to act, too much of a coward to fight back. Not a word escapes my lips. I grab my bag, ignoring the umbrella, and slam the door behind me.

The rain lashes my face without mercy as I run to the sidewalk. I try to flag down a cab, but there are no vacant taxis in sight.

"I know why you want to get married, Rohana. You want to see the world without me. On your own."

"Oh, come on, Dinar. What choice do I have? Someday, you'll get married too. They'll find you a man from a good family who works in an office and wears a suit. You'll be a wife, a mother, a grandmother. You won't be a tiger anymore. We have

to hide, you and I. There's no place for what we share. We have to disguise ourselves. We're dangerous."

"But I don't want to be anything else."

"Nonsense. You'll be a teacher, and I'll write for the cause. For the women of the Revolution."

"Do you love Rusli?"

"Marriage doesn't need love. Love is just an overblown bedtime story. And I don't want my eyes closed once I join the struggle.

"I hope he makes you happy."

"There's no one like you, Dinar. There'll never be anyone like you."

"Do you promise to visit me? Come to Karang. We'll meet at Harapan Beach."

"Oh, Dinar, Dinar! You must come to Jakarta too, to visit me. Then go wherever your heart leads. Anywhere at all. Around the world. We'll live out our dreams."

Here I am, hiding out in a three-star hotel, writing about Dinar and Rohana, building a shrine to my grandmother's memory. I'm in transit, taking refuge from the glare and the din, from my control freak of an older sister who wants to be right all the time, from my younger sister who blasted herself to bits but lives on, dead yet not dead. Mutiara wasn't at home when Sri opened the door for me and helped me load my suitcase into the cab. From the doorway, the witch's four cats looked on as my taxi pulled away.

Nadir and I spoke on the phone for an hour. I shivered the whole time, addict that I am, but I held myself back from asking if he'd spoken to her, or even more stupidly, *do you love her*. Like Rohana says, love is just an overblown bedtime story. I've been walking too long with my eyes closed, and worse, hoping for a house, a home.

This hotel room was meant for the revelry of rats, but none of that this time. No panting breath, no sweat, no sighs. No steamy passion in a cramped bathroom or tangled in white sheets that speak of trysts between other couples, other bodies. Only me here, writing, chasing my grandmother into the darkness, shedding tears for ghosts.

Amidst dense forest, where my grandmother roars and lunges, I gasp. The ringing of the phone brings me back to my bed, the computer open on my lap. An inkblot stains the sheets.

“Hello?”

“Good evening, ma’am. Your sister is waiting downstairs.”

Mutiara. I left the hotel’s address with Sri, in case I died, and my sister had to bring her broom over to clean up. Why is she here? To apologize? I get out of bed and put on my shoes.

The elevator opens onto the lobby, and I scan for my sister, but all I see is a middle-aged man sitting on the sofa, engrossed in his phone. And there, standing by the window, near the red curtain—a woman dressed in a kebaya, hair in a bun.

She turns around and looks at me. She smiles.

“Hello, Maya.”

I hold my breath at the sight of her, this face from the past. My body tenses, but it’s as if my flesh is disintegrating, dissolving into fine grains. Grains of salt.

“Rohadi—” I stop, correcting myself. “Rosalinda. Hello.”

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DEBTS

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REVOLUTION

A Tragicomedy in Four Acts

Behold, ladies and gentlemen! The curtain rises! And in the spotlight stands yours truly. Your faithful storyteller, ready to regale you with tales, to set you swaying to music, to serenade you with ballads of yore. Ladies and gentlemen, put your hands together for the one and only Miss Rosalinda, the Blossom of Coral Cape!

Now, where shall we start tonight, my dear ladies and gents? Victoria's granddaughters have scattered to the wind. One swishes past, death buckled to her waist, our very own Annisa; another's made a bolt for it; the third is bent on burying the dead. A pair of eyes watches from behind the curtain, recording their tale. But the girls are oblivious. They're too busy on their treasure hunt.

Nana's long gone, but the granddaughters keep searching, and oh! Our poor little sister, the fairest of the three. She went poking in the wrong place and just like that, she's turned to ash! Then there's the oldest, the most wretched of all of them, alone in an empty house and still no key to show for it.

Yes, if it weren't for the tale of the three sisters, Miss Rosalinda would have run out of material long ago.

How about you, Miss? Why don't you tell your story? Yes, you, my dear, pretty in purple, gazing off into the distance, like you're waiting for something. Are you expecting someone, my dear? Your lover with the rakish moustache? A white wedding gown with a long train trailing the floor? An adventure in a foreign land? Or a way out—that must be what you're looking for. Ah, in that case, your story won't be too different from my own.

This is a tale of three sisters. Isn't it always about them? But tonight, I'm taking the reins. This is a tale of the forgotten one. You could say she plays a supporting role—indeed, her mother was what you call "the help." But in her lifetime, Miss Rosalinda, the Blossom of Coral Cape, has been lucky enough to wander the world blessed by three mothers, leaving those three treacherous sisters in the dust. Then she met a handsome prince, slipped into the pages of a fairytale and got drunk on love—before the coach of romance went rotten, leaving a moldy pumpkin behind.

Esteemed ladies and gentlemen, hear your humble servant's tale.

[Act One: Tanjung Karang]

Once upon a time, in Tanjung Karang, so named for its coral-studded cape, there lived a child. A boy to all eyes, not a blossom yet. And the child lived in a big house with two mothers, Romlah and Victoria. The first he called Mamak and the other Nana. One by one, Nana's children left home—to Jakarta, Bandung, and Batam—until the house was empty and the child was free to run around. He'd go from corner to corner, from the terrace in front to the well out back, even from room to room whenever he helped Mamak sweep and mop. From an early age, the child had been taught the proper place for everything, and his own place as well. This isn't our house, Mamak said, but isn't Nana kind, giving us shelter, paying your school fees, buying you new clothes every Eid.

I love Nana, declared the child.

She's not your Nana, you know.

And Mamak would state this loudly, clearly, so her child would know where he belonged: that Mamak was just a maid—*bedinde* was the colonial term—and Nana, the Master with a capital M. Mamak worried her child wouldn't know his station, would think himself a peacock when he was merely a duck. But it couldn't be helped. When the child started school, he made a request: don't tell anyone this house isn't ours. Sitting at the well, scrubbing clothes, Mamak laughed. Stupid, she said. Everyone knows whose house this is.

This is the Master's house. Here we eat, work, sweep, mop, and use the Master's tools.

Mamak hadn't always lived in Tanjung Karang. She and her husband had come as transmigrants from Java.

Wow, Java, like the President? asked the child.

No, cackled Mamak. Like Brebes.

The child was confused. For him there was only one Java, lovely, graceful, gentle. Like the First Lady. Like the mothers in the lesson books at school.

The young couple had been all aflutter about boarding a ship and making a new start, but transmigrant life turned out to be tough. Uprooted from their native soil, they now had to till foreign land—Sumatran land, where people spoke too loud and lost their tempers too fast. The money didn't flow as freely as the government had promised. Mamak's husband began to gamble—just to make a little extra. But though he kept losing, he soon got hooked. He took to drink. And beat Mamak when he got drunk. One evening, he shoved her and she fell. But she didn't make a sound, and for one second, two, he could only stare, stunned at what he'd done. Then, blood soaking her housedress, flowing down her calves, he began to scream.

He knelt at Mamak's feet, weeping for the loss of their first child, less than three months in the womb. He swore off drink. But as they say, in a harsh world, even the gentlest dove can't keep its word. A year later, Mamak found herself pregnant once more. She wanted an abortion. Why bring a child into the world if you yourself aren't safe? But at the dukun's door, she froze, unable to take another step. What possessed her, who knew, but she turned and hurried home, stuffed some clothes into a bag, and whisked herself and the child away.

A few people she knew chipped in to help, and she wound up working at Victoria's House. How pleased Nana was to see her house so neat and clean. How she adored her clever new *bedinde*. When Mamak's water broke, Nana ran to phone the midwife from the living room, fingers trembling—anxiously, impatiently—with each turn of the dial. And so, Mamak's child was born in Tanjung Karang not knowing his father, and would grow up in Victoria's House speaking Malay, not Javanese. After the

birth, the midwife cleaned Mamak off and told her to rest. Nana rocked the baby in her arms and hummed a lullaby.

Romlah, have you thought of a name, she asked.

Mamak, still weak, shook her head.

Such a beautiful child, said Nana. He reminds me of someone I love.

Had the Master always intended to name the child? Baby in her arms, Nana mulled. And just as Mamak was drifting off to sleep, she sprang the idea.

Rohadi. We'll name him Rohadi.

Are you still with me, ladies and gentlemen? Yes, Rohadi. That's what they called me when I, not yet a blossom, still lived in Karang.

For years, my national identity card read as follows:

Name: Rohadi
Sex: Male
Place/date of birth: Tanjung Karang, 1 July 1980
Religion: Islam

Just Rohadi. No last name. I still use it for official documents.

How I loathed that ID card—its acknowledgement of only two categories: *female* or *male*. And if I don't think of Mamak, who brought me into this world and raised me, I can't even bring myself to say "Rohadi" with no last name. The Master's grandkids always had two: Annisa Dinda, for example. I never asked Mamak why she agreed to the name Nana chose, but I can guess. "Rohadi"—very Javanese, and a combination of my parents' names, Romlah and Adi. Mamak no longer wished to see my father, but I knew she still felt love for him.

Later, when I was living in Yogyakarta, a trans woman activist visited our community and spoke of the importance of having an identity card.

But my father kicked me out, said my friend Natasha. He has all my documents. It'll be hard to get an ID.

I don't want an ID with my birth name on it, piped Susmita.

Can you blame her? With a birth name like Suharto?

The main thing is to have one, the activist replied. What if we suddenly die?

And indeed, for us, every day is filled with the sudden, our lives are so worthless—sudden beatings, sudden death.

Eid was always special for little Rohadi. Nana's three granddaughters would visit Tanjung Karang, and he would act as their bodyguard. Nana was said to be the daughter of a high-ranking official, but the three sisters were as ordinary as could be. They loved how big Nana's house was compared to their home in Jakarta, which was small.

Life's tough in the capital, Mamak would remark.

The child wondered whether the sisters were peacocks or ducks, or if they knew their place. But the three of them didn't seem to give much thought to such things. Apparently, knowing one's place didn't apply to everyone, at least, not to them, not then. Not as they played make-believe under his watchful gaze, and climbed trees, and snuck into the kitchen to gape at the enormous kuali, each one big enough to cook a child.

The oldest sister, Mutiara. The bossy one.

The youngest sister, Annisa. The prettiest, always wanting everything to be perfect.

The middle sister, Maya. The dreamer, the clever one.

Rohadi and Maya were born in the same year, and both loved to make up stories. *Ladies and gentlemen, put your hands together for the Beauty of Ancol Bridge!* And out she'd saunter in her headscarf, kebaya, and ruby-red lips.

They had a special connection, Rohadi and Maya. Or so Rohadi felt. Because one time, Maya came to live at Nana's house, and she swore they would always be best friends.

Never believe the Master's sweet words.

As you already know, ladies and gentlemen, the two older girls envied their beautiful little sister and plotted to throw her into the well, but their plans were foiled. No one dared approach the well after that. Especially when they found about the kuntilanak.

In the seasons when the house was empty, no guests, no grandchildren, Nana listened to jazz and kroncong. In the evening, as the sun dimmed, she would sit in her rocking chair, Sam Saimun's voice floating through the air, filling her with emotions of all kinds. Sometimes she'd smile and

sing along. Other times, her eyes would glisten with tears and she'd lose herself in thought. The handkerchief she was embroidering would remain in her lap, but she'd put down her needle, staring off into the distance, out the window, into another time.

In your face I see the moon

Lurking behind a smile

At moments like these, Rohadi would keep his distance, observing Nana from afar.

But then a new song might come on, calling out, *Hey, hey, ladies and gentlemen, let's go! It's cha-cha time!*

Nana would bob her head, rise from her rocking chair, call Rohadi over.

What are you hiding for? Come here!

Nana always knew exactly where the child was hiding. Nana knew everything.

Come out. Don't you want to play?

Taking Rohadi's hand, Nana would invite him to dance. They'd twirl together in the living room, swaying to the right, sashaying to the left. Nana's laugh always made him happy. He imagined a lively night market at dusk, thronged with people, with handsome young men and pretty young ladies out for a stroll, exchanging glances, trading winks, flashing smiles.

Do you like this song? asked Nana.

The child nodded, eyes bright. She told him the name: Boy, Girl. *Boy, girl, sailing out the door in the hope of finding a match*. And then, amidst all the hustle and bustle—a dapper man with a pencil mustache, sweet-smelling, neatly groomed, strolling hither and thither as he whistles and croons his tune. *A voice like Effendi, setting hearts aflutter*. Not quite a teenager, Rohadi still didn't know who Effendi was, or the boy out the door. But a handsome man with an alluring scent?

Yes, please.

[ACT TWO: JAKARTA]

Jakarta, oh, Jakarta! How overjoyed Rohadi was when he heard he was going. He imagined himself skipping and shimmying down dazzling city streets teeming with life, packed with skyscrapers and glittering lights.

If Nana's health hadn't deteriorated, Rohadi may never have gone to Jakarta when he did, at twenty-three. Her children had decided: Nana would relocate to the capital. Hospitals were better there, and two of her children, Sulaiman and Norma, would be nearby should anything happen.

Nana gave her consent but rejected the idea of being cared for by some random nurse. Only Rohadi would do. So they both were brought over from Karang to stay with Sulaiman—the House of the Three Sisters—much smaller than Nana's house. Rohadi received a monthly sum, for Nana had insisted at a family meeting that he should be paid for working as a nurse. Nana's children agreed but called it an allowance, not a salary. After all, hadn't they put him through school and treated him like one of the family?

Should someone be paid to look after their own grandmother? Wak Norma sniffed.

So Rohadi moved to Jakarta and got an allowance, which, truth be told, was still below minimum wage. He was like one of the family, you see. Yes, one of their own, though after high school, he was told to enroll in vocational school—tailoring, hospitality—while the three sisters got to attend university. Nana once pressed Sulaiman to fund Rohadi's studies, but he refused. It was Rohadi's own fault, for not passing the public university entrance exams. Private schools are expensive, he said. And I spent all my money paying for my brothers, remember? Benny didn't even graduate!

So, there turned out to be no magic, no glitter to the city. Nothing but walls and overgrown lots as far as the eye could see, and a few warung, a short walk from the house. Since he had to look after Nana, Rohadi mostly stayed at home. Even buying something from the warung made him happy enough—he could chat with one of the owners, Asih, who had moved to the city from Ciamis. Meanwhile, the three sisters were busy with their own lives, the oldest working hard to support the cats (who knew cat food was so expensive. Why can't they just eat salted fish?); the second wandering off to parts unknown; the third studying in Bandung, coming back during school breaks. Only once in a while, when Nana had

doctors' appointments, did Rohadi get to glimpse, from the inside of a car, the peddlers and beggars, the roads choked with vehicles, and a sky polluted gray. Whenever they were caught in traffic near Tanah Abang Market, Rohadi remembered Nana's records and Sam Saimun's voice. *The din of Tanah Abang, a maze of girls and boys.* As if anyone would dream of seeking love there now, in 2003—the vendors peddling their wares on the sidewalk, being roasted alive by the sun; perspiring coolies hefting bolts of cloth; the motorbikes weaving in and out of traffic, sideswiping mirrors from time to time.

Jakarta, sweaty and surly, was hardly the beauty Rohadi had expected. But worse still was the event that forced him to sever his ties with Victoria's granddaughters. There, outside Asih's shop, walled with stacks of Indomie and garlanded with packets of shampoo, he asked himself, *What are you looking for, Rohadi?* And then he left everything behind.

How naive he was, once upon a time, when he played with the sisters every Eid, believing himself special in their eyes—he could even be the stepsister, he didn't mind. But as it turned out, each one was concerned solely with her own welfare, her own success.

One day, beneath Jakarta's scorching sun, Rohadi made up his mind to depart. As Rosalinda. Because revolutions always begin with ugly stepsisters.

[Act Three: Yogyakarta]

And so, ladies and gents, I dumped—or rather, doffed—Rohadi. We need not look back. That outfit is obsolete, and I'm no beau in search of a belle. I'm Rosalinda—beautiful, bewitching, bold.

They say Yogyakarta is a city of art and culture. So I boarded a train. *Yogya, here I come.*

I dreamed of becoming a teller of tales, a spinner of yarns. Not a writer. I'm no Maya, nose always in some book, happy to stay in school till who knows when. I ran off to Yogya when she was applying for a scholarship to do her master's degree in America. I wanted to tell my stories in my own way, beneath the glow of the stage lights, with movement and music,

perhaps. Like when I used to accompany Nana, dancing to jazz and kroncong, singing classic Malay songs. I'd long imagined myself as a storyteller, Miss Rosalinda the Blossom of Coral Cape, elegant in kebaya and shawl. And pretty, like Thalía, the telenovela star. I watched all of them: *María Mercedes, Marimar,* and *Rosalinda*, of course.

It wasn't an easy road, to be sure. Ask any of your trans friends, ladies and gentlemen—is it easy for them to find work? Is it easy to become an insurance seller or bank teller, a cashier or civil servant, when people think we "spoil the view"? (Says who? You're imagining things I'm sure.) Our mere presence causes a stir. In Yogya I lived off my savings, from my "allowance." I worked odd jobs, helping out with bridal makeup, singing on the street, receiving "uncles." At first it was thrilling—I'd listen to a lecture from Uncle Professor, I'd learn a bit of law from Uncle Attorney—but over time it took its toll, plundering my flesh, piece by piece. Good luck meant being princess for a day. Ah, but bad luck meant returning to my rented room, face bruised and swollen, money stolen. The final uncle said, *Don't call me Uncle, just call me Brother*. He then trussed me up, beat me, and dunked my head underwater until I nearly drowned.

I was lost. How I longed to return to Mamak's arms in Karang, but I'd only be a burden. I began attending a Qur'an study group. Some friends teased me. *A pious tranny*. But I knew only one way of seeking solace, to pray the way I was taught by Mamak and Nana. There I met Mami Cindy, the organizer, mother to each of us. Sometimes Mami would invite an ustadzah. Sometimes we led the readings ourselves. Mami would answer all our questions, from the fearful—*Mami, will Allah really punish us?*—to the practical—*Mami, what should I wear when I pray? A mukena or a peci and sarong?* Mami would smile and say, *Listen to what God is telling you in your heart. Every religion teaches love.*

I couldn't tell you how often I had to borrow rent money from Mami. Sometimes I paid her back, sometimes she "forgot." I'd been attending for less than a year when she decided to go back home to Kotawijaya. But Mami had left her mark. I'll always be her child, like all the others whose lives she touched.

In my quest to bring Miss Rosalinda to life, I began searching for spaces where creatives would gather. Eventually I found work in a café owned by

a couple—an Italian named Aurelia and an Australian named Chris. My hospitality courses at Karang weren't a waste after all. The café, a favorite of artists and foreigners, regularly hosted events—music, poetry, stand-up comedy. Too shy to speak, I eavesdropped: *that artist is working on a show, this artist is doing a collaboration, that other one has a residency abroad.* I watched from the sidelines, as I did before, when I observed the three sisters, initially my playmates before we grew up, and then, apart. Them, receiving the best education possible, and me—"just like their brother"—granted, only a rudimentary one. "Just like their brother." Ha.

I began attending free events and talks of all sorts. One awful art exhibition stands out in my mind—"participatory," it called itself. The term alone made my lip curl. But I heard a curator praise it as "fresh" and "radical" and blah blah blah. I had no idea what he was saying, dropping Westerners' names and using words that made no sense to me at all. I started saving up more, so I could go back to school and learn enough bullshit theory to smack down anyone trying to puff up bullshit art.

Little by little, my path became clearer. I worked up the courage to take part in open mic nights at the café. I still remember my first performance, wearing a Chinese-style kebaya and singing one of Sam Saimun's songs. Then I launched into my story: a granny stirring a giant kuali in her kitchen, dancing the cha-cha-cha. After several shows in which I performed different numbers—Sam Saimun, Madonna, a little telenovela (*Rosalinda ay, amor*), dangdut, Bollywood tunes (*Tum paas aaye yun muskuraye*)—I began getting invitations, from restaurants to experimental theater venues. There, in Yogyakarta, Miss Rosalinda emerged from her cocoon.

And as for the dapper gentleman with a pencil mustache, your humble servant managed to snag one of those too.

[Act Four: Sydney]

I, Rosalinda.

Sure, my passport still says "Rohadi" with no surname, much to the surprise and amusement of immigration officers everywhere.

Nevertheless, I've succeeded in crossing the deep blue sea. We're more than what's printed on our passports, after all. This drab little green book of mine may lack muscle and arouse suspicion at borders, but at least it got me to Oxford Street.

I stood in the crowded streets, watching the parade—troupes decked out in sparkles and sequins, buses festooned with colorful ribbons and twinkling lights, and on the upper decks, gorgeous queens dancing to the pulsing beat of DJs spinning tracks. Then, one community group after another: feminists, queer Muslims, university academics in their gowns—and togas. The year was 2014—my first time in Sydney. And I vowed that one day I too would be part of that parade, clad in kebaya and headscarf, sashaying, unflinching, head held high. I looked about in amazement—was I in heaven? And I'm not just talking about all the hunky white men. Every corner had been transformed into Sydney Mardi Gras Country. Huge rainbow banners, stores offering tempting discounts. *Come on, ladies and gents, let's shop! Let's celebrate bodies of all shapes and sizes*! Look, even the ATMs have been touched with a magic wand. *Abracadabra, GAY-TMs!* But where are the Trans-TMs? What a shame. Even in Indonesia, we have TransJakarta buses.

Okay, I'll admit it. I got a little too excited—*Look, transfolk everywhere! Strutting in the streets, riding trains, working in malls, eating in restaurants, not going hungry! Hello, my tranny comrades!* At the time, I knew nothing about the past violence suffered by activists, or why only now corporations seemed so queer-friendly. I also knew nothing about whom this land had been stolen from, didn't ask whether, at Sydney Mardi Gras, we really could all feel the same, whether we could actually hear everyone's voice, Rosalinda included, with her sawo-brown skin and her broken English, Rosalinda the third-world ladyboy.

How did I reach Australia? 'Tis a long tale, ladies and gents. A combination of hard work and steamy romance, I suppose.

Let's rewind. In Yogyakarta, I finally cobbled together enough funds to attend university—with a little help here and there, including from Mami Cindy, who chipped in. I was sick of feeling stupid. I went to classes during the day but still gave performances at night. Because it was fun, but also,

because I needed to eat, and because it gave me room to play around. So the Blossom from Coral Cape could continue to experiment, to grow.

One time, an artist who had already gone international told me, You're not a blossom yet; you're still a bud. You have to learn how to sell yourself.

I'm done with that, I answered.

That's not what I meant, honey, she said with a laugh.

So, I added another subject of study to my list: self-promotion. Branding, she called it. *What am I, laundry detergent?* I thought.

I was learning a lot—from school, from mingling with other artists—and I began to give more thought to the words I chose, to how I phrased things, to the concepts behind my work. Storytelling is more to me than theories and formulas, and I'm not ashamed to admit it: my tales are how I pour out my heart, singing and dancing how I seek joy. I want to revel and sway, to rebel and slay, to stir shit up. No more crying for me.

Gender and the body—something else that I learned about from Yogya's artists. It's a sexy topic, they told me. Take advantage of it, love.

One step after another. Doors opened one by one. Until finally, Miss Rosalinda flew to Singapore and Kuala Lumpur to do some shows. Maybe it didn't count as "going international," but a neighboring country is still another country. And who knew? Maybe I'd even catch a glimpse of the one and only Sheila Majid!

Now for the romance part. Chris, the café owner, had split up with Aurelia. He and I grew closer, and together with Miss Rosalinda's baby steps toward recognition, tender feelings began to take root. For the first time, I fell madly in love. But alas, Chris' business in Yogya began to stagnate, and Sydney began calling out to him. Since Chris often supplied the art scene there with artists' names and international projects, he received an offer to manage a new performance space in Redfern. I applied for an artist's residency in Sydney to stay close to my Honey Bunny. I met with success, and then bagged another. Finally, we were able to apply for a de facto partner visa, for couples who aren't married but living together under one roof.

Sydney first saw *Miss Rosalinda* performed at the place where Chris worked, and also in a few small cafés. I had to summon the nerve to deal with a completely foreign language. It was awkward at first, but slowly I

learned. I'd compose the script in Indonesian, and Chris would translate into English. Then I'd rehearse, careful to e-nun-ci-ate each word. And thus, ladies and gentlemen, were born several versions of each script, which I'd perform in different venues. This particular story, however, has but one version. It's just for you.

As if the journey wasn't hard enough. I heard the sneers, of course: *Must be nice to have a sugar daddy. Lucky her.* The remarks didn't come from my trans friends but other artists, many of them men. The kind who got jealous if a fellow bro happened to marry a white woman and move abroad. It's enough to make a girl slip off a stiletto and hurl it, just to see the blood gushing from a hater's nose.

But I choose peace. For under these lights, I am the queen. And so now, from my throne, I proclaim: Hear me, dogs! Don't you know my story—the child of a servant, fatherless, betrayed by her masters, driven to sell herself on the streets? Go ahead. Bark all night. But here on this stage, it is I who reign.

I, Rosalinda.

Last name or no last name.

Dear ladies and gents, your servant's story is a lovely one, is it not? Ah, but if only it ended there: girl gets boy and ascends the stage, an immigrant success story. The audience goes home happy. And from there, you could dream up sequels, spinning your own happily-ever-afters—projections of your own hopes and dreams.

Sadly, the story continues. One day I came back to find a man—a *very young* man—in Chris' bed. I never knew he fancied men. But over the years, I'd come to learn he fancied everything that moved (and things that didn't too). But the most hurtful part was that he had the nerve to bring that boy-toy into our home. Correction: not my home. My lover's. I was always just a guest. Chris tried to stop me from leaving: Where will you go? Who'll find you jobs, translate your scripts, arrange everything for you? And that's when I saw it—what I hadn't seen before.

This is the Master's house. Here we eat, work, sweep, mop, and use the Master's tools.

Too late. Though hasn't this sage advice been passed down in song through the ages: *Love can't be trusted*? So, I left my lover boy, my Mr.

Handsome with the pencil moustache. I moved out of his Newtown apartment and rented a room in a house belonging to an Indonesian family. I knew them through the Muslim community in Lakemba. Maybe all my friends in the arts scene will disappear one by one. Maybe without Chris, I really am a nobody.

Ladies and gentlemen, life is a bitch.

It doesn't stop there. There I was, convinced that the breakup was the worst thing that had ever happened to me. But then I lost her. My third mother. The mother who came to my rescue when I felt I had lost all spirit, all hope. *Mami Cindy.*

When I heard the news, rage coursed through me. Mami Cindy. Blown to pieces. And who murdered her but Annisa. The godly sister. The fairest of us all.

Such is my tale, dear ladies and gentlemen—and also, the reason I pay these visits. Why I must appear to Victoria's granddaughters, at the hospital, at the hotel. They pale and stiffen at the very sight of me. You'd think they'd seen a ghost.

Dear ladies and gents, the time has come for us to part.
Until we meet again, I'll hold you in my heart.
I bid you good night, for the light outside now starts to fade.
Miss Rosalinda has somewhere to go. There's a debt that must be paid.

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THE CARETAKER

The Guests Arrive

Kneeling on the prayer rug, I turn to each shoulder to greet the angels who sit there: Raqib on the right and Atid on the left. It's 5:00 A.M., and though the lights are on in my room, the hairs on my neck are standing on end and I don't know why. There's a presence behind me, following my movements—raising both hands, placing right hand over left, kneeling—as if I'm leading a prayer. As I finish, I hear a faint whisper, also greeting those watchful angels. Without looking back, I recite istighfar. I can't waver now; the guests are starting to arrive.

I still remember when the phone rang at my parents' place all those years ago, also at 5:00 A.M., after the Fajr prayer. Folding my prayer rug and mukena, I overheard what was being said. I sat on my bed waiting, but I already knew.

Before long, Mama knocked on my door in her white mukena. She had come to tell me the news.

"Inna Lillahi wainna ilayhi raji'un."

We hugged each other.

"Get ready," Mama said.

And this is what I must do now. Get ready.

It had been Papa on the phone, calling from the hospital where he'd spent two nights keeping vigil over Nana. Her children and grandchildren had been hoping she would pull through, but after Fajr we made haste, stuffing clothes, towels, and toothbrushes into backpacks. Nana hadn't wanted to be buried in Jakarta.

In the taxi, I opened my notepad, examining everything I'd written down about the travel agency and transporting the body. Annisa fell

asleep. Mama rested her head against the window, gazing up at the dark clouds, which were changing color by degrees, gray mixed with gold. As the sky grew brighter, the roads became more congested. I didn't cry, and each step seemed so clear—do this, then that. Go here, then there. Everything had been thought of. I was strong and proud of myself.

When we reached the hospital, Papa looked haggard and dazed, as if he'd been in a fight. Mama took his hand and gave him water. "Bismillah," he uttered as he drank.

My father, the eldest son, had been the only one at Nana's side. Nobody dared ask, at least not directly, about her death.

"Inna lillah," muttered Wak Norma, tears and mucus streaming down her face.

She asked my father quietly, "Was it smooth? Difficult?"

Papa merely shook his head.

"She's at peace now," he said. "That's the important thing."

My father guarded Nana's secret closely. And no one pushed him to recount what had happened, or why he was pale and trembling, or, more to the point: how had Nana finally released the tiger within? Those with such powers suffer agonizing deaths, so rumor had it. It was unspoken, but everyone knew. We could only hope that her passing would be as painless as possible, and no one dared speculate on what Nana had suffered in her final moments. *Don't go there. It's taboo.* My sneering uncles and aunties, who so comfortably dismissed others as nonbelievers, kept their mouths shut for once. They were all busy praying that God would forgive Nana, that she wouldn't be numbered among the infidels. Hadn't she been diligent with her prayers, with studying the Qur'an, with giving alms?

As for me, I've forgiven my grandmother for thinking Mama needed a dukun's purification, as if she were dirty. I've forgiven her, though I remember it to this day. And I still wonder how she ended up raising such arrogant and self-righteous children. As to whether she sinned through practicing magic, whether it made her a mushrik, I have no opinion. It's not for me to judge.

Nana's body was flown to Tanjung Karang. Some family members were on the same plane. Others took cars and crossed on the ferry to save on costs. Papa, Wak Norma, and I went ahead of the others, my father tasked

with heading to the gravesite. Fortunately, it had been ready and waiting since 1991, when everyone thought Nana was about to die. I helped Wak Norma and the other women cook and arrange tents for the reception. The floors gleamed and the cupboards were free of dust when we arrived at Nana's. Mak Romlah had cleaned all the rooms. We rolled out the carpet.

I texted Mama: *Everything is ready*.

Her reply: *Keep doing as Wak Norma says*.

Mama, Annisa, Wak Norma's husband, and my other cousins arrived six hours later by car. Maya, who believed herself to be Nana's favorite, stayed in New York.

I've made no effort to call Maya after our quarrel. She left the address of the hotel where she's staying, so at least I know she's okay. I have too much to take care of, and I don't have time to think about my ingrate sister, bent on chasing the things of the world, as if she could take them with her when she dies. We've both known the values of Islam, and we both know it's better to give than to receive. But my sister only takes, and burdens others, and never extends a helping hand.

Sri and I go to my parents' house. We unroll the carpets neatly stored in Annisa's room and drape them over the gate to air them. Just like Papa did, four days before Mama died. I still remember what Sri asked him as they hauled the carpets into the yard:

"Will people be coming over, sir?"

"Who knows Allah's plans."

My father's tone was flat, thin. He began beating the carpets, dust flying through the sunlit air. Sri started sneezing.

When my mother's body arrived from the hospital, our house was clean, tidy, and somehow less cramped. When Nana had died, my elders had taken the lead. But now that it was Mama's turn to be seen off, I was in charge and didn't need to take orders from anyone else. With the ever--capable Sri at my side, no detail escaped me, from the catering for all the guests to tipping the gravediggers at the cemetery.

By the time Wak Norma arrived, there wasn't much left to do. She bustled about, adapting to the new role she'd found for herself—the family matriarch welcoming those who'd come to pay their respects.

Then, once all the guests were gone, she went to my mother's room, surveying the clothes in her wardrobe. She called me in, ordered me to pick out what could be donated or thrown away. I still remember how tightly I was gripping the door handle as I stared unblinking at my formidable aunt, her back stooped but her authority intact, policing the contents of my mother's wardrobe, the doors flung out wide.

"Now?" I asked.

She continued to eye my mother's clothes a little while longer before striding past me toward the door.

"Just don't forget," she said.

I took notes that day—whose words were soothing and whose were wounding, who bothered to come and who wasn't there. Even now, I remember. We'd finished performing the funeral prayer by the time Annisa and her family touched down in Jakarta. Standing over Mama's coffin, she bid her farewell before we moved en masse to the cemetery.

Maya arrived the next day. The sun was already setting when she opened the gate, rolling her suitcase behind her, eyes swollen and red. We hugged her in turn, and I felt her tears wet on my shoulders, but what is recorded can't be crossed out. She was late.

The guests will be arriving soon. It's only a matter of time. I've taken down every image of Annisa: old photos of Papa, Mama, and the three of us, group photos from Annisa's wedding, family photos of Annisa with her husband and kids. That's what happens when you're fruitful and multiply—versions of yourself, all over your walls. Sri watches me remove the photos but doesn't dare raise questions. Tying a cloth around her nose and mouth like some sort of ninja, she goes to work on the carpets hanging outside.

Before Sri and I head back home, I peer into my parents' room. It's still there, the blue bed. My mother's friends pooled together and bought it for her as a gift. My father was planning to donate it to a sick colleague, but he put it off and put it off, and wound up keeping it instead.

"I can use it if I fall ill," he explained.

Except he fell in the bathroom and had to be rushed to the hospital. So much for trying it out for himself. He never experienced it in the end, how Mama felt, spending years in that bed, gazing at him pacing—worried, sad,

bored, angry—every day. With every call to prayer, he'd leave for the mosque, those mini-vacations at Fajr, Zuhr, Asr, Maghrib, Isha, while my mother prayed supine. I wonder now, had she been reciting verses, or counting each passing second, one by one?

After cleaning my parents' house, I visit Papa. I read Surah Al-Fatihah, verses for the dead—that the road home may be clear—but also for those still alive or half alive but lost. I picture my father stranded on a long road, unable to find his way back or to the end. I whisper in his ear: "I forgive you, Papa. I promise. For all your sins against Mama. And how you sold Nana's house behind my back. I've let it go."

Allah will show you the way. Wherever it may lead.

I gaze at my father lying there, eyes closed, his lips slightly parted as if to speak, pushing past the tubes taped to his face, and the frigid air, and the lingering scent of disinfectant, demanding to know: *Where's Annisa? Where's Maya?*

I wonder how much he knows on that road. If he doesn't know anything, wouldn't he try to find a way to come back? If he knows everything, maybe not. Suddenly his brow furrows, as if in frustration, wanting an answer to his questions. He's stuck, but he's stubborn. I sigh.

Papa, Papa. Aren't you tired?

I leave him and return to the waiting area. I'm taking out my Qur'an when a white woman with chestnut brown hair sits down beside me. I've seen her face somewhere before.

"Excuse me, Ma'am," she says, addressing me in English. "Can we chat for a minute?"

It dawns on me. She's the woman Maya pointed out the last time we were here. The woman steals a glance around the room before offering her hand.

"Karen Anderson. From the *New York Tribune*."

I draw back. How naive of me. I thought she was here for a patient too—a husband, or her in-laws. Something like that. When she came up to me just now, I thought she was going to ask me about the hospital procedures, or which doctor was caring for my father.

"My condolences," she says.

I shake her hand.

"I hope your father recovers soon. And I'm very sorry about the incident in Kotawijaya."

She must have been observing me for some time. Mentioning Annisa's name, she explains that she's writing a piece about suicide attacks, in particular those involving women and families. She glances down at the Qur'an in my hands.

"If I could ask you just a few—"

"I've already told the police everything."

Hastily, I put the Qur'an back in my bag. She nods sympathetically, speaking more gently, warmly, but her gaze pins me down.

"It must be very hard."

I stare at her. "What do you mean?"

"All of this," she says. "It breaks my heart to see children caught up in this too. Are you a mother?"

I shake my head.

"The poor children."

I say nothing. Turning away, I shift in my seat, trying to draw away.

But she only leans closer, giving chase, posing another question, "How do you feel about that, Ma'am?"

I know I should send this sneaky woman packing, like I did with those other reporters. But I merely sit, clutching my handbag to my chest. I can see her sizing up the situation, calculating her next move. She seems to know that if she's patient enough, words are bound to come out of my mouth.

"Indonesia isn't a terrorist country," she says. "The outside world must learn that too. That's why we need another point of view."

"'Another point of view?'" I echo.

"You know. From someone like yourself."

"I have no right to speak for anyone else."

"But you certainly don't want Islam to be considered a religion of terrorism."

Her tone is still gentle and warm, but something inside me starts to itch. My throat feels dry, ticklish.

"What Annisa did is not what Islam teaches," I say, my voice coming out hoarse. "I don't know what kind of religion she believed in. We never

talked much."

My fingers feel cold. The woman waits and nods, but her eyes are getting bigger, as if she's preparing to swallow her prey. She knows my defenses are crumbling.

"Did she ever say anything? Maybe something that escaped your notice at the time?"

My mind fixes on that one word: *escaped*. I failed to see it, failed to catch it, and so the evil rolled itself into a ball and slipped away. It was my fault. And now this reporter has me in her clutches, and I can't escape.

Then, behind me, a voice, quiet but firm. "She doesn't want to answer."

I turn my head. A woman in a kebaya stares pointedly at the reporter, arms folded. Karen looks irritated. "*Excuse* me?" she asks, her eyes narrowing into slits.

"I *said*, she doesn't want to answer. Stop pushing her."

"Are you family?" she asks.

"Yes, I am. And we decline to comment."

And so we meet again, after all these years—Rohadi standing in front of me, all dressed up, chin held high. No, not Rohadi. My mistake. There's no Rohadi here. It's Rosalinda, from Annisa's wedding when she made her entrance, her transformation stunning everyone. It wasn't just her hair or outfit, there was defiance in her eyes. We hadn't bothered to invite her and she had come to pass judgement on us all.

She comes closer. "How are you, Muti? Lots of reporters, I see."

I'm at a loss for words.

"The Westerners are the most annoying," she mutters. "They think we're just lining up to talk to them. Exploitative and colonial to boot."

I don't tell her about the local reporters I shooed away, or why I just sat there as that American reporter wrung the words out of me bit by bit. Maybe a small part of me was naive enough to see it as an opportunity—a chance to tell the world. *My sister's Islam isn't mine.* But what would be the use? Hadn't the president done the same? It seems to have made no difference at all.

I take Rosalinda into the ICU, to see Papa. From the corridor, through the window, I watch her stand by his bed, head bowed, as if in prayer. But

when she emerges, there's a certain look in her eye. And I know she hasn't come here all the way from Sydney just to see my dying father.

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THE TRAVELER

And the Teller of Tales

Standing together in the hotel lobby, we go through one motion, then another: holding each other's gaze, tentatively drawing close, finally meeting in an awkward embrace. Though she's not the awkward one, I am. I feel naked, overcome with the urge to cover myself with words, to remark on how pretty she looks now. Or how plump. Or how slim, or young, or old. To take refuge in one of those vacuous comments people resort to in uncomfortable social situations. I want to flee, though it's not like Rosalinda's after me or anything, she's merely present, as before—the wedding guest we forgot to invite. She stands there smiling, her manner graceful, her eyes never leaving mine.

"Mutiara told me you were here."

Her voice is softer than I remember, but the Sumatran accent is still there. Being from Jakarta, we used to find it amusing—a Javanese boy who sounded like Nana. But now it's not Rohadi before me, but Rosalinda. Stronger. And sharp.

"I met her this afternoon," she says. "I went to see your father."

I ask when she arrived from Yogya, tilting my head upward because of her height, and I feel as if I'm shrinking. She shakes her head.

"I came from Sydney."

"Why were you in Sydney?"

"I live there."

"Oh. I thought—"

"Yogya? Not anymore. That was a very long time ago now."

And before I know it we're playing the game of *where from, where now, where to*. Rosalinda seems to know it well, as do I. And only now, after all

this time, I realize that she too is a traveler, accustomed to revisiting past events grown indistinct, past names scattered to the wind.

"2008, wasn't it?" she muses. "The last time we saw each other, I mean. At Annisa's wedding reception."

She's not really asking, of course. I'll never forget her entrance, the hall bedecked in jasmine, and her, sailing in—head held high, imperious, the fairy queen we'd neglected to invite. She had come to demand her due—but not to curse, only to shame. And now, Annisa's name, leaping unbidden from her lips, appearing in our midst, forcing me to turn away. I can't distinguish the shames now mingling inside me: shame over not inviting Rosalinda, shame over my sister's crimes. I cast my eyes downward, studying the navy-blue carpet, and people's feet, wheeling their suitcases toward the elevator; and also the feet coming out of the elevator, some in sandals, some in proper shoes. And in their midst I spy the hem of a gown, and its long white train sweeping the floor.

"Where were you when it happened?" she asks.

"New York."

"I'm sorry."

Her perfume smells of flowers. And though I don't detect any notes of grief, she seems sincere, if only out of respect for the memories of a bygone age: Mutiara, Maya, and Annisa putting on plays, Rohadi as their bodyguard, sometimes joining in, playing one of the stepsisters. In this respect, we were alike, Rosalinda and I, both on the sidelines, unseen.

Rosalinda suggests we go to a Padang restaurant not far from the hotel. I hesitate at first, but then I think, why not. The story about my grandmother has come to a hopeless standstill, and the whole "in transit" status of my relationship has left me stuck: my lover is somewhere out there, with another woman most likely, while here I am, alone, feeling sorry for myself.

"My wallet's in my room," I said. "I'll get it."

"Don't worry about it. My treat."

The night air feels oppressively warm and humid. Rosalinda fishes a case from her glossy red handbag and takes out a cigarette. The security guard outside the lobby entrance glances in our direction. His gaze falls on Rosalinda.

He points to a designated smoking area. “Sorry, ma’am. Over there.”

We start out for the restaurant. Rosalinda lights her cigarette and takes a drag. Then she takes my arm in hers, watching for a break in the traffic. Beneath the dim glow of the streetlight, we cross the street, her skin touching mine. She releases her grip when we reach the other side.

“I didn’t think anyone smoked in Sydney,” I joke.

“Bad habits die hard.”

Rohadi didn’t smoke when he lived with us in Jakarta. But maybe I just didn’t know about it because, busy with my own life, I was hardly at home. And then suddenly he left. My father said Rohadi had left out of shame over some mistake, though he’d refused to say what: *do not reveal the faults of others*, he reminded me. I, who never trusted my father, assumed that Rohadi had left due to Papa’s short temper. Taking care of Nana must have been stressful enough, I reasoned. I never tried to find out what really happened, or what became of Rohadi after that. Nor did I ever wonder why it didn’t even cross my mind to find out. Life rolls on—that was the only explanation, tick tick, click, clack, like the sound of Rosalinda’s high heels against the pavement. Only now do I notice that she’s wearing heels, and how uneven the road is. Her feet must be tired, but her face gives nothing away.

“So what’s the story?” she asks.

“What story?”

“Mutiara said you were staying with her, but you left.”

“She didn’t tell you why?”

Rosalinda shakes her head and exhales, sending cigarette smoke drifting into the air.

“Mutiara hasn’t changed much,” she remarks.

“As self-righteous as always?”

Rosalinda snickers.

“I don’t mean that. She looks young for her age. She has amazing skin.”

Meanwhile, behind us, the low roar of a car engine gets louder and louder. A white sedan pulls up alongside us and rolls along, keeping pace with our steps. The window rolls down to reveal some young men, probably college-age. They whistle.

“Hey, don’t be rude,” snaps Rosalinda.

They burst into hysterics and start hurling insults. *Fag! Tranny!* Rosalinda picks up a small rock and takes aim.

"You fuckers!" she shouts.

The car's occupants quickly roll up the windows, and the driver steps on the gas. I seize Rosalinda's hand, her palms cold, and for a moment I feel my fingers close around the past: *You'll always be my best friend. I promise.*

"Sorry about that," she says.

"What for? They were assholes!"

"Sometimes I return to old ways, old traumas," says Rosalinda. "From being on the street."

"On the street?"

"Yeah. Selling sex. It was awful. A lot of shitty men out there."

My hand drops. I can't tell who let go. I'm still silent and confused when Rosalinda resumes walking, her steps firm. Her heels click against the asphalt, hard.

"I'm sorry," I croak. "I didn't know—"

"Yeah, there's a lot you don't know. That's why I'm here."

The restaurant at the end of the street is like almost every other Padang restaurant in Jakarta: fluorescent lights that make every pore, every bead of sweat on your face stand out; no AC, only ceiling fans that make your head spin a little; soap operas playing on TV—not for the benefit of the staff, who barely pay attention, but to provide background noise. And, of course, a photo hanging on the wall of an old man in a peci, either a prominent elder in the community or the restaurant founder, take your pick.

As soon as we enter, two families steal glances in our direction. I've never experienced such a deluge of stares in a single night.

A server sets assorted dishes before us, along with two cups of hot tea. Rosalinda takes a piece of rendang from one of the small plates, and I opt for gulai ayam. We eat in silence. During Eid, my grandmother always reminded us children not to make too much noise at the dining table. Strangely enough, the adults were allowed to chatter away. Back then we didn't complain about it. We were too busy enjoying the food on our plates.

“Nana’s rendang was better,” Rosalinda comments, breaking the silence.

“You still remember it?”

“Of course. When was the last time you had Nana’s cooking?”

“Before she got sick.”

“Only at Eid, right? I ate it almost every day.”

Her tone of voice unsettles me, as if it were a competition. I ask how she ended up in Sydney, and she sighs, as if to say, *long story*.

She asks a question in return. “You’re not curious about anything else?”

“Such as?”

“Such as how I survived in Yogya after getting fired by your dad.”

I don’t know what my expression conveys. I must not be good at hiding my shock.

“I thought you—”

“Quit? Ran away?” Her smile is bitter. “Yes, it’s a bit of a gray area.”

She rises from her seat to wash her hands. When she returns, she takes out her cigarette case, waves the waiter over, and asks if she can smoke inside. The waiter nods and brings an ashtray.

“I did all kinds of work in Yogya,” says Rosalinda. “Busking at first. Sometimes I washed dishes. Then I became a sex worker. It started out fine, extra money to buy food. But over time, the men got worse, and the final time, I was almost tortured to death.”

She taps the cigarette against the ashtray as I stare wordlessly at her slender fingers. Her name is Rosalinda now, but in the back of my mind I still see Rohadi, that scrawny little kid, the two of us reflected in the mirror, Rohadi primping as Maya preened. Rohadi, who played and went to school, like any other kid—for there too, I never asked many questions. Never bothered to learn what his school was like, or if its roof leaked, or why he didn’t have any extra-curricular activities. Suddenly a crack appears in the gates I shelter behind—all my knowledge, all my books.

Ask me if I can read—between the lines, against the grain, backwards. Ask me to wrestle with a text. But don’t ask me why I never wrestled with the matter of what I took for granted. Why my parents took out loans so their three daughters could afford tutoring to help them get into the best universities. Why Rohadi on the other hand, had to help Mamak with

chores after school. Why Rohadi got no farther than becoming Nana's maid.

"It was Mami Cindy who rescued me. In Yogya."

She lobs the name at me, just like that, out of nowhere, as she did with my sister's, leaving me to pick up the pieces, scrambling and stammering. *Mami Cindy*. I know who that is, of course; I've committed every victim's name to memory. But I can't quite make the connection.

"I'm so sorry, I didn't know—"

"And what is it you *do* know, Maya?"

I fall silent. Look at all these dirty footprints, Annisa. And we're the ones who have to clean them up.

I shift my gaze to the TV screen. The camera zooms in for a dramatic close-up of a woman weeping after being slapped by her mother-in-law. Shitty soap operas. Rosalinda asks for the check and takes some money out of her purse.

"Mutiara said you want to go to Kotawijaya. I want to visit too, to see Mami Cindy's daughter. Shall we go together?"

Rosalinda picks me up at the hotel at eight the next morning, stepping out of the taxi looking stylish in a modern Balinese kebaya and jeans. She's wearing her hair loose with the ends curled, and she's swapped out her pointy heels for platform sneakers, which make her look even taller and slimmer.

"That's it?" She looks incredulously at my backpack.

"Yeah. My suitcase from New York is too big to lug to Kotawijaya. I'm paying to store it at the hotel."

Rosalinda opens the trunk, and I place my backpack on her medium-sized suitcase. She looks me up and down.

"Do you always wear black?"

"Why?"

"If you're short on clothes, I have plenty."

"I'm not short on clothes."

"All right, all right," she says, nodding. "You be Marilyn Manson and I'll be Dita Von Teese."

I open my mouth in protest but shut it again when she opens the cab door and ushers me in.

The taxi speeds along the toll road toward Soekarno-Hatta Airport. There's a little glare from the nine o'clock sun, and beside me, Rosalinda dons her shades. I gaze out at the tall buildings and the large roadside banners. Rosalinda points to one of them—a woman in a jilbab advertising a fridge.

"She won the Princess Indonesia competition a few years ago," she says, sighing. "I used to dream of becoming a princess myself. But no one came to my rescue. And my 'prince' turned out to be a real jerk."

Eventually, Rosalinda tells me how she got to Sydney. I hear about her journey as an artist, working her way up from appearances at an open mic in Yogya to being scouted and performing in neighboring countries. She tells me about her partner's affair, renting a room and moving out, and waitressing while strategizing her return to stage. She applied for funding from several places before finally securing a generous grant, which she used to take a break from her job and complete a new piece.

"You're thirty-eight now, right?" she asks.

"Yeah, we're only four months apart."

"Just imagine your boyfriend fooling around with a twenty-year old. The kid was still in diapers when Suharto stepped down!"

But I'm busy imagining Rosalinda onstage, looking beautiful in her kebaya and shawl, a single spotlight bathing her in magenta as she croons oldies into a microphone. At the end of the song, she sits herself in a chair and takes up her embroidery. The lights go blue, and she launches into a tale.

"What are Miss Rosalinda's stories like?" I ask.

"Like my own. And yours. Her stories are the stories of us all."

"And who are you when you're offstage?"

"I'm Rosalinda," she says. "Just Rosalinda, no last name."

How changed her voice sounds, full of pride and fresh as the morning rain, dewy and fragrant—nothing like when we were little, smearing Nana's lipstick all over our lips. Nothing like when we started growing up, and Rohadi began fading into the background, disappearing, whenever my sisters and I came to play at Victoria's House. I should have tried to find out her story when she came to Annisa's wedding, but she was standing too far away. Or rather, I was too timid to approach her.

“Of course, the boundaries between onstage and offstage can get fuzzy,” she says. “But you get that. You’re a writer.”

And so, we two travelers from faraway places thousands of kilometers apart, arrive together at a hotel in Kotawijaya. One room, two beds. After dinner and a shower, Rosalinda leans back on her pillow and observes me typing away in bed.

“What are you writing?” she asks.

“A novel.”

“About what?”

“About Nana.”

My honesty surprises me, but I feel compelled to tell her somehow. Maybe I also feel Rosalinda has the right to know.

Her next question is unexpected. “Which Nana?”

“What do you mean?”

“There are so many versions, aren’t there? Old Nana in her wheelchair in Jakarta. Healthy Nana, in her kitchen, smoking kretek. The Nana who was—”

“A weretiger.”

Silence. In my mind’s eye, I see us sitting together as children, Rohadi telling me the story of the weretiger and the kuntilanak guarding the well.

“How was it for Nana when she died?” she asks.

“I wasn’t there.”

“I hope it wasn’t how she thought it would be.”

I try to look unbothered as I go back to typing, hiding how jealous I feel. What did Nana imagine, and how did Rosalinda know about it? I know the superstition—those who possess mystical powers die difficult deaths—but before now, no one has ever brought up how Nana might have felt. Was she afraid to die? I type faster. My hands begin to ache. Rosalinda goes back to talking about life on the stage.

“So what are your stories about, exactly?” I ask.

“They’re about the granddaughters of a magical woman.”

She gets out of bed, picks up a bottle of mineral water from near the TV, and, holding it like a mike, turns to face me.

“Good evening, ladies and gentlemen! Do I have a story for you! Tonight, a tale of three sisters, and how every year, to grandmother’s

house they would go. How they loved playing in the garden, and visiting the kitchen to gape at the gargantuan pots and pans. *But beware*, Nana would warn. *Stay away from the well. It's dangerous there.*"

I'm stunned speechless. Meanwhile, Rosalinda returns to her bed.

"You use us as material for your stories?"

"And what about your novel? Aren't you doing the same thing? Stealing your grandmother's stories? Turning them into fiction?" She smiles. "We're not so different, you and I."

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THE TALE OF THE OGRES AND THE TIGER'S PROMISE

The curtain rises to reveal Rohadi, now fifteen, all dressed and ready for school. Chest out, shoulders back, he struts around the room. He peers into the old, rusty mirror and smiles at the hazy reflection inside—at Rosalinda, dazzling goddess from the future: bewitching, bold, and beautiful. Rohadi longs to have special powers. He'd transform into Rosalinda—poof! Just like that. He could skip all this suffering—going to school, having to deal with others, coming home, doing housework. But where would he get these powers from? Rohadi touches the mirror, and the Goddess speaks, a finger to her lips: *shhh, it's a secret*. Rohadi shares a room with Mamak, so Rosalinda can't linger long. He gets his school bag and shuts the door on his way out. Never mind about becoming Rosalinda; beyond the safety of his room, even being Rohadi is too hard. He's trained himself to have no identity, not to sway or make eye contact. Not to walk too tall.

He knows he must pass a gang of bullies waiting at the school gate on his way home every afternoon: foul-mouthed punks, ready to fight, acting all tough. Because that's what being a man is—or so they learn from their brothers, their uncles, their dads. Rohadi stoops as he passes them, eyes on the ground. *Head low. Keep walking. You're invisible. You can do it.* But dammit, disappearing is hard. Their hurtful words always bury their hooks in him. *Hey, faggot! Sissy! Come suck my dick.* They're students too, no older than eighteen, but to Rohadi they're ogres, trampling the weak because they can.

Rohadi often cries after he gets home, and when Mamak and Nana ask why, he refuses to talk. But the fact is, all is not well. He daydreams more and more, and his grades start to fall. So Nana accompanies Mamak to the school, ready to fight, acting every bit the Master, though now she's just a widow living off her late husband's pension. There she stands, in the principal's office, hands on hips, hair pulled back in a bun and draped in a

head covering of black lace (no more smoking though—doctor's orders). Her voice is thunder: I don't want those youngsters who hang around the gate bothering my grandson!

Yes, somehow, she is aware of the gang who likes to hang around the gate.

The principal well knows who stands before him: Victoria, daughter of Haji Tjek Sun, an important official from way back when. Her family donated the land the school sits on. They may no longer have money, but they still have influence. Immediately, the principal has the gym teacher round up and punish the troublemakers.

Make them regret it, he commands. Have them run around the school ten times and clean the toilets, really go after them.

For two weeks, Rohadi is safe. But one afternoon, after school, the gang of ogres confronts him on a quiet street. One pulls down his pants, and another pushes Rohadi from behind onto his knees. One by one, they punch him in the face until they've had their fill. Rohadi slumps onto the asphalt, eyes swollen, lips gashed, a tooth knocked out. In the end he no longer begs for mercy. He can only hear their whoops: *Clobber him! Punch him! Beat him to death! Harder, finish him off! Hey, enough—you wanna go to jail like your brother? Moron.*

Rohadi survives, but their parting words will always stay with him, ringing in his ears: little faggot Rohadi, little Rohadi the maid's kid, hiding behind his Master's skirts.

At the hospital, Rohadi's cuts are stitched, and a medical note allows him a three-day absence. Mamak feeds him as he cries.

Enough now, she orders, Be quiet, don't fuss. We're just little people. Don't go looking for trouble.

Rohadi says nothing. He never looks for trouble. It simply finds him.

The second night, as Rohadi recovers, Nana sits on his bed in Mamak's place. She leans forward, strokes Rohadi's hair and asks:

Rohadi, do you want me to pass my tiger powers on to you?

Rohadi is stunned. His lips still hurt too much to speak.

Life is hard for people like you, she says. You must be brave!

Rohadi loses himself in thought, imagining himself challenging an ogre, lunging, disappearing. With Nana's magic powers, he could shapeshift: be

bewitching, bold, and beautiful. Like a tiger. Maybe he could even transform himself into Rosalinda.

Think it over, says Nana. These aren't just any powers. You will see many things, you will become strong. But you must release your powers before you die.

Nana rises and walks towards the door. When she reaches it, she turns around.

I'll be waiting. A week, a month, a year, ten years. As long as I'm alive, I'll be here, waiting for your reply.

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THE BRIDE

Angels Entrusted to Us

SON OF GUARD KILLED IN KOTAWIJAYA BOMBING
REMEMBERS FATHER
Islam Today, Sunday, 20 May 2018

Sixteen-year-old Reza Febrian remembers his father, Hartono, as a loving man who always put family first. Hartono was one of the church security guards who perished in the Kotawijaya suicide bombings. In addition to being employed as a security guard, Hartono worked as an ojek driver to supplement his income. According to Reza, his father always hurried home from the mosque after the Isha prayer to join his family.

"Father never worked nights," Reza recalled, his eyes filling with tears. "He never missed dinner with Mama and me."

Hartono passed away at Bhayangkara Hospital after spending nearly a week fighting for his life after the bombing left 80 percent of his body covered in burns. He had sustained the injuries trying to prevent bombers Abdul Moertidjo and Ahmad Qomaruddin from entering the Church of the Risen Christ.

Regular church attendee Nathan Lim remembers Hartono's warmth and dedication despite his different faith: "He always said hello and knew everyone's names. And he was always eager to help."

Hartono was known to colleagues as a devout Muslim, especially attentive to prayer.

"Nothing unusual," Reza replied modestly when asked. "Like most Muslims, really."

The passing of Hartono, the family's sole breadwinner, has shaken his wife and son emotionally and financially. The wife of the deceased,

Rachmi Nuraini, is a homemaker. Reza is still in high school.

Kotawijaya Mayor Astrid Maharani visited the home of the bereaved to express her condolences. According to the mayor, all costs of the victim's funeral are being borne by the Kotawijaya Municipal Government. She has also arranged for a psychologist to assist the family.

"When the time comes, Reza is welcome to work with us at the Kotawijaya Municipal Government," the Mayor said.

THEY WERE TOO YOUNG TO DIE
thejavapost.com, 16 May 2018

Angela and Amelia Santoso, twin daughters to Yohanes and Maria Santoso, were among those who died in the suicide bombing at the Church of the Sacred Heart on 13 May 2018. The two eleven-year-olds had been dropped off with their mother in front of the church while Yohanes Santoso looked for parking. Maria Santoso went in first, while Angela and Amelia waited for a friend at the church entrance.

Angela and Amelia were flung some distance by the force of the blast and aided by bystanders. Angela suffered burns and internal bleeding and passed away shortly after arriving at the hospital. Amelia survived her twin sister by several hours but eventually succumbed due to loss of blood.

Angela and Amelia's aunt, Sugiharti Santoso, spoke with journalists on behalf of the family. She requested that their privacy be respected as they continue to grieve, and had this message to convey:

"Thank you for keeping us in your thoughts and your prayers. We forgive all that has been done. Yohanes and Maria have made their peace —their twin girls have been called home to their Father in Heaven."

Sugiharti told reporters how the girls' favorite items were placed in their coffins, including their diaries and favorite plush toys. In keeping with a longstanding family tradition, Maria taught her children to keep a written record of all the blessings in their lives. *Thank you, Lord Jesus*, such entries would begin. Whenever they received new clothes or shoes, they would write it down.

"Angela and Amelia are at peace up there. They're looking down from Heaven, like angels. Your prayers are appreciated. We thank our Lord

Jesus that they've gone to a better place."

Condolences continue to flow in for the Santoso family, as attested to by the many messages on Maria Santoso's Facebook wall. Teachers and friends of Angela and Amelia remember them as sweet, polite, and always kind to others. One classmate wrote the following:

Farewell, Angela and Amelia. May you be at peace with Our Father in Heaven.

THE FATE OF THE CHILDREN OF SUICIDE BOMBERS
video reportage from Nara TV, 19 May 2018

EXT. CHURCH OF THE SACRED HEART COURTYARD

Video footage of the explosions from multiple sources flashes across the screen. Violin music in background.

NARRATOR (V/O)
This is Maghfira Alatas, reporting for Nara TV.

MAGHFIRA:
Often overlooked in suicide attacks are the children of those who have been injured or killed. Their entire lives are forever changed, their future taken from them by force.

Photo montage of the children who died or lost families in the explosions, culminating with a photo of a little girl with plump cheeks, Patricia Dinda.

MAGHFIRA:
This innocent little toddler, Patricia Dinda, perished in her mother's arms when Annisa Dinda carried out her abominable act. And what about the surviving children of those who commit such acts? After their parents' traumatizing deaths, what comes next?

INT. OFFICE OF THE MINISTRY OF SOCIAL AFFAIRS OF THE REPUBLIC OF INDONESIA, JAKARTA.

A middle-aged woman wearing a black headscarf and glasses appears on screen. A caption states her name and position: Uswatun Khasanah, Director General of Social Rehabilitation, Ministry of Social Affairs of the Republic of Indonesia.

USWATUN:

Children are entrusted to us by Allah. It is our duty to care for them. Hence, it is our usual practice to assess the children of suicide bombers. Will they be able to adapt to their new environment? They can’t be sent back to school or returned to the community right away.

EXT. BHAYANGKARA HOSPITAL, KOTAWIJAYA

Maghfira Alatas stands outside the hospital entrance, microphone in hand, facing the camera. In the background, an ambulance drives by.

MAGHFIRA:

Viewers, I’m at Bhayangkara Hospital, where victims of the attack are undergoing treatment, including the surviving son of the suicide bomber couple, Muhammad Fahri and Annisa Dinda. 9-year-old Gibran Fairuz managed to run away from his father’s motorcycle just before the bomb went off. His condition is improving, but he still refuses to speak.

INT. BHAYANGKARA HOSPITAL, KOTAWIJAYA

The camera centers on Gibran, lying in a hospital ward. His features are blurred out. He doesn’t move, but his face is turned to the left, toward the window by his bed.

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THE BRIDE

Mami Cindy

Facebook Post—Mami Jenny, Kotawijaya

I've known Cindy for such a long time. She and I were part of the same community in Kotawijaya. We had our differences, but we were still close. Cindy was religious and always went to mosque, while I can't be bothered to go to church, even now. I dropped out of high school, but Cindy was smart, from a well-off family. She could have been a doctor if she hadn't quarreled with her dad.

Cindy's mom was Bugis, of bissu descent, but her dad was in the military and just couldn't accept that Cindy was trans. He even made Cindy take taekwondo as a kid, so she wouldn't be so girly, but guess what? In the end, she got a black belt and was brave and confident . . . and still girly. But her dad got really angry when he found out Cindy was seeing someone. It was too much for her and her boyfriend, so they ran away to Yogya. They broke up soon after, but Cindy decided to start a new community there, for trans women wanting to study the Qur'an.

I once asked her if she regretted not continuing her studies. After all, her relationship with that guy didn't end up going anywhere. But Cindy said if her dad had paid to put her through university, she probably would have felt like she needed to follow orders and do as he said. She told me she never wanted to be a doctor anyway: "I may not have a man in my life, but I do have a family. The ones who don't fit in. The ones who've been driven away. These are my children now."

Cindy came back to Kotawijaya eventually. I wouldn't call her life comfortable: she lived in a rented house in an alley, but she refused to touch any of her inheritance money. She helped a lot of people. Whatever she had, she gave. The last time we met, I told her how in

awe I was of her, providing a safe space for trans women to read the Qur'an together, taking in that kid and raising her by herself. Meanwhile, look at me, nothing's changed—all alone, no family, in debt. I joked, "Cindy, you have a kid, and I don't even have a cat!" But she scolded me. "Jenny, come on. What about the funds you raise for friends who can't pay their medical bills? How many friends' funerals have you arranged? We're all part of the struggle, okay?"

I've always told Cindy, ever since we were young, that I wanted her to arrange my funeral when I die. That I didn't have anyone else. But Cindy would just give me a good hard pinch. "You're not dying anytime soon, Jenny. Only the good die young." Then we'd both laugh.

Now you're gone, Cindy. At only 56, still young. You were a good person. That's why God took you away so soon.

Facebook Post—Natasha Ayu, Yogyakarta

Dear Mami, I'm heartbroken.

I'm sorry I didn't get to introduce you to my mother. I made a promise, but life has a way of making us wander around, traveling far. And she never got to meet you in the end.

Who knows where I'd be now if you hadn't found me sleeping under the bridge that morning. I remember you waking me up: "What are you doing here? Come with me!"

I was always an obedient child. Maybe that's why I followed you, just like when I would follow my mother. You were wearing a pink headscarf and batik housedress too, just like her.

You asked me what my name was. I was only eighteen. I had run away from home in Subang and was still so confused and scared. About putting on makeup, about God (do I really have to wear a peci and sarong when I pray? Will I go to hell?), about what I should call myself (Dina? Dini? Susi?), though I knew one thing for sure: I would never go by the name my father gave me. He taught at a madrasa, a skinny man with a gentle voice. I still remember how gently he said it: Better for you to leave than bring us shame.

Mami told me to bathe. Then she fed me. Her home was always full of cats. She'd find them in front of her house or on the street and bring them in. Sometimes they had wounds from other cats. Sometimes, it was clear they'd been tortured and abused. "It's not safe around here," Mami said. She told me about an army general who liked to shoot stray cats for fun.

At Mami's house, I made a new friend. Her name was Susmita. She had also run away from her family. When she found out how I couldn't decide on a name, she suggested "Natasha," after one of Mami's cats. "It's a pretty name! And it sounds so cool."

I laughed at first, but after a while, I thought, "She's right." Natasha suits me, and I like cats. For a long time, Mami had two Natashas to take care of: Pretty Natasha and Kitty Natasha!

I lived in Yogyakarta for a few years longer before going to work in Hong Kong. Finally, I returned to Subang. My father was dying. In his final moments, he accepted me for who I am. And I forgave him.

After he died, my mother asked me to take her to Yogyakarta to see you. She said she wanted to meet Mami Cindy, my second mom. I told her Mami Cindy moved to Kotawijaya, but that we'd visit her someday.

Mami, forgive me. For not getting around to repaying your kindness to me that morning. For not getting around to having my two moms meet.

Instagram Post—Rosalinda, Sydney

One day, I was helping Mami Cindy at the salon and I asked her, "Why do you rescue so many cats? Do you really have all that cash to spare?"

She laughed. "If I had cash to spare, do you think I'd be in so much debt?"

This made me smile. I was blow-drying a customer's hair at the time, and Mami was busy reading a magazine. She came over, and, staring at her reflection in the mirror,

adjusted her jilbab. “I just have a heart for wild things and strays,” she murmured.

Today, there is weeping in the city, in every corner and alleyway—a loud cry rising up from within the dumpsters and beneath the bridges. Mami’s strays, howling in sorrow, all through Yogyakarta and Kotawijaya, Sleman and Subang, Sydney and Hong Kong. They are weeping for their mother, clawing, leaping, stricken by grief. But soon the weeping gives way to other sounds, voices raised in protest, defiance, Qur’anic verse, and song. Farewell, Mami. We will endure. We will beat the drum.

To this day, whenever I feel lost, I remember how Mami would quote Surah Al-Baqarah. “Allah will not test His servants beyond what they can bear,” she would say. “This is all merely a test. It too shall pass.”

“If it’s only a test, why is it so painful?” I’d ask her.

And Mami would reply: “What do you expect? Almighty is Allah, and so, mighty too are His trials.”

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THE TRAVELER

Rubble

Smoke from Rosalinda's cigarette curls into the air as we stand together in front of the Church of the Risen Christ. It's a busy little street, full of different faiths and worldly activities of all kinds. To the right of the church are a Catholic kindergarten and elementary school, and a series of food carts lining the pavement. And behind us: a dentist, a center for followers of Indigenous beliefs, a Batak eatery, a tailor specializing in Muslimah garb.

The police line has been taken down, but there are still large white boards around the church gate, blocking access. Construction workers enter and exit through a narrow opening. They seem to be preparing the site before the restoration work will begin. Through the opening we glimpse shattered windows and blackened pillars—glass shards and ashes too, yet to be cleared away. In one corner stands a statue of Mary arms open, resigned, gazing down at the rubble scattered at her feet. Rosalinda bows her head, like Mary. Eyes closed, she clasps her hands over her chest, she whispers the surah of Al-Fatihah.

I too bow my head. Faced with these ruins, though, I find it hard to believe in an all-loving, merciful God.

Rosalinda's halfway done with her cigarette. From behind the white barrier comes the sound of a drill. I watch the cars on the road and the people passing by, their pace brisk. A few of them glance in our direction, but none of them stop. The city is eager to return to normalcy, though some of us find ourselves stuck. Rosalinda and I cross the street, back toward the rental car we've parked by the side of the road. Then Rosalinda turns to look at the church once more.

"Who could ever clean all this up?" she says, shaking her head.

She flings her cigarette butt on the pavement and grinds it out with the toe of her sneaker.

It's eleven when we arrive at the hospital. The receptionist gives us directions to Gibran's ward. When we get there, I mention his name, and the nurse immediately picks up the phone to call her colleague. We're passed from one nurse to another until, finally, a middle-aged woman in a white jilbab and slacks—a senior nurse, evidently—comes out to meet us. She wants to know if we're related to Gibran.

"I'm his aunt," I explain.

"Do you have an ID? Birth certificate or a copy of a family register?"

In short, she needs proof of our connection. Too many journalists have been trying to gain access to the child. A few reporters had managed to snap some photos while covering the mayor's visit to Gibran. Still others claimed that they were family. The hospital staff were caught off guard, and it was making Gibran's trauma worse. As a result, the doctors and psychologists responsible for Gibran's care have warned them to be extra careful when letting people in.

Rosalinda suggests I call Mutiara and ask for help, but I flat out refuse. "Are you crazy?" I ask.

But it's not long before I concede defeat. I get out my phone. I can feel my spirit shriveling in anticipation of the lecture I'm going to get. I imagine how smug she'll sound, how self-righteous: *What did I tell you? No one can depend on you because you're never here. And see? You can't even follow through on the plans you made and, in the end, you have to call me.*

But when she picks up, her tone surprises me. It's cold, as usual, but not aggressive. She doesn't even mention our fight.

"Hmm. It's tricky," she says. "Annisa hasn't been listed on our family register since she got married. It's just the two of us."

"What about an older copy?"

"Are you asking me to dig through all our records?"

"I mean—"

"Is Rosalinda with you too?"

I glance behind me, where Rosalinda is standing. Even if we could come up with the right documentation, they probably won't let her in since she's not family. I hear Mutiara take a deep breath.

"Okay, okay. I think I can help."

We decide to wait in the hospital café until Mutiara calls us back. Rosalinda orders a cup of black coffee. It's too weak. She makes a face and I tease her about being a snob. Two hours later, we're just about to give up and go back to the hotel when Mutiara sends me a photo of an official document. It's an old family register, dated 2003.

"She still has it?" Rosalinda exclaims.

"Yep," I say. "She doesn't let anything go."

There it is. A complete list of every individual residing in the house after Nana was carted off to Jakarta from Tanjung Karang. *Sulaiman: head of household. Maemunah: wife. Mutiara: child. Maya: child. Annisa: child. Victoria: mother. Rohadi: servant.* It's hard to believe there was a time when we were all listed together, collected on a single card, our roles in the family described so simply, before some of us left, and some of us died.

Rosalinda and I leave the hospital to get the photo printed out before returning to the ward. The nurse in the white jilbab studies the sheet of paper, brow furrowed. She removes her glasses and looks skeptically at us.

"This is fifteen years old."

"Yes," I said impatiently. "We haven't lived in the same house for a long time—"

"All right, all right. You have half an hour."

Our visit doesn't even last fifteen minutes.

The pale green walls of Gibran's room remind me of the hospital where Nana was treated in Tanjung Karang. At least it's brighter here, under the glare of these halogen lights. I wonder if they've just been replaced. But there's something off, emanating not only from the walls but the bedsheets and pillowcases, which are a similar hue. Verdant and cheery, striking the wrong tone altogether. Lush, leafy green, the color of heaven, walling me in with—I don't know how to put it—"nauseating virtue," maybe. And here, in this room, for the first time in years, I see my nephew. He's the only one of his family left. He sits on the side of his bed, looking out the window. When we enter, he doesn't turn his head.

There are three of us: me, Rosalinda, and a psychologist who is there to ensure the conversation doesn't trigger any trauma. As we approach, I see that there's a sketchbook on Gibran's lap and a pencil in his hand. Outside,

the psychologist told us that Gibran's been given a sketchbook as well as a notebook so he has an outlet for his feelings and thoughts. The notebook is still blank, but just a few days ago, he started drawing. Gently, the psychologist gets Gibran's attention. He has visitors. Auntie Maya and Auntie Rosalinda are here.

Gibran glances at each of us in turn and goes back to drawing.

"How are you, Gibran?" I ask. "Do you remember me?"

The psychologist motions for me to be patient, more cautious. Then she asks him a few questions. Did he sleep well? Did he eat breakfast? Gibran nods but doesn't make a sound.

He's drawn a house with two windows, in thick, bold strokes. On the left, the curtains are open, revealing a head peeking through the windowpane. It's someone inside, staring out. A typical drawing for a nine-year-old, except this isn't just any nine-year-old. This is a boy who wanted to get out, to escape. He jumped off his father's motorbike because he wanted to live, because wasn't life worth fighting for? But how could he know it would end like this—alive but alone. Everyone else dead. It had all been in vain. And when I turn my attention to the right side of the drawing, I feel something fall out of me. Like a coin sliding out of a pocket, slipping away, gone. Suddenly, like Gibran, I don't want to make a sound.

There's a tree to the right of the house. Long shirts hang from its branches, billowing, fluttering in the wind.

Empty garments. No bodies inside.

I can't remember how our visit ends. Maybe the psychologist reminded us of the time. But also, maybe I couldn't bear it any longer, being speechless and stuck within those cheerful green walls. Before we leave, I notice Rosalinda speaking to Gibran, and for the first time the boy looks up. The two make eye contact, only for a second, but long enough to spark surprise, as well as hope—before the boy returns to the drawing in his sketchbook, to the figure peeking out from behind the curtains.

We speed along, Rosalinda behind the wheel in sunglasses to ward off the harsh 2:00 P.M. glare. I sit beside her, staring out the window. Everything in the city is in constant motion; even the traffic lights seem reluctant to stay red for too long. Amid the cars and motorbikes, images

flash before me, of Gibran's pale green room. Of a figure staring out the window, of clothes hanging from a tree.

Before we left the hospital, the psychologist explained to us how things would proceed. Gibran would spend a year in a rehabilitation center before being returned to his family. It could be any relative, a grandmother, or an aunt or uncle, but if no one was willing to take him in, he'd go to an orphanage. I recall how my sister wanted nothing to do with Gibran, poor boy, left behind in his family's fervor to kill themselves, tarred with sin, tainted forever.

"Mutiara doesn't want him," I tell Rosalinda.

"Why does it have to be Mutiara?"

I see a glimmer of a smile on Rosalinda's lips, her eyes still on the road.

Isn't it obvious, I think. Who else could take care of Gibran? I'm always on the move. I couldn't possibly raise a child. My sister, on the other hand, has set down roots, lives all by her witchy self with her feline brood.

"You still believe in Nana's prophecy, do you?" asks Rosalinda. "And Mutiara's the caretaker. Isn't that right?"

She goes on without waiting for a response. "Ah, but of course you do. You get to be the traveler. How wonderful for you."

"Mutiara chose her own path."

"That doesn't mean she wants to be a caretaker forever. No one wants to be nailed down for life."

I recall my conversation with Mutiara at Koh Acong's workshop. How she felt, after everything that had happened, it was impossible to leave. Maybe I was secretly glad to hear it because I thought it would be best for everyone.

"You know," says Rosalinda. "I used to imagine growing old with Chris. How we'd be lonely empty nesters once our kids grew up and had their own lives. Of course, that was before he robbed the damn cradle."

"And since then, you don't want kids?"

"I didn't say that."

I notice the Toyota Alphard in front of us—the decals on the rear window with a stick-figure family, a father, mother, and three children. Déjà vu. I wonder if this is how everyone ends up, dreaming of shackles, of anchors, even people like Rosalinda.

"And you? What's the plan with your boyfriend?"

Her question catches me off guard. She must have been watching me this whole time. I tried dialing Nadir several times yesterday, then last night, he called right before bed. I thought Rosalinda was sleeping, but she probably heard our conversation.

"No plan," I said. "It's not going anywhere."

"Why not?"

"He has a wife."

"Oh." Rosalinda adjusts her sunglasses. "Better let him work that out first. Don't take credit, only cash."

"I'm not sure I want to be with him."

"But you kept waiting for him to call?"

I lean my head against the window, my face away from her. I don't want her to see my expression.

"He's settled down. I'm always on the move."

"Aren't you tired of being on the run?"

We stop at a red light. A busker dressed in a grimy full-body Dora the Explorer costume weaves through the cars, jingling an instrument and doing a little dance. She stops next to the car in front and holds out an oversized hand. No luck. The driver must not be amused. What a cruel world, to force someone to earn a living like this—walking the streets in a buffoon's costume, in this boiling heat. I picture the poor soul drowning in sweat inside Dora's enormous-eyed, cartoon-fringed head.

"Huh. She's like you," remarks Rosalinda.

"Who?"

"Dora. An explorer. *¡Vámonos!*"

"I thought they made busking on the roads illegal in Kotawijaya."

Dora spins wearily, to the left, then to the right, before starting with the jingling and dancing again.

"It's a clean city, that's for sure," sneers Rosalinda. "A middle-class paradise. Naughty Dora! You rule-breaker, you!"

Dora approaches us. Rosalinda rolls down the window and hands her a green bill. Bowing in thanks, Dora retires to the side of the road and removes her huge head. The person behind Dora is revealed—a guy with a mustache, fanning himself in the shade of a tree.

"You gave him twenty thousand rupiah?"

"Solidarity. Between performers," Rosalinda says.

The light changes, and we roll on.

Rosalinda pulls over and parks. The instant I leave the car's air-conditioned interior, my face flushes and grows sweaty in the heat. I survey the house—two stories, a white gate—and turn to Rosalinda, my eyes squinting in the sun.

"This is where she lived?"

Rosalinda shakes her head and takes me further down the street. We turn into an alley, too narrow for cars to enter. We pass children playing near an open sewer canal, motorbikes coming from the opposite direction, chickens and cats wandering about. Five minutes later, we reach a tiny house painted ivory white, the door ajar.

"This is it, on the left," she says. "Mami Cindy's."

The house has neither a gate nor a yard. Rosalinda calls out a salam at the door, and a white cat comes running out, meowing. Rosalinda crouches to pet it before looking up. A teenage girl in a white headscarf comes out too. She greets us. She can't be more than fifteen.

"Fatimah?"

Rosalinda envelopes her in a hug. The girl hesitates at first but then returns Rosalinda's embrace. When she sees me, she lowers her eyes.

"This is Maya," Rosalinda says.

She gives no further explanation. I can't tell whether I feel relieved.

After inviting us over to the mat to sit down, Fatimah goes to the kitchen to get us something to drink. Rosalinda takes out a tissue to dab at the sweat that has started to course down her brow. I look around the living room. There are only two plastic chairs, a small table, and two framed photographs hanging on the wall. One is of Fatimah, probably recent. The other is of Mami Cindy in a bright yellow headscarf at a beach with little Fatimah in her arms.

The cat circles me, sniffing, then lies down, tummy up, in my lap. Uneasy, I scoot over, though the cat's probably just being friendly. Fatimah appears with glasses of cordial and a jar of cookies.

"Shakira," she calls.

The cat pads over to lie at Fatimah's feet.

"Mami promised to give Shakira to Mami Jenny," says Fatimah, stroking the cat.

“Then who’ll keep you company?” Rosalinda queries.

Fatimah stares at the cat thoughtfully, then smiles. She tells us how her mother’s friends—Mami Dolly, Mami Jenny, and Bunda Shinta—have been taking turns staying at the house and caring for her since her mother died. “I have lots of mothers who love me,” she says. Mami Cindy’s younger sister is going to legally adopt her, and she’ll go to stay in the house Mami grew up in, bigger than this one, and closer to a good school. Fatimah is a little worried. This is the only life she’s ever known; she’s been helping her mother manage the An-Nur study group since she was little, and she’s grown up with all these women, whom she calls *Mami* and *Bunda*.

“No one makes fun of you at school?” asks Rosalinda.

“All the time. But I don’t care.”

“You don’t care?”

“No,” says Fatimah. “But, of course, I care what Mami’s friends think. One of them is always waiting for me when I get home from school. They cook and tell stories. They say Mami was an amazing woman, even though she was never on TV.”

Rosalinda nods. “TV can’t be trusted.”

“Auntie, how did you get to know Mami?”

“I met her in Yogyakarta,” Rosalinda says. “You never forget the people who lend a hand in times of need.”

She tells Fatimah how Mami Cindy lent her money so that she could go to university. But studying to become an artist kept her busy, too busy to attend the group. She was determined to start coming again but found out Mami Cindy had returned to Kotawijaya to care for her recently widowed mother, who was in poor health. Rosalinda never got the chance to pay Mami Cindy back.

I take all the stories I’ve gathered today and weave them together. I know they’re not complete, but I’m beginning to see the Rosalinda I’d never known, and—dare I admit it—a Rosalinda I’ve never spared a single thought for. I too want to ask questions. I want to apologize to Rosalinda, to Fatimah. But the truth is, I’m in awe, unable to do anything but listen to them celebrate Mami Cindy’s life. For I know there will never be any mention of Mami Cindy in history books. And as I sit in my silence, I’m afraid that Fatimah will notice a putrid smell—that it’s coming from me,

who doesn't belong here, who is sitting on her mat, infecting her house with my sister's foul blood.

"I want to pay her back."

It's late afternoon. Rosalinda hands Fatimah a white envelope. The girl nods and says thank you, not surprised in the least.

"Everyone is Mami's child," she replies.

Rosalinda frowns.

"What do you mean?"

"On TV, they kept asking the victims' relatives what their last words were to them. And those were the last words I heard Mami say."

"Did any reporters actually ask you?"

"No, nobody. I just want you to know."

"When did Mami say it?"

"The day before she died. Someone else came to pay Mami back. Mami said, 'Alhamdulillah, at this rate, I'll be able to help people with medical costs even more.'"

Rosalinda shoots me a glance. But I feel myself shrinking, retreating inward. I look down, my attention fixed on the tissue in my hands that I've been wringing since sitting down on Mami Cindy's mat.

Fatimah goes on. "Then Mami said this: I know a lot of people haven't paid me back, but I know how it is. I know what it's like to go through tough times. I know what it's like to be driven from home. I don't want to ask anyone to repay me. Everyone is Mami's child."

On the way back from Mami Cindy's house, Rosalinda and I don't say much. Rosalinda only speaks when necessary, to confirm she's going the right way, and I help a bit by checking the map on my phone. On the radio, chatty DJs play pop songs I've never heard of, but I don't change the station. I steal glances at Rosalinda, wondering if this is her kind of music, but she stares straight ahead, clearly not listening. I look out the window at all the tall buildings, but my thoughts are still back in Mami Cindy's house, on that mat, where I sat sweating in front of Fatimah, not confessing, not apologizing, not doing anything apart from sitting there numbly, wishing I could make myself disappear.

I've let Rosalinda down.

I've let myself down too.

When we reach the hotel, we head directly to our room. Rosalinda turns on the TV, and we sit on our separate beds, our eyes locked on our phones, taking refuge, waiting. I open my mouth to say something, but Rosalinda excuses herself to go out for a smoke, leaving me with a quiz show, the contestants vying for big cash prizes, playing on the screen.

Rosalinda dresses up for the evening. Her makeup is more dramatic than before—false eyelashes, shimmery brown eyeshadow, crimson lipstick—and her hair is pinned up in a chignon. She goes into the bathroom to change and emerges in a red nyonya kebaya and a black batik sarong decorated with peacocks and flowers. She tells me she bought the kebaya when she was performing in Malaysia. For the first time since returning from Mami Cindy's, she smiles at me, as if her costume change signifies a change of mood.

"Let's go," she says.

"Where?"

"To have noodles at the restaurant next door."

There's a noodle shop beside our hotel, supposedly one of the best in town. Plumes of steam waft out into the street. Rosalinda strides in purposefully, turning a few heads. We each order the same thing: bakmi ayam with bakso. Rosalinda asks if I remember the noodles Nana liked to order from the market. I shake my head, my memory hazy. We end up talking about the cities we live in (New York, Sydney), the best neighborhoods to find Indonesian food (Elmhurst, Kingsford), and other light matters. I save myself the burden of taking on a conversation I don't have the courage for. And perhaps Rosalinda is sparing me on purpose, at least for now.

After eating, we return to the hotel and head up to the bar, which is quiet, probably because it's Ramadan. I order a beer and Rosalinda opts for red wine. We continue chatting but soon lapse into silence, gazing together at the piano player in the corner who occasionally croons along. Soon, though, he has finished his set. No songs left to sing, no anecdotes for us to squeeze out. I muster up the courage to say what I must.

"I'm sorry."

Here I am. In the end, I've gone back to the start, to the source of the wound. Rosalinda raises an eyebrow.

"For what?"

Yes, for what? She's right to demand clarification. Too many sins, crisscrossing—it's hard to keep track. Am I merely expressing condolences, or am I apologizing on behalf of Annisa? Or am I asking forgiveness for staying silent when faced with a victim of my sister's reprehensible act?

"For Mami Cindy."

Even as the name leaves my lips, I know my answer isn't enough.

She laughs softly, bitterly. "People like us, no one cares if we die."

I'm quiet.

"There are two things that ruin people in this country," she reflects. "One, you're well-off—a master, not a worker. You go to a good school, you get enough to eat, you've never had to live on the streets. Two, you're Muslim. Part of the majority. If you're not careful and your parents don't raise you well, the combo can turn you into a tyrant."

Rosalinda gets up and walks over to the bartender to order a second wine. My glass is still full. I'm stung by what she's said. I live in New York on scholarship money. I have no savings. Her barbed remarks were unfair.

"Who exactly are you talking about, Rosalinda?"

"Annisa, maybe" she says. "Or maybe all three of you."

"I'm no master."

"You're the master's daughter. That's how you made it to New York."

I try to remind myself that she's still mourning Mami Cindy. I try to restrain myself from asking point-blank: *Exactly what are you trying to say?*

"You still can't see it?" she asks. "Everything is connected. Everything is tied together. The same system that made it possible for this to happen—for someone 'religious' to stray so far—is the same one that lets people like me and my community be oppressed."

Her words pierce me to the heart. I feel like I've been judged unfairly, but maybe Mutiara's right: whatever I do isn't enough. It has never been enough. Then, with some exasperation, I say, "You think I knew what Annisa was thinking? I don't know where we left her behind."

"What about me? Do you know where you left me behind?"

The bar gets livelier as the night goes on. It's not just the piano player anymore. Act two: a singer in a glittering black gown takes a spot next to the piano and bids the guests good evening. She begins singing in a low, husky voice. A few of the other guests sing along, first "When I Fall in Love," then "Fly Me to the Moon." I glance around: we're surrounded by middle-aged uncles and aunties. They're not doing their tarawih prayers, so either they're not Muslim or they haven't reformed their ways yet.

Rosalinda is on her third wine. When the song comes to an end, the audience applauds. The style of the music changes, and the singer launches into "Juwita Malam."

"'Night Beauty,'" says Rosalinda. "By Sam Saimun. This was Nana's favorite song."

She tells me how Nana would play her records and invite her to dance. I know she lived with my grandmother for longer, but still, it makes me jealous to think about how familiar Rosalinda was with Nana's everyday habits.

"My favorite is 'Bujang Dara,'" she tells me, breaking softly into song. "*Boy, girl . . .* Whenever she played it, Nana and I would dance."

Rosalinda sits in her chair, swaying to the music.

"Rosalinda?" I touch her arm. "What did you mean just now?"

"Hmm?"

"Why did you say I left you behind?"

Her laugh is full of scorn.

"Oh, come on, Maya. You didn't invite me to Annisa's wedding, you didn't try to find out why I left your house . . . "

She polishes off her wine and leans back, staring at the ceiling as I sit opposite her, back straight, suddenly frozen to my seat.

"Do you still remember your promise?"

"Yes."

"Go ahead. Say it."

My mouth is locked shut. In my mind's eye, a memory unfurls, of Maya making a promise to Rohadi. *You'll always be my best friend.* Yet how many years did I pass without knowing what became of her and never trying to find out until she appeared amid the rubble and the ruins, with a name on her lips that shook me to the core, *Mami Cindy*.

“Best friends forever,” scoffs Rosalinda. “Until you all were old enough to realize I was only the servant’s child.”

Rosalinda gets up and walks over to the musicians. They talk briefly, and the piano player nods. Soon, Rosalinda is the one at the microphone. It’s my first time hearing the song, “Boy, Girl.” Rosalinda looks so elegant next to the pianist, transformed into Miss Rosalinda, the Blossom of Coral Cape, shimmering and beautiful. Meanwhile here I sit, awed and envious, haunted by a promise I didn’t keep: *You’ll always be my best friend.*

Cross your heart?

Cross my heart.

Rosalinda steadies herself on my arm as we leave the bar and get into the elevator. She’s had too much to drink but insists she is sober. Back in the room, she takes off her high heels and lies down. I wash my face and brush my teeth, and when I emerge from the bathroom, I see she’s fallen asleep. I get into bed and turn off the light, but then she starts murmuring softly to herself before asking if I want to hear a bedtime story. I mutter something—do I say yes? I can’t remember—and, with the lights still off, the story pours out, like a rushing stream. It twists and turns, and there are bumps along the way, but I can picture it all nonetheless. She never stops once, or checks to see if I’m listening, or even awake, or maybe pretending to be asleep. But I’ll always remember what she says at the end:

“Revolutions always begin with ugly stepsisters. So, what’s your revolution, Maya?”

In the darkness, I quietly weep.

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THE UGLY STEPSISTER'S TALE

Ladies and gentlemen, turn out the lights. Some stories need to be told in the dark—not because this story is about ogres, but because who knows what creature you might become by the time it's done.

It's seven years after the beating—the one so severe it costs Rohadi a tooth. He no longer ran into gangs, but ogres take the most unexpected forms. Sometimes they're beautiful, or young. Sometimes they even call themselves family.

Let's go to Jakarta, to the House of the Three Sisters, where Rohadi is trying to piece together what has happened. That night, chaos reigns. Annisa is late coming home, and when she does appear in the doorway, her face is battered and bruised. The pretty little thing was beaten up by thugs and her motorbike was stolen—so her story goes.

Annisa's in shock, says the oldest sister. Don't keep asking her questions.

But Nana—Nana, ever deafer and more forgetful—knows something is wrong.

Annisa's home, repeats the middle sister, but over and over: Don't stop until you find her, Nana says.

I, Rosalinda, see those welts for what they are. I've been there, experienced them for myself. But this is the House of the Three Sisters, and there is only Rohadi, frail and naive, still ignorant of the ways of the world.

Before Nana goes to sleep, she tugs Rohadi's hand.

Look for my granddaughter until you find her, she says.

But Annisa's home, Nana.

Rohadi thinks he hears a tiger's growl.

Follow her. She's lost. If you don't find her now, no one will ever get her back.

The next day Rohadi carries out his duties as usual, looking after Nana, doing some light sweeping, watering the plants. But he begins taking note of Annisa's movements. The girl stays in her room except for trips to the bathroom. Two days pass, then three, and she's still keeping to herself. When Annisa finally does leave the house, neatly dressed, in a hijab, Rohadi follows. She walks for some distance, past Asih's warung and out of the housing complex, before stopping by the main road. Rohadi thinks she's going to take a minibus, but a few of them pass and she doesn't wave one down. A motorbike approaches. The rider, a man in a helmet, pulls over. Annisa gets on behind him and they drive away. Rohadi records the license plate number.

The motorbike is Annisa's. It hasn't been stolen after all.

Rohadi thinks hard: should he tell Nana? Or Mutiara or Maya? Or their parents? He doesn't want trouble. Little people shouldn't look for trouble, Mamak said. *But why did Annisa lie?* Rohadi decides to keep quiet. He continues watching Annisa. The girl's trips to the bathroom grow more frequent, and when she comes out, her face is blotchy, and her eyes are wet. She goes before dinner, after dinner, sometimes in the middle, even. Eventually Mutiara asks, Why are you peeing so much?

Then, one day, Rohadi overhears Annisa talking on the phone. Her bedroom door is ajar. Maybe she thinks everyone is out and that Rohadi is busy caring for Nana. Rohadi listens. He can only make out some of the conversation, but he knows Annisa is crying.

I'm scared, says Annisa.

The person on the other side speaks, at length, as if trying to convince Annisa of something.

And you think everything will be okay after that? she asks.

Again, the other person speaks at length. Why is he talking so much—is he giving a lecture?

Yes, we both sinned, says Annisa. But you're not the one who'll suffer the consequences.

One by one, the pieces come together. Rohadi tries to connect the dots and understand: Annisa's claim that her motorbike was stolen; Annisa sequestered in her room, looking tired and pale, always going to the

bathroom; Annisa on the phone; Annisa silent, as the person on the other end speaks, trying to convince her, perhaps.

Rohadi wants to help Annisa, but he suspects she doesn't want her family to know anything. So, when the house is quiet, Rohadi knocks on her door. A burden shared is a burden halved.

You can tell me, Annisa.

Annisa stands motionless, her hands wringing the hem of her blouse.

You know, my mother didn't want me at first, says Rohadi. My father had a temper and was prone to hitting. Mamak was afraid. I can't speak for her, but I'm grateful she had me. And even if she'd decided not to keep me, I believe Mamak was trying to make the best decision she could for us both.

Annisa stares at Rohadi, her eyes filling with tears. For a moment, Rohadi thinks she's going to rush over and give him a hug—Annisa, his little sister too, dear childhood friend. And he will watch over her, a faithful bodyguard. This is the story of three sisters, but there are more than three, surely. We must all care for each other. We're Victoria's grandchildren.

Slowly, Annisa comes closer. Rohadi waits, expectant, another sibling, from a story that might be. Our little sister whispers in Rohadi's ear:

I have no idea what you're talking about.

Two days later, the father of the three sisters invites Rohadi to go for a drive.

We'll run some errands, says Sulaiman. But they don't go to the market. Sulaiman just doesn't want his wife or mother around to protest the decision he has made.

Apparently, Annisa's headscarf went missing. A light blue one, an expensive gift. Rohadi looks out the window. This street is familiar, and yet he feels lost. The car leaves the complex, goes out to the main road, and turns into another housing estate.

We turned everything upside-down, says Sulaiman. But we finally found it. In your room.

Rohadi has never even seen this light blue headscarf, and he wonders what Sulaiman means by we.

I won't tell the others, says Sulaiman. There's no need for a fuss.

Rohadi gazes out at the passing scenery: house after house, warungs, a mosque. It's two o'clock and the weather outside looks hot and dry. Eventually he understands.

I never stole any headscarf.

Enough. We've accepted it.

It's a lie!

You also took Nana's lipstick.

Rohadi trembles. He did take the lipstick from Nana's room, but she hasn't worn it for ages—a dozen years at least. The lipstick was broken, tucked away in her dresser drawer. The three girls would use it when they put on plays. He never intended to put it on. He just wanted to remember. That's all.

Sulaiman sighs and pulls the car over.

Rohadi, have you ever thought about getting work experience somewhere else? Who knows? Maybe you'll find somewhere that's a better fit for you. Maybe you'll meet people like you.

Rohadi doesn't know what is meant by people like you. People who aren't boys who aren't considered girls? People who are workers, not masters like Sulaiman?

He realizes that Sulaiman is kicking him out, two days after he thought he was coming to Annisa's aid.

Years later, when Rosalinda is learning to drive in Sydney, she will be reminded of Sulaiman behind the wheel. She'll look over at the passenger seat and see Rohadi, cowering, frightened, and she'll want to berate him: *Why didn't you fight back when your boss bullied you?* It will take years for Rosalinda to forgive Rohadi.

When the car returns to the house, Rohadi runs inside. He spies Annisa peeking at him from behind her bedroom door. Rohadi wants to go up to her and ask for an explanation, but he stops himself. (*What were you scared of*, Rosalinda will always ask). He returns to his room, a servant's room, cramped and dingy, a thin mattress on a woven mat. His tears spill over, onto the shabby beige sheets. Ogres are everywhere, can take all forms—pretty girls, family members—and they can stomp on anyone they choose.

Amid thoughts about ogres, Rohadi considers Sulaiman's words. There are other places out there, beyond Asih's warung, beyond the dusty minibus stop, beyond even the toll roads and the big trucks with women's

faces painted on the back. Someplace better, a way out, though who knows if it's real; he can only dream. Maybe, after all these years of trying to find out who he really is, of trying to remember he's not a peacock, just a duck, he will finally be free.

That day, Rohadi leaves the House of the Three Sisters without a word of farewell to anyone. The third sister has betrayed him; the other two, well, maybe, maybe not—but you can't trust the sweet words of the Master's child. He regrets not saying goodbye to Nana. He is afraid Nana will defend him, prevent him from leaving, and that he'll relent and let himself be imprisoned once more.

But, looking back, maybe Rohadi underestimated her.

Before they moved to Jakarta, Rohadi had answered her question: I'm sorry, Nana. I don't want your tiger powers. But it's not because I'm afraid of a painful death.

Even as he spoke, Rohadi was terrified of how furious she would be. He imagined her scolding him. *You ingrate! How dare you!* Instead, Nana hugged him and said:

Ah, I'm so old-fashioned, Rohadi! Of course. You want to use your own magic to shapeshift. That's all right. I'll wait for you to become a butterfly.

And so, ladies and gentlemen, here ends our bedtime story. The ugly stepsister is transformed. She's Rosalinda now. She's launching a revolution. Sweet dreams.

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THE TRAVELER

The Music Box

The sound of a hair dryer rouses me from sleep. Rosalinda is in the bathroom, and I've woken with a headache. I reach for my phone. It's already 10 A.M. There are no messages from Nadir. I'm anxious, as if I've run out of medicine—although what condition I'm treating, I don't know. I feel a certain emptiness as I stare at the ceiling. Then, as I glance over at the crumpled blanket on Rosalinda's bed, feelings of stupidity follow, of being left behind and the last to know. I get up slowly and sit on the side of the bed. The TV is off, but I stare at it, dazed, as if I've been slapped. I don't understand. How did I get here?

The hair dryer stops. Rosalinda bustles over to her handbag from the bedside table and slips a compact and lipstick inside.

"We promised to be there at eleven," she says. "You're sure you want to come?"

I'm not, but I nod.

"About last night—"

"We'll talk later."

I get out of bed.

At the bathroom sink, I get out my toothbrush and toothpaste and begin brushing my teeth. I keep my eyes on the faucet because I can't bear to look myself in the face.

We don't speak on the drive over. I search the sidewalks, behind the road barriers, along the black-and-white-painted curbs, looking for Annisa. She always seems to appear in the most unexpected places—on the street or a park bench, in a train, catching me unawares, sending a warning, motioning me to stop: *You have no right to keep going, you don't*

deserve to sit here. So, today, on the way to Angela and Amelia's house, I summon my sister. I stand inside a bell tower, tugging a rope until the great bell tolls. One. *Annisa.* Two. *Annisa. Oh sister, dear sister, show your face. Don't turn away.*

I'm here because of you.

I keep my eyes on the quiet streets, but there's no sign of her. It's partly my fault. I don't know which Annisa I'm calling to: the Annisa who liked everything perfect, everything whole? The Annisa racked with shame, who urged my father to get rid of Rohadi? The Annisa turned wife and mother, whom I increasingly kept my distance from and couldn't understand, whom I ignored and allowed to drift away. No, Annisa's not here today, just my own cowardly self.

Rosalinda and I stand outside the gate for a long time. Eventually, a gray-haired woman comes out to greet us. Her name is Sugiharti, Angela and Amelia's aunt. She studies each of us in turn. Her gaze falls on the bouquet in my hand. I imagine she's received visits from far too many people, and that she's learned exactly what answers to give and how to act toward them all: the police and reporters, the relatives and neighbors, her fellow parishioners, even strangers offering their condolences for the twins. She must feel devastated, not to mention exhausted, standing in for her younger sister, Maria Santoso, too shattered to face the public herself. Rosalinda explains who we are and Sugiharti listens, trying to be polite. But with each passing second, my torment grows, until finally—where the courage comes from, I don't know—I blurt out my name, and my sister's. Sugiharti stares, attempting to mask her shock. She asks us to come inside the gate. She goes into the house, and when she returns, she has us follow her into the living room.

We pass through a large wooden door. The floors are made of white marble. In the living room, a woman, pale, dressed in white sits in a carved lacquer chair. There are dark, almost black, circles under her eyes. My pulse races when she's introduced:

"This is Maria."

Maria. The mother of the girls who are no more. Mother Maria, head bowed, gazing at the ruins of the church.

Sugiharti informs us this is the first time Maria has agreed to meet anyone. Without getting up from her chair, Maria looks at me, her gaze piercing, passing through me, as if I'm only a shadow, an apparition, nothing more. Slowly, I take the seat beside her. I give her the bouquet, and, in a trembling voice, I offer my condolences. I still can't bring myself to say it—*sorry*; it won't come to my tongue. Maria accepts the flowers but says nothing. We all watch her, waiting, and I feel my breathing grow more labored the longer we sit. Sugiharti asks if we'd like something to drink—a small effort to make this meeting less painful—and we shake our heads. After a while, Maria rises. Come, she says softly. I follow, despite my worry—come where?

She shows me her daughters' room. It's spacious, with white walls and two pink beds. The sheets look recently changed. There's a wardrobe, two desks, two chairs, a mirror—I take pains to avoid my reflection. The neatness of the room, everything in place, makes apparent what has been stolen away: no schoolbags lying around, no broken pencils, no sun-soured uniforms hanging behind the door, no tattered notebooks, the edges beginning to curl.

"They should have made it to high school. They should have graduated."

Maria's gaze is somewhere else as she mentions this, as if in passing, but those words echo in my ears: *should have*. They should have lived to attend their graduation party, in outfits they'd laugh about twenty years later. They should have exchanged tearful promises with classmates, *we'll see each other again*.

I turn my gaze to one of the bare desks, where a music box sits, its lid shut. It's pink, like the bedsheets. Maria says that the rest of her daughters' favorite toys were placed with them in their caskets. But she's kept this music box. When Angela and Amelia were toddlers, they refused to go to sleep without hearing the ballerina's song. Maria opens the box and sets it playing. Tinkling music, and a ballerina with her leg raised, twirling slowly, as if taking in the whole room, and us. We watch her in awkward silence. From the corner of my eye, I swear I see a curtain move. But then all is still.

The music stops.

"Forgive me."

The words finally come, with great difficulty, because I'm still a coward. For a moment, I hope she'll take my hand and say, *It's not your fault*. And I'm ashamed of myself for even thinking it possible when Maria, wiping her eyes, turns away.

"All is forgiven," she murmurs.

She walks out the door without looking at me, and for a few seconds, I'm alone, in Angela and Amelia's room—the two girls who are no more. No, Annisa's not here at all. Just cowardly me, submitting to the silent explosion of a mother's fury, accepting the punishment I deserve.

We return to the hotel room for the rest of the day. Rosalinda orders in food for dinner, but I don't have the appetite to finish my meal. Instead of checking my phone, I let it lie on the bedside table and get out my notebook.

I came here seeking resolution. How arrogant I was. Rosalinda's right—who could ever clean this up? And here I am, caught up in it all, hopelessly entangled. Or even worse: maybe this is just the beginning. I listen for my grandmother's voice, calling silently to her. I try to imagine her sitting here on my bed, whispering in my ear: *You must go on. Don't stop writing. I have seen you on a boat, with books.* But no. No weretiger's voice, magical, unseen. I wasn't even Nana's favorite, like I thought. There is no boat, no books—just as in Angela and Amelia's room, there are no books or pens. A storm is coming, and now, without a boat, I will drown. I seem to hear the tinkle of a music box, faint, followed by children's voices—happy laughter, stolen away. Then, ever so slowly, the tinkling notes turn into a persistent mournful buzz.

"Do you hear that?" I ask Rosalinda.

She shakes her head.

I've spent all these years fleeing from one place to another, afraid of being tied down, or called to account for promises I've never kept. But those connections, the system that Rosalinda spoke of—they have always supported me, and perhaps they always will. As families go, we've never strayed from the norm—not too poor, not too different, not too weird. Average—and therefore, the majority. Everything was easy. Eid was ours, as were mosques, and the streets, and the city. The red carpet was rolled out at the markets especially for us—to shop, to pray, to gain entry to

heaven, so we just let it all be. And isn't that just what I did, when I left it all behind, running away as fast as I could, believing I was beginning a revolution?

I have no memory of closing my notebook. The last thing I remember is Rosalinda, not my grandmother, by my side. She holds me and strokes my hair, as I burst into tears in her arms.

On Saturday, under the searing sun, Dinar waited at the pier, her purse tucked under her arm, a bouquet in her left hand, a parasol in her right. Tip-toeing in her low-heeled mules, she scanned the crowd of people getting off the ship. No sign of Rohana. Dinar straightened her bun, touched up her lipstick and adjusted her dress—a floral print with two pockets—because, as Rohana used to say, women needed pockets too.

In the late afternoon, her husband Hasan comes over to wait with her. "Could you have gotten the date wrong?" he asked.

"Impossible! She wouldn't break our promise," she snapped. "I've been waiting twenty years for this day!"

Hasan retired to a shaded bench, took out a pair of glasses, and started reading a book. Though he could not fathom his wife's anger, he didn't mind waiting patiently. He'd only meant well by accompanying her.

Soon it would be Maghrib. Dinar took out a cigarette and began pacing, back and forth, until an officer came with the news: no more ships would be pulling into port today.

"Didn't you hear about the chaos in Jakarta, ma'am?"

In the car, Dinar sat, shaking, hair hanging loose around her face. Hasan drove on, not daring to ask any questions. Keeping his eyes on the long, dark road stretched out before them, he heard Dinar sob.

On Sunday, Dinar returned, without her husband, searching for a glimmer of hope. She came again on Monday. And Tuesday.

She and Rohana never met at Harapan Beach like they said they would.

It's midnight. I'm lying in bed, unable to sleep, staring at the ceiling in the dark. The ring of a cell phone shatters the quiet. It's my sister.

"Hello?" I say.

"Maya." Mutiara sounds hoarse. "Papa is gone."

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WHISPERS

From the evil of the devil,
The lurking tempter,
Who whispers into the hearts of mankind.
(An-Nas: 4-5)

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PAPA'S BRIDE

25 July 2008

Just before Maghrib, Papa called me into the living room. He opened the glass display cabinet and slipped his hand between the old dolls and religious books. He pulled out a green wooden box containing a Qur'an and prayer beads. The Qur'an was large, bound in green velvet with embossed letters in gold on the front. I'd never seen it before. The Qur'an I usually see lying around the house, on a chair or the dining table, has a laminated reddish cover, and its pages are yellowing and starting to fall out.

Papa opened the green Qur'an and turned its pages, one by one, showing off its thick, glossy paper.

It's imported, he said. I bought it on installment. Twelve monthly payments.

I know Mama's still paying off the installments for our washing machine since the old one broke. Was Mama okay with Papa buying such an expensive Qur'an?

This is my favorite Qur'an, he said. It's for you. A wedding gift.

I shook my head. Maybe Mutiara could afford something like this without worrying about installments, but this was Papa's prized possession.

Papa wouldn't take no for an answer. He placed the Qur'an in my hands.

Come see us often, urged Papa, before raising the issue again, about me moving to Kotawijaya after the wedding. He sounded sad.

Who knows how long anyone will live, he said. Who knows, I might die soon.

Don't talk like that, Pa.

I'm not getting any younger.

Well, maybe God will call me home first.

Don’t be foolish, he retorted. A parent shouldn’t have to bury their child.

I weighed Papa’s Qur’an in my hands, then hugged it to my chest. Who knows how long anyone will live.

I wonder if Papa told Maya similar things when she left for America. Probably not. And I doubt whether he’s ever been worried about Mutiara leaving. After all, she’s always there, always the same, caring for the family.

Tears filled Papa’s eyes. No matter what, you’re Papa’s girl. Papa’s favorite.

True love belongs only to Allah, I wanted to say. But not a word escaped my lips.

The call to prayer sounded then, filling the air. So I continued to keep my silence. I thought about my sisters, especially Mutiara. All that money he had borrowed from her for my wedding; I had a hunch he would never pay it back. I kept quiet, knowing how much Papa loved me—so determined was he to pass his beloved Qur’an onto his little girl before she was whisked away—and how I didn’t feel the same. I kept quiet, imagining his sadness when I’m not by his side to see him off—and his shame when he realizes that he’s picked the wrong one.

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A Tale of Night Magic

Tonight, at Sulaiman's house, sitting with Maya in the dark, I feel the need to get up, to walk outside. I'm not sure why, but I go out to the terrace, and how magnificent the night is! How enchanting, with all the stars scattered through the sky, beckoning me. And, oh, that moon! A big round platter, brimming with magic, its bright light revealing a path. And a whisper: *Lo! Someone comes, like a weretiger, shifting, changing shape.* There, on Sulaiman's terrace, I sit down. I close my eyes. Beside me, a voice, greeting me.

Assalamualaikum, Rosalinda.

I hold my breath. I know that voice well. Slowly, I turn to my right.

Mami Cindy!

O, Moon! How clever you are at gladdening my heart! It's Mami Cindy, sitting there in her headscarf and housedress, a black cat rubbing against her legs. It's not one of hers. I've never seen it before. Leaping into Mami's lap, the cat closes its eyes in contentment as Mami caresses it with her hand.

Mami, how are you? I miss you so much. Then I sigh. But you're dead.

As dead as can be, she affirms.

But maybe being dead isn't all bad. Her skin looks amazing. Simply radiant. And the cat looks good too, her coat thick and lustrous.

What do you feed her? I ask. How do you both look so gorgeous?

But Mami ignores my question—maybe she didn't hear me—and asks instead:

Rosalinda, dear, aren't you tired of collecting on debts? Don't you want to lay down your sword?

How gentle her voice is. But I answer her. Firmly. This is my tale, after all.

For the pretty sister, there will be no mercy. She will *not* be redeemed—by anyone or anything. And her sisters must suffer too. Just as you and I

have.

Mami smiles.

But they have already suffered, she says. Can't you see that, Rosalinda?

I wish I could hold her hand, but she's all ablur, indistinct—here but not here, beyond touch, beyond reach.

Can't I be angry? I ask.

Of course! But then who will look after my strays? Who will beat the drum?

There comes a knock, and a rustling. I turn. No one's there. Just the sound of branches, knocking against each other in the wind.

Then she's gone. I can still feel her voice reverberating through the air, though there's no trace of bodily warmth on the seat she's left behind.

Ladies and gentlemen, the curtain has risen, the doors are open. Come in, come in! Let us gather. Let us sit on this carpet, newly aired in the sun—no mustiness or mildew here—and together we shall read the surah of Yasin. Let us pray: *O Allah, make smooth the path of the faithful, reserve for them the best place at Your side, grant Sulaiman's descendants strength.*

But on the third night, after we recite tahlil, the eldest sister goes to her parents' room—Mama's room, she calls it—a place for memories, a place to seek refuge from failure and loss.

The middle sister begins to worry. She knocks on the door. It doesn't open.

Sulaiman, I wonder: what do you have to say down there, buried deep beneath the earth, maggots gnawing your flesh?

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THE TRAVELER

Earth

The gravedigger is waiting for us, standing by the tomb, shovel in hand. His hair is white, and his faded collared shirt is drenched in sweat. As the funeral procession approaches, he looks at Mutiara and gives her a nod—a caretaker and gravedigger exchanging a secret message of sorts. They must have seen each other a few times since Mutiara arranged Mama's burial. Papa can't be placed next to Mama. The plots next to her have been taken, but at least they're not too far apart. My mother's grave is shady and cool, sheltered by a frangipani tree. My father, unfortunately, does not have the same luck. The sun beats down on us. It's skull-crushingly hot. Rosalinda takes out her sunglasses. I tug at my headscarf and lower my head.

We made it, Papa. We're all here at your grave. Your daughters (minus one), standing on loose earth, staring into the pit; lined up next to us are your loud-mouthed brothers and sisters; and here are your friends from the mosque—men waiting for their turn, devout in their worship because they know that day will come: that day when we leave our earthly husks (off they go to be recycled) and must believe, must stand firm, even though there is no guarantee that our journey will continue, no guarantee that on the other side is anything but a wall, a dead end. Believe; fear God; accumulate merit. For in death, the angels tally our deeds—so you would counsel us when we were little, giving us religious lessons laced with capitalist zest. I forget when I stopped believing—in you, in the views you held—though maybe I just wanted to be a rebel without a cause. But today, here I am, your other daughter, the one who's always on the run. I've come to see you home.

And look how popular you are, Papa! So many friends from the mosque! Who would have thought? They're helping out as much as they can, practically driving Mutiara up the wall—you know how scared she is of running out of work to do, because she can't bear facing up to herself—and when all is ready, the gravedigger asks which family member will descend into the pit and lead the prayer. I know Mutiara would volunteer if she could, but women don't enter the pit—so, with a heavy heart, she glances over at your brothers, Uncle Benny and Uncle Boy. After a few minutes of squabbling, trying to get the other one to do it, Benny and Boy go down together. Damn you, Papa. Maybe all three of us were girls, but you know, despite what an asshole you could be, in the end, we're weeping for you nonetheless. I gaze at your body in its shroud, bound at the head, neck, and feet, like a piece of white candy, wrapped neat and tight. Carefully, they lower you into the earth. You don't seem very heavy. I crane forward, wondering how it must feel to lie in that narrow hole, shedding all you have ever accomplished, every flame extinguished, all your work reduced to dust. What regrets do you have? If only I knew.

After finding out about my father's death, Rosalinda and I caught the first flight back to Jakarta. At eight, when we arrived at my parents' house, Mutiara was just about to lock up and head out to the mosque. She had already handled the paperwork and helped bathe Papa at the hospital. Then she'd arranged for him to be taken directly to the mosque. Our house was too small for the Janazah prayers—too many of my father's neighbors wanted to take part. Upon seeing Rosalinda and me emerging from the taxi, Mutiara asked whether we had headscarves to wear. Rosalinda nodded. I, of course, never carried one or thought ahead. Mutiara went back into the house and returned with two options, white or black. I chose black. Mutiara hurried toward the mosque, with Rosalinda and me trailing behind. My sister and I didn't even get the chance to hug.

Wak Norma, Uncle Benny, and Uncle Boy were already gathered in front of the mosque; Aunt Linda was still on her way. I kissed Wak Norma's hand, and she folded me into her arms. For a few seconds I put my loathing aside and we were united by a shared sense of loss; how long we had known him, in our own different ways. Once we'd finished our embrace, Wak Norma glanced sharply at Rosalinda behind me, hair

covered and in long sleeves. Uncle Benny called her by her childhood name, as if wanting to make sure it was really her.

"Rohadi. Rohadi, right?"

Rosalinda merely nodded. Nobody had the energy to create a scene.

I removed my shoes and stepped inside, passing several people seated on the carpet. My father's body was there, in its shroud, a batik cloth draped over him like a blanket, but his face had yet to be covered. How strange it was, to see my father wrapped in white cloth, the folds framing his face, like a jilbab. His skin was gray, his lips so thin, so violet, verging on black. His nostrils had been stuffed with cotton wool. Suddenly my chest felt tight. I kept an eye on all the people moving about, to make sure no one was taking any pictures. Because, shit, Papa you look like hell, truly hideous. I won't let anyone capture you like this and I won't let my mind record you this way, no longer young and sure, no longer asking who loves Papa. And suddenly, there on that carpet, I saw my own future: lying stiff and purple, cotton wool shoved into every orifice.

"Maya," Rosalinda touched my shoulder. "It's okay, Maya."

I couldn't breathe. Rosalinda helped me up and brought me to sit with the other women on the carpet. She got a bottle of water and offered it to me.

"Breathe."

I did, a deep inhale, but it caught in my lungs. I broke down sobbing.

"I know my father was a jerk."

"But?"

"But I've never been so close to a corpse."

It was true. I hadn't been around a dead body in ages. I cast my mind back, ten years, even twenty, trying to recall the last time. Being on the run, I'm absent from every death, moving from terminal to terminal like a fugitive. Meanwhile, life is catching up to me, in all its transience, its fragility. And I pretend not to know.

After the burial, my parents' house becomes a bazaar for three days and nights. Close relatives—and distant ones—neighbors, and former co-workers come and go, joining in readings of the Qur'an, or simply offering condolences. As with weddings, there's something about funerals that draws out people from the past, like a magnet. Ali, Mutiara's former crush

who turned out to be after Annisa, shows up with his wife and a two-year-old child. I remember how he looked in his twenties and thirties—thin, with a thick head of hair parted to one side. He's still skinny, but now he has a paunch and the hair at his temples is receding. While his wife chats with Mutiara, he approaches me.

"I heard you're getting a PhD. And you're still in America? Mashallah."

I nod.

"Is your husband there too?"

I smile, then glance at the child in his wife's arms.

"Don't you already have three?"

He clears his throat. I ask whether the child is indeed his fourth.

"Fourth. And first," he says, somewhat sheepishly. "From my second."

I remember he's a politician now, wealthy enough for two wives. Nonetheless, he brings up my sister.

"Annisa—"

He pauses.

"Such a pity," he says.

He mutters the words over and over, like he's regretting wasted food. It occurs to me that he's thinking "if only," and it gives me the creeps. If only he'd tried harder. If only Annisa had become his second wife. I quickly make my escape and go greet other guests.

Wak Norma, Uncle Benny, Uncle Boy, and Aunt Linda show up each day, from the burial to the tahlil service on the third night. On the first day, conversation centers around how my father's condition progressed, especially his last moments in the ICU. The day before he died, Mutiara saw his fingers move, and his head shift a little. She immediately alerted the nurse. The movement wasn't very significant, said the doctor, but perhaps it was a small sign that he was gradually recovering consciousness. But the next day, as Mutiara was getting ready for bed, the hospital called to deliver the bad news. My sister wasn't even there to see the line on the ECG monitor go flat.

Mutiara recounts every detail, retelling the story seamlessly to every guest before thanking them for coming and making sure to present them with a box of small cakes. Meanwhile, Rosalinda, Sri, and I, succumbing to social fatigue, take turns seeing to the food and bottles of water. Only Ali mentions Annisa. No one else dares, at least to our faces. But late in the

afternoon, after the burial, I see Wak Norma talking with Mutiara for a long time. I suspect she's digging for information. Their conversation is interrupted when a thoughtful neighbor appears at the gate, bearing food.

On the second day, as the conversation begins to branch out, no longer focusing on the deceased, my uncles and aunties begin probing for cracks. They remember how Papa would take Annisa everywhere, then shake their heads: poor Annisa, such a tragedy.

"How's her son?" asks Aunt Linda.

"Undergoing treatment. Rehabilitation," I say.

"Does he even have a future? Since he was brainwashed like that?"

By the third day, people are growing tired of acting mournful for such long periods of time. We're all sitting on the carpet reciting Yasin when we hear the sound of laughter. It's Uncle Benny and Uncle Boy. They're chatting on the terrace, getting louder and louder, erupting in guffaws every now and then. The neighbors exchange looks but try to ignore them, turning back to the recitation. Rosalinda puts down her booklet. I follow her outside.

Both my uncles are wearing Bermuda shorts, like little boys. One wears a polo shirt and the other, a black Harley Davidson tee. Benny sits on a chair with his feet up, while Boy leans against a pillar, smoking. Rosalinda asks them to keep their voices down. They both look surprised. Probably because they've never had anyone reprimand them for anything. Boy takes a drag on his cigarette.

"So have you already had the operation, Rohadi?"

I see the smoke from his cigarette rise and billow, before descending on Rosalinda's hair. Benny snickers and makes a chopping motion.

"My name is Rosalinda."

Her voice sounds calm. Benny and Boy laugh, then Benny hums a telenovela song. *Rosalinda. Rosalinda. Rosalinda ay amor.*

"How'd you turn out like this?" asks Uncle Boy. "It must be pretty small, huh?"

"Show some respect," says Rosalinda. "Your brother just passed away."

"What did you say?"

"I said to show some respect."

Boy takes a step forward. Then it begins, a ridiculous, unnecessary show. My father is dead, and now we have to deal with the ones who are

left. A family of clowns. It's not long before Boy starts jabbing a finger at Rosalinda, accusing her of being rude. Then Benny gets up from his chair and reminds her that she isn't part of the family. This isn't her affair. Rosalinda stands still as a statue, head held high, eyes fixed on some faraway point, beyond the buffoons jeering at her. I try to say something, but the words catch in my throat in my shock, and shame, and disgust. And that's when Mutiara appears. I've never heard her voice so piercing.

"Leave."

Benny and Boy stop talking. They stare at Mutiara, confused, as if wanting to make sure they've heard her right. It's probably inconceivable to them that the niece who has never acted up—a sad, sorry spinster, yes, but always steady—has the gall to rebuke them. Mutiara picks up the broom by the door and starts sweeping the terrace. She pushes bits of trash toward Uncle Benny's shoes, making him jump backwards.

"Leave, Uncle," she says. "I'm tired. Go on. Clear out, clear out."

My father's neighbors and friends from the mosque leave the house at half past nine in the evening. At last, the exhausting affair is over. Sri helps us clean the carpet and roll it back up. Then she says goodbye, taking some of the leftover food.

My father's relatives left early, before the tahlil and sermon were over. After the drama with Uncle Benny and Uncle Boy, Aunt Linda and Wak Norma felt too insulted to stay. Indignantly, they rose to their feet, and packed up, fuming, telling us how ungrateful we were, and before they left for their cars, one of them—I don't remember who; it makes no difference—took a parting shot, "Get your own lives in order. Your sister was a terrorist." After all this, who knows when we'll meet them again. Perhaps never.

My sister looked at us. "Rosalinda," she said.

Rosalinda turned around. The three of us were still standing on the terrace, looking out toward the street.

"I apologize."

"It's okay," said Rosalinda. "I'm used to it."

"For more than what happened just now."

Mutiara, still holding the broom, looked down. The terrace floor was all too clean.

“I apologize for Papa.”

My sister fell silent for a while before she went on. “And for Annisa.”

Mutiara didn’t make eye contact. Rosalinda nodded slowly, almost imperceptibly, and my sister went back inside. Mutiara never apologizes. For anything. Maybe she didn’t wait for Rosalinda to answer because she knew it wasn’t that simple, that not all forgiveness is so easily dispensed.

Now that the house is empty—still a mess, but much more peaceful—we collect the Yasin booklets and Qur’ans that were distributed to the guests. Wak Norma and a few other elderly relatives asked specifically for the Qur’an because the booklets were too small, too straining on the eyes. We got out a few copies from the display cabinet in the living room, where they were shelved among various souvenirs and old dolls. Mutiara is returning the copies to the cabinet when she calls us over. We find her standing there, frozen to the spot, staring at a Qur’an bound in green velvet, lying open in her hands.

“Did anyone use this one?” I ask.

Mutiara doesn’t answer. Her face turns paler, and she doesn’t respond when I call her name. Rosalinda and I exchange a worried glance. Eventually I see it, the note that’s been slipped between the pages of my father’s Qur’an. Mutiara hands it to me, shuts the book, and walks, as if in a daze, to Mama’s room. The door shuts firmly behind her.

I unfold the letter. The paper is thick, cream-colored with blue lines, not torn from just any old notebook. At the top I see my name and Mutiara’s, then rows of familiar handwriting—Annisa’s—with letters like those in the postcard she sent. I still recall the shape of every M and A, big and round. My fingers shake.

I read the letter from top to bottom, then start again, top to bottom, over and over, but I still don’t understand.

I should be satisfied (though maybe that’s not the right word)—surely, here’s the answer we’ve been looking for. But I still don’t understand. I desperately want to believe we’ve found our answer, so we can finally turn the page, and yet I can’t. This is a fragment of Annisa, nothing more. At that moment, I realize that we’ll never find anything to hold on to. Annisa has blown herself up. She’s scattered herself all over, and there’s nothing we can do but crawl around amidst her remains.

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THE BRIDE'S GAME

Dearest sisters,

Do you remember Nana's treasure hunt when we were little? We searched and searched but found nothing. Consider this another hunt, except I don't need to tell you how to play. By the time you find this letter, you'll already have reached the end.

I play out in my mind how you both have arrived here. If you're holding this Qur'an, there are only two possibilities: either a miracle, because Papa has recovered, or a tahlil, because someone has died. This is Papa's favorite Qur'an. I've returned it to the cabinet.

I am writing to ask for everyone's forgiveness. I apologize to Papa because I didn't deserve to be his favorite. We all know who Papa's most devoted daughter is, and may Allah grant him clear vision. I'm sorry, Muti, Maya. Even now you probably still feel confused, angry, disappointed—if only we had talked more.

If only you could read—truly read.

What a fallen world we live in. Exhausting, isn't it? You may not understand because you both depend upon it so much. Muti, have you ever considered the source of all your wealth, the money you use to take care of the family, the money that makes Papa soft, and meek, because you hold the power now? And, Maya, aren't you weary of wandering, seeking affirmation from foreigners?

If you search long enough for answers, you'll see that all is an illusion, a treasure hunt. That we seek but do not find. That's why I hold fast only to The One. But I don't believe those charlatan imams. They say that women earn Allah's approval by being devout wives, so we should just follow our husbands. They say our husbands are the ones to seek heaven, and we will be taken along. They say women who wish to die as martyrs only do so out of disgrace, regret, or suffering, because they've either been wronged or raped.

The men in our group speak of traveling abroad, supporting the jihad of our brothers and sisters in the Middle East, as if our struggle can only be valid when we orient ourselves toward the Arab world. It makes me feel like a fraud, as if my faith will never be complete, just because I'm just a girl with small eyes and straight hair who'll never be Arab.

I've spent my entire life being someone else. Obedient daughter, devout wife, handed from father to husband. And then, once I became a mother, raising children, caring for life, yet I apparently still needed to be guided, to be led. I don't trust those imams, so I'm taking matters into my own hands. This was all my decision, my calculations, my plan. Little by little I persuaded our group to turn, and I told them: we determine our own fate. Our struggle is here.

My husband follows the path I choose because he loves me too much, and perhaps this is his final chance to prove himself a leader. I work in the background. It's all a game, a performance: the virtuous wife, the good neighbor.

We worry about the children. I care with every fiber of my being for these little lives, and I don't trust anyone else with them. No one can navigate this treacherous life without a mother.

So we are taking them with us.

Farewell, my sisters. One day the three of us will be together again. This is my hope, even though I can't say for certain.

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THE TRAVELER

Light the Candle

On the terrace, Rosalinda and I sit sprawled in chairs, exhausted. There's an unspoken presence in this house, pooling, congealing. Perhaps that's what has drawn us to sit here together; maybe it's not even our choice. A furtive, creeping night, an awkward, fragmented night, and yet how splendidly the sky is arrayed. I don't think I've ever seen so many stars before, at least not at my parents' house.

Rosalinda says it must be Laylat al-Qadr, the Night of Power. I don't put stock in such things, but from what I can remember of my religious lessons as a child, no one can predict when Laylat al-Qadr will come. Only Allah knows, says Rosalinda, but people are always on the lookout for clues: on the Night of Power, all will be calm, the air fresh, not too hot or too cold, and Jibril and the other angels will descend, scattering blessings throughout the earth.

"I don't feel like I'm being blessed," I observe.

"Angels aren't all about you," Rosalinda quips.

I look out at the neighboring houses. It's eleven, and the streets are quiet though there are still a few terrace lights on. I wonder if the neighbors also think tonight is Laylat al-Qadr and are engaging in more prayer in their homes. Shouldn't they come out? What an enchanting, starry night! And here the two of us sit, in awe, savoring every second. Somehow we know something's headed this way, long, black, and slithering. It's rolling toward us, picking up speed until it will disgorge itself, submerging us all.

And we wait.

"I never imagined we'd arrive at this point."

"Do you think this is the end?" asks Rosalinda.

"No. This is the middle. Or the beginning. Who knows."

I think we both want it to be the end. After braving all of this, we had hoped we would emerge unscathed. We retraced our steps, went back to the beginning. We thought untangling the past would make the path ahead clearer. But tonight, I realize something. We will never escape.

"I'm worried about Mutiara," says Rosalinda suddenly.

"Why?"

After reading the letter, Mutiara went straight to our parents' room and she still hasn't come out. Neither of us want to disturb her. Maybe she needs time alone. Maybe she's already asleep.

"Mutiara is the strongest of us all," I say.

"You seem so certain, Maya. Tell me, have you ever clung to anything else with such determination?"

That sensation. Of something slipping from my grasp, of it rolling away. But I say nothing. We return to staring at the sky in all its mystery. In silence, we wait.

At two in the morning, I'm woken up by a knock I've been asleep for less than two hours. Rosalinda's standing there when I open the door.

"Mutiara is gone."

"What do you mean?"

"Her car isn't here."

I stumble into the living room and sit squinting on the sofa for a moment, my eyes adjusting to the bright lights. Rosalinda leads the way past the kitchen to the garage. No sign of Mutiara's car. I get a glass of water and check my phone. No messages from my sister.

I knock on my parents' bedroom door, where Mutiara has been sleeping for the last three nights. No response. I turn the handle. The clutter disorients me at first. The sheets on my parents' bed are rumpled, a sign it's been slept in. Flush against it sits my mother's nursing bed, and memories surface—not of Mama in the bed, which I don't remember much of, but of many years before her illness, when she would go into her room, eyes puffy and swollen, then come out later and resume cooking in the kitchen. My teenage self regarded it as a sort of magic act, like pulling a rabbit out of a hat: Mama going in and reemerging as someone else.

Hastily, I close the door and turn to Rosalinda, who has just finished checking the rest of the house. Mutiara really has left without telling us.

"Maybe she just went out for a while," I say.

"At 2:00 A.M.?"

Suddenly everything goes dark.

A power outage. Rosalinda sighs. What a joke. A blackout at a time like this. I turn on my phone flashlight and go outside. The streets and neighboring houses are all pitch black.

"Shit, everything's out. How long will it last?"

"Maybe a couple of hours," says Rosalinda. "It's normal. This is the third world, remember? Don't tell me you've forgotten."

"My phone's going to die."

"Are there candles?"

We check the kitchen cupboard. Even after so many years away, I remember my father kept candles there. Sometimes he'd light them during lunch to keep away flies. But then he was taken to the hospital. There's a whole pack of candles, unused, still wrapped in plastic. Rosalinda takes one out.

"Let's pray."

"Pray? Why?"

"Because I'm lighting a candle, darling," she says.

A moment of silence. Illuminated by the flashlight on my phone, in my parents' kitchen, Rosalinda closes her eyes. I have no choice but to follow. I recite Surah Al-Fatihah, for my dead father, the only way I knew how to pray.

"Who are you praying for?" I ask Rosalinda.

"Those who are lost."

I hear the flick of a lighter. A candle's yellow flame brightens the kitchen.

We return to the living room and sit at my father's marble dining table. Between us stands a single white candle, wax dripping onto a small saucer, wick ablaze. Suddenly Rosalinda laughs.

"Just look at us," she says. "It's like the legend of the Boar Man."

Rosalinda shares the story her mother used to tell her, of a poor man who would break into rich people's houses and steal from them by

turning into a boar. While he was in action, his wife would guard a candle at home. If he was in danger, the candle would flicker, and the wife would have to blow it out so her husband could return safely.

"What if she fell asleep?"

"The husband would die horribly."

"Oh. Sad."

"That's life for you. Some turn into weretigers, others turn into boars."

Rosalinda continues telling stories as I struggle to stay awake, waiting for Mutiara, just like we waited for Annisa at this same table, all those years ago. Rosalinda has never been present whenever I've pictured us sitting here, only Papa, Mama, Annisa, Nana. They're all gone now and here I am, waiting. How lonely it is, but now there are two at the table, Rosalinda and I.

When I open my eyes, the room is dark again. I fell asleep. The candle is out. I call Rosalinda's name. No answer. She must have fallen asleep too. I reach for the phone in my lap, but it's no use. The battery's dead. I fumble around the table for the lighter. A chill runs through my fingers. I call out for Rosalinda again. But still no reply. I feel a cold gust of wind on the nape of my neck.

At last, I find the lighter. When the candle is lit, I see Rosalinda is no longer at the table. Candle in hand, I scan the room. Nothing. Just the old dolls in the cabinet. Everything is in its place. All is quiet and still. I don't know how long I sit here, waiting. The candle grows dim, as if about to go out. And suddenly, I'm her, the keeper of the candle. Someone's in danger.

From somewhere beside me come the tinkling notes of a music box. A ballerina's song. Then the laughter of children. Rosalinda must be back, for I seem to hear her whispering, *Don't look.* Holding the candle, I turn slowly to my right. With me sits not Rosalinda but another woman, pressed close to my side, draped in white—a wedding gown, a headscarf, a veil.

"Wake up, Maya."

I shake my head, my breath loud and ragged in my ears.

"Maya!"

Rosalinda takes me by the shoulders. My eyes flutter open. The power's back and the lights are back on. Rosalinda stands in front of me and points to the clock on the wall. It's half past three.

"Were you dreaming?"

Wordlessly, I jump up and give her an enormous hug. I'm so relieved she's here, alive, heart beating. Her breath is warm on my ear.

At four in the morning, we begin to panic and make a list of who to contact: the neighbors, my father's family, the police. I suggest we start with the neighbors, followed by the police. Rosalinda nods. Much better to save the aunts and uncles for last. As the time for the dawn prayer approaches, we head to the mosque. Mutiara isn't there. Neighbors promise to help look.

"Should we call the police?" asks Rosalinda.

I nod weakly. Everyone else is gone. Mutiara is all I have left. I should have taken care, I should have kept watch, but instead I dozed off.

You fuck-up, I think. *You can't even look after a candle.*

If something happens to Mutiara, I'll never forgive myself.

At half past five, we hear a motorbike stop in front of the house. Rosalinda and I run outside. There, I see Mutiara in a long white nightdress, coming unsteadily through the small gate and grasping at the wall for support. Behind her is the gravedigger who helped bury my father. He tells us in a faltering voice what happened, how he came upon my sister. My heart beats louder and louder in my ears. I look to the east, to the sun, rising but without any rays. I approach Mutiara, standing stiffly by the gate. Her eyes are fixed on me, but whether she actually sees me, I'm not so sure. She's peering through me, into the distant past. Or the future. I don't know. But she's not here with us.

Only after some time do I realize that my sister isn't wearing a headscarf or shoes. Her feet are covered in dark earth. And then it dawns on me—how long it's been since I've seen her without a hijab. My sister's black hair is shot through with silver. It cascades down her shoulders in wild waves, like snakes.

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THE CARETAKER

Night of A Thousand Hells

Maya liked to say I was lost. And that was why I turned to religion. She was wrong. Allah showed me the straight path after I was done keeping my mother company beside her blue bed, after she succumbed and left, and gradually we all began to sway. Allah gave me peace and oblivion so I could serve as caretaker. Every sharp pin I slipped into my headscarf secured what had shaken loose and run wild.

But that night, as I held Annisa's letter with trembling hands, everything keeping me together collapsed. An avalanche. Something whispered in my ear. *Run.* So I drove through the streets, leaving home far behind. I played a recording of Ayat al-Kursi over and over, my head bobbing to the rhythm, *Allahu la ilaha illa huwal hayyul qayyum, Allahu la ilaha illa huwal hayyul qayyum.* I felt I was dancing in the darkness, purifying myself, purging myself of the evil that chased me, of the demon that lurked in the well. I got out of the car and ran toward the grave without looking back, dissolving into the moist soil, the prickly grass. I was disturbing your rest, Mama, but I could no longer be strong. Kneeling where you lay, I gazed up at the sky. Beyond the frangipani, the full moon shone, its beams glittering on the nighttime dew. We've both been here, Mama, on a night of a thousand hells.

The blue bed had been moved back into Mama's room. I spent the vacation period between Christmas and New Year's with my mother, that bed, and Ayat al-Kursi. It was in the afternoon, when my father was away at the mosque, that I heard the whisper for the first time. I had just turned off the recording of Ayat al-Kursi because I thought my mother was

asleep. But I felt her hand brush against my fingers—her skin was so dry—and she spoke.

Muti, can you help me?

Please. I'm so tired.

She asked me to come closer. Then she whispered in my ear. I drew back, my lips uttering istighfar. Mama groaned in pain, then spoke again, softly, almost a hiss, begging, and begging. My feet turned cold, my palms were clammy. I shook my head, harder and harder still. Meanwhile, my mother pleaded, tears streaming down her cheeks onto the blue bed. I left the room to settle myself, but I couldn't leave her for too long. There was no nurse on duty and Papa was out. I'd never felt so relieved as when I saw Papa getting off his bicycle and coming into the house.

The next day, when Papa went to the mosque, she did it again. This time she burst into tears, like a small child. She said the pain was unbearable. Day after day she kept crying, begging, and she no longer wanted to listen to Ayat al-Kursi. The room was so still. Except for the sound of my mother on the blue bed, moaning, maddening. *Help me, Muti.* I tried ear plugs, but I could still see her weeping, eyes shut, head raised. *You have no choice but to look after Mama. You don't love Mama.* I held her in my arms—my effort to staunch the darkness streaming from within her.

I do love Mama.

I love Mama more than anything.

Then, after days of holding out, I succumbed. My father had left before the call to Maghrib prayer ended. As I heard the muezzin—*la ilaha illallah*—I placed the pillow over my mother's face, pressing down with all my strength. Tears welled in my eyes as I watched her struggle, her bony hands gripping the sheets. Just a little longer, Mama. Just a little longer, and you will be free.

Say the name of Allah, Muti.

Faintly, I heard the voice of the imam leading prayer through the mosque's loudspeaker. Suddenly I recalled it—the question that had never been answered: How did I know that the woman in the headscarf who had returned from Sukabumi was truly my mother? Where those whispered pleas for death were coming from, I didn't know, but that wasn't Mama's voice. The devil had emerged from the well to whisper in my ear, to manipulate me. I flung the pillow to the floor. My mother coughed in

spasms, I gave her some water, and she closed her eyes without a word. I left the room then, fleeing, seeking refuge from the accursed demon whispering in my ear.

When my father returned, I said goodbye and left the house. I couldn't take it anymore, I said, before loading my suitcase and cats into the car. Mama died the following day. I don't know when because, that final time, before I ran out of the bedroom, abandoning her on the blue bed, my mother's eyes had flown open. Smiling broadly, she hissed:

Run, Muti. Run.

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THE CURTAIN FALLS

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NO SHAHRAZAD'S TALE

Shahrazad told tales to cheat death. Rosalinda tells tales out of rage. Maybe I'm a djinn, made of fire, for embers breathe spirit into the stories I collect at every turn: on the streets, across the sea, at Victoria's House, where I was born, at the House of the Three Sisters, where I chose to go. I record it all and tally everything up. I remember how they spat on me, unzipping their flies, forcing me to kneel; how they punched me in the face and dunked my head in water; I remember the hot asphalt against my cheeks and the salty blood on my tongue before everything went black; I remember my tears soaking a mattress in a dark and cramped room; I remember Mami Cindy and how she died.

It's not over just yet, but that morning, when Mutiara appeared at the gate, escorted by the gravedigger, I thought about endings. Perhaps here we can release our grudges and finally let go. The sins have yet to fade, but my rage recedes, slowly. I came here, weapon in hand, but all I found was rubble, like at the church that morning, Mother Mary gazing upon the ruins. There was nothing left to collect on, nothing standing that could be destroyed.

The road to forgiveness is a long one. Who knows when we'll arrive. One year, maybe twenty? But here, at Victoria's grave, I stop to hug my childhood friends, Mutiara and Maya. I may have once been the ugly stepsister, but I've shifted shape now. Just like Nana. And I'm moving on. One day we shall meet at these crossroads again.

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THE TRAVELER

Victoria's House

Before Rosalinda returns to Sydney, we visit Victoria's House in Tanjung Karang, where everything began. At first, I thought Mutiara would refuse to come. Back when she learned that the house had been demolished, she no longer wanted to know or see or hear about the place, much less set foot in Tanjung Karang. But now that Papa's dead, she's changed her mind. Something's different now: we're braver. Because we're together. The three of us.

Rosalinda's behind the wheel, and Mutiara sits beside her. It occurs to me we'll lose our way, fall under a spell, like those drivers who felt as if they'd never reach their destination. And maybe, secretly, I hope for this, because I don't know how I feel about seeing Nana's house razed to the ground. But the spell has been broken. No well, no kitchen, no ghosts—no obstacles at all on the way to Victoria's House. We've arrived. I hear Rosalinda's warning—*don't look*—which I of course disobey.

The scene before us is more depressing than any empty lot: Victoria's House, transformed into a two-story shophouse, sloppily designed, with unimaginative rectangular lines. The whole structure is a nauseating, goofy green, with the windows framed in brown. The pillars already show signs of mildew. The stairs in front are overlain with tacky white tiles. It was obviously done in a hurry so the owner could start pulling in rent. No one had even planted any trees to make atonement for this monstrosity.

"Should we get out?" asks Rosalinda.

She pulls over but keeps the engine running. I can't see my sister's face clearly from the backseat, but her head remains perfectly still.

"Keep going." Her tone is brisk.

Rosalinda shifts gears and we drive off. None of us bothers to look back. Victoria's House stands no more, and even the image of it has been forced from our minds by the butt-ugly creation of some guy with plenty of money and zero taste. We didn't even get to gaze upon the ruins of our childhood. There's nothing left.

And it's no homecoming for Rosalinda either. Mak Romlah has moved on. After spending forty years—half her life—serving Nana and assuming she'd die at Tanjung Karang, she ended up returning to Brebes and opening a warung. She was an outsider all over again. Her hometown had changed while she was gone. "Mamak has a new husband," Rosalinda told us. A new chapter, at sixty-three. Perhaps we're all travelers in the end.

We drive down street after street. Rosalinda points out the mosque, the market where she would tag along with Mamak to do the shopping, the cinema she rarely went to because she had no money. The car slows down when we pass her school, dilapidated, on the verge of collapse—because any old school would do, really. It wasn't as if the kid had anything else ahead of him. I wish Nana would whisper in my ear. I would seize my chance, demand an explanation. *Why?* But my question echoes and returns: *why are you only asking now?*

It's nearly dusk by the time we reach Nana's grave. Under the shade of a banyan tree, we sprinkle the ground with rosewater and recite Surah Al-Fatihah. The gravestone reads *Hajjah Victoria, daughter of Haji Tjek Sun*, the same name that once adorned the wooden plaque on her front door. This is Victoria's House now.

The three of us kneel. Mutiara takes out the surah of Yasin and begins to recite. Meanwhile I whisper:

"Nana, your three granddaughters have come."

Forgive my failures. But I'll look after what's left. The three of us will care for each other. Mutiara, Maya, Rosalinda.

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The Tale of the Plague

Two years later, all of us found ourselves in the same story, the tale of the plague. You remember, don't you, ladies and gents? Walking deserted streets, going into a supermarket, doing a little dance—sidestep, then backwards, no jostling now! Grabbing whatever you could (yep, they're still out of toilet paper). Hurrying home, again through empty streets, and shutting the door. Mission accomplished. But of course, not everyone had a home, and behind closed doors, no two tales unfolded in the same way. Some endured, some were in danger. Some were hungry, some were bored.

In those days I was grateful for my job as a cashier at Woolworths. But my savings were running low. No more shows. Cafés and theaters weren't allowed to open. I heard my friends in Yogyakarta had lost their sources of income. They weren't allowed to busk, and all the beauty salons were shut. I sent money to people collecting donations, but I felt secure and it troubled me—the security of being able to work, buy essentials, sleep, close the door—I still had a door to close. I'd been out on the streets before, but through the plague, my life continued—what a stroke of luck—while others like me fell, one by one. News of death flooded social media. The gravediggers couldn't keep up.

Then I received a message from Fatimah, Mami Cindy's daughter, asking for prayers, as well as donations to help with Mami Jenny's funeral. I didn't know Mami Jenny well, but I knew she would often stop by Mami Cindy's house. Fatimah had given her one of the cats so she wouldn't be too lonely.

I called Fatimah. How did she die? Was it Covid?

No, not Covid. Malnutrition.

Malnutrition.

Ladies and gentlemen, such is our tale: death in the time of Covid—not from the virus but from having nothing to eat.

After much anxious thought, I decided to go back to Indonesia. I knew returning to Australia would take a while, as the government had restricted the number of flights.

You might not be able to come back, said an Indonesian friend who also worked the checkout at Woolworths.

I know, I told him. But I have to take care of things at home.

Where was home? Who knew. It certainly wasn't the green shophouse in Tanjung Karang. Maybe I would go to Brebes to make sure Mamak was okay. Or maybe I would go see Maya and Mutiara. Maybe I'd head to Yogyakarta. How my home has shifted and spread out through the years. My home is Mami Cindy, Mami Jenny, Natasha, Susmita—the solidarity of sisters, mothers, aunts. My home is Mami Cindy's strays. My home is those who are forgotten, those who must endure suffering, those who cling to each other to carry on.

In mid-2020, I turned in the keys to my apartment. On the train to the airport, I gazed at my reflection in the window—the kebaya I was wearing, the floral-pattern mask. I studied my big red suitcase, its bright metallic sheen undimmed in the glass, my whole life crammed inside.

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THE TRAVELER DOES NOT DEPART

I didn't end up returning to New York. When I decided to postpone going back that wretched year, I never imagined I'd be stuck through the next, and even the one after that. I did something I'd never dreamed of doing my entire life: I became a caretaker.

To be clear, I did start looking for plane tickets a month after Papa's funeral. I had no pressing need to be there, but I didn't want to stay alone in my parents' house for long. There was something suffocating about waking up every morning in the room from my teenage years, about walking out the door only to see that old marble table and smell the dust settling in the corners of my parents' room. My mother's blue bed was still there, as were memories of Mutiara bustling around, caring first for one parent, then the other, both now no more. Fragments of past events would come to me unbidden as I sat in bed, brushed my teeth, ate breakfast. Images from the TV news coverage of the explosion would flash randomly through my mind—Annisa as a child, an on-screen Annisa, an Annisa who might as well have been a total stranger, even though all her old stuff, familiar, intimate, was still being stored in this very house.

The call from Sri came while I was sitting at the dining table in front of my laptop, just about to buy a ticket. Her screeches were ear-piercing. Mutiara had been hit by a car. My heart stopped; I imagined blood splattered all over the street—after the bombings, I really was capable of imagining the worst—and in my panic, I began screeching along. I implored Sri to calm down even though I myself had lost all composure. Finally, with some coherence, Sri told me that a neighbor had been driving home from work when Mutiara dashed in front of him. Startled, he had slammed on the brakes and jumped out of the car to find Mutiara unconscious. She had knocked her forehead against the asphalt. The wound itself didn't look too serious, and she regained consciousness

shortly after, but the neighbor felt guilty and terrified. He brought Mutiara to the house and urged Sri to take her to the hospital.

I shut my laptop and immediately ordered a taxi. I would meet Sri and my sister there. Mutiara had never passed out in her life, and she certainly would never carelessly run across the road. Everything in her life was calculated and planned, except—of course, how could I forget—the night when she vanished. I recalled the state in which she had reappeared that morning, and how she had run straight into my parents' room. She had slept for hours. Then, emerging neatly dressed and in a jilbab, she'd gotten into her car and driven off without a word.

I'd never brought up what had happened. Maybe I was too much of a coward. Maybe I was afraid to rouse whatever it was inside her, hidden yet not asleep.

For the few days my sister was in the hospital, I stayed close by. We came home with a box full of meds. Physically speaking, she was fine, just some bruises and scratches, but according to the doctors and psychiatrists, she was showing signs of severe depression. And so, I stayed. I lived at Mutiara's, took care of her cats, and accompanied her on her regular visits to the psychiatrist. Bit by bit, session by session, the events from the past were brought to light. At first, my sister hid within a fortress, behind its thick walls. But then, at long last, the doors began to open—doors that, for so many years, had been sealed shut. And how many secret doors there were! Each time one opened, a ghost appeared. My sister's ghost. My mother's ghost too.

I played at being nurse even though I knew I wasn't suited to it. I lacked strength and stamina, my movements were awkward, and everything slipped from my grasp. I couldn't think about anything other than my sister's recovery. I couldn't write. I didn't know how to face up to my own doors and ghosts.

It felt as if I were balancing a teetering stack of glasses. Amidst all the acrobatics and dread of seeing them slip through my clumsy fingers, I gave up. I had to let something break. I ended things with Nadir. He said I was being unfair, but, in my despair, I also felt the relationship was unfair to me. I had seen what happened to Mutiara and needed to take care of myself.

"We're all in this together," he said.

"*We*?" I asked. "Me, you, and all your baggage?"

We talked for hours, going through the five stages of breakup grief: plea bargains, temper tantrums, weepy outbursts, mutual recriminations and, finally, exhausted silence.

"I want to wait," said Nadir. "After all this is done, I'll be waiting for you."

"Don't waste your time. We have no future."

"I don't believe that."

"I can't see anything at the other end."

"Can't we take a chance?"

By 2019, I thought my sister had pretty much recovered. I started thinking about leaving Jakarta, but the previous year suddenly repeated itself: my sister collapsed and was rushed to the hospital. She had been in the office when news broke of the Christchurch massacre on TV. Fifty-one Muslims were killed. I took a leave of absence from my PhD and extended my time in Jakarta by a year. Then in March 2020, as I was preparing to return to New York, borders closed.

In those years I often woke up in a panic, soaked in sweat. My life was passing by, and I hadn't accomplished anything. Then I'd remind myself: after running away for so long, I shouldn't feel regret. I was simply repaying what I'd stolen from my family. Yet at the same time, especially while we were being held captive by the pandemic, my thoughts kept returning to the story of the taxi driver in Tanjung Karang. How dark and endless this road seemed. I was in a car, unable to escape, driving round in circles, going mad. Every now and then I would hear the whispers of my grandmother, the weretiger: *you'll get there soon. Don't look back.* But of course, I did. Don't we all turn around, fools that we are, and make mistakes, like Orpheus? Whenever I glanced in the rearview mirror, checking on the passengers in the back seat, remorse was of no use: everything slipped through my fingers, again and again. The bride in white was too heavy a burden.

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THE CARETAKER WRITES

Jakarta, 17 May 2020

My sister Annisa,

When I found your letter, tucked into Papa's favorite Qur'an, I asked myself, "What is this, anyway?" And I was angry. Angry because I wasn't sure it answered any of my questions. Angry because of its arrogance: a letter that wanted no reply, a closing statement, a manifesto. I couldn't accept it.

I tried to piece together the past in hopes of finding you, to learn where we lost you, and in each story I found a different you. Maybe this is how I should have seen that letter, as just one of many fragments, one of Annisa's many faces. You have no power to determine how all this will end. And I reject your statement.

But I'm not as strong as I thought. Sometimes, when I read your diary—the naive scribblings and dreams of your youth—I miss you, and I catch a glimpse of my own face. Annisa's our sister, says Rosalinda. But I have a more terrifying thought: Annisa is us.

Only now, two years after what happened, am I able to write to you.

I must admit, your letter felt like another bomb. That night, all I wanted to do was run. I should have foreseen what was happening to me when Papa was still in the hospital and I realized that something had come loose. I should have prepared myself, one way or another, so I could stay strong. But too late. The nails flew out and I fell to pieces.

At Mama's grave, I wept and raged. I had always wanted her to find me, to see me. *Look, Mama! Didn't I grow up to be your child?* But instead, it was I who found her, in that room.

A month later, Sri took me to the hospital, and Maya stayed by my side day after day. I hate looking weak in front of anyone, let alone Maya. But after seeing so many people's lives shattered by you; no shame can be

more abiding, more penetrating, more enduring than that. I carry that shame every day. The bitter lash of it draws blood.

I was still too weak to reply to your letter, but being with Maya gave me a measure of strength. Over time, she saw how I changed, and I witnessed the change in her too. I rarely saw her open her laptop. I'd been under the impression she had a boyfriend, but she never spoke to anyone on the phone. She cooked and cleaned. She looked after my cats. At Maya's encouragement, I took my psychiatrist's advice and started writing letters. I was hesitant at first. I'm not Maya. I'm not trained in expressing my thoughts, not in writing, nor in any other way. But Maya said I could write whatever I wanted and never had to show my letters to anyone.

So, I wrote. I wasn't sure why I was writing—to get through every day? To put off dying? But I wanted to start by asking forgiveness.

I wrote to the victims' families. For several weeks, the paper remained blank. Then I wrote two sentences. *Forgive me. I'm so ashamed.* You have no idea how painful it was, after all that, to only be able to write like a child. Since I didn't know what else to say, I wrote them fifty times, those childish lines, like a primary school kid being punished. For months, I had no other words. Then, after reading more about the victims' families, I began adding details. I wrote, *I too have experienced loss*, before crossing it out. It felt wrong to compare my feelings with theirs.

Every day I added sentences. Every day I crossed out what I had written.

A year passed. The house seemed different. I sat at my desk, writing page after page, sometimes to the same person, with the same words. Outside my room, Maya swept, and my black cat padded after her.

In the second year, my letters grew longer, and for the first time I asked Maya to look at them. In the end we wrote a letter together. The first letter we sent was to Fatimah, Mami Cindy's daughter. Then we sent a letter to the family of another victim. The reply from the second letter came more quickly than I expected. They couldn't forgive us. I couldn't sleep for days, fixated on one line, painful but deserved: *how could you not know?*

Fatimah's reply came a month later. She said that she had used the money that Rosalinda and I sent to pay for her schooling. I was happy to hear that she'd been selected as best performer in a youth theater competition. Perhaps she'll carry on Rosalinda's legacy.

Now we're in a pandemic. The whole world has closed its borders, we've shut ourselves in, and Maya can't leave. It's as if she's being punished for all her years of wandering. The news is nerve-wracking. Graveyards are full. So many have died. The outbreak is at its peak, and all we can do is stay put, perhaps waiting our turn. Amidst all the news of death and sorrow, I hear that Rosalinda has returned to Yogyakarta. She's opened a soup kitchen and is helping the transgender community raise funds. I envy her. I envy her managing things, offering care and strength. At the same time, I secretly wish I could live like this forever. I've buried myself, vanished from the world, and no longer need to deal with anything, not even the mess you've made.

But in these uncertain times, there's one thing I know: I'm still angry. Therefore, I'm still alive. And maybe, ever so slowly, bit by bit, I still have hope. And so, early one morning I'll stop by our house and slip this letter into Papa's favorite Qur'an—the most obvious place for it, on top of your own letter. If I die in this plague, I want someone—Maya? Rosalinda?—to find our letters and know: there is never just one story.

Little sister, I may not be able to forgive you, but I allow you to be present. You'll always be coming and going and opening doors. And when you do, the sins I keep locked up will tumble out into the light. I walk a path my mother didn't choose. I live on, my headscarf covering my rotting stench.

Maybe someday I will learn to forgive myself.

Mutiara

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NANA AND THE THREE SISTERS

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THE TRAVELER

7 June 2022

I get on at Bundaran HI station. It's not too crowded on the MRT today. After taking a seat and adjusting my mask, I place my backpack in my lap and get out my little black notebook. Today's a weekday, and it's been half a year since Mutiara left and I started work. I write my dissertation in cafés and libraries, although I spend most of the time working at Mutiara's, with her cats. My scholarship ran out, and I depend on freelance jobs as a writer and translator. I don't go out too much. Ten trips from home, and my monthly budget for coffee and transport is shot. I don't know how people here get by.

I've also returned to my novel about Dinar and Rohana. I don't expect to finish it anytime soon, much less publish it. But I'm breathing life into Victoria again. So here I am: whenever I get writer's block, I take the train, anywhere at all, for the sake of imagining something in motion and to get my brain moving too. The mask gives me the freedom of anonymity, sheltering me from stares as I observe people's movements. In my notebook I jot down all kinds of things—meetings on the train, conversations in cafés. And I started thinking about the ending for Dinar and Rohana's story. I want Dinar to be happy, but how, given she and Rohana never met at Harapan Beach?

Leaning back, I glance over the faces of the other passengers on the blue seats across from me, a row of women in headscarves and masks, workers or university students perhaps, busy on their phones. I turn my attention to my notebook. My grandmother still whispers the same thing: *You, on a boat, with books.* Ah, Nana. How are you? Suddenly I'm forty-two and not on a boat. And if the devil came into my room promising me youth, I'd sell my soul for sure. Well, let's just admit it: I'm stuck. But I refuse to say it's because of Mutiara. It's not her fault, and the idea of

casting it as a sacrifice on my part makes me shudder. If I ever get self--righteous, slap me.

Then, just when I think I'm alone with my thoughts, and the grandmother in my head, I hear a voice so familiar my heart nearly falls out of my chest.

"How are you, Maya?"

I look up and see a flicker of movement in one of the faces. Nadir stands before me, holding on to a pole. He pulls his mask down to smile and say hello before raising it again. The look in his eyes is still the same, but his hair is almost completely gray (how long has this pandemic lasted, anyway? Do people who enter it suddenly age?) I don't drop my mask, less because of the virus than my jumbled thoughts. I don't know how to calm the pounding in my chest and all the feelings spilling over within—nervousness, delight, fear. Before long, dismay steals in. Why is he even here? Didn't I leave him behind at the Rat Hotel?

Stay there, Nadir. Don't say anything. You're a memory. Don't start wandering about.

Yet here he is, on a moving train, asking if he can sit beside me. For a while we don't speak and stare awkwardly ahead at the other passengers. I steal a glance at his hands, the color of cinnamon, with their long spindly fingers. I remember his touch on my arm, my neck.

He breaks the silence. "I thought you went home to America."

Going home. There was a time when we would talk a lot about how confusing the phrase was: where was home? Was it here or over there? The confusion was thrilling. I'd think of my shoes, the shoes of a third world woman, clicking against the pavement, conquering places that weren't mine. And now? I felt like a loser. I wasn't going anywhere anymore.

"I've been here the whole time. At Mutiara's house."

Through the window I see the stations come and go, in constant motion, changing rapidly, mechanically. Nadir doesn't ask why I never responded to his emails or texts. He knows I don't have to explain myself. He asks about Mutiara and Rosalinda. I give the minimum response: Mutiara went away, and I'm looking after her cats.

I don't tell him that meanwhile, the wooden beams in my parents' ceiling have begun to warp due to termite damage. Or that I'm in a similar

situation, though what's doing the consuming, I'm still not sure.

Instead, I add that Rosalinda has become the organizer for a transgender community in Yogyakarta. I don't tell him she intends to adopt a child, or that it sent me into a panic when she mentioned Gibran's name. I don't recall my exact reaction at the time. I probably babbled some nonsense because I didn't know what to say. But I remember something Rosalinda said:

I don't want to be consumed by revenge.

Four years have passed. The storm is abating, and we must move on. But in all honesty, I have no idea how to wrap things up without letting the past rise up like a flood.

I lower my head and, keeping my eyes on the scribbles in my notebook, I ask how he's doing. Some things I don't want to know, or rather, I do want to know but have no courage to hear. Nadir then shares that he's gotten a scholarship to do his PhD, in New York. Behind my mask, my lips purse into a thin line. My grip tightens on my backpack.

"I'm probably too old for it, huh?"

I shake my head, congratulating him, but he can tell something's wrong.

"You're not happy for me?" he asks.

"Just surprised."

Years ago, whenever I imagined coming back to Indonesia, Nadir would always be present in my thoughts of home, even if we couldn't fully be together. But I never dreamt that someday I'd be the apples and pears on the dining table, the home left behind, and that he, not me, would be on a boat, with books.

"But why?" I murmur.

"Why New York, you mean?" Nadir takes a deep breath. "Because I'm taking a chance."

The brakes screech as the train comes to a halt. At Senayan Station, new passengers flock on board. I think about our parting conversation years ago. Is there any end to this road?

We pass station after station, the rumble of the wheels rescuing us from having to talk, and I restrain myself from asking the obvious question, the terrifying question that will strip away all pretense: *with whom?*

Who is he going with? I'm too scared to ask, anticipating the name he'll utter and my disappointment, my heart spilling out onto the train floor. And I'm also afraid to imagine the opposite: taking a chance on love, impossible dreams. Mutiara has left, Rosalinda is on her own journey, and I—I just want to have hope, here, on this moving train, among all the passengers getting on and off. But I'm afraid of bleeding, of pain. Maybe this is just another long dark road, and I'll never arrive. We know who else has travelled this road. We've been here before.

And that's when I see her.

How cunning she is, sneaking in among other women: pregnant mothers-to-be, university students, workers, women in headscarves.

"Maya?" Faintly, I hear Nadir calling me. "Maya, what is it?"

The fragrance of jasmine fills the train. There she sits, unable to blend in because of her long white dress, trailing on the floor. At the sight of the crimson stain on her front, my eyes shut.

"Maya, Maya!"

To this day, I don't know where my sister took a wrong turn. We've tried to guess—*maybe it was this, or that*—adding and subtracting to make sense of it all. But now, after four years, I realize how strange it is, this obsession with having things make sense. And just how everywhere she is, just how undead. Here she is, among us passengers, and somehow I know that when Nadir and I finally summon the courage to talk about taking chances and the future, and endings, she'll be waiting for me at the crossroads.

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THE CARETAKER

16 January 2022

The orange sky gradually darkens and fades to black, and now nothing is visible through the plane window. I lower the shade. I've recited Ayat al-Kursi and left them all behind, the three cat siblings, and Layla too, a blessing from Allah on the night of Laylat al-Qadr—my children, sweet-smelling and clean. I had no choice but to ask Maya to be their caretaker, and strangely enough, I feel at ease. I trust her.

I don't know what to call this trip: whether it's turning over a new page, as some might say, or opening an old book that I shut because I didn't dare read on. Also, I never thought it would feel like this, not having a home. Victoria's House is no more, transformed into a ridiculous joke. I've left the House of the Three Sisters, having buried its inhabitants. Despite everything, I never broke my promise to Nana. I saw off the dead and now I'm caring for the little that's left—the sliver of my own life.

And I'm still Mama's child. I love Mama more than anything.

Once the immigration officer has finished asking questions and stamped my passport, I head to the restroom. I turn on the faucet and let the water run between my fingers, clear and warm, washing away all the unseen germs. I remove my mask and splash my face with water. I survey my dull complexion in the mirror, and the bags under my eyes. But my headscarf looks tidy, pinned firmly in place. Don't let anything escape. I put my mask back on and run my hands under the blower until they're clean and dry.

I haul my two large suitcases off the conveyor belt and load them onto a trolley. Passing through customs, I make my way out. *Welcome to Wellington*, reads a sign. Anxiously, I scan the crowd, searching for her face, not daring to hope. What if she hasn't come, I wonder. What if she's changed her mind? Or what if this is all just a dream, like the one I had in

that hotel room in Kotawijaya, when I dreamed that my sister hadn't died? Smiles adorn the faces of the people waiting outside the exit. One by one, they find their loved ones: an elderly couple waves to their teenage grandchildren, a man runs to his sweetheart and envelopes her in his arms, little kids present their mother with balloons and a bouquet. And then there's me, pushing my trolley, seeking her face in the crowd.

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Dinar and Rohana

For my sister Mutiara

It's dark in the train station, apart from the flickering candles, which bathe the cold, black platform in a soft glow. Not far from the ticket counter, Dinar sits on a bench. The station is completely deserted, but she waits patiently. A big black clock overhead shows twelve, but its hands are still. No station employees, no ticking sounds. Then behind her comes the squeaking of wheels, and footfalls. Dinar turns.

It's Rohana, walking a bicycle, smiling at her. She's dressed in a blouse with a Peter Pan collar and a floral skirt. Dinar's heart pounds.

"You haven't changed a bit, Rohana. Even your clothes are the same."

"You too. Your hair is black."

"I waited for you," says Dinar. "I went every day."

"Forgive me."

Rohana's eyes glisten with tears. She gazes at the railroad tracks. Dinar puts a finger to Rohana's lips. A blinding light appears in the distance. As the train approaches, Rohana takes Dinar's hand.

"But I was always with you, Dinar. At your house. You know that, don't you?"

"I know. I liked to hear you sing."

"Where to now?"

"I'll follow you wherever you go."

A train car, dark green with golden trim, rolls to a stop in front of them. A female conductor in a navy-blue uniform motions for them to board. Dinar doesn't hesitate. Rohana leaves her bicycle on the platform and follows suit.

"Where will the train stop?" Dinar asks the conductor.

"We come to pick people up, but no one gets off."

"What are you saying? We can never get off?"

The conductor's lips widen into a Cheshire cat grin.

“Of course you can, sweetie,” she says. “I’m just telling you that, so far, no one’s ever wanted to get off.”

Dinar and Rohana walk through the car. Left and right, passengers are busy chatting, and reading books, and knitting. Some sport leather jackets and pilot caps, complete with aviator goggles. Some are wearing kebayas. So many ladies, dressed in their finest, and how happy they look! Rohana selects a seat and opens the window shade. Outside an open meadow sparkles in the sun.

“I’m sorry, Rohana.”

“What for?”

“I know why you didn’t come. And I wasn’t with you—”

“Don’t bring it up. It’s too painful.”

Dinar squeezes Rohana’s hand.

“How are your granddaughters, Dinar?”

Dinar doesn’t answer right away. The train passes a school. How very similar the school looks to their school back in Padang Panjang. Girls stream out through the door, followed by the sisters and Mevrouw van Aerden.

Staying strong, Dinar says finally. I hope they stay strong.

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BOY, GIRL

Dear ladies and gentlemen, look who's still here, standing in the spotlight! Yours truly, Miss Rosalinda the Blossom of Coral Cape. But the night grows long, and soon we will all return to our homes. Mr. Handsome in the front row to Darlinghurst, Ms. Marvelous in the balcony to Marrickville. Filled with happiness, you'll remember your humble servant fondly, for behold! The trans woman from the third world has managed to translate her story into English, transcending bigotry and misery. What strength! She persevered. She rose again. Ladies and gentlemen, for that matter, give yourselves a round of applause—"There are many stories to choose from, but let's hear Rosalinda's," you said—and retire to your beds, stirred with emotion, fists raised.

I am your revolution, even if only in your dreams.

How strange our transactions these days—in the end I was no holier than my sisters. But I collected my debts. I crossed borders, I visited cities. I've seen it all, and now I've told it too. This is a tale of three sisters. Things are still messy, and maybe this is only the start. This is a tale you didn't ask for, of the unseen, the unheard, the unremembered. And to Mami Cindy I have promised: I will continue to beat the drum.

Good night, ladies and gentlemen. Turn out the lights, this is our final tale.

Rohadi left the House of the Three Sisters without bidding Victoria farewell. But, really, they had already parted ways late one afternoon, the day before they left for Jakarta. Rohadi kept Victoria company, sipping tea and gazing out the window. Keeping them company was Sam Saimun, crooning in the background. Then Nana asked Rohadi to wheel her behind the house. They stopped by the well.

We go our separate ways this evening, said Nana. Take care, Rohadi, be well.

Stop acting so strange, Nana. I'm going to Jakarta with you, aren't I?

Yes, but I don't have much time. I'll never see this house again.

Don't talk like that, Nana.

It's going to be very painful.

What will be painful?

My end. They say that people like me have a difficult death.

Enough, don't—

We're all headed there in the end. You too.

Are you scared, Nana?

A little.

Nana was silent for a moment, then her voice brightened.

But death is just one station on a longer journey. After that I'll meet her. And we'll travel together.

Meet who, Nana?

Nana merely smiled. She stared at the well, transfixed, and Rohadi was reminded of the kuntilanak. Everything would remain here, the kuntilanak, the dark kitchen, the whispering well; everything, without exception—wardrobes, cookbooks, the sewing machine. The forbidden chamber. The forbidden book. Slowly, Rohadi reached into his pocket and produced a key attached to a pair of tiny red shoes.

I kept this for years, he said.

Ah, I knew it, I always knew!

Rohadi had found the key long after Nana's game had ended, after the sisters had returned to Jakarta, tucked away in a book Nana said was forbidden. A book that reminded her of her beloved. Rohadi had held on to the key with great hope, telling himself that when the time came, he would return it to Nana and say, *Thank you, Nana, your spells worked. I'm leaving now.*

Nana shook her head, coughing.

Hold on to it, Rohadi, she said. As a keepsake from me. But there are no spells. Look after yourself. The road ahead is steep.

Was Victoria predicting the future? Rohadi thought about it but concluded that a steep road wasn't fortune-telling but a fact. This life is difficult for people like you, Nana had said once. Rohadi didn't care whether Nana truly had magical powers, but he couldn't help but ask.

Why didn't you tell my future back then?

Back when? Nana didn't remember, or she pretended not to. So Rohadi reminded her: at the hospital, when she was bedridden, and everyone thought she was about to die. Nana had predicted her three granddaughters' future. But not Rohadi's. She'd forgotten Rohadi.

I didn't need to because you are everything, said Nana. Traveler, caretaker, bride.

Rohadi was stunned. He didn't understand what being everything meant. But being a bride might be nice, a handsome gentleman at one's side. A fine fate, who knows?

Nana cackled. Rohadi, Rohadi. My dear grandchild. Are you a boy or a girl? It's not clear.

Like you, Nana, replied Rohadi. You're a girl, but as a tiger, you're a boy.

Nana and Rohadi giggled gleefully.

I'm going to the kitchen, said Nana. Alone.

But you're not strong enough.

You don't believe your grandmother?

Rohadi was silent. I believe you, he said.

Then he helped Nana up from her wheelchair. Slowly, Nana walked toward the kitchen, leaning on her cane. Rohadi watched every painstaking step and heard Nana singing softly. *Destinations unknown. Boy, girl out the door*. Boy girl, boygirl.

Rohadi caught a whiff of kretek laced with betel nut. Nana kept walking toward the kitchen with its blackened cement floor, with the giant pots and pans hanging on the walls, into the secret depths, into the dark.

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About the Author

Intan Paramaditha is an Indonesian author and a Harvard Radcliffe Fellow. Her story collection *Apple and Knife* is part of the Vintage Classics Weird Girls series, and her novel *The Wandering* was longlisted for the Stella Prize and received the English PEN Translates Award. She holds a Ph.D. from New York University and teaches at Macquarie University, Sydney. She is co-founder of the feminist collective Sekolah Pemikiran Perempuan.

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